
GUILDS &
DRAGONS
A Web Novella Edition

GUILDS & DRAGONS

Book One — A Dragon Among Mortals

Chapter 1: Falling Star

The goblin screamed as the arrow took it through the throat.

It fell through the branches and struck the ground at the boots of a weary human in dented mail. He drew a ragged breath, raised his shield, and glanced over his shoulder.

“How many is that?” he panted.

“Seven,” the elf in the branches called back, already drawing another arrow. “Eight if you count the one you tripped over.”

The dwarf, armored in chainmail and heavy with holy symbols, didn’t look up as he brought his hammer down on a goblin. “Less counting, more killing!”

Broken branches and goblin bodies littered the clearing. Blood lent its copper tang to the damp air. Moss-wrapped trunks crowded the fighters, their canopy turning the afternoon light murky green. The goblins came in shrieking knots, stabbing with crude spears and scrambling over their own dead.

The human—Tomas—parried another jab and kicked his attacker away. “Ryn, I thought you said this was a small nest!”

The elf—Ryn—loosed his arrow. Another goblin shrieked and fell. “This is small by goblin standards!”

At the edge of the fight, the fourth adventurer gripped a staff in both hands. The young mage’s robes were too clean, their eyes too wide. Magic shimmered around their fingers, refusing to take shape.

“I—I’ve almost got it! Just hold still!” they called.

“Tell them that!” Tomas snapped, shoving a goblin away with his shield.

Goblin shrieks, clashing steel, and the dwarf’s roaring battle-prayer filled the clearing.

At first, nobody noticed the change in the sky.

The green light darkened to a hue Ryn had never seen. A warning prickled at the back of his neck, and it had nothing to do with goblins.

He looked up.

High above the trees, past gaps in the canopy, something burned its way across the sky.

A bright streak cut through the gaps in the canopy. A shooting star, he thought—until it flared, swelled, and he understood that it was not passing overhead.

It was coming straight toward them.

“Uh,” he said. “Everyone might want to—”

The thing hit the forest a few hundred paces away.

The world turned white.

Sound followed: a crack like the sky splitting open, then thunder that battered the trees. The ground bucked. Tomas went sprawling with the goblins; the young mage hit the dirt and lost their half-formed spell. Leaves and twigs rained down as birds burst screaming from the canopy.

A blast of air flattened the brush and sent the surviving goblins tumbling. Brannoc landed on his back, staring into the settling dust.

“What in the nine—” he started.

“DOWN!” Ryn shouted.

A second gust tore through the clearing, bending trunks and snapping branches. Debris followed. A rotten limb as thick as Tomas’s leg struck the ground where he had stood an instant earlier.

Then the forest went still. Leaves drifted through the dust.

For a heartbeat, nobody moved. Their ears rang.

One goblin broke first, shrieking as it fled. The others abandoned the fight and vanished into the undergrowth.

Tomas pushed himself up on an elbow. “Is… everyone alive?”

The young mage groaned. “My everything hurts.”

The dwarf sat up, coughed, and spat out a mouthful of dirt and a crushed leaf. “Aye. Still here. What in the Stones’ good name was that?”

Ryn hauled himself upright, already looking toward the impact. A column of dust rose beyond the trees, threaded with an unfamiliar light.

“Something just fell out of the sky,” he said quietly. “Close. Very close.”

Tomas followed his gaze. “Meteor?”

“If that was a meteor,” the dwarf muttered, standing with a grunt, “it was a gods-damned angry one.”

Mira swallowed and tightened her grip on the staff. “We should probably look, shouldn’t we? Things don’t just fall out of the sky.”

Tomas looked around at the battered clearing, then at the direction the goblins had fled.

“Given the choice between ‘follow the mysterious explosion from the heavens’ and ‘chase goblins into their tunnels’?” he said. “I’ll take the sky-rock.”

“Sky-rock it is,” the dwarf agreed.

They approached with weapons drawn. The closer they came, the stranger the forest looked: uprooted trees, split trunks, blackened bark still hissing with sap. Scorched wood filled the air.

Beneath the smoke lay another smell, metallic and sharp. It lifted the hairs along their arms.

The young mage whispered, “Can you feel that?”

Ryn nodded, jaw tight. “Magic. Old magic. Strong.”

They pushed through a final screen of bushes and stopped as one.

The impact had torn a crater through the forest floor, a ragged bowl of earth and shattered roots. Trees lay toppled in a widening ring. Heat still shimmered above the smoking ground.

At its center, a figure knelt with one hand braced against the earth.

Blackened plate covered him from head to foot, its overlapping edges sharp as broken blades. Scorch marks and old battle scars marred the metal. Steam curled from the pauldrons. A narrow, frowning visor concealed his face.

Beside him, driven point-first into the earth at an angle, was a sword.

The weapon was less a sword than a slab of battered steel. Its hilt rose to a man's chest; the chipped blade looked fit for a siege engine. Tomas could not imagine lifting it, let alone fighting with it.

A broad metal bracelet encircled the stranger's right wrist like a shackle. Five short chains hung from it, each ending in a different stone.

The stones were behaving strangely.

A cracked red gem glowed like banked embers. Mist stirred inside a nearly transparent crystal. Condensation crawled upward along a deep-blue stone. Gold-veined black rock trembled against its chain. The fifth crystal spat pale lightning across the links.

As the adventurers watched, the lights faded one by one. The crackle in the air subsided. The armored stranger exhaled.

Inside the armor, Shade took inventory.

Arms: attached. Legs: attached. Spine: complaining, but functional. Head: ringing. Scales: currently skin—right, he was supposed to be "human." He flexed his fingers experimentally, metal gauntlets creaking.

The impact had been rougher than his mother's tests, but survivable. This plane was heavier than expected, its magic thinner. The seals had held—mostly. For an instant, when gravity seized him, the gods had screamed through his bones, each stone tugging at a different piece of his nature. Even now he felt the urge to spread wings his borrowed human shape did not possess.

He rolled his right shoulder. The bracelet's chains chimed softly.

"…Ow," he said to himself. The helm muffled his voice.

"Sweet Mother of Stone," the dwarf breathed, very softly, from the rim of the crater.

Shade turned toward the sound with the unhurried attention of a predator listening to something move in the grass.

Four figures stood silhouetted against the sky above: one with a bow, one with a staff, one with a shield, one with a hammer. Mortals. Short-lived races. The sort of people his mother wanted him to "understand."

Good, he thought. The test begins immediately.

He rose, shedding clods of dirt from his armor, and took hold of the sword buried beside him.

The blade came free with a scrape. Shade lifted it onto his shoulder as easily as Tomas might lift a walking stick.

From above, Tomas' grip tightened reflexively on his own far more modest sword.

"He just—" the mage whispered. "That thing— did you see—"

"No man swings steel like that," the dwarf muttered. "Not in that much plate."

Ryn watched the bracelet. He had felt the world tighten around that falling light; now the stones were dark, as if nothing had happened.

The stranger tilted his helm, listening. One stone sparked in irritation. Shade resisted the urge to swat it.

Behave, he thought at it. Mother will be watching.

He remembered her last words before the magic had ripped him out of their realm and hurled him down:

Go, Shade. Walk among the lesser flames. Learn why they burn as they do. And remember—your fire is sealed. Use it only when all else fails.

He'd asked how he was supposed to tell when "all else" had failed.

She had smiled in that way that meant you will find out the hard way.

Four mortals stared down at him, frightened and fascinated, yet stubbornly unwilling to run. Dragons found that habit of theirs both irritating and admirable.

Shade decided that, to begin with, he should probably not terrify them.

He lifted his free hand slowly, palm open, in what he'd practiced as a neutral human gesture.

"Greetings," he called up, his voice carrying easily. "I hope I did not land on anything important."

Silence followed.

Tomas gave a startled laugh. "Just the forest," he said. "And the goblins. They're very dead."

Shade glanced around at the scorched crater, the shattered trees, the lack of goblins. "Ah," he said. "Then… you're welcome?"

The dwarf snorted despite himself. The mage's shoulders relaxed a fraction.

Ryn's eyes never left the bracelet. "Who are you?" he asked.

Shade considered the titles he could give: Heir of the Blue Flight. Child of the Storm Crown. Bearer of the Fivefold Seal. None would help these mortals remain calm.

He chose the simple one.

"My name," he said, "is Shade."

He left out the rest: And I am here to learn how not to break your world.

The stones at his wrist lay quiet and heavy, like the eyes of sleeping gods.

For now.

Chapter 2: A World Called Aleris

Shade waited while his name settled over the crater.

Nobody ran. Encouraging.

Tomas shifted his battered shield and cleared his throat.

“Well, Shade,” he said, “on behalf of… whatever this forest is called, thanks for crushing the goblins and not us.”

“You’re welcome,” Shade replied, aiming for friendly rather than regal.

An awkward silence stretched between them.

He remembered his plan.

Right. Step two.

“May I ask for directions to your…” Shade searched for the term. “Adventurers’ guild? I was told it would be the most efficient way to become acquainted with this world.”

The group blinked at him in almost perfect unison.

Mira spoke first. “You fell out of the sky, and now you want to join the guild?”

“Yes,” Shade said. “Is that unusual?”

Brannoc laughed. “Lass, I’ve seen worse applicants. At least this one landed on the right side.”

Ryn eased his bowstring and returned the arrow to its quiver. His gaze remained sharp and wary.

“There is a guild in Greenhollow,” the elf said slowly. “Closest town. Day’s walk from here, if we don’t trip over any more goblin warrens or falling knights.”

“Excellent,” Shade said. “May I accompany you?”

Tomas looked to the others. Brannoc shrugged; Mira nodded with undisguised curiosity. After one last appraising look, Ryn agreed.

“All right,” he said. “You helped clean up the goblins. You’re not trying to kill us. And I’d feel better if that… landing… isn’t wandering around on its own. Come on, then.”

He gestured toward the trees. “Path’s this way. Watch your step.”

Shade climbed from the crater with his sword across one shoulder. The slope barely slowed him, despite the armor that made every step look as though it ought to be difficult.

Tomas glanced from Shade to his own battered mail and sighed.

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The forest closed behind them, swallowing the crater. Birds had begun to call again, cautiously at first.

Without discussion, the adventurers settled into their usual order: Ryn ahead, Brannoc and Mira in the middle, Tomas behind. Shade walked wherever the path allowed room for him.

For a while, the only sounds were boots on earth, armor clinking, and the occasional snap of a twig.

Shade decided to make conversation. Mortals did that, according to his reading. They formed attachments by exchanging noises.

“I am grateful for your guidance,” he said. “I lack a map of this plane.”

The mage gave him a sidelong look. “Plane?”

“World,” Ryn corrected automatically from the front, stepping over a root. “Most folk just say ‘world.’”

“Ah,” Shade said. “Yes. World.” He filed the correction away. “What is this one called?”

The group slowed.

“You don’t know the name of the world you’re on?” Tomas asked.

Too much, Shade thought.

“I was… in a hurry,” he said. “The landing was… imprecise.”

The dwarf snorted, but there was less suspicion in it now and more amusement. “You don’t say.”

“Aleris,” Mira supplied. “The world is Aleris. This continent is Verdan, and these are the Greenwood Marches. We’re a few days from the Lyran Kingdom’s border. Greenhollow is the nearest frontier town.” She studied him. “You truly knew none of that?”

“I do now,” Shade said, honestly.

Their curiosity was becoming difficult to ignore. Shade sought safer ground.

“And you?” he asked. “What are your names?”

The dwarf thumped a fist against his chest. Holy symbols clinked. “Brannoc Ironvein. Priest of the Stonefather. These goblins were chewing on pilgrims. Bad for business.”

“Tomas,” the human said from behind, raising his sword in a little salute. “From nowhere important. Sellsword, when someone’s paying. Idiot, when no one is.”

Shade could not tell whether Tomas was insulting himself or performing some human courtesy, so he nodded solemnly.

“Ryn,” the elf said without looking back. “Just Ryn. Forester, guide. I try to keep these fools from dying.”

“I’m Mira,” the mage said. “Apprentice to the Circle of Emberfall. I… throw magic vaguely in the correct direction. Usually.”

“Usually,” Tomas echoed dryly.

Shade repeated each name carefully. “Brannoc. Tomas. Ryn. Mira.”

Buyakugan’s stone sparked against his wrist, apparently unimpressed by his gentleness. He ignored it.

“Where do you hail from, then, Shade?” Brannoc asked. “Don’t think I’ve heard that accent. Or seen that kind of plate.”

Shade translated the truth—the Storm Crown Aerie above the Sapphire Sea, beyond this sky—into something less alarming.

“Far from here,” he said. “A place of high cliffs and… much lightning.”

Brannoc’s eyes lit up. “Ah, the northern fjords, maybe. I’ve cousins up there. Nasty weather, good ale.”

Shade did not know what a fjord was. The rest sounded plausible enough for a dragon roost.

“Yes,” he said. “Those.”

Ryn’s mouth twitched, but he said nothing.

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Beyond the crater, the forest grew gentler. Birds called overhead; small animals rustled in the brush.

Mira edged closer to Shade, peering at his armor with unconcealed fascination.

“Doesn’t that get… unbearably hot?” she asked. “And heavy? Most knights only wear full plate to war. Not just… walking around the woods after goblins.”

Shade remembered sunning on obsidian cliffs, lava flows, and the comforting violence of storms. He also remembered his mother insisting that he wear something appropriately vulnerable.

“I have worn heavier,” he said. In full dragon form, that was certainly true.

Mira tried to lift the edge of his greatsword with two hands. It shifted only a little before she gave up with an embarrassed puff of air.

“Right,” she said. “You’re very strong.”

Shade, who had been told since hatching that he was worryingly small by dragon standards, blinked.

“I am… adequate,” he said.

Tomas laughed. “If that’s ‘adequate,’ I don’t ever want to meet ‘impressive.’”

“You already did,” Brannoc muttered. “When your mother threw a chair across three rooms.”

“That was different,” Tomas said. “That chair had it coming.”

Shade filed that away. Chairs were apparently a source of conflict here. His briefing had omitted the detail.

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“Tell me more of this… adventurers’ guild,” Shade said after a time. “Is it a temple? A military?”

“The guild?” Ryn glanced back over his shoulder. “None of the above. Kind of both. Kind of neither.”

Tomas seized the chance to explain. He appeared to enjoy talking, which made him useful. “Think of it as a monster-killer’s union.”

“A union,” Shade repeated.

“You sign up,” Tomas said. “They give you work—escort jobs, monster culling, artifact retrieval, whatever villages can’t handle alone. In return, they take a cut of your pay, patch you up when you’re injured, and try to stop you from doing anything too suicidally stupid.”

“They also keep records,” Mira added. “Ranks, bounties, maps. It’s how people who don’t have noble birth or a temple behind them get ahead.”

Brannoc nodded. “A decent guildhall’s as good as any tavern for news. Better, if you don’t like your news drunk.”

“And they can vouch for you,” Ryn said. “Work with the guild, you’re less likely to get mistaken for a bandit with unusual fashion choices.”

Shade considered the arrangement: a hub for information, sanctioned violence, contracts, and social standing. Efficient. No wonder his mother’s advisers had suggested it.

“And they will accept anyone?” he asked. “They do not… object to unusual origins?”

Tomas scratched at his stubble. “So long as you don’t eat clients, steal from the guild, or pick fights inside the hall? They’ve let worse in than a strange knight with terrible landing skills. Plenty of foreigners, mercs, even a tiefling or two.”

Mira nodded. “And they’ve got assessment forms for measuring ability. They’ll figure out where to start you.”

Shade imagined the assessment forms. Could you lift a crate? Had you slain goblins? There was unlikely to be a box for annihilating a rival dragonflight during a territorial dispute.

“I see,” he said. “It sounds… ideal.”

Only afterward did he wonder whether he had sounded too eager. Humans seemed to distrust enthusiasm for institutions.

Ryn, ahead, hid a smile.

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They stopped beside a stream to drink and refill their waterskins. Shade knelt at the bank. His reflection wavered beneath the helmet’s narrow visor, a hint of blue-white light where his eyes should be.

He didn’t take the helmet off. His mother had been very clear. Human face. Human teeth. No slitted pupils, Shade, you’ll scare them.

He cupped water in his gauntlets, more from habit than thirst. It tasted thin. Mortal. He swallowed anyway.

Mira perched nearby on a rock, staff across her knees.

“So,” she said, “you don’t know the world’s name, you didn’t flinch when you fell out of the sky, and you carry a sword that weighs as much as I do. But you want to join the guild like… just anyone.”

Shade watched the light move across the water.

“Yes,” he said simply. “I was told that to understand a people, one should live as they do. Work as they do.”

“’Course you were,” Brannoc said, wading in up to his boots. “Some mentor of yours must be very wise. Or very lazy. ‘Let the guild sort him out,’ sounds like something my high priest would say.”

Tomas knelt to scoop water, pausing to flex his sore shoulders. “You got coin, Shade? The guild charges joining fees. Plus they’ll want to see what you can do.”

“Coin,” Shade repeated.

His mother had supplied a pouch. “For bribes,” she had said. “Mortals love round pieces of metal. Do not hoard them. That comes later.”

He opened a leather pouch at his belt. Inside lay coins of bluish gold, each stamped with a dragon's head on one side and the Storm Crown's sigil on the other.

He poured a few into his palm.

The others stared.

Brannoc let out a low whistle. "That is not local mint."

"Is it worth anything?" Shade asked. Dragonflight currency depended as much on magic and obligation as on metal.

Tomas picked one up, turning it between calloused fingers. "Gold is gold. A moneychanger will fuss about the stamp, shave off a bit, complain, then pay you anyway. You've got enough there to pay your fees and then some." He frowned. "Just… don't flash it all at once in Greenhollow. You'll attract the wrong sort of attention."

"Bandits?" Shade asked.

"Worse," Brannoc said. "Tax collectors."

Shade decided taxation would be an interesting topic to research later.

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On the road again, Brannoc steered the conversation toward religion. He did that often.

"The Stonefather holds up all things," the dwarf said, thumping his hammer against his armor with each point. "Mountains, cities, contracts, marriages. You want something to last, you say a prayer to him."

"Some of us worship the Lady of the Wind," Ryn said. "Travel, luck, the spaces between places. Rangers, sailors, thieves. Anyone who lives in motion."

"The Circle follows the Flame," Mira added. "Not just fire, but change. Knowledge that spreads. Purification. It burns away what's rotten."

Shade listened, the bracelet heavy against his wrist. Fire. Air. Earth. Did these mortals worship lesser faces of the powers that bound him, or were their gods entirely different?

"And you, Shade?" Brannoc asked. "Got a god where you're from?"

His first answer was five, currently attached to my wrist.

He glanced at the bracelet. The stones were dull, quiet. No help there.

"I… am still deciding," he said at last. "I have not met any gods personally here."

Ryn's brows rose. "You met some elsewhere?"

Shade heard the implication too late. "In stories," he amended.

Brannoc chuckled. "Well, you're headed the right way. Guilds and gods go together like ale and arguments. You'll meet priests of all stripes in Greenhollow. Pick one that doesn't try to kill you."

"Sound advice," Shade said gravely.

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By late afternoon, the trees gave way to stumps, cultivated ground, and wagon ruts. Woodsmoke drifted on the breeze.

“Nearly there,” Ryn called back. “Greenhollow’s just ahead, past that rise.”

Anticipation stirred in Shade’s chest. Beyond the rise lay his first mortal settlement, full of people he was meant to understand. For reasons he could not explain, that prospect unsettled him more than the fall.

He checked his armor straps. The familiar weight steadied him; the bracelet chimed as he flexed his wrist. The stones remained quiet.

Behave, he reminded himself. Do not frighten them. Do not set anything on fire. Do not eat anyone’s chair, no matter what Tomas’ mother did.

“What’s the guild like?” he asked as they crested the hill.

“Loud,” Tomas said. “Crowded. Smells like sweat, steel, ink, and bad beer.”

“Full of idiots,” Brannoc added affectionately. “And heroes. Sometimes both in the same body.”

“Watch the notice boards,” Mira said. “They’re how you find work. Don’t take anything marked with three skulls. Or anything that mentions ‘experimental magic.’ I learned that the hard way.”

Ryn nodded toward the roofs emerging beyond the hill.

“And remember,” he said, glancing back at Shade, eyes serious now, “try not to act like you fell out of the sky yesterday. People in town startle easier than we do.”

Shade considered the advice and dipped his helmet in acknowledgment.

“I will,” he said. “How do people who did not fall out of the sky act?”

Tomas groaned. “Oh, this is going to be fun.”

They went down toward Greenhollow together: an elf guide, a human sellsword, a dwarf priest, a nervous mage, and a half-dragon in battered plate, trying his best to pass for an ordinary adventurer.

Chapter 3: The Guild Test

Greenhollow was exactly as loud as Tomas had promised.

Greenhollow huddled in a shallow valley behind a low palisade, all timber walls and stone chimneys. Cooking smoke carried the smells of leather, food, and too many people packed too closely together.

From behind his visor, Shade watched the gate guards straighten at the sight of his armor, then relax when they recognized his companions. Children abandoned their games to stare. A dog took one look at him and hurried away.

“Try to look… less like a siege weapon,” Tomas muttered as they passed through the gate.

“I am walking,” Shade said. “Is that not correct?”

“Walk less like you’re about to conquer something,” Ryn added.

Shade tried a different stride. It felt absurd. His mother had never mentioned that humans could walk incorrectly.

✦ ✦ ✦

The adventurers’ guildhall was impossible to miss.

The guildhall stood near the town center, a broad stone building with the stubborn proportions of a barn. A painted sign above its doors showed a crossed sword and staff over a shield. Laughter and shouting carried into the street, accompanied by music that sounded like a bard losing an argument with his lute.

Tomas grinned. “Home.”

Shade paused at the entrance. The building was modest by dragon standards but crowded with life. Faint strands of magic passed through the walls like spider silk.

The five stones stirred. Terra approved of the foundations; Fenris cooled at the scent of nearby water; Djing and Djang tugged his attention in opposite directions, toward the crowded hall and the open sky.

Behave, he reminded them—and himself.

Ryn pushed the door open and walked in. Sound hit them like a wave.

The hall teemed with adventurers eating, drinking, and arguing over maps. A noticeboard sagged beneath scraps of paper marked with names, rewards, and skulls. Near the bar, the bard continued his losing battle with rhythm.

Conversations faltered as the newcomers entered. Everyone saw the dark-armored stranger with a sword taller than some of the patrons.

When nobody drew a weapon, the noise resumed. The staring did not.

“Don’t mind them,” Brannoc said cheerfully. “They’ll get used to you, or be too drunk to care.”

“Front desk,” Ryn said, nodding toward a counter off to one side.

Behind the counter sat a woman in her thirties, surrounded by ledgers. Ink stained her fingers; a brass guild badge gleamed on her vest. She looked up with the practiced impatience of someone who had heard every possible excuse.

She looked up as they approached.

“If you’re here to complain about reward shares,” she began without preamble, “the board is clear—”

“We’re not,” Tomas said quickly. “We’ve got a new applicant.”

Her eyes traveled from Shade’s helmet to his sword, then to the chained stones at his wrist.

“…Of course you do,” she said. “Name?”

“Shade,” he said.

She waited.

He waited back.

“Just Shade?” she prompted.

“Yes,” he said.

She sighed, dipped her quill in ink, and wrote anyway. “Fine. Shade. Race?”

There was a tiny, simultaneous tug on all five stones.

“Human,” he said.

Buyakugan’s lightning crystal gave a single, disbelieving snap against the chain. He ignored it.

The woman’s eyebrows rose a fraction, but she kept writing. “Place of origin?”

“Far north,” he said quickly. “Cliffs. Lightning. Few chairs.”

Tomas coughed into his fist. Brannoc looked suddenly fascinated by a crack in the floor.

She held his gaze, then evidently decided she had better uses for her afternoon.

“Previous guild experience?”

“No.”

“Can you read Common?”

“Given time,” Shade said. “The letters are familiar.”

She squinted at him. “Any… special talents?”

He considered mentioning dragonfire hot enough to turn sand to glass, storms called from clear skies, and claws that could tear granite.

“I am… adequate with a sword,” he said.

Mira made a choking noise. Ryn covered his mouth to hide a grin.

The woman just nodded. “Right. You’ll need to take the aptitude assessment, then. Standard procedure. Ryn, Tomas, I assume you’ll vouch that he isn’t a bandit in very fancy armor?”

“He fell out of the sky on a goblin nest,” Brannoc said helpfully. “If he’s a bandit, he’s a very committed one.”

She stared. “…I am choosing to ignore that sentence. Assessment is through that door. I’ll send for Grig. He’s overseeing tests today.” She slid a wooden token across the counter to Shade. “Take that and don’t break anything expensive.”

Shade took the token between two careful fingers. “I will try.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The guild’s assessment room held straw targets, a chalked fighting circle, and several devices that looked equally suited to athletic training and torture.

Ryn, Tomas, Brannoc, and Mira settled onto a bench to watch.

Shade stood in the center, feeling the bracelet’s weight more keenly in the quiet.

A broad-shouldered, scarred man in his fifties entered carrying a clipboard. His receding hairline and unimpressed expression made him look as though he had grown tired of applicants decades ago. A heavy axe hung at his hip.

“Right,” he said, eyes flicking up from the page to Shade. They stuck there for a moment. “You the new one?”

“Yes,” Shade said. “I am Shade.”

“Grig,” the man said. “Senior assessor. I decide whether you’re guild material or just another drunk who bought a sword.” He eyed the greatsword. “Or in your case, bought a cart axle and sharpened it.”

Grig circled him, boots scraping across the boards and axe knocking softly against his mail.

“Armor’s functional. Movement good. No tremor. That sword’s ridiculous, but if you can use it, that’s my concern, not yours.”

He stopped in front of Shade again. “We’ll run this simple. Strength, agility, control, judgment. No magic—” he glanced at Shade’s wrist, frowned, but moved on “—unless that’s your main thing, and from that slab of steel I’m guessing it’s not.”

“That is correct,” Shade said.

“All right then.” Grig jerked his chin toward a massive stone block set on a heavy sled near one wall. “First test. Dead weight drag. Get that from the line to the chalk mark as fast as you can. No magic, no tricks. Just muscle.”

The stone block was roughly the size of a horse. Deep grooves already scarred the floor between the starting line and the chalk mark.

Shade walked over and wrapped one gauntleted hand around a handle. The stone resonated pleasantly under his fingers; Terra’s gem on his bracelet warmed, approving.

He reminded himself: Blend in. Do not break the floor.

He braced his legs and pulled.

The sled lurched forward. Shade nearly lost his balance, not because the weight challenged him but because he had expected some resistance.

He recovered and trotted to the mark, dragging the shrieking sled through a spray of dust and splinters.

He stopped and let go. The sled slid another few inches before shuddering to a halt.

Silence.

Tomas shut his mouth.

Mira whispered, “He moved it like a crate.”

Grig inspected the grooves in the floor, then Shade.

“You were… holding back?” he asked carefully.

“Yes,” Shade said. Honesty seemed safest.

Grig made a strangled noise and wrote furiously on his clipboard.

“Fine. Strength test… noted.” He jerked his thumb toward a row of posts with swinging sandbags and dangling wooden beams. “Agility course. Full armor, full speed. No knocking over the marked obstacles. Start at the gong, end at the rope.”

Shade examined the swinging weights, beams, and hurdles. Dragonets used similar courses on cliff ledges, though those were usually harder.

He stepped to the start, placed one hand on the gong, and waited for Grig’s signal.

“Go!”

The gong’s clang echoed.

Shade moved.

Shade ducked beneath a beam, slipped between swinging sandbags, and ran across a narrow balance rail. His armor resisted the sharp turns; his body barely noticed. Djing and Djang’s crystal trembled with delight.

He dropped from the rail, cleared a hurdle, rolled under a pendulum, and reached the finishing rope in one fluid sprint.

The bell attached to it rang bright and clear.

He turned, breathing steady, a sheen of sweat under the armor more from the room’s stuffiness than exertion.

Grig stood with his quill suspended above the page.

“Time?” Ryn called from the bench.

Grig looked from the hourglass to the marks beside it. “Fast,” he said finally. “Very fast. Agility passed.” He narrowed his eyes. “You sure you’re not a monk under there?”

Shade considered the mental image of himself in orange robes trying to politely ignore being on fire. “…No.”

“All right.” Grig shook himself. “Dummies. Let’s see your control. You get three strikes. Aim to disable, not destroy. Imagine they’re—”

Shade stepped up to the first target and raised his sword in a two-handed guard. The blade settled naturally into position.

He inhaled.

Do not cleave. Demonstrate… precision.

He exhaled and cut.

The greatsword whispered through the air. The dummy's right arm fell off at the shoulder in a clean line. The rest of the target didn't move.

His second blow was a thrust through the target's chest, stopping just short of the wooden post. The third severed its supports. The dummy collapsed without scattering its straw.

He stepped back.

The room smelled of dust and dry grass.

Grig walked over and prodded the cuts, then the post, then Shade's sword.

"You do know this thing isn't supposed to be a scalpel," he said.

"It serves," Shade said.

Grig looked like a man taking stock of every god he might recently have offended.

He flipped to a different page. "Last bit. Judgment. Scenario questions." He cleared his throat. "You're escorting a merchant caravan. Bandits attack. Do you: A) Charge the bandits, B) Defend the wagons, C) Retreat and regroup?"

Shade considered the choices. They assumed a very small battlefield and a remarkable reluctance to use overwhelming force.

"I would… position myself between the bandits and the wagons," he said slowly. "Break their charge. Attempt to end the fight quickly with minimal loss of life. If possible, I would… encourage surrender."

"Encourage how?" Grig asked.

Shade imagined a roar that shook mountains. "…Firm words," he said.

"Any use of the local terrain?" Grig pressed. "Ambush options? Cover?"

Shade pictured setting the forest on fire and decided that was not the answer. "If there were ditches or rocks," he said, "I would use them to deny the enemy easy approach."

"Mm." Grig actually looked satisfied at that. "Second scenario—"

The scenarios continued: goblins holding hostages, a collapsing dungeon, a dishonest client. Shade steered his answers between what he would do as a dragon and what a human was expected to do. Brannoc and Tomas exchanged glances but kept quiet.

At last, Grig lowered his clipboard.

"Well," he said. "Strength absurd. Agility ridiculous. Weapon skill… concerning, but in a good way. Judgment… not terrible. Could use seasoning."

Grig studied him, gaze pausing on the bracelet. "You're not exactly standard. Neither is half this guild. I've seen worse applicants survive long enough to become a nuisance."

He took a small wooden card from his belt pouch and stamped it with a metal seal. Then he held it out.

"Provisional bronze rank," he said. "You'll need to complete a group evaluation before we bump you anywhere higher. Guild doesn't throw unknowns straight into work where they get themselves—or others—killed."

Shade accepted the card. His name was stamped beside the guild insignia.

Relief eased a tension he had not recognized. It was only a provisional rank, yet here was proof that he belonged to something in this strange world.

“Thank you,” he said.

“Don’t thank me yet,” Grig snorted. “You’ve got to survive the part where you meet other idiots.”

He turned his head toward the bench. “Ryn, Tomas, you said you’d stick around?”

“We’ll vouch he didn’t tear the place down,” Tomas said. “And that he only mildly traumatized the goblins.”

“Good enough.” Grig shoved the clipboard under his arm. “Front desk will sort you out with lodging, Shade. We’ve got a bunkhouse for new blood, or you can find an inn. Either way, be back here at third bell tomorrow.”

“For the group test?” Mira asked.

Grig nodded. “We’ve got a pre-made bronze party coming in. Short job in the woods. Spider cull. Nothing too fancy. We’ll put Shade with them, see how he handles working in a team that doesn’t already know him.”

He glanced at Shade again, mouth quirking. “And see whether the team survives him.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Lana—the name on the plaque behind the counter—handled his lodging with ruthless efficiency.

“Bunkhouse bed is three silver a night,” she said, tapping her ledger. “Includes breakfast, excludes any trouble you start. You break it, you pay for it. You snore like a troll, your bunkmates may kill you; guild is not responsible.”

“Are there… chairs?” Shade asked, suddenly unsure.

“Last I checked, yes,” she said slowly.

“I will be careful,” he said.

She weighed several of his unfamiliar coins. “Three nights paid, at the exchanger’s rate. Here’s your bunk token. Don’t lose it.”

He accepted the small carved wooden chit and tucked it safely away.

Ryn clapped him lightly on the shoulder plate. “We’ll leave you to settle in. Bunkhouse is just across the yard. Big long building, smells like socks and regret. You can’t miss it.”

Tomas grinned. “We’ll be here tomorrow to watch you try not to pulverize spiders too hard.”

Brannoc waved his hammer. “If you can’t sleep, lad, there’s a decent tavern two streets over. The ale’s rubbish but the fights are good.”

Mira smiled, a little shy but honest. “You did great. For someone who arrived via crater.”

Their friendliness caught Shade unprepared. He nodded to each of them.

“Thank you,” he said. “For guidance. And for not running away.”

“Eh,” Tomas said. “We’re adventurers. Running away is usually step three, not one.”

They drifted back into the guildhall, already debating their next job.

Shade stepped into the courtyard beneath a sky streaked with evening gold. Light glowed from the bunkhouse windows across the yard.

He looked down at the bracelet.

The stones were quiet, but awake. An ember lingered in Ifret's gem; Buyakugan's crystal crackled as though the tests had disappointed her. Terra pulsed with slow approval. Fenris cooled his skin. Djing and Djang stirred toward the bustle of the hall and the freedom of the road.

"A day," Shade murmured to them, to himself. "One day, and I have not destroyed anything important."

The chains chimed softly when he flexed his wrist.

Tomorrow he would work with strangers, restrain himself, and take orders from someone who was neither dragon nor god.

He squared his shoulders and crossed toward the bunkhouse, the guild card a small, solid weight at his belt.

One step at a time.

Chapter 4: The Trial Party

At third bell, Shade stood precisely where Grig had told him to wait: in the courtyard, armored, greatsword across his back, doing his best not to look as though he intended to besiege the guild.

Mist hung over the yard. Adventurers spilled from the bunkhouse in various states of wakefulness, some arguing already, others too hungover to manage it. The guildhall doors swung steadily open and shut.

“Shade!”

Grig strode across the yard, clipboard wedged beneath one arm.

“Your test party’s inside,” he said. “Try not to traumatize them. Too much.”

Shade inclined his head. “I will try to be… moderate.”

“That’s what worries me,” Grig muttered.

✦ ✦ ✦

The party waited in a briefing room off the main hall, where a regional map covered one wall and the table smelled faintly of damp parchment and ink.

Four people were already there.

Two were scarcely more than children: bright-eyed, eager, and still convinced every adventure would end with a story worth telling.

The boy, perhaps sixteen, had unruly brown hair, creaking leather armor, and a shortsword a little too large for him. The girl looked his age, with freckles, a messy braid, and a bow she carried as though it were a sacred relic. Their equipment was a jumble. Their excitement matched perfectly.

Between them leaned an elf.

Age had scored the elf's face without dulling his gaze. Weathered-straw hair escaped beneath a battered hood; a long knife and much-used bow lay within reach. He regarded the room, the map, and its occupants with equal dislike.

And then there was the dwarf.

She stood at the far end of the table, arms loosely folded as she studied the map. Lamplight warmed her bronze-hued skin. Jet-black hair fell in a thick braid bound with copper rings, and when she looked up, her eyes shone with the reds and oranges of banked coals.

Her lips were full and impossibly red. Dark sigils traced the line of her throat: a warlock's marks. Shade, who could calculate battlefield losses at a glance, lost track of his own thoughts.

The five stones at his wrist fell still. It was as though the gods were holding their breath with him.

Grig cleared his throat. “Right. Children, fossil, disaster waiting to happen—this is Shade. He’s your evaluation case.”

The human boy straightened, nearly saluting with the wrong hand. “I’m Jerrin!” he blurted. “Future legendary swordsman. Probably.”

The girl elbowed him. “I’m Lysa. Best archer in Greenhollow. Soon to be best archer in Verdan.”

The elf gave a sound halfway between a scoff and a sigh. “Varinel. Tracker. Guide. Babysitter, apparently.”

His scowl flicked up and down Shade’s armor. “You planning to fight spiders dressed like a siege tower?”

Shade hesitated. “…Yes?”

“Of course you are,” Varinel muttered.

Grig gestured to the dwarf. “And this is your handler. Arcebek.”

She smiled. Shade's heart missed a step. He had felt fear before; this was considerably less familiar.

“Arcebek will do,” she said, her low voice carrying an easy warmth. “Bronze Circle. Pact-bound. I throw magic vaguely in the correct direction. Usually.”

Shade had heard that line before, from Mira. Here, it sounded like a joke worn comfortably.

Shade opened his mouth. Nothing useful emerged.

“Good morning,” he managed.

Her gaze traveled over his armor and sword before settling on the chained stones at his wrist. Buyakugan's crystal gave an embarrassed spark.

“Shade, was it?” she asked.

He nodded.

“Interesting name,” she said. “We’ll see if you live up to it.”

He nodded again. Apparently, that was the limit of his conversational ability.

Grig clapped his hands. “Listen up. Mossford, half a day's walk east. Cave spiders are moving out of the old nest, taking livestock and frightening the farmers. Find the nest, cull it, bring back proof. Straightforward bronze work.”

He pointed with his quill. “Varinel leads. Jerrin, Lysa, follow his orders and stay alive. Arcebek, keep the others in one piece and vaporize anything with more than eight legs. Shade, follow instructions. I want to see how you work with people who didn't meet you in a crater.”

Jerrin’s hand shot up. “What about loot rules?”

“Anything that’s not nailed down and isn’t cursed is fair share,” Grig said. “Anything cursed goes to the guild vaults and you get hazard pay.” He eyed them all in turn. “Any questions that aren’t stupid?”

No one volunteered any.

“Good.” Grig pushed a rolled letter across the table. “Give this to Mossford's reeve. And if you return with fewer people than you left with, I'll be very disappointed.” He looked directly at Shade. “In you.”

Shade straightened. “I will do my best to prevent… party reduction.”

“Good lad,” Grig said, and stomped out.

✦ ✦ ✦

East of Greenhollow, wagon ruts gave way to a narrow track between fields and thin stands of scrub. The sun burned the last mist from the road.

Varinel took the lead with the endurance of a man who had spent centuries enduring fools. Jerrin and Lysa followed in a shifting tangle, talking over each other as they walked.

“So there was this one time,” Jerrin said, “we fought four wolves at once.”

“It was two,” Lysa corrected.

“Four,” he insisted. “You just didn’t see the other two because I scared them off.”

Arcebek walked beside Shade with easy, measured strides. She smelled faintly of spice and woodsmoke, and carried herself with the self-possession of a banked fire.

Shade concentrated on walking normally. He had never found the task so difficult.

“So,” she said after a time, glancing up at him, “first time on a guild job?”

“Yes,” he said. “First time.”

“Word of Grig's assessment got around,” she said. “You dragged that stone sled as though it were packed with feathers?”

“I misjudged the friction,” Shade said. “It will not happen again.”

“Most people misjudge it the other way.” She studied him. “Where did you train?”

Dragon aeries. Celestial battlefields. One regrettable incident in a molten cavern.

“Far from here,” he said aloud. “With… demanding tutors.”

“I can imagine,” she murmured.

He wanted to ask about her pact, the sigils on her skin, the strange power that clung to her without resembling any god he knew. Instead, he heard himself say, “Your hair is very… braided.”

Buyakugan’s crystal did a tiny, horrified crackle.

Arcebek blinked, then laughed. There was delight in it, not cruelty.

“It is,” she agreed. “Thank you, Shade.”

Shade counted that as a successful conversation.

✦ ✦ ✦

By midday, fields had given way to rock and thorn. The path squeezed between a low cliff and a ravine full of brambles. Birds had stopped calling.

Varinel’s hand went up, fingers tightening around his bow. “Quiet,” he snapped over his shoulder. “Mouths shut. Eyes up.”

Jerrin and Lysa shuffled into place, whispering despite the order.

Shade felt the change a heartbeat later: an unfamiliar pressure in the wind and the silence where birdsong should have been.

Djing & Djang’s dual crystal trembled on his wrist, tugging his attention skyward.

He looked up.

Three shapes wheeled high overhead, their ragged wings dark against the blue. Human torsos narrowed into birdlike limbs, and yellow talons flashed as they turned.

“Harpy sign,” Varinel hissed. “Damn it.”

Arcebek’s eyes narrowed, the fire behind them shifting. “They’re not supposed to nest this close to the road.”

“Someone's been dumping scraps in their hunting grounds,” Varinel muttered. “Or they've scented young, loud, and under-armed from a mile away.”

He stepped under an overhang, bow ready. “Against the rock. Don't give them a clear silhouette.”

Jerrin and Lysa scrambled for the cliffside, pressing their backs to stone. Arcebek stayed near them, fingers flexing, a faint shimmer of heat starting to coil around her hands.

Shade took the position Varinel indicated. With rock at one shoulder and a drop at the other, there was little room to swing his sword.

“What’s the plan?” he asked.

“Hope they’re just passing,” Varinel said. His eyes tracked the shapes. “If not, stay grounded. Don’t get lifted out of line. They like to grab and drop.”

“Charming,” Arcebek said.

“Whatever you do, don’t let them—”

The rest of the sentence vanished under a shriek.

The nearest harpy folded her wings and dropped like a thrown spear.

Three harpies stooped in staggered dives, their cries halfway between birdsong and a scream. One swept toward Lysa, another toward Jerrin, and the third aimed for Shade.

Shade saw each approach. Danger stripped the world down to angles, distances, and choices.

He could withstand a harpy's strike. Jerrin could not.

The boy raised his sword far too late, eyes wide.

Shade moved.

Shade left the shelter of the ledge. Wind shifted around him; Djing and Djang's crystal flashed hot at his wrist.

He reached Jerrin as the harpy struck and shoved the boy against the rock. Talons shrieked across Shade's pauldron, throwing sparks.

Another harpy twisted in mid-dive. Her claws caught the gap beneath his left breastplate and sliced into flesh.

Pain flared, followed by a cold numbness creeping along his nerves.

Harpy poison would have locked a mortal's muscles within moments.

Shade's dragon blood met it with profound indifference.

He didn’t slow.

The harpy that wounded him beat her wings to climb away. Shade caught one feathered leg before she could escape.

Momentum did the rest.

He turned with her momentum and swung.

Bone, feathers, claws, and a furious scream whirled around him. Ifret's stone pulsed with unmistakable enthusiasm.

He threw her.

She struck the second harpy in mid-dive. Their wings tangled, and both plunged into the ravine, shredding brambles on the way down.

The third spread her wings to climb. Shade stepped beneath her and swept the flat of his greatsword upward.

Steel struck ribs. She hit the cliff and fell motionless onto the path.

Then came quiet, save for the party's breathing and a last, dwindling shriek from below.

Shade scanned the sky. Nothing else moved.

He turned.

Jerrin sat against the rock, his sword still raised at an angle that would have stopped absolutely nothing. His mouth opened twice before sound came out.

“Uh,” he managed. “Thanks?”

“You are welcome,” Shade said, trying not to sound like he’d just batted a particularly annoying insect out of the air.

Varinel lowered his bow, an arrow still nocked.

“I've fought harpies,” he said flatly. “I've watched them carry men off, poison them stiff, tear them apart. I have never watched anyone use one as a gods-damned flail.”

Arcebek was staring at Shade’s side.

“Your armor,” she said. “You’re wounded.”

He glanced down.

A jagged opening in his plate exposed torn cloth and a little dried blood. Beneath it, his skin already itched with healing.

Fenris’ stone on his bracelet pulsed, cool and soothing, boosting the natural regeneration without quite breaking its seal.

“I am… scratched,” Shade said.

“Their talons carry paralytic venom,” Varinel snapped, striding closer. “Even a graze should have dropped you by now.”

Jerrin’s eyes went round. “Poison? He’s been poisoned?”

Lysa’s hand flew to her mouth. “Oh no—”

“I am fine,” Shade said.

Arcebek stepped in, one hand already rising toward the wound as if to cast. Up close, her eyes were very bright. “Can you feel your fingers? Toes? Any numbness? Tingling?”

“I can feel everything,” Shade said. “The poison appears ineffective.”

Varinel stared at him. “Ineffective.”

“Yes.”

“In what world,” the elf said slowly, “does harpy venom count as ‘ineffective’?”

Shade considered several worlds in which that venom might have mattered. None was this one.

“In this one, apparently,” he said.

Arcebek’s gaze flicked from his faceplate to the gap in his armor and back. Her pupils were narrowed, curious. “You didn’t even slow down,” she murmured. “Most fighters drop like sacks of grain from half that dose.”

Shade shifted his weight. He had clearly revealed too much. “I have a strong constitution.”

The stones answered in their own fashion: Ifret eager, Buyakugan exhilarated, Terra displeased, Fenris calmly attending to the wound, and Djing and Djang still humming with the altered wind.

Arcebek lowered her hand. “We'll examine it in Mossford. If you decide to collapse, try to do it somewhere other than the cliff edge.”

“I will keep that in mind,” Shade said.

Varinel prodded the fallen harpy with his boot. “Road wardens will want proof of a nest. We can take the head.”

Jerrin and Lysa recovered enough to start peppering Shade with questions.

“Where did you learn to throw like that?”

“Did you see how far they went? I thought harpies were, like, super dangerous!”

“Are you sure you’re human?” Lysa’s voice dropped. “You’re not, like, blessed by the Stonefather or something?”

Shade cleaned his blade on a dead harpy's feathers before sheathing it.

“I have had… a lot of practice,” he said. “And harpies are dangerous. Do not assume otherwise because I made them… airborne in an unintended direction.”

“Airborne in an unintended direction,” Jerrin repeated, grinning. “I’m stealing that.”

“Don’t,” Varinel said. “You’ll definitely use it wrong.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The rest of the journey passed without another attack, though everyone watched the sky. The land dipped toward greener fields, and the river flashed between the distant trees.

By the time Mossford came into view—clustered timber houses around a central well, a small stone chapel, fields of late grain—the sun was already dipping, painting the sky in streaks of orange and purple.

“Late,” Varinel muttered. “Damn harpies.”

“Better late than dead,” Arcebek said.

Mossford had no wall, only a stout fence around its houses. Farmers paused in their work to watch the party approach, their tired faces betraying what the spider attacks had cost them.

Cooking smoke drifted from the chimneys, mingled with wet earth and a faint sour smell like old webbing.

“Inn's the large building with the painted sign,” Arcebek said. “First we see the reeve, show our letter, and find out where the spiders come from. Then you may collapse dramatically if the poison changes its mind.”

Shade glanced at the wound under his armor. It had stopped bleeding entirely; the skin felt tight but whole. “I do not anticipate collapsing,” he said.

“Humor me,” she said, and flashed him a quick grin that did unfortunate things to his ability to form sentences.

He settled for a nod.

They entered Mossford through the gate. Chickens scattered. A dog barked at Shade, thought better of it, and hid behind a barrel. Children stared from doorways until someone called them inside.

The inn was two stories, with a painted sign swinging overhead: a moss-covered stone by a stream. Warm light spilled from the windows. Voices drifted out, muted but present.

On the threshold, Shade considered the day: a new party, a harpy ambush, poisoned claws that should have killed a man, and a warlock who had somehow rendered him incapable of speech.

Ifret’s stone was a quiet coal; Fenris cool as river water; Terra solid; Buyakugan humming faintly; Djing & Djang pulling his attention both inward and onward.

He squared his shoulders.

“Ready, Shade?” Jerrin asked, bouncing a little on his heels.

“As I will ever be,” Shade said.

They stepped into the inn together, the door closing behind them on the darkening village square.

Chapter 5: Mossford

The innkeeper took in Shade's armor, Jerrin and Lysa's exhausted faces, and the enormous sword. He decided not to ask questions.

“You can have the back room,” he said gruffly. “For the lot of you. One silver, food included. No breaking furniture.”

His eyes lingered on Shade’s greatsword.

“I will be gentle,” Shade promised.

The man looked unconvinced, but took the coin anyway.

✦ ✦ ✦

The back room was a narrow chamber upstairs with three beds and a jumble of bedrolls. River damp seeped through the shutters, and the floor complained beneath every step.

Varinel claimed a bed without asking. Jerrin and Lysa immediately began arguing over who got the second.

“You snore.”

“You kick.”

“You drool in your sleep.”

“That was one time—”

Arcebek rolled her eyes. “You can share. I’ll take a bedroll. I’ve slept in worse places than this on purpose.”

They both subsided, chastened and a little impressed.

Shade set his sword carefully against the wall and hesitated. In a dragon aerie, evenings meant battle plans, weapon care, or listening to elders while pretending to admire one's hoard. Here, everyone settled into private rituals: boots off, cloaks folded, belts unbuckled.

“You should let me see that wound now,” Arcebek said.

She shrugged off her coat and draped it over a stool. Lamplight touched the bronze of her skin and caught fire in her eyes.

“It is no longer a concern,” Shade said. “It has… resolved.”

“That’s not how harpy poison works,” she said. “Sit.”

He sat.

It seemed safer than arguing.

She pulled the stool close. Her braid fell over one shoulder, carrying the scent of smoke and a sharp, resinous herb.

“Arm up,” she said.

Shade lifted his arm. Arcebek's fingers worked the stubborn buckles more easily than his own ever did. She eased away the breastplate, exposing the gambeson beneath.

“Shirt too,” she said absently, eyes on the faint stain of dried blood.

Buyakugan’s crystal made a tiny, traitorous tink against its chain.

Shade hesitated. “Is that… necessary?”

“Yes,” Arcebek said. “Unless your people wear their skin over their shirts.”

Point.

He tugged the gambeson up, exposing his side.

There should have been a ragged cut and swelling at the very least. Instead, his skin was unbroken, marked only by a faint patch of redness. No scab. No bruise.

Arcebek went very still.

“…Huh,” she said.

She brushed the spot with careful fingers. Shade held himself still. He was accustomed to hands that struck, restrained, or tested him—not hands that touched without demanding anything.

“No puncture. No dead tissue. No stiffness.” Her voice shifted into the brisk precision of a healer's. “You're not even bruised. How do you feel?”

“Fine,” Shade said. “A little sore from the impact. That is all.”

“Harpy venom attacks the nerves,” she said, thinking aloud. “Dwarves feel it despite our resistance. Humans drop. Elves lose their balance. You throw a harpy into her friends and walk away.”

“It was lighter than the stone sled,” Shade said.

Her eyes flicked up to meet his. The corner of her mouth quirked.

“I bet it was,” she said softly.

She leaned back and studied him rather than the wound. Shade wondered whether she could see the weight of the bones and strength beneath his borrowed human skin.

“You're not blessed by the Stonefather or the Lady of Wind,” she said. “Their marks feel different.” Her head tilted. “There's something wrapped around you. Something old. Heavy. Nothing like my patron.”

The bracelet on Shade’s wrist gave a collective, imperceptible flinch.

“I am… from far away,” he said carefully.

“I noticed,” Arcebek said. “You move like you think gravity is a suggestion.”

She reached for his gambeson. Suddenly her face was close enough that he felt her breath against his collarbone. The lamplight caught the red of her lips.

Ifret’s stone pulsed once, inappropriately approving.

“You’re interesting, Shade,” she said quietly.

He swallowed. “That is… not usually the word used.”

“Dangerous, then?” she suggested. “Unsettling? Unnatural?”

“Frequently,” he admitted.

She smiled, slow and just a little wicked.

“I like interesting,” she said.

He had faced armies with fewer doubts than this conversation inspired. Courtship manuals offered advice about hoards and wingspans. Neither seemed helpful.

“I am… glad?” he tried.

Arcebek laughed again, that low, delighted sound.

“You’re terrible at this,” she said, not unkindly.

“Yes,” Shade said with relief. “Very.”

She handed him his gambeson. “Good news: you won't die of delayed venom. Bad news: you've ruined my excuse to keep you half-undressed.”

Buyakugan’s crystal cracked so sharply he worried the others could hear it.

“That is… perhaps for the best,” Shade said, dragging the gambeson back down with intense focus.

“Mm.” She watched him a moment more, then stepped back. “Sleep, Shade. We have spiders to murder in the morning. Try not to dream about harpies.”

“I do not usually dream about… harpies,” he said.

“What do you usually dream about?” she asked.

“Falling,” he said before he could stop himself.

For a heartbeat her teasing fell away. “Then perhaps tonight you'll dream about landing instead.”

She turned away to sort her own gear, braid swaying.

Shade sorted his armor in exacting silence. Jerrin and Lysa whispered across the room, stealing glances at him and Arcebek. Varinel pretended to sleep, although one pointed ear was turned unmistakably their way.

The evening was no easier.

Downstairs, Arcebek seemed to enjoy testing the limits of his composure. She asked questions that edged toward the truth and smiled when his answers became tangled. There was nothing cruel in her attention, only a confidence he had no idea how to answer.

He fetched water he did not need, helped the innkeeper move barrels, and spent several minutes considering the structural merits of the ceiling.

Yet whenever her hand brushed his arm or her shoulder touched his, he found he wanted her to stay.

He went to sleep eventually on a bedroll against the wall, armor stacked neatly beside him, staring up into the dark.

The gods in his bracelet were mercifully silent.

✦ ✦ ✦

Spiders, at least, were less complicated.

Mossford’s reeve was a thin, rope-muscled woman with deep lines around her mouth. She took one look at the guild letter, another at Shade, and decided to focus on the letter.

“They’ve been coming from the old quarry,” she said, jabbing a finger at a rough map on her table. “First just webs on the edges. Then sheep went missing. Then my brother’s dog. Yesterday they dragged off a calf in broad daylight. If you can burn the nest out, I don’t care what you do to the stone.”

“Burning we can do,” Arcebek said.

“Careful with ‘burn,’” Varinel put in. “Dry brush all over. Last thing we need is a forest fire.”

Arcebek rolled her eyes. “Smother, then. Or melt. We’ll improvise.”

Shade listened. This was why he had come: to watch mortals turn a threat into a plan rather than solve it by overwhelming force.

They reached the quarry by midmorning. Grey and brown stone stepped down into a pit half-filled with murky water. Abandoned tools rusted under thick webs that hung like dirty snow, growing denser around a dark tunnel at the far end.

Jerrin made a face. “Ugh. They’re big, aren’t they?”

Lysa smacked a fat spider the size of her hand off her sleeve with the flat of her bow. “Depends what you mean by big.”

“They’re big enough,” Varinel said. “Keep your heads. Shade, you’re front with me. Jerrin, shield Lysa if anything gets past. Arcebek—”

“I know,” she said. “Stay behind the steel, make things explode, try not to set everyone on fire.”

He grunted. “Good.”

Shade drew his sword. Against cave spiders, it felt almost unfair.

Cave spiders were dangerous to the careless, the unarmed, and the isolated. This party was none of those things.

With Shade and Varinel holding the front, creatures that burst from the cracks fell beneath steel. Arcebek's molten bolts tore through clusters along the walls, burning holes in web and chitin.

She cast with practiced economy, forming words in a harsh, beautiful tongue as sigils brightened at her throat and wrists. Shade caught himself watching her. He turned back just before a spider found the gap beside his greave.

Jerrin and Lysa fought bravely, though they still flinched when spiders dropped from above. Shade intervened where necessary, cutting legs and bodies with measured precision. For him the work resembled a training exercise; for the others, every step was earned.

They found the nest in a hollow off the main tunnel: a swollen, glistening mass of webbing heavy with egg sacs. It pulsed faintly, which no one appreciated.

“Absolutely not,” Arcebek said.

Arcebek answered with a spell unlike the fire she had used before: a dense wave of bronze light that rolled over the nest. Web and egg sacs blackened into brittle husks. The stench drove several larger spiders from their crevices and straight onto Shade's sword.

They checked the remaining tunnels, cleared stragglers, and made certain nothing alive still hid in the webs.

“Take the sacs near the entrance,” Varinel said when they were done, wiping ichor off his blade with a grimace. “Proof for the reeve. And a couple of big fangs if you can find them. Apothecaries pay for those.”

Lysa, nose wrinkled, gingerly hacked down a cluster of desiccated egg husks, stuffing them into a sack. Jerrin pried loose a pair of glossy black fangs from one of the larger corpses.

Shade gathered the remains with the others, though his instincts protested. An heir of the Blue Flight, collecting spider parts? His mother's voice supplied the answer: You will start at the bottom. It will build character.

He picked spiders.

✦ ✦ ✦

When they returned to Mossford, the afternoon light was fading. Mud coated their boots; webbing clung to nearly everything else.

The reeve met them in the square.

“Well?” she demanded.

Varinel nodded to Lysa, who held up the sack. The reeve peeked inside, winced, and shut it again fast.

“That’ll do,” she said. “I’ll have the boys check the quarry for strays, but if those are gone, we’re likely clear.”

She produced a small wooden board with the guild’s symbol burned into it and a bit of ink.

“Hold still,” she said.

She scrawled a few lines: Mossford, spiders culled, no further sightings. Then pressed her thumb in ink and stamped it under the words.

“Take that back to your hall,” she said, handing the board to Arcebek. “They’ll settle the rest.”

“Thank you,” Arcebek said. “If you have more trouble, send another notice.”

“Hope I never see your kind here again,” the reeve said gruffly. “No offense. Just means something’s gone wrong if I do.”

“None taken,” Varinel said. “If you see harpies instead, send word to the road wardens. They’re sniffing around.”

The reeve grimaced. “Wonderful. I’ll tell the hunters to keep their eyes open. Safe travels, then.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They left Mossford with the reeve's signed proof wrapped in cloth inside Arcebek's pack.

The return journey was quieter. Jerrin and Lysa had exhausted their conversation. Varinel appeared fractionally less offended by the world now that everyone had survived. Arcebek hummed a tune Shade did not recognize.

“How’s the side?” she asked at one point, falling into step beside him again.

“Healed,” he said. “As you observed.”

“Any soreness? Weakness?” she pressed.

“No.”

“Shame,” she said lightly. “Would’ve given me an excuse to fuss over you again.”

He stumbled over a rock he absolutely should have seen.

“I do not require… fussing,” he said.

“Everyone requires fussing sometimes,” she said. “Even walking siege engines.”

He had no argument for that.

Greenhollow's fields rose ahead as evening settled in. Lanterns were being lit along the main street when the guildhall finally came into view.

Something in Shade eased. They had left as five strangers and returned as a party. He had followed orders, protected the others, and never once needed to force his seals.

It was ordinary work: spiders, mud, proof of completion. And Arcebek's fingers against skin where a wound should have been.

He touched the guild card at his belt pouch, then the bracelet.

The stones were quiet, balanced. Ifret a low ember, Buyakugan a faint hum, Terra steady, Fenris cool, Djing & Djang flickering with the shifting breeze.

Day two, he thought. Still standing.

He followed them toward the guildhall, the reeve's proof safe in Arcebek's pack and her presence beside him a pleasant mystery he had no idea how to solve.

Chapter 6: A Party of Two

The guildhall felt different with cobwebs still caught in their hair and a completed job behind them.

They arrived as the evening crowd began to swell. Dice clattered across tables, and arguments over pay and monsters rose above the noise.

Varinel headed straight for the front desk, the proof board tucked beneath his arm. Arcebek kept pace with him. Behind them, Jerrin and Lysa were still caught somewhere between exhaustion and triumph.

Shade followed, spider ichor dried into the joints of his scuffed armor, his greatsword resting comfortably across his back.

Lana did not look up until Varinel set the board in front of her.

“Mossford job,” he said. “Quarry spiders. Nest cleared, no casualties, minor delay due to harpies on the road.”

“Harpies,” she repeated. “Of course.” She scanned the report, rubbing a thumb over the reeve’s seal. “Any bites? Casualties?”

“None,” Varinel said. “They tried. Failed.”

Her gaze flicked toward Shade. “Good. I’ll flag the east road and have someone investigate the nests. Payment in an hour; we’re backed up.”

“Fine,” Arcebek said. “We’re not going anywhere tonight.”

Lana nodded, then turned her attention to Shade.

“And you. Provisional Bronze.” She opened a smaller ledger. “You came back alive, kept the party intact, and Grig hasn’t written ‘liability’ beside your name.” She struck through provisional. “Congratulations. You’re an adventurer.”

Something settled inside Shade. The title had been granted by someone who knew nothing of his birth or the wars he had fought, and yet it felt earned.

“Thank you,” he said.

Lana slid a small leather tag across the counter. The guild sigil marked one side; a rough but legible Shade — Bronze marked the other. A tiny rune tingled through his glove.

“That’s your hall token,” she said. “Gets you in the side door after hours, marks you as a member if the guards get twitchy. Try not to lose it; they’re a pain to replace.”

He fastened it beside the bracelet. The five chains chimed against the new token.

“Now find yourself a regular party,” Lana said, reaching for another ledger. “We don’t recommend solo work at Bronze. It tends to end in paperwork.”

“He’s already got one,” Arcebek said.

Shade turned his head. “I do?”

She gave him a smile that held equal measures of mischief and calculation.

“You don’t have a permanent team. I did, until a troll ate half of it and the survivors decided marrying bakers sounded better than another disemboweling.”

She shrugged. “Since then I’ve taken whichever party needs a warlock. Inefficient.”

Her gaze travelled from his armor to his sword, then lingered on the side where the harpy had wounded him.

“You’re absurdly strong, poison apparently disagrees with you, and you can follow an order without arguing.” Her eyes rose to his helm. “Besides, you’re interesting.”

His mouth had gone dry. “I have little experience forming parties. I would not want to hinder—”

“You made spiders boring. That’s an accomplishment.” She tilted her head. “And if you get yourself killed, I’d rather be there to stop it. Or at least complain about it.”

“If that’s not friendship, I don’t know what is,” Varinel muttered.

Lana looked from Arcebek’s expression to Shade’s rigid posture and sighed. He could almost hear her calculating the paperwork.

“I can register you as a provisional team. Arcebek of the Bronze Circle and Shade—just Shade. You’ll receive joint postings. But if either of you comes crying to me about the other, I’ll separate you myself.”

Arcebek’s gaze stayed on Shade. “Well?” she asked. “Want to be my sword arm, Skyfall?”

The bracelet tugged in five directions. Ifret flared her approval; Terra offered a warning rumble; Fenris seemed resigned. Buyakugan crackled with delight, while Djing and Djang could scarcely contain themselves.

He knew it was unwise. A permanent companion meant questions, attachments, and no place to hide. Especially a warlock with fire in her eyes.

“Yes,” he said before he could reconsider.

Her smile widened, slow and satisfied. “Good.”

Lana entered their names with the expression of a woman signing away her peace. “Done. Try not to make me regret it.”

“Oh, we absolutely will,” Arcebek said cheerfully. “Just not tonight. Tonight we celebrate.”

Jerrin perked up. “We’re invited too, right?”

“You carried proof sacks,” Arcebek said. “You’re in.”

Lysa whooped. Varinel sighed but didn’t argue.

✦ ✦ ✦

The inn nearest the guild was exactly what Brannoc had promised: low beams, sticky tables, stale ale, and chairs that looked accustomed to flying across the room.

Shade’s armor drew stares as he ducked inside. So did Arcebek, though those stares tended to end when their owners noticed how she carried herself.

They claimed a corner table. Tankards arrived, followed by coarse bread, a dubious stew, and a bowl of vegetables that appeared to have surrendered some time ago.

“To Mossford,” Jerrin said, raising his drink.

“To spiders that die quickly,” Lysa added.

“To pay,” Varinel said.

“To not dragging paralyzed idiots home,” Arcebek said, her eyes flicking briefly to Shade.

Shade hesitated, then lifted his own tankard. “To… not falling,” he said quietly.

Arcebek studied him over the rim of her tankard before touching it to his.

The evening blurred, though not for any reason alcohol could claim.

Jerrin and Lysa grew louder with every drink, arguing over which of them had killed more spiders. Varinel drank in grim silence, as though trying to outlast a memory. Arcebek took her time with each tankard and watched the room through half-lidded eyes.

Shade discovered that alcohol had almost no effect on him. His body burned it away as fast as he swallowed, leaving only a little warmth and none of the haze settling over the others.

Unfortunately, he remained painfully aware of Arcebek.

Her braid brushed his arm when she leaned close. Her teeth flashed when she laughed. Between stories, she slipped questions into the conversation so deftly he sometimes answered before recognizing them.

“So what did you do before deciding ‘monster hunter’ was a good life choice?”

“I trained.”

“With who?”

“Demanding tutors.”

“Military? Temple?”

“…Independent.”

“Did they teach you to throw harpies?”

“Yes.”

She snorted. “I want to meet these tutors. Or at least send them a fruit basket. You’re useful.”

At one point, a pair of brash-looking adventurers from another table drifted over, drawn by Arcebek’s laugh.

“Didn’t know the Bronze Circle was recruiting,” one said with a grin. “You ditching us for a new boytoy, Bek?”

Shade had killed enemies for less. He kept his hand still around his tankard.

Arcebek’s smile sharpened. “I’m upgrading. Now run along before my new boytoy decides to test how far you can fly.”

They withdrew under Shade’s unblinking stare.

“You didn’t have to say ‘boytoy,’” he said when they were gone.

“I didn’t say I was talking about you,” she said. “Maybe I meant Jerrin.”

Jerrin, who had his face in his arms at the table, made a faint, confused noise.

Shade opened his mouth, recognized the trap, and closed it again. Arcebek laughed and bumped his shoulder.

“Relax, Shade,” she said. “If I wanted to embarrass you, I’d do it in ways that didn’t involve idiots with more ego than sense.”

He was not certain that helped.

✦ ✦ ✦

By closing time, Jerrin and Lysa were leaning on each other and giggling. Varinel had gone upstairs earlier, muttering about children and headaches.

“We should get you back to the bunkhouse,” Shade said. “You require rest.”

Arcebek shook her head, braid swinging. “Bunkhouse is full of snorers and fleas. I’m at the Broken Anvil.”

“The Broken what?” Jerrin mumbled.

“Different inn.” Arcebek rose, not quite as steady as before, but still composed. “Better beds. Less chance of waking with a knife in your ribs. Usually.”

She turned to Shade. “You’re coming.”

“I have lodging,” Shade said. “Guild bunkhouse.”

“Which is full of drunk Bronze idiots,” she said. “You want to sleep? Or spend all night listening to them argue about who peed in whose boots?”

He considered the bunkhouse. It had been noisy even before anyone began arguing about boots.

“I prefer sleep,” he admitted.

“Good,” she said, and closed a hand around his wrist.

The bracelet chimed at her touch. Buyakugan sent a single amused spark along the chain.

Arcebek tugged him toward the door. “Come on, Skyfall. You can walk me to my inn. Try not to look like you’re escorting me to an execution.”

Outside, the streets smelled of woodsmoke and rain-damp stone. Arcebek knew every turn through Greenhollow’s lantern-lit lanes, and Shade found himself shortening his stride to match hers.

“Why do you call me Skyfall?” he asked after a time.

“You fell out of the sky,” she said. “Onto goblins. It fits.”

“It seems… revealing.”

“Only if someone connects the dots,” she said. “Most people don’t like dots. They prefer lines someone else already drew for them.”

The Broken Anvil was a considerable improvement: stone-faced, solidly built, with polished panels and a sign carved into the shape of a split anvil. Warm light spilled from a quiet common room.

Arcebek nodded to the night clerk, who knew her well enough not to question the armored giant following her upstairs.

“Second floor,” she said. “You can take the guest cot. I’m not sending you across town after a day of spider webs and poison.”

“I am not fragile,” Shade said.

“No,” she said. “But I’ll sleep better if I know where you are.”

That silenced him more effectively than any command.

Her room was small but comfortable: a bed, chest, washstand, and single chair. Strange metal charms hung by the window; several books teetered on the chest. There was little wasted space.

She pointed at the narrow cot against the wall. “There. Armor off. Try to occupy less than the whole floor.”

He removed his armor piece by piece, placing each plate with care. She watched without comment. The gods at his wrist seemed calm, though Shade himself could not say the same.

The cot creaked beneath him, considered its options, and held.

Arcebek paused between the door and her bed. Lamplight warmed her bronze skin and caught the copper rings in her dark braid.

“If you snore,” she said softly, “I’ll set your pillow on fire.”

“I do not think I snore,” he said.

“We’ll find out,” she murmured.

For an instant neither spoke. The silence felt more charged than the lightning trapped on Shade’s wrist.

Then Arcebek gave an exaggerated sigh and retreated to her bed.

“Good night, Shade,” she said. “Try not to dream about spiders.”

“Good night, Arcebek. I will attempt to dream of fewer legs.”

She laughed, extinguished the lamp, and slipped beneath the covers. In the dark, the rustle of blankets and the soft thump of her braid against the headboard felt unexpectedly intimate.

Shade lay awake listening until her breathing slowed.

The stones kept their own quiet counsel: Ifret warm, Buyakugan restless, Terra steady, Fenris cool, and Djing and Djang stirring like a breeze caught indoors.

He slept.

✦ ✦ ✦

Pale light and the smell of baking bread greeted Shade when he woke. He was alert before his eyes fully opened.

Arcebek sat by the window, unbraiding and reweaving her hair with practiced fingers. Without her traveling gear she looked different to him—not less formidable, but less guarded.

“Morning,” she said, fingers moving through her hair with practiced ease. “You don’t snore. Disappointing.”

“I apologize,” Shade said.

“Come on. Let’s make this official before you wander back to the bunkhouse and disappear beneath a heap of sweaty Bronze recruits.”

He donned his armor again while she finished her braid. They went downstairs together.

The innkeeper, a stout woman with iron-grey hair, looked up from a ledger heavy enough to serve as a club.

“Bek,” she said. “You bring me trouble?”

“Always,” Arcebek said. “This time in a more literal shape.” She gestured at Shade. “He needs a room. Long-term. Put him on my floor.”

The innkeeper assessed his height, breadth, and the probable cost of replacing anything he touched.

“Three silver a night,” she said. “Four if he insists on keeping that sword inside.”

Shade reached for his coin pouch. Arcebek’s hand landed lightly on his wrist.

“Weekly rate,” she said. “He’ll be here a while. And you know the guild pays its tabs.”

The innkeeper narrowed her eyes, then sighed. “Fine. Two and a half per night if he stays at least a month. Breakfast included. No smashing doors.”

“I do not usually smash doors,” Shade said.

“Yet,” the innkeeper replied.

Arcebek gave his wrist a brief squeeze. “You can afford it. And when a job comes in, I’ll know where to find you.”

“And other reasons,” the innkeeper muttered.

Arcebek shot her a look; the woman only smirked and reached for a key.

“Next to yours?” she asked.

Arcebek drew a breath. Desire and caution crossed her face so quickly Shade might have imagined both.

“Next to mine,” she decided.

She took the key and pressed it into Shade’s hand.

“Second floor,” she said. “Third door on the left. Mine’s fourth. Try not to mix them up unless you mean to.”

The key was warm from her fingers. He closed his hand around it.

“Thank you,” he said. “For… arranging this.”

“Don’t thank me yet,” Arcebek said. “You’ve just made it very easy for me to drag you out of bed at dawn when a job hits the board.”

“I rise early,” he said. “That will not be a problem.”

For once, her smile carried a hint of shyness.

“Of course you do,” she said. “Come on, Skyfall. Let’s show the guild we survived spiders and each other. Then we see what the board has for a brand new party.”

He followed her into the street, his new key resting heavily in his palm. A room beside hers. It should have been an ordinary arrangement.

Every instinct warned him against it.

He walked beside her anyway.

Chapter 7: The Library

The notice board offered little encouragement.

Shade stood beside Arcebek in the crowded hall, studying notices mostly stamped taken. Those left unclaimed were scarcely worth the ink.

“Escort drunk merchant to next town,” Arcebek read. “Hard pass.”

“Rat infestation,” Shade said, tilting his head at another. “Is that truly a guild-level threat?”

“Only if the rats are on fire,” she said. “And even then…”

Silver-tier hunts and expeditions crowded the upper board, beyond the reach of their newly registered Bronze party. At the front desk, Lana dismissed yet another adventurer trying to argue his way into a higher-ranked contract.

“So… nothing,” Arcebek sighed. “At least nothing that won’t pay in ‘exposure’ and complaints.”

Shade considered the board. “We are to… wait?”

“Welcome to adventuring,” she said. “Half screaming death, half sitting on your hands until someone notices a problem big enough to pay for.”

The waiting unsettled him. Dragons could spend centuries pursuing a plan, but that patience came more easily in an aerie than in a hall thick with sweat, ale, and other people’s arguments.

“Come on.” Arcebek bumped his shoulder with hers. “If we’re stuck in town, I might as well show you where things are. You keep saying you need to ‘understand the world.’ That doesn’t happen standing in front of a job board.”

He hesitated only a moment, then nodded. “Lead the way.”

✦ ✦ ✦

By daylight, Greenhollow scarcely resembled the town Shade had first entered at dusk.

Arcebek led him through the market square, past root vegetables piled in wicker baskets, bright fabric, cheap trinkets, and a fishmonger shouting himself hoarse. One woman sold charms woven from straw and colored glass.

“These are… protective?” Shade asked, picking one up.

“Supposed to be.” Arcebek shrugged. “Most of them do nothing. A few are real, usually by accident. If you ever feel one hum, tell me before you put it on and wake up cursed or married.”

“I will endeavour to avoid both,” he said.

At the smithy, Shade lingered to watch a broad human and a slender dwarf hammer glowing steel. The dwarf glanced up, measured his greatsword with one look, and nodded with a smith’s professional respect.

“Stay away from her if you like money,” Arcebek murmured. “She’ll talk you into re-forging that monstrosity ‘for your own good’ and charge you triple.”

“Her technique seems sound,” Shade said, eyes lingering on the clean strikes, the way she folded the steel.

“Oh, it is,” Arcebek agreed. “That’s the problem.”

She pointed out the important temples—Stonefather, Lady of Wind, a small shrine to a river spirit—and the less important ones—gods of luck, dice, and not getting caught cheating.

He measured each shrine against the powers bound to his bracelet. Terra stirred near the Stonefather’s hall; Djing and Djang tugged at the wind shrine; Fenris took notice of the river. Ifret and Buyakugan remained silent.

“And this,” Arcebek said at last, stopping in front of a squat, two-story building squeezed between a scrivener’s shop and a candle-maker, “is the place you’re going to love or fear.”

A wooden placard hung over the door: an open book, inked in faded black.

“Library,” she said.

Shade studied the sign. The simple image of an open book stirred something close to excitement.

“You have a library,” he said, as though she had revealed a hidden treasury.

“Most towns don’t,” Arcebek said. “Greenhollow thinks it’s clever. Caravan stop, minor trade hub, all that. So they keep records, maps, and a few shelves of things people thought were worth writing down.”

She pushed the door open.

Inside was… quiet. Blessed, soothing quiet.

Inside, silence surrounded them. Shelves lined the walls and formed neat rows through the middle; scrolls, ledgers, and bound volumes occupied every available space. At a central table, two apprentices copied text by lamplight.

The air smelled of ink, leather, and dust warmed by sun through the high windows.

Shade breathed more easily. This, at least, was a place he understood.

A thin man wearing round spectacles looked up from the desk. Surprise at Shade’s armor gave way at once to a librarian’s suspicion.

“No weapons on the tables,” he said sharply. “No open flames. No food. No drink. No loud voices. And if you bend a page, I will personally feed you to whatever’s on the far back shelf that we don’t talk about.”

“I will… not bend any pages,” Shade said solemnly.

The man gave a satisfied grunt and returned to his catalog.

Arcebek smirked. “Welcome to the other kind of temple,” she whispered. “Go on, then. See what catches your eye. I’ll be over there wondering why I brought you here when I could have used the time to nap.”

Shade moved between the shelves almost reverently.

Local histories. Trade records. A treatise on Verdan’s weather. Half a shelf devoted to the beasts of Greenwood, illustrated with creatures of increasingly questionable anatomy. He ran careful fingers along the spines, reading each title.

He picked a book at random—A Brief History of the Kingdom of Lyran—and opened it.

The writing differed slightly from the script he had studied, but the structure was familiar. After a few lines, he found the rhythm and began to read.

Pages turned beneath his fingers. Dates, battles, dynasties that rose and fell in what seemed to him only a few centuries. The scale was startlingly intimate.

He finished the book, closed it, and realized he wanted more.

Three more appeared in his hands in quick succession: On the Major Faiths of Aleris, Bestiaries of the Eastern Marches, A Survey of Known Planar Events.

He devoured them, comparing their accounts of gods, planes, and monsters with what he knew. The contradictions intrigued him most. Here, the elemental powers appeared under different names and in stories that scarcely resembled the beings on his wrist.

At some point, Arcebek dropped into the chair opposite him.

“You’ve been very quiet,” she said.

He looked up. Afternoon sunlight slanted through the windows. One apprentice had fallen asleep over a scroll.

Arcebek had brought a book of her own, though she seemed to have spent more time watching him than reading.

“You’ve read four,” she said.

“Yes.”

“In… about two hours.”

“Yes.”

She rested her chin on one hand. “Did you read them, or were you merely turning pages to impress me?”

“I am reading them,” he said. “They are… interesting.”

“Most people take a week to chew through ‘Major Faiths,’” she said. “You just inhaled it.”

“I hoard knowledge,” he said—and immediately regretted his choice of words.

Her eyes lit faintly. “Do you, now?”

“My tutors insisted,” he added. “There were many books. And long winters.”

“Long winters make scholars,” she murmured. “Or madmen. Sometimes both.”

He looked down at his hands. “I do not always know the difference.”

“You’re doing fine, Shade. Especially for someone who didn't know the name of this world a week ago.”

He touched the books. “They help. I can see how your histories fit together. How your gods are understood. The scale of your wars.”

“Our wars,” she corrected.

He went still.

“You’re here now,” she said. “You’re adventuring, reading our boring histories, complaining about job boards. That makes them your wars too. At least a little.”

He considered her words while the stones at his wrist lay quiet.

“I will… keep that in mind,” he said.

“Good. Now come on, hoarder. The librarian is about to throw us out, and I’m hungry enough to eat the paperwork on my pact.”

The librarian was indeed approaching with a stack of volumes and a stare that suggested the books were his favored children.

Shade returned each book to its place, already making plans to come back for the planar surveys—and perhaps a volume on local law.

Outside, the sky was sliding toward evening, clouds tinted orange and pink. The market had begun to thin; stall owners packed up their wares, shouted last prices.

“Food,” Arcebek declared. “Then sleep. Then we pray to whatever bits of Ifret and Fenris are listening that tomorrow someone notices a ghoul in their cellar and pays us to remove it.”

“Do you often… depend on prayer for work?” Shade asked as they walked.

“No,” she said. “I depend on rich people doing stupid things. It’s more reliable. But praying gives you something to do with your hands while you wait.”

They ended up at a quieter inn this time, one Arcebek claimed had “edible food and beer that doesn’t taste like regret.” The stew was better than Mossford’s; the bread didn’t fight back.

Jerrin and Lysa were elsewhere, probably boasting of a spider nest that grew larger with every telling. Varinel was likely drinking alone in some ill-lit corner.

It was peaceful. Shade was surprised by how little he minded.

Arcebek supplied gossip, a disastrous teleportation into a chicken coop, and an argument with a priest over whether pact magic counted as proper magic. Shade listened more than he spoke.

“And what about you?” she asked at one point, pushing her empty bowl away. “Apart from reading everything that sits still, what do you actually… enjoy?”

He blinked. “Enjoy?”

“Yes,” she said. “Fun. Pleasure. Things that aren’t training or not dying.”

No one had ever asked him that without expecting an answer useful to a negotiation, a duty, or a campaign.

“I like… flying,” he said before he could swallow it.

Her brows rose. “Flying?”

He scrambled. “Metaphorically,” he amended. “Speed. Freedom. Seeing how things connect from… above.”

It wasn’t entirely a lie.

“Hmm.” She took a sip of her drink. “Might have to get you on an airship someday. See what you do with a view.”

He pictured an airship rising above the clouds while the stones on his wrist strained against the remembered freedom of flight. Longing and dread came together.

“I would… like that,” he said quietly.

Arcebek watched him, then let the subject rest.

They returned to the Broken Anvil in easy silence. Lanterns swayed in a cool breeze, and Djing and Djang stirred appreciatively.

At the inn, Arcebek paused at the foot of the stairs.

“Tomorrow,” she said, “we hit the board again. If there’s still nothing, I’m dragging you back to the library. I want to see if you can break the librarian’s composure by finishing his entire religion section in a week.”

“That seems… unkind,” Shade said.

“Think of it as a test,” she said. “For both of you.”

Shade laughed under his breath.

“Good night, Arcebek,” he said.

“Good night, Shade,” she replied. “Dream of something other than falling and spiders. Maybe books this time.”

“Books are acceptable,” he said.

She shook her head, smiling, and headed up to her room.

Shade climbed to his own, key warm in his hand, the faint noise of the inn below fading as he shut the door behind him.

No contracts, but progress: a town taking shape in his mind, a library waiting to be explored, and a warlock who noticed far too much yet still chose his company.

He sat on the bed and unbuckled his armor while the last daylight faded from the window.

“Tomorrow,” he murmured to the quiet room, to the gods on his wrist. “Maybe something more.”

Ifret’s stone glowed faintly, as if in agreement.

Chapter 8: The Goblin Horde

Work found them the following morning.

A crowd had formed around the guild notice board. Lana stood beside a newly posted map, arms crossed and jaw tight. Someone had marked a red circle far to the east.

“Village of Brackenridge,” she was saying. “Near the old border forts. Scouts from the roadwardens spotted a goblin host moving through the woods—too organized, too many. Not a raid band. Could be a horde forming.”

At the word horde, the hall fell quiet.

Arcebek worked her way to the front, Shade following. “Range? Numbers? Distance?”

Lana glanced their way. “Best estimate: a few hundred, plus beasts. Direction puts them within striking distance of Brackenridge in a week or two if they don’t change course. Maybe less if there’s something driving them.”

“Any sign of what?” Shade asked.

“The scouts preferred to keep their heads attached,” Lana replied. “If you want to get closer, volunteer.”

Arcebek studied the map, fingers drumming on her belt. “Brackenridge sent for help?”

“Two letters.” Lana nodded toward the broken seals on the desk. “The village isn’t wealthy, but they’ve scraped together enough for a contract. We’re building a mixed-rank response. Meanwhile, I need Bronze parties on the road—scouting, warnings, and any smaller threats they can clear safely.”

She fixed Shade and Arcebek with that sharp administrative gaze. “You two wanted work? You’ve got it. One week’s travel if you don’t dawdle. You, Skyfall, can probably carry the other half of your party when they get tired.”

“I will not carry Varinel,” Shade said automatically.

“Good,” Lana said. “He bites.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They left at noon, supplied for the journey and less cheerful than they had been the day before.

The same five traveled together: Varinel leading; Jerrin and Lysa quieter after their first mission; Arcebek and Shade keeping to the middle and rear. They moved faster now and watched the road more carefully.

A few goblins could harry a farm. Hundreds, moving with purpose, could empty villages and burn the harvest before anyone thought to send help.

The eastern road narrowed as settled fields gave way to scrub, then dense woodland and stretches of bleak heath.

The nights grew cold enough to turn their breath white. They kept the fire low and shared watches.

On the third night, they camped in a hollow between two hills, their fire hidden from the road by boulders. Jerrin and Lysa collapsed into sleep beneath their blankets. Varinel took the first watch a short distance from the light.

Shade rested against a boulder, his armor set aside but his greatsword within reach. Firelight caught the five stones on his bracelet.

Arcebek dropped onto the log beside him, a bowl of stew in her hands.

“Trade you,” she said.

He looked from her bowl to his untouched one. “For… what?”

“Company,” she said. “You look like you’re about to overthink the stars.”

“I do not overthink stars. They tend to be reliable.”

“Mm.” She ate a spoonful, made a face, and kept eating anyway. “Goblin hordes aren’t, though. Lana wouldn’t have posted it if she didn’t think it could turn ugly.”

“Do you expect many casualties?” he asked.

“I expect a mess. Half the reports will be wrong, someone in a comfortable town will dismiss it as ‘just goblins,’ and by the time they take it seriously, the rest of us will be sent to clean up. Or bury the dead.”

He watched the fire reflected in her eyes.

“Your people form hordes too?” he asked quietly. “Goblins, or other… tribes?”

She huffed. “Dwarves?”

“Yes.”

“We form work crews and grudges,” she said. “Close enough.” Then she shot him a sidelong look. “What about your people?”

He weighed his answer. “We do not… horde,” he said slowly. “We gather. Flights. Aeries. Territory. We do not swarm in the same way.” A beat. “Most of the time.”

“I’ll take that as a ‘yes, but differently,’” she said. “That seems to be your answer for everything.”

“It is often accurate,” he admitted.

Silence settled between them. The fire popped; beyond its light, Varinel shifted his weight.

After a while, Arcebek spoke again, voice a little lower. “Shade.”

“Yes?”

“How old are you, really?”

He thought of the long passage of seasons and the absurdity of trying to squeeze dragon years into a mortal measure.

“Old enough,” he said. “Young, for my kind. Not so young, for yours.”

She snorted. “So… somewhere between ‘just hatched’ and ‘pushing retirement’ by dwarf standards. Helpful.”

He almost smiled. “I am learning. About many things.”

“Oh, I’ve noticed,” she said. Her tone shifted—lighter on the surface, something sharper beneath. “Which brings me to a question I’ve been meaning to ask while the children are snoring and the elf is pretending not to listen.”

Varinel remained motionless, though Shade doubted the elf had missed a word.

Arcebek leaned back, bowl on her knees, eyes on the fire. “Have you had lovers before?”

Every stone on the bracelet fell still.

Shade blinked. “…That is a direct question.”

“Better than dancing around it for three weeks,” she said. “We’re walking into danger together. I’d like to know if I’m traveling with a complete innocent, a walking disaster area, or something in between.”

Shade stared into the flames. They were much easier to face than Arcebek.

“Yes,” he said at last. “I have… had lovers.”

“Plural,” she said. “Good. I won’t have to explain everything.”

Heat crept up his neck. “Nothing lasting. Arrangements. Meetings. Nothing that endured.”

“Why?” she asked. No judgment, just curiosity. “Bad choices? Wrong people? Or something else?”

He hesitated longer this time.

“…My position,” he said finally. “Did not allow it.”

“The work?” she pressed. “Or the expectations around it?”

“Both.” He kept his eyes on the flames. “Duty first. Always. Anything else was… distraction. Indulgence. Tolerated, sometimes encouraged, never meant to take root.”

The admission tasted bitter. His mother’s voice rose unbidden: You may warm your bed as you please, Shade. Just remember no one shares the Throne.

Arcebek let the silence stand.

“Ranks,” she said softly. “Titles. Responsibilities. People looking at you and seeing… functions. Not a person.”

“Yes,” he said.

She took another spoonful of stew. It had begun to congeal.

“Same,” she said.

He glanced at her.

“I’ve had lovers,” she said matter-of-factly. “On and off. Nothing long-term. Nothing that survived more than a season. Few months, a job, sometimes just a night.” Her mouth curled without humor. “Warlock. Pact-marked. Bronze Circle. Useful in a fight; dangerous to be seen standing too close to for too long, in case something from the other side decides proximity counts as consent.”

“That seems… unfair,” Shade said.

“World often is,” she said. “People like me, we’re good for heat and a little chaos. Not so good for ‘meet my parents’ or ‘settle down and have three kids and a bakery.’” She tipped her head, braid sliding over her shoulder. “Truth is, I never pushed it. Easier that way. No roots, no one to rip out when the job goes wrong.”

He pictured aeries hewn into mountain stone, guarded nests, and bloodlines recorded across generations.

“And now?” he asked quietly.

“And now I’m walking into goblin country with a man who throws harpies and reads theology for fun,” she said dryly. “And asking him about his past lovers by the fire like a bored noble.”

“You are not boring,” he said before he could stop himself.

She laughed, low and surprised. “Careful, Shade. Flattery might get you somewhere.”

“That was… not intended as flattery,” he said. “It was observation.”

“Even more dangerous,” she murmured.

She set her bowl aside and stretched her boots toward the heat. Firelight traced the sigils at her throat, suggesting words in a language Shade could not yet read.

“You regret any of them?” she asked, softer now. “The lovers. The not-lasting.”

Faces surfaced: a dragon-blooded sorcerer whose laughter recalled lightning, a scarred mortal knight, a half-blood who had taught him to kiss without showing his teeth.

“No,” he said slowly. “I regret… what I could not give any of them. Promises I never made. Futures I knew I would not… choose.”

She hummed, a quiet sound. “That’s almost honest.”

“It is… mostly honest,” he said.

“What about you?” he asked, surprising himself. “Do you regret any?”

“Some. Those where I stayed too long. Those where I left too soon.” She smiled without much humor. “And the ones who thought they could rescue me from my pact. Exhausting, every one.”

He wanted to ask if anyone had tried to save her from anything else—herself, her temper, her isolation. He didn’t.

Instead, he said, “You are not in need of saving.”

“Everyone’s in need of saving from something,” she said. “Even if it’s just their own worst habits.”

She turned from the fire to him. Its reflection brightened her eyes, but not all the warmth there came from the flames.

“And you?” she asked. “What do you want now, Shade? Lovers, no lovers, roots, none—what does someone in your… position… even get to want?”

The question stirred the gods at his wrist: Ifret eager, Buyakugan impatient, Terra cautious, Fenris still, Djing and Djang circling each other.

Duty. Power. Knowledge. The trial. His mother’s approval. His flight’s safety. He could have answered with any of them, and none would have been false.

But by this small fire, in a world where no one knew the weight of his titles, he found himself answering differently.

“I want… to see what I become when no one is telling me what that must be.”

Arcebek's breath caught.

“That,” she said, “is a terrifyingly honest answer.”

“I am… still learning how much honesty is allowed,” he said.

“With me? Quite a lot.” She smiled. “I like sharp edges. Just mind where you point them.”

“I will… attempt not to,” he said.

She rose then, dusting off her hands. “Get some sleep, Skyfall. We’ve got miles to cover tomorrow, and goblins to count. You can brood about lovers and destiny another night.”

“I was not brooding,” he said.

“You absolutely were,” she said, and there was affection under the teasing. “Don’t worry. It looks good on you.”

She rose to relieve Varinel on watch. Her braid swung against her back as she stepped beyond the firelight.

Shade rested his head against the stone and looked up at a sky he had not fallen through.

The fire crackled. Jerrin snored. Somewhere in the darkness, something many-legged scuttled away from the camp.

He glanced at the bracelet. The stones were calmer now.

“Nothing lasting,” he murmured, echoing both their words.

Ifret’s ember glowed, as if to say: We’ll see.

He closed his eyes and listened to the night. Goblins waited ahead. Beyond them lay a future he could no longer predict.

For the first time in years, that uncertainty felt like an invitation.

Chapter 9: Brackenridge

Brackenridge looked less like a village than an open wound.

A half-finished palisade surrounded it, rough logs sunk into churned mud. Thin smoke rose from chimneys and firepits; even the wood seemed rationed. Villagers watched from doorways and gaps between buildings, weighing the strangers with exhausted suspicion.

The reeve met them in the square: a broad man worn rope-thin, his grey-streaked beard framing a face hardened by too many sleepless nights. Hands once accustomed to a plough now bore the calluses of a spear haft.

“Greenhollow guild?” he asked. His gaze passed over Varinel and Jerrin, caught on Shade’s armor, then lingered uneasily on Arcebek’s sigils. “You have the writ?”

Arcebek handed it over. He scarcely glanced at the seal.

“They’re close,” he said. “Goblins. Tracks at the field edges. More prints in the ash every time we burn the brush. They’re not raiding. They’re counting.”

“Scouting,” Varinel said. “Testing the fences. Looking for the weak points.”

Marek worked his jaw. “We can put men on the walls. We have bows. What we don’t have is—”

A door slammed open across the square.

A woman stumbled into the square, apron stained, hair coming loose around her face. She caught the reeve by the arm with both hands.

“Marek,” she gasped. “They’re gone.”

The reeve—Marek—went stiff. “Who?”

“Elsa. Bren. The miller’s niece.” Her voice cracked. “They went for kindling in the lower copse. They never came back. We found—”

She held out a torn scrap of muddy cloth. The rest of the sentence would not come.

The air seemed to tighten around Shade.

Varinel swore. Beside him, Jerrin and Lysa fell silent.

“When?” Arcebek asked. The warmth had left her voice.

“This afternoon. While the sun was up. We called for them, searched everywhere.” The woman swallowed. “Tracks went toward the north ridge. Goblin tracks. I know what I saw.”

Marek shut his eyes, opened them, and faced Varinel. “Can you follow them? If there’s still a chance—”

“There’s a chance,” Varinel said. “If we move now.”

Varinel looked to Shade. “We may need those crate-moving talents of yours.”

Shade nodded once. His throat felt tight.

✦ ✦ ✦

The tracks were not subtle.

Even Shade could read the trail: heels gouging the earth, clusters of goblin prints pressed into damp soil, cloth snagged on thorns, a broken bead caught between roots.

The forest north of Brackenridge was older and darker than the woods around Greenhollow. Moss softened the ground; beneath its scent lurked something sour.

They moved at a near-run. Varinel led, alert to every shift in the brush. Arcebek kept pace without complaint. Jerrin and Lysa followed in grim silence.

Shade stayed a little apart, senses straining. Ifret smoldered at his wrist; Terra pressed like buried stone; Fenris watched with a winter's stillness. Buyakugan murmured like distant thunder, while Djing and Djang chased uneasy currents through the trees.

They reached the cave as the afternoon light thinned.

Its mouth opened black beneath the north ridge, framed by stones daubed with crude signs in blood and ash. Bones littered the approach. Most were animal. Not all.

The tracks went in.

"That smell," Jerrin whispered, covering his mouth.

Rot, sweat, old fires—and beneath them a sharp metallic tang.

"Goblins," Varinel said, nocking an arrow. "Possibly worse. Keep the light low. We need to see as much as they do."

Arcebek summoned a small orb of bronze-tinged light to her palm. It hovered over her fingers, casting long shadows.

"Quarry formation," Varinel whispered. "Shade, with me. Children, middle. Arcebek, be ready if we get pinned. Keep quiet and watch the side passages."

They went in.

The passage descended beneath a ceiling that forced Shade to duck. Slime slicked the rock; roots dangled like pale fingers. Each step took them deeper into the damp reek of an overcrowded den.

Goblins chittered somewhere ahead, the echoes impossible to place. They skirted a side chamber where smaller goblins slept in heaps. Varinel waved them past without a word. The captives mattered more.

Shade clenched his jaw until his teeth hurt.

They passed crude shrines—piles of bones, stones stacked and painted with handprints. A skull, human-sized, with candle stubs melted into its eyes.

Then came a sound no one could mistake: someone sobbing.

Human. Young. Struggling for breath between cries.

Jerrin flinched. Lysa's hand tightened on her bow.

Varinel swore under his breath. "There," he whispered, pointing.

The passage widened into a cavern. Goblin markings smeared the walls; stolen crates and household goods lay scattered beneath them.

Three figures were bound to a leaning post at its center.

Three girls.

One did not move. The other two trembled and wept, their clothes torn, bruises dark against their skin. A goblin sat by a small fire, turning the coals with a stick.

Shade's vision narrowed to the post.

The cave sounds seemed to recede. Arcebek's bronze light cast shadows too sharp to be real.

He knew what goblins could do to captives. He had read the accounts, and in other wars he had seen pits filled with the dead. He had watched dragonfire erase places like this and called it justice.

He had never stood so close to those still waiting to be saved.

The goblin glanced up at them.

Shade moved.

Shade crossed the cavern in three measured strides and took off its head.

The creature never rose from its rock.

Blood struck the post. One girl recoiled, checked by the ropes around her wrists.

"Shade," Arcebek hissed. "Wait—"

He heard Arcebek but could not make himself answer.

He wiped his blade on the goblin's tunic. Jerrin and Lysa were already working at the girls' knots, their hands shaking. Arcebek knelt beside them, her expression taut.

Varinel searched the cavern, his eyes moving from the captives to the passages beyond.

"Too quiet," he whispered.

Shade looked up.

The air prickled along Shade's neck. Djing and Djang rattled their crystal; Buyakugan sparked.

Ambush, he realized. Of course.

"Down!" he snapped, just as the first volley hit.

Darts, arrows and sharpened bone flew from cracks in the walls and openings overhead. For an instant, goblin eyes flashed in the dark.

Shade stepped into the volley. Missiles rang against his armor, but he could shield only one direction at a time.

A dart slipped beneath Arcebek's collar and grazed her neck. She tore it free with a curse and began a spell.

"Poison," Varinel spat, snapping a dart in his fingers. "Sleep—"

His knees buckled.

Jerrin collapsed over the bindings. Lysa sagged against the post. Varinel reached for cover, then fell behind a crate.

Arcebek finished one word. The next dissolved on her tongue. She swayed, hand pressed to her neck.

For Shade, the moment stretched unbearably.

Poison sweetened the damp air. Arcebek's stubborn dwarven blood resisted it, but the dose was far too strong.

She turned her head, swaying, and her gaze met his.

Her pupils widened. A thread of blood ran from the scratch on her neck.

"Shade—" she started.

He knew she was falling before her knees gave way.

Something shifted deep within him.

The girls had opened the fracture. Arcebek's collapse tore it wide.

The gods on his wrist roared.

Ifret exploded, ember becoming furnace. Buyakugan's crystal shattered light through its fractures, jagged and wild. Terra woke fully, a deep grinding of stone. Fenris surged, cold tide trying to contain fire. Djing and Djang screamed like a gale.

The bracelet scorched his skin. Its chains bit into his wrist.

The poison entered his blood and vanished against defenses older than this world. Sleep reached for his mind and found nothing it could hold.

He could yield. Let sleep take him and trust the seals to keep the rest contained.

He could do what he had been ordered to do.

Or—

Or he could break them.

Arcebek's body hit the ground, limp.

A sound escaped Shade's throat that no human mouth should have made.

The cave trembled.

His armor split across the shoulders as the body beneath it began to change. His spine lengthened; the cavern seemed to shrink around him.

Fire and lightning surged up his throat, through his teeth, down his arms, along bones suddenly remembering they had once been built for wings.

The bracelet's chains snapped taut, stones flaring, runes along the metal blazing in five colors at once. For a moment they held.

Last trump card, a voice gasped—his own, his mother's, one of the gods, he couldn't tell.

Then something gave.

Arcebek, halfway under the tide of sleep, saw the world tilt.

The last things she registered were impressions, not clear images.

Shade, not Shade. Larger, wrong, beautiful in the way storms were beautiful.

Eyes a killing blue-white, slit like a serpent's, light blazing from them.

Armor splitting as something scaled and massive shoved through—a taloned hand tipped in lightning, teeth too long for a human jaw, the suggestion of wings made of fire and storm cramped in a space far too small.

The sound of a roar, echoing off stone, that was not meant for mortal ears.

A wall of heat washing over her as blue-white fire poured past, not at her but over her, around her, like a curtain.

Stone split overhead.

The goblins screamed. Not for long.

Then the poison caught up, and the darkness that had been pressing at the edges of her vision finally won.

✦ ✦ ✦

Arcebek woke to smoke and bitter herbs.

Wattle and daub replaced the cave ceiling. Light filtered through an oiled-cloth shutter; low voices murmured nearby.

Her limbs ached with the distant, wrong soreness of magical exhaustion. Her throat felt scraped raw.

“Easy,” someone said. A hand—calloused, careful—slid under her shoulders, lifting her enough that a cup could be pressed to her lips. Water, just this side of cool. She drank greedily.

The hand belonged to a woman she didn’t know. Older than Arcebek, hair plaited tight, sleeves rolled up to reveal inked symbols of the River-Warder. A village healer, by the look and smell of her.

“You’ll live,” the woman said. “You all will. Barely.”

Arcebek fought to speak. “Shade.”

“Alive,” the healer said. “Sleeping. Like you were. Stronger stock, but even he can’t spit in the gods’ eye without paying a bit.”

Memory returned in fragments: the girls, the darts, Shade’s eyes.

“What… happened?” she rasped.

The healer hesitated, then glanced toward the doorway.

“Ask him,” she said.

Arcebek turned toward the door.

The room was larger than she’d first registered. Jerrin and Lysa lay on pallets nearby, pale but breathing, bandaged where rough stone or goblin knives had found them. Varinel sat on a stool between them, looking like a man who’d been carved from worry and old anger. His bow leaned against the wall.

And on the far side, near an open window where the air was a little cooler, Shade lay on a low bed.

Armor piled in a fused, half-melted heap nearby, scorched and twisted. He wore only a rough linen shirt and trousers someone had scrounged for him, the fabric strained over a frame that still felt a size too large for the room.

Shade's chest rose and fell evenly, but even in sleep he looked braced for another blow.

Arcebek sat up. Her muscles protested; the healer frowned but let her move.

"Let her," Varinel said quietly. "She was asking his name before she could say her own."

There was soot in Varinel's hair that washing had not removed. He looked years older.

"What happened?" Arcebek repeated.

Varinel's mouth tightened.

"The short version?" he said. "We got hit. You all went down. He didn't."

He rubbed a hand over his face, fingers digging into his eyes. "I don't remember all of it. Poison had me by the throat. But I was half-awake enough to hear the goblins start their little victory chant. Then I heard him."

"Him?" she said.

"Your pet walking catastrophe," Varinel said. "He… changed."

Arcebek felt a chill despite the warmth of the room.

"Changed how?" she asked, though she already knew.

Varinel met her gaze. For once, his bitterness concealed nothing.

"Like something out of the old stories," he said. "Fire and storm. Claws where his hands should be. Teeth. Too many teeth. He filled the cave in a way no man should. The goblins… stopped chanting very quickly."

"And the cave?" she asked.

The healer snorted softly. "Go look out the window," she said. "You'll see."

With effort, Arcebek swung her legs over the side of the pallet and stood. The floor swayed; she rode it out, one hand on the wall, and shuffled to the open window near Shade's bed.

The north ridge filled the window.

The cave entrance had vanished.

Half the hillside had slumped, fused into something dark and glassy. Stone that had once been layered and cold was now a smooth, black bulge, streaked with red where it still cooled. Wisps of steam drifted from cracks. Trees near the base were charred, leafless skeletons.

Heat still drifted from the fused rock, faint but unmistakable even at this distance.

"The ground shook," the healer said quietly behind her. "Like a quake. Then fire. We saw light through the cracks like the mountain had gone hollow. When it stopped, the goblins stopped with it."

She made a complicated sign over her chest. "We found you and your friends at the cave mouth. Unconscious. Burned in places, but not like them. He"—a glance at Shade—"was lying in front of you like a felled oak. Too hot to touch at first. I thought he'd die before he cooled."

Arcebek turned back to Shade.

Asleep, he looked younger. The lines of watchfulness had eased; soot smudged his jaw. A red mark circled his throat like the memory of a chain.

Then she noticed his wrist.

The bracelet had survived. Barely.

The metal was blackened in places, edges warped as if it had been submerged in molten rock and then yanked out again. The chains were dull, some links lumpy where they'd burned and been forced back into shape.

And the stones—

Ifret's shard was more crack than gem now, shot through with spiderweb fractures that glowed faintly, like magma under cooled crust. Buyakugan's crystal was chipped at the edges, a hairline fracture running from base to tip, little arcs of lightning crawling along it and vanishing. Terra's stone was intact but scarred, surface roughened, a long gouge along one side like something had tried to rip it out. Fenris' gem was clouded, as if trapped bubbles swirled inside. Djing and Djang's twin crystal had a new line splitting it further; the two halves quivered independently, never quite still.

They… pulsed when she looked at them. Not physically, but in the air. Like distant drums.

Shade stirred.

Shade opened his eyes.

For a heartbeat, she saw the dragon again—not fully, not with teeth and claws, but in the way his pupils narrowed against the light, the way something behind them looked out and measured the room, the village, the world.

Then he saw her, and the dragon retreated behind his familiar face.

"Arcebek," he said, voice rough.

"You melt one hill and that's how you say hello," she said. "Terrible manners."

He blinked. "You are… alive."

"Very," she said. "Annoyingly so, according to the healer." She gestured toward the ridge. "You did that, you know."

His head turned. He took in the fused rock, the steam, the broken trees.

The memories struck without warning.

The girls. The poisoned darts. Arcebek falling. The gods screaming. Then fire and stone, lightning, and goblin voices cut short.

His hand went to his wrist before he could stop it.

The bracelet burned cold under his fingers. The stones thrummed, each with a different feel—Ifret restless and sated, Buyakugan twitchy, Terra furious, Fenris disapproving, Djing and Djang dizzy.

He exhaled shakily.

"I… remember pieces," he said.

"Good," Arcebek said. "Someone should. The rest of us were busy snoring on the floor."

There was no accusation in her tone. Not yet.

"How many?" he asked. "Goblins?"

“Hard to say,” Varinel said from his stool. “Harder to count when they’re charcoal paste under new rock. But from the tracks, the blood, and what we saw in the first chambers… enough. More than Brackenridge could have handled.”

“And the girls?” Shade asked.

Arcebek’s mouth tightened. “We got two out,” she said. “Alive. They’ll carry scars.” A beat. “One was already gone when we got there.”

Shade shut his eyes.

He remembered the small body slumped against the post, and could not forget its stillness.

“I broke the seal,” he said.

Arcebek stepped closer to the bed. “You bent it,” she corrected. “It’s still on your wrist.”

He raised his wrist. Light caught in the fractured stones.

“For now,” he said.

She followed the line of fractures with her gaze. He had the sudden impression of her seeing not just the damage but the thing underneath, pushing.

“You saved us,” she said simply. “Whatever else happened, start there.”

Shade searched her face.

“I also showed them,” he said. “The villagers. The goblins, if any survived. The gods. What I am.”

Varinel snorted. “The villagers saw fire and heard roaring. They think the gods answered someone’s prayer and dropped a miracle on the goblins’ heads.” He shrugged. “Let them. I’m not in the habit of correcting people who think the world is kinder than it is.”

“And you?” Shade asked.

The elf shrugged again, thinner. “I saw a man in too much armor turn into something that made a horde dig its own graves in molten rock. I’ve seen worse. I’ve seen better. I’ve never seen anything quite that… efficient.”

“Terrifying,” Arcebek supplied.

“That too,” Varinel said.

Without asking, Arcebek sat on the edge of his bed, close enough that he could feel her warmth.

“You scared me,” she said, and there was no humor in it. “Not because you changed. Because of why you changed.”

He swallowed. “You were—”

“I know,” she said. “And don’t you dare apologize for that. If I go down, I fully expect whoever’s left standing to cheat on my behalf.”

“You don’t think we should… talk about the part where you apparently have a dragon in your pocket?” Varinel said dryly.

Arcebek waved a hand. “Later. When he’s had water that isn’t herbs and I’ve had more than one working spell in me.”

She looked back at Shade. “You didn’t lose control completely,” she said. “We’re alive. The village is still standing. You didn’t level Brackenridge on your way back.”

“That is a… low bar,” he said.

“It’s the one that matters,” she said. Her gaze flicked to the bracelet again. “The gods are angry?”

“Yes,” he said. “And afraid.”

“Good,” she said. “They should be. Maybe they’ll think twice next time before turning a person into a pressure cooker and dropping them on a world full of kindling.”

He almost laughed. It came out more like a cough.

The healer checked their pulses, scolded them all, and ordered more rest. Nearby, Jerrin and Lysa began to wake. Whatever dreams they had carried out of the cave, Shade suspected they would keep them for years.

Outside, Brackenridge moved carefully around its day, villagers glancing often toward the fused scar on the ridge, making signs against evil and whispering thanks to gods they thought had heard them.

Shade lay back against the rough pillow, feeling the cracked stones on his wrist pulse in slow, uneven rhythm.

He had broken the rules. Bent them until they screamed. Used his draconic power not as last resort in some world-ending crisis, but because three girls had been taken and one had already died and a warlock with fire in her eyes had fallen at his feet.

His mother would be furious.

The gods bound into his seal were… divided.

But Arcebek was alive. Jerrin and Lysa were alive. Varinel was alive. The village still stood.

He turned his head, met Arcebek’s gaze.

“This is not… nothing lasting,” he said quietly, thinking of the firelit conversation the night before.

Her lips curved, not into her usual wicked smile, but into something smaller and more complicated.

“No,” she agreed. “It isn’t.”

Then she patted his shoulder—carefully avoiding the places that still ached—and stood up.

“Rest, Skyfall,” she said. “Heal. Let the gods sulk. We’ll argue with them when you can walk without falling over. Then we’ll see what the guild thinks of ‘goblin horde pre-emptively turned to glass.’”

He closed his eyes, letting the exhaustion win for now.

Out on the ridge, the new rock cooled slowly, hardening from magma to obsidian under an uncaring sky.

Chapter 10: Iron and Confessions

The village smithy rang with hammer blows before sunrise.

He'd never seen someone walk into his forge the morning after a rockslide-that-wasn't, set down a heap of half-melted plate, and say, very politely:

"May I borrow your tools?"

The man stared at the twisted mass of metal that had once been Shade's armor. It was scorched and warped, edges bubbled where heat had tried to eat through entirely.

"You wore that?" the smith demanded.

"Yes," Shade said.

"And you're alive."

"Yes."

A long pause.

"...Fine," the smith said at last, stepping aside from his anvil with all the dignity he could muster. "Let's see how badly you ruin my workbench."

✦ ✦ ✦

It wasn't ruined.

It was... education.

Shade worked in a steady, focused silence, stripped to shirt and trousers, cracked bracelet glinting on his wrist as he moved. He handled the heavy pieces of armor like they weighed nothing, setting each twisted plate into the coals, watching the color shift.

He did not use fire-breath. He did not call lightning into his hands.

He did nudge Ifret and Buyakugan, just a little, through the fractures in their stones—enough that the forge's flames licked higher, hotter, more precise when he needed them to. Enough that the hammer in his grip moved with absolute confidence, each strike exactly where it should be.

He found the fault lines, followed them. Where the metal had bubbled, he smoothed. Where it had thinned, he folded, reforging layers with the care of someone re-braiding bone.

The smith, who had started out watching with arms folded and a skeptical snort, slowly lowered his hands.

"You've done this before," he muttered.

Shade didn't look up from the pauldron he was reshaping. "Yes."

"On... what?" the man asked. "Siege plates? Gatehouses?"

"Armor," Shade said. "Mine. Others'. Sometimes bigger."

"Bigger than this?" the smith demanded.

Shade thought of dragonflight battle-plate—interlocking metal over scales the size of dinner plates. "Yes."

By the time the sun was properly up, the pauldron was back to its original curve, only now with a faint new pattern where the layers met, like ripples in water. Shade quenched it, steam rolling off the metal.

The smith swore under his breath.

Shade moved on to the breastplate, his rhythm unbroken. Heat, hammer, fold, cool. The metal seemed to want to obey him.

By mid-afternoon, the armor was a suit again instead of slag. Blackened in places, yes, edges a little more angular than before, but whole. Strong. If you looked closely, you could see subtle changes—reinforced seams, added flanges, little dragon-scale echoes in the way plates overlapped.

Arcebek leaned in the doorway for most of it, arms folded, watching.

"You're making him look bad," she said at one point, nodding at the smith.

The smith grunted. "I am standing right here, warlock."

"Then you should see how fast he is," she said, smirking. "It's almost indecent."

Shade quenched another piece, steam ghosting up around him.

"This is not… unusually quick," he said.

"Yes," Arcebek and the smith said together, in very different tones.

When he finally tightened the last strap, testing the fit, the armor felt right again. Different, but right. It sat on him like it had accepted the changes, the memory of fire and stone baked in.

The smith ran a hand over one of the greaves, calloused fingers tracing new joins.

"I hate you," he told Shade, without heat. "But in a… professional way."

"I am… sorry?" Shade offered.

"You'll pay me with a day at the anvil next time you're in Brackenridge," the man said. "You can show my apprentices how you did that folding on the joins. Then I'll hate you less."

"That is acceptable," Shade said.

✦ ✦ ✦

They left Brackenridge the next morning.

The villagers watched them go from the half-built palisade and the doorways, hands raised in blessing-signs, heads bowed slightly when their eyes met Shade's.

They called him a lot of things under their breath—"the Storm's Fist," "the Hillscourge," "the Burned Knight." They lit candles at shrines to Fenris and Ifret and asked that the gods who had answered once might answer again if needed.

None of them said "dragon."

Shade was grateful. And guilty. And relieved. And not sure which feeling he was supposed to lean into.

The road home was quieter.

No harpies. No spiders. Goblin sign grew fainter with each day's travel, the horde's remnants having scattered or turned in other directions after their den caught fire from the inside.

Jerrin and Lysa cracked jokes again, but softer, with a hesitation that hadn't been there before. They walked a little closer together now. Varinel was back to muttering about everyone's footwork and the state of the trail, though sometimes Shade caught him watching the horizon with an extra layer of caution.

Arcebek stayed near Shade, as she always did. The bracelet's cracked stones seemed to settle in her presence, their pulses smoothing out when she laughed or cursed or argued with Varinel about tactics.

Three nights out, they camped in a clearing near a thin stream. Stars spilled overhead in clear, cold brightness. The air was cool enough that the breath misted just a little in the firelight.

Second watch was Shade and Arcebek's.

Jerrin and Lysa curled up with their blankets, murmuring themselves into silence. Varinel lay with his back to a tree, cloak over his face, the picture of someone absolutely not asleep and yet definitely recovering.

After a while, Shade realized he and Arcebek were the only ones whose breaths were steady and awake.

She tossed a twig into the fire, watching sparks jump.

"You've been quiet," she said.

"I am often quiet," he said.

"You've been quiet and thinking," she corrected. "That's different."

He considered the flames. They danced, reflected in the cracks of Ifret's stone. "I have been considering… what to tell you."

"About the dragon in your pocket," she said. "And the gods on your wrist."

"Yes," he said simply.

She turned to face him more fully, one knee drawn up, elbow perched on it. Firelight traced bronze along her cheekbones.

"All right," she said. "Tell me. The whole truth, or as much of it as you can stand."

He looked at her for a long moment.

Then he began.

"I am not… human," he said. "Not fully. You already suspected."

"If you told me you were just 'very fit,' I was going to hit you," she said. "Continue."

"My mother is… the Matriarch of the Blue Dragonflight," he said. Saying it out loud here, under this sky, felt strange and right at once. "She rules my kind's territory in our reality. Our plane. We do not call it that, but the word serves."

Arcebek's head tilted. "And your father?"

"Human," Shade said. "Mostly. That is a longer story."

He flexed his hand, watching the bracelet shift. The stones glinted.

"I was born between," he said. "Dragon and human. Expected to bridge that gap. To be… weapon, negotiator, heir. The one who can walk in both worlds."

“Sounds lonely,” she said quietly.

He didn’t deny it.

“Our world is older,” he said. “Steeper. Many powers. Many teeth. The gods there tried to eat each other as often as they tried to shepherd anything.” A faint huff. “Some still do.”

“Ifret. Buyakugan. Terra. Fenris. Djing and Djang,” she said, nodding at the bracelet. “Those teeth.”

“Yes,” he said. “They are… pieces of them. Or their attention, bound. They made this”—he lifted his wrist—“to chain things that should not move. Demon lords. Ancient monsters. Thoughts that learned to walk.”

“And instead it ended up on you,” she said.

“My mother asked,” Shade said. “And bargained. She saw futures where I burned worlds because no one had taught me to do otherwise.” His mouth twisted, something between bitterness and dark humor. “She was not entirely wrong.”

Arcebek’s eyes softened, just a little.

“She asked them to chain you?” she asked.

“To… limit,” he said. “To bind my draconic power so I could walk in smaller places without turning them to glass when I sneezed.” He sighed. “They agreed. Not because they are kind. Because they are… afraid. And curious. They wanted to see what I would become under pressure.”

Her gaze flicked to the cracked stones. “Pressure,” she echoed. “Nice word for it.”

“They anchored each of my… aspects,” he went on. “Ifret to my fire. Buyakugan to my lightning and speed. Terra to my strength and resilience. Fenris to my shifting and regeneration. Djing and Djang to my movement, my sense of air and path.” He shrugged one shoulder. “They decided that if I wanted to use what was mine, I would have to do it under their eyes.”

“And your mother sent you here,” Arcebek said. “To our plane. To the guild. To goblins and spiders and badly cooked stew.”

He nodded. “She told me: ‘Go. Walk among the short-lived. Learn why they burn as they do. Learn restraint. Learn… care.’” He looked down at his hands. “Her words. Not mine. At the time.”

“What were your words?” she asked.

He smiled, thin and self-mocking. “I told her it sounded like exile with extra steps.”

Arcebek snorted. “You’re not wrong.”

He met her eyes again. “I am… supposed to learn. To understand. To practice holding back. To use this—” he touched the greatsword beside him “—instead of this.” His fingers brushed the bracelet.

“And if you don’t?” she asked. “If you fail the test?”

“I become what they fear,” he said quietly. “A dragon who never learned to see mortals as anything but kindling and coins. A storm with no aim but itself. An excuse for gods to make more chains.”

The fire popped softly. Somewhere in the dark, an owl called and was answered.

“And now,” she said, “you’ve cracked their pretty seal.”

“Yes,” he said. “At Brackenridge. I pushed until it broke in places. I used what I was not supposed to use for something that was not a world-ending catastrophe.” He huffed. “To them.”

“To you,” she said, “three stolen girls and a goblin pit was enough.”

His jaw clenched. “Yes.”

She watched him for a long moment.

“So that’s what you are,” she said finally. “Half-dragon. Son of a Matriarch. Walking experiment in divine binding. Field trip from a bigger, meaner reality.”

“Yes,” he said.

“And why you were sent,” she went on. “To learn. To not burn everything down. To decide what you want to be when you’re not just what they tell you.”

“Yes,” he said again, quieter.

Silence stretched between them, the kind that feels like a held breath.

Shade looked down at his hands, at the cracks in the stones.

His voice, when it came, was almost a whisper.

“Are you… afraid of me now?” he asked. “I would understand if you were.”

There it was. The thing he’d not let himself say aloud. The piece that had haunted every laugh, every shared joke, every time her hand had brushed his.

A warlock who knew monsters. Who was a monster, by some people’s definitions.

A man who had just admitted to being something bigger, older, and sharper than anyone in this camp.

Arcebek didn’t answer immediately.

He forced himself to look up.

Her eyes were on his, steady, reflecting the fire and something else. Her expression was not fear.

“It would be easy,” she said slowly, “to say no. To make a speech about how I’ve seen worse, I am worse, blah blah blah.”

Her mouth quirked.

“But you don’t want easy,” she went on. “So here’s the truth.”

She shifted, moving closer, knees almost touching his.

“Yes,” she said. “Part of me is afraid of you.”

He flinched.

She reached out, catching his hand before he could pull away. Her fingers were warm, calloused, strong.

“I’d be stupid not to be,” she said. “I watched you turn a hillside into slag. I watched you bend a god-seal until it cracked. I can feel the power under your skin when you move.”

She squeezed his hand. Just once.

“But I’m also afraid of what you do to me without any of that,” she said softly. “When you sit by a fire and tell me you hoard books. When you throw yourself between goblin darts and children without thinking. When you look at the mess the gods made of you and still ask whether you scared me.”

His throat tightened. Words fled.

“I’m not afraid of you,” she said. “I’m afraid of losing you. There’s a difference.”

He stared at her.

The gods on his wrist had gone very, very quiet.

Arcebek’s fingers slid up from his hand to his cheek, thumb brushing a soot-smudge he’d missed.

“You asked if I was afraid,” she murmured. “My turn.”

She tilted her head, eyes searching his.

“Are you going to run?” she asked. “Now that I know. Now that I’ve seen you melt caves and can’t unsee it.”

“No,” he said at once. The answer surprised him with its certainty. “I do not… want to.”

“Good,” she said.

And then she kissed him.

It wasn’t cautious. Arcebek didn’t do anything cautiously.

She leaned in, closing the small distance between them, one hand still on his cheek, the other braced against his shoulder. Her lips met his with warmth and intent, the faint taste of smoke and whatever awful stew they’d eaten lingering there.

For a heartbeat, his mind blanked.

Then instinct—older than dragons, older than gods—caught up.

He kissed her back.

Carefully, at first. He had to remember that this body was smaller, softer, more breakable than his own real form. That she was mortal and he was full of fire.

But she made a small approving sound in the back of her throat and tugged him closer by the front of his gambeson, and something in him uncoiled.

The fire crackled. The night pressed close. Somewhere, an owl decided it had better things to do than watch.

Her lips moved against his, slow and thorough, as if she’d decided that if this was the first time, it would not be forgettable. He followed her lead, then met it, then matched it.

His free hand found her waist, fingers splaying over leather and cloth, careful but firm. Her fingers slid into his hair, tugging just enough to draw a soft, surprised sound out of him.

When they finally parted for breath, foreheads resting together, the world felt fractionally… rearranged.

“You are…” Shade started, then stopped, because every word his mind produced sounded inadequate.

“Dangerous?” she offered. “Irresponsible? Highly kissable?”

“Yes,” he said. “All of those.”

She laughed against his mouth, the sound muffled and happy.

“Your turn,” she murmured. “What am I kissing, exactly? Shade? The half-dragon? The experiment? All of the above?”

He considered. “You are kissing… me,” he said. “All of me. I do not know how to separate the parts anymore.”

“Good answer,” she said, and kissed him again.

Time became a strange thing.

They kissed until his lips felt swollen and her braid had half undone itself. Until the fire burned down to coals and had to be nudged back to life with clumsy hands that kept drifting back to each other. Until the stars shifted noticeably overhead.

They didn’t go further than that. There were lines neither of them quite stepped over—not with Jerrin mumbling in his sleep a few steps away, not with Varinel pretending to be unconscious within earshot, not with goblin country still somewhere ahead and behind.

But there were hands on cheeks and at the nape of necks, thumbs brushing skin, whispered half-jokes and softer admissions between kisses. At one point, Arcebek muttered against his mouth:

“If you tell anyone your first kiss here was by a fire on goblin patrol, I’ll deny everything.”

“This is your first?” he asked, surprised.

“First that mattered,” she said. “Don’t get smug.”

“I am… honoured,” he said.

Something in her expression went unguarded for a heartbeat. Then she kissed him so hard he forgot how to think again.

They only stopped when Varinel’s voice drifted over, dry as ever:

“If you two are quite done terrifying the local wildlife, it’s my watch.”

Arcebek broke the kiss, breathing a little fast, and leaned her forehead against Shade’s for a last moment.

“Later,” she murmured.

“Yes,” he said.

They settled apart, reluctantly. Shade took a long breath, forcing his heartbeat back under some semblance of control. The gods in his bracelet pulsed in a disjointed chorus—Ifret gleeful, Fenris amused, Terra resigned, Buyakugan buzzing, Djing and Djang spinning lazy loops.

He looked at Arcebek as she rolled into her blanket, braid messy, lips a little reddened.

“Afraid?” he asked.

She met his gaze over the edge of her cloak.

“Terrified,” she said. “Of you, of me, of what this is going to look like when your dragon mom finds out.”

A slow smile curled her mouth.

“But I’m not running,” she added. “You?”

He lay back, staring up at the stars, feeling the warmth of her kiss lingering on his skin.

“No,” he said. “I am not running.”

They traded the rest of the watch with Varinel, who studiously did not comment on anything beyond goblin tracks and cloud cover.

When Shade finally lay down, sleep came easier than it had in years.

He dreamed—just for once—not of falling, or fire, or chains.

He dreamed of wings folded small enough to fit beside a mortal fire, and of lips like impossible red, and of a future that, for the first time, didn’t feel entirely written by gods or Matriarchs.

Morning would bring more walking, more work, more questions.

But for now, he let himself rest.

Chapter 11: The Broken Seal

Greenhollow's gate guards grew uneasy at the sight of the returning party.

Brackenridge had left its mark on Shade: soot on his armor, new scale-like ripples in the reforged steel, and fine cracks running through the gems at his wrist.

By the time the party crossed the guildhall threshold, Lana was already waiting.

Lana held the Brackenridge writ, tapping one edge against her palm.

"In my office," she said. "All of you."

✦ ✦ ✦

The office was a cramped room off the main hall, lined with ledgers and dominated by a scarred table that had survived years of arguments and spilled ink.

Grig leaned against the wall, arms folded. A regional map covered the table, Brackenridge and the north ridge circled in red.

Lana closed the door behind them.

"Let's start with the easy part," she said. "You went to Brackenridge. You found proof of a goblin host. And then the scouts started bringing back stories of a hill that melted."

She slapped the writ down on the map. "Reeve Marek says—and I quote—'the gods sent a burning storm-man who turned the goblins' nest to glass from the inside.' Care to explain?"

Her eyes went straight to Shade.

He opened his mouth.

Arcebek stepped in before he could.

"Host was larger than expected," she said. "They'd already grabbed some of the villagers' girls by the time we arrived. We tracked them to a cave system in the ridge. It was… bad in there."

Varinel's jaw tightened. "Ambush in the main cavern," he said. "Darts from the walls. Poisoned. They took out the kids and me with sleep venom in the first volley. Arcebek too. Shade held."

Lana's gaze flicked between them. "Held," she repeated.

Varinel shrugged, all brittle nonchalance. "Some people just don't take naps easily."

Grig snorted once, but he was watching Shade with a hunter's interest.

"And the cave?" Grig asked. "The hill?"

Arcebek nodded toward Shade. "He doesn't go down to poison," she said. "You saw it with the harpies. Same thing, larger dose. He picked up a harpy and threw it. This time it was goblins and stone."

Lana's brows arched. "He threw… stone."

"The cave wasn't stable to begin with," Arcebek said smoothly. "Goblins had dug too many side passages, burned too many supports. I hit the webs and egg sacs with a high-output spell. They burned. He…" she gave a small, crooked half-smile, "encouraged the rest of it to come down."

Shade listened to her careful omissions. Arcebek was offering Lana an explanation that might be true in another world.

Grig frowned. “Encouraged how?”

Varinel snorted. “You saw him move that sled in the test. Now imagine him under a collapsing ceiling you already set on fire, hauling goblins into falling rock. It doesn’t take a wizard to see how that ends.”

Lana tapped her quill on the table. “That explains a collapse,” she said. “It does not explain magma.”

Arcebek met her gaze squarely. “Lana,” she said, voice calm, “I am a warlock whose patron specializes in destructive transmutation and planar breach. I hit a goblin nest full of stolen kindling with everything I had. The earth decided it had had enough.”

The explanation was plausible. Warlock magic could twist stone and fire into terrible things.

She spread her hands. “You wanted the host broken. It’s broken. The ridge will be cooling for years.”

Grig’s eyes narrowed. “We also want our assets alive. You almost cooked yourself.”

“Almost,” Arcebek said. “Not quite. And our ‘assets’ are standing right here.”

His gaze slid back to Shade. “And you?”

Shade chose his words with care. “I did… what was necessary,” he said. “To keep the goblins from using that cave again. To protect the village. I relied on my resilience and… familiarity with collapsing structures.”

Lana studied him long enough to make even Grig uncomfortable.

The cracked stones on his bracelet pulsed, faint lines of light running through Ifret’s fractures, tiny arcs snapping along Buyakugan’s crystal.

At last, Lana sighed.

“I hate this job,” she muttered. “People go out, break natural laws, come back, and dump the paperwork on my desk.”

She jabbed the map. “All right. Officially, this reads: Bronze team engaged goblin nest, encountered larger-than-normal force, warlock’s magic plus structural weakness caused catastrophic cave-in. Goblin host scattered, Brackenridge secured. Casualties: one village girl dead before arrival, multiple goblins, one hill.”

Grig grunted. “Unofficially, I want to know if I need to start writing contingency plans for ‘what if Shade sneezes in the guildhall.’”

“I will not… sneeze in the guildhall,” Shade said, almost offended.

He held Grig’s gaze.

Whatever the older man saw there made him snort again, but less sharply.

“Fine,” Grig said. “For now, I’ll treat you like I treat every walking disaster. Useful until proven otherwise.” A corner of his mouth twitched. “You did good. Reckless as hell, but good.”

Lana’s tone softened by a fraction. “Brackenridge sent a second letter,” she said. “This one wasn’t a contract. It was thanks. They’re calling you their ‘Storm-Knight’ and lighting candles in your honor. Don’t let it go to your head.”

Shade had no answer, so he nodded.

“Payment will be processed by tomorrow,” Lana went on briskly. “You’ll get hazard bonuses. Arcebek, Varinel, you get extra for leadership and not letting your Bronze idiots die.” She glanced at Jerrin and Lysa, who were trying very hard to look like seasoned veterans and not wide-eyed teenagers who had recently been poisoned by goblins.

“Any questions?” she asked.

No one volunteered any.

“Good. Get out of my office before someone else melts a landmark and expects me to turn it into a line item.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The questioning left Shade more drained than the ride home.

Outside the guildhall, he stood in the courtyard and let the cool air touch his face.

Arcebek appeared at his elbow, as she usually did.

“Well,” she said. “That could have been worse. Grig didn’t demand we chain you in the basement as an ‘emergency asset.’”

“I am… grateful,” Shade said.

The gems still pulsed, their fractures aching with the strain of something bent too far.

“I need to… repair this,” he said quietly.

Arcebek followed his gaze.

“Can you?” Arcebek asked, curious rather than doubtful.

“Yes,” he said slowly. “In time. With… the right materials. Each stone is tied to its god. To mend them, I must mend that connection. With things that echo their domains.”

“Components,” she said. “Let me guess: nothing cheap.”

“Nothing simple,” he agreed. “For Ifret: something that has seen true fire and survived. For Buyakugan: a lightning-struck rod or sky-metal. For Terra: deep stone, unworked. For Fenris: water from a place that never dries. For Djing and Djang: wind-bottled, or feathers from a bird that never lands.”

She raised her brows. “You just described the shopping list from a particularly ambitious ritual.”

He tilted his head. “Will you help me find them?”

It was a simple question. It carried a weight that was not simple at all.

If she said yes, she was binding herself closer to what he was, not just who. Standing with him not only as party and lover, but as someone who helped him negotiate directly with gods who had once sealed demon lords.

Arcebek watched him for a moment.

Then she smiled, slow and sure.

“Of course,” she said. “Someone has to make sure you don’t pick up cursed sky-metal and accidentally give yourself another sentient bracelet.”

“That is… unlikely,” he said.

“With you, I’m not betting on unlikely,” she said. “We’ll start small. Shrine to Ifret on the south side has a reliquary of fire-hardened relics. I know a river priest who might let us steal a vial of water from the Deep Pool under the falls for Fenris. Terra’s easy enough if we dig in the right place. Djing and Djang…” she shrugged. “We’ll talk to the wind priests. Or climb something tall and see what answers.”

“And Buyakugan?” he asked.

She grinned, sharp. “That one will be fun. There’s a storm festival in a few weeks. Lots of kites, lots of lightning rods, lots of drunk priests shouting at the sky. If we can get you struck without killing you, that should make your thunder god happy.”

“The thunder god is rarely happy,” Shade said. “But he might be less… fractured.”

She squeezed his arm. “Then we’ll give him something to crackle about.”

✦ ✦ ✦

That night, the guild paid them.

Gold clinked on the counter—heavy pouches for each of them. Jerrin and Lysa immediately made plans to waste a portion on shiny gear they didn’t strictly need. Varinel mumbled something about arrow fletching and better boots.

Arcebek counted her share, weighed it in her hand, then slid a quiet cut of it into Shade’s pouch without comment.

“You reforged your armor,” she said, as if that explained everything. “You don’t get to argue.”

He didn’t.

They ended up celebrating at the Broken Anvil.

Returning to the Broken Anvil felt different now.

Last time, Shade had been Arcebek’s odd tagalong. Tonight, he was one of the party returning from a job that had nearly gone very wrong. People noticed that.

Tankards appeared. Someone bought a round “for the Brackenridge burners.” A song started—bad, off-key, and probably improvised—as news of the glassed hill spread through the room.

Jerrin and Lysa got noisy and flushed, boasting about “facing down a goblin host” with enough embellishment that anyone with sense would cut the story in half. Varinel drank like a man measuring out his own limits carefully.

Arcebek sat close to Shade, their shoulders pressed together in a way that wasn’t quite casual and wasn’t at all hidden.

Once, when someone asked too loudly how exactly the hill had melted, she just smiled over the rim of her drink and said:

“Trade secret. But if you pray hard and pay your guild dues, maybe the gods will answer your complaints with molten rock too.”

The questioner found somewhere else to drink.

Shade took in the warmth, the noise, and the solid reassurance of Arcebek's leg pressed against his beneath the table.

At some point, Jerrin tried to arm-wrestle Shade and lost so fast he accused him of cheating. Lysa collapsed in giggles. Varinel shook his head and muttered something about "children" and "show-offs."

By the time the inn thinned, the lamps had burned low and smoke hung beneath the rafters.

Arcebek leaned in, lips near Shade's ear. "Come on," she said softly. "Before someone challenges you to see if you can drink the entire bar and still walk."

"I likely can," he said.

"I know," she said. "That's the problem."

She took his hand under the table, fingers sliding between his, and tugged him gently toward the stairs.

No one stopped them. No one commented. Varinel lifted his tankard in a lazy salute; Jerrin and Lysa were already half-asleep at their seats.

Shade followed her up, heart beating a little faster, the cracks in the stones at his wrist aching faintly in time.

✦ ✦ ✦

Her room was the same.

Small, sturdy, touched by her presence: the stack of books, the charms at the window, the faint smell of herbs and smoke.

Shade hesitated inside the door, more nervous than he had been in the goblin cave.

Battle was easier. Fights had rules and patterns. You survived, or you did not.

This offered no rules he trusted, and far more to lose.

Arcebek shut the door gently behind them.

She watched him.

He held her gaze.

No armor. No weapons. Just Arcebek: hair loosened from its long braid, eyes dark and intent, lips soft and a shade he knew now was only mostly from pigment.

"If you want to stop," she said quietly, "this is the moment."

She meant it. No teasing, no test: she was giving him a choice.

"I do not," he said, equally quiet. "I have… wanted this. For some time."

Her shoulders loosened. She smiled.

"Good," she said. "Me too."

He stepped forward.

They met in the middle.

Their kiss held none of the earlier surprise. She rose onto her toes; he bent to meet her, placing his hands carefully at her waist. Neither hurried.

His own response startled him.

So did the gods.

Ifret's cracked stone warmed. Buyakugan buzzed. Terra rumbled under his skin, reminding him just how much force he could bring to bear without thinking.

Careful, he reminded himself.

He had broken hills and melted caves. He would not hurt her.

Arcebek's hands slid under his shirt, calloused fingers finding scar and muscle and the tense lines of someone trying very hard to hold themselves in check.

"Relax," she muttered against his mouth. "You're wound tighter than a crossbow."

"I am… large," he managed. "And strong. And not entirely sure of—"

"Then we go slow," she said. "And you let me tell you when to stop. When to push. When to breathe."

She punctuated the last word with a nip at his lower lip that made him inhale sharply.

He did as she said.

They found a rhythm: her leading, him following, then meeting, then matching. Clothes came off in fits and starts, with more laughter than he would have thought possible—at tangled sleeves, at bumping elbows, at his startled hiss when her fingers traced the edges of the still-healing patch on his side.

He measured every touch, every movement, listening for any hint of discomfort.

It exhausted him.

And he would not have traded it.

At some point, he realized his whole body hurt—not from pain, exactly, but from the strain of holding back, of keeping dragon strength throttled down to something human, something gentle.

He never let himself lose that care.

Nor did he want to.

They moved together under the thin inn blankets, the world narrowed to warmth and skin and breath and the small, honest sounds two people made when they let themselves be here and nowhere else for a while.

When it was done—whatever "done" meant in a tangle of limbs and shared breath and a sense that something had shifted—he ended up half-curled around her, one arm under her neck, the other over her waist.

His shoulders ached from the effort of holding back.

Arcebek lay with her cheek on his chest, fingers drawing idle patterns on his skin.

"You're trembling," she murmured sleepily.

"I am… tired," he admitted. "And sore."

"Good," she said, smug. "Means you did it right."

He huffed a low laugh. "I have fought for days without this much… strain."

“Yes,” she said. “But you weren’t trying not to win too hard then.”

He thought about that, then decided it made more sense than it seemed to.

“Are you… all right?” he asked. The question came out softer than he intended.

She tilted her head enough to look up at him. Her hair was a wild halo now; her eyes were heavy-lidded but clear.

“Very,” she said. “You?”

He considered the question.

Physically: sore, pleasantly spent, aware of every line of tension he’d held and released.

Mentally: oddly quiet. The constant buzz of planning, of second-guessing, had dulled. The gods on his wrist were a soft, distant thrum, more curious than critical.

Emotionally, the answer was harder to name.

“I,” he said slowly, “am… glad I did not run.”

Her smile was small and fierce.

“Me too,” she said.

He woke several times that night. Each time he listened for her breathing, felt her warmth beside him, and fell asleep again.

At dawn, when the first light seeped in around the shutter, he woke with a groan.

His whole body ached.

Not like battle wounds. Like he’d spent the night braced against a boulder, every muscle clenched.

Arcebek stirred against him, grumbling. “If that’s you trying to sneak out of bed, don’t,” she muttered. “I worked too hard for this pillow.”

“I cannot feel my left arm,” he said.

“That means you did the cuddling right,” she said. “Welcome to mortals’ problems.”

He looked at her.

She was a mess. Hair everywhere, smudged makeup under her eyes, lips swollen, a faint bruise already coloring her shoulder where his fingers had almost been too tight before he noticed and eased up. She was also… beautiful, in a way that had nothing to do with pact marks or bronze skin or impossible lipstick.

Shade smiled before he could stop himself.

“Good morning,” he said.

“Mm. Jury’s out,” she replied. “Ask me after coffee.”

He flexed his sore shoulder and winced.

She noticed, of course.

“Sore?” she asked, more gently now.

“Yes,” he said. “I held back. A great deal.”

“I know,” she said. “I felt it.”

He tensed. “If I was—”

“Shade,” she cut in softly. “You were perfect.”

The praise struck deeper than anything he had earned in battle.

He breathed out, the last of his anxiety beginning to loosen.

“Next time,” she added, wickedness curling at the edge of her mouth, “we can see if we can get you half that sore and twice as relaxed. But one miracle at a time.”

“Next time,” he echoed.

The gods on his wrist pulsed in quiet, uneven harmony.

Ifret warm and pleased. Fenris cool, approving the restraint. Terra solid. Buyakugan buzzing with anticipation. Djing and Djang spinning lazy circles, delighted with every shift in the wind.

For once, Shade did not wonder what they thought.

He lay there in the narrow inn bed, sore and tired and strangely at peace, a dwarf warlock tucked against his side and a future that was messy and uncertain and very much his.

Outside, the guild would wake. Job boards would fill. Someone would complain about goblins, or spiders, or taxes. There would be components to hunt, gods to bargain with, and a Matriarch’s eventual wrath to face.

For the moment, this was enough.

He let himself enjoy it.

Chapter 12: Small Jobs, Large Feelings

The following week was mercifully ordinary.

After Brackenridge, Lana kept them close to town: rats in a grain warehouse (no fire, she warned Arcebek twice), a spice caravan needing an escort beyond the fields, and strange noises in a tannery loft that proved to be one enormous, deeply offended owl.

Easy work. Local work. Nothing that called for melting a hillside.

Shade had no complaints. His body needed the quiet, and so did his mind.

The damaged stones seemed grateful for the reprieve. Ifret's ember settled into a steady coal; Buyakugan's erratic sparks calmed; Terra's anger wore down to patience. Fenris kept time with rain and river, while Djing & Djang stirred at passing breezes rather than the frantic winds of the cave.

One afternoon, a simple boundary patrol took them to the old windmill overlooking Greenhollow.

Its cracked white stones sheltered mice and a territorial rooster, but no bandits. Shade and the others had barely finished searching when dark clouds massed over the western hills.

A farmer passing below shouted for them to get indoors before the road turned to mud.

"See?" Arcebek said, leaning against the mill. "Sometimes the world is content to be boring."

Thunder muttered overhead. The world, apparently, had changed its mind.

Varinel glared at the sky as though it had insulted him personally. "We're leaving. Roads'll turn to soup."

Jerrin and Lysa set off down the hill, hoods raised, still arguing about whether the rooster counted as a fight worth boasting about.

Arcebek turned to Shade. "Coming?"

He stood at the broken railing, watching the town below. The rising breeze tugged at his hair and made Djing & Djang's crystal sing.

"In a moment," he said. "I will follow."

Varinel grunted. After Brackenridge, he had learned which arguments to abandon. "Don't get struck." He followed the youngsters downhill.

Rain swept over the ridge before they reached the road.

Halfway down the slope, Arcebek noticed that Shade's heavy footsteps had never joined them.

She turned. Through the rain, his dark silhouette remained beside the mill.

Of course it did.

She could keep walking, leave him to brood in the weather, and meet him at the inn when he finally returned dripping wet.

Instead, she sighed and climbed back.

Varinel spotted her turn. "Of course," he muttered. "I'll get the children under cover. Try not to die of feelings."

“No promises!” she called into the wind.

By the time she reached the mill, rain had soaked her to the skin and plastered her braid to her back.

Shade stood at the hill’s edge, helm removed, face turned toward the clouds. Water ran from his hair and down his jaw.

He was singing.

His voice travelled with the storm instead of struggling against it.

The melody rose and fell without repeating, carrying turns no human or dwarven song would make. A phrase would swell toward resolution, then retreat as though something had pulled it back.

She did not recognize the language.

Its sounds rolled deep in the throat, then snapped into hard endings: thunder and rain on hot stone.

Even without the words, she knew a dirge when she heard one. Grief ran through it, and anger, but also the love of someone mourning what could never return.

Arcebek stopped in the broken doorway and listened.

Below the hill, Greenhollow blurred into wet roofs and chimney smoke. Shade’s voice reached her clearly through the rain.

She realized he had no idea she was there.

He sang another verse. The tune climbed, only to fall away before its final note.

The stones on his bracelet answered.

Fenris kept time with the rain; Djing & Djang with the gusts. Ifret glowed beneath the falling water. Even Terra sent a low vibration through the hill.

Arcebek crossed the remaining distance carefully. Shade finished the verse but did not turn.

For a few breaths, there was only rain.

She came to stand beside him. He let the final note fade into the wind.

Then, very softly, she said, “Don’t let me interrupt.”

He huffed a breath. It might have been a laugh.

“You are not interrupting,” he said. “The song was… nearly done.”

His gaze stayed on the lanterns moving between the houses below.

“What was it?” she asked. “I didn’t recognize the language.”

“Draconic,” he said. “An old mode. My mother’s mother used to sing it. Before she… became what she is.”

“A funeral song?” Arcebek guessed.

“Many funerals,” he said. “It is used for… endings. Of people. Of places. Of ways of being.”

Rain streamed down his cheeks, making it impossible to tell whether he had been crying.

“I started it for the girl who died in the cave,” he said. “I… kept going.”

“For Brackenridge?” she asked.

“For the goblins,” he said quietly. “For the parts of me I burned to kill them. For the hill that will not grow trees again for a very long time.”

At last he turned to her.

His eyes were the same blue they always were, but in the grey light and the rain they looked brighter. More dragon than man. The cracks in the stones on his wrist glowed softly, a faint five-colored echo.

“Your people sing for their enemies?” she asked.

“Sometimes,” he said. “Not for all. Not for those we hate. For those we… understand. Or pity. For those who never had a chance to be anything but what they were made for.”

“Goblin horde,” she said.

“Goblin horde,” he agreed. “Born in dark, fed on scraps, taught to take or be taken. It does not absolve them. It does not undo what they did to those girls. But the song is not for absolution.”

“What is it for?” Arcebek asked.

He listened to the rain before answering.

“For reminding myself,” he said slowly, “that burning something does not mean it never… was. That even enemies had days before they became enemies.”

Arcebek let him have the silence.

Behind them, the mill’s broken sails creaked.

“You’re allowed to mourn them,” she said at last. “And her. And yourself. All tangled. That’s how we work.”

“We,” he echoed.

“Mortals,” she said. “Half-mortals. Warlocks. Dragons slumming it in guild armor. All of us.”

His laughter was brief and raw, but unmistakable.

“The words,” she said. “What do they mean?”

He hesitated, then gave her the literal version, piece by piece. “The first verse is… ‘We remember the shape of you in the firelight. We remember your teeth, your hunger, your hands. We remember the way you stood between us and the dark, or became the dark. We remember that you were real.’”

“Cheerful,” she said, but there was no mockery in it.

“It is not meant to be… comforting,” he said. “Only true.”

“And the last verse?” she asked.

He looked down at the town again, the little cluster of roofs and chimneys that had no idea someone had just sung a dragon dirge over them in the rain.

“‘If there is another side,’” he translated, voice softer, “‘may it be kinder than this one. If there is not, then let the echoes of you be enough.’”

She swallowed.

“Remind me never to get on your bad side,” she said. “You sing better lamentations than most priests.”

He smiled, faint and crooked. “You are not in danger of that.”

“Of your bad side,” she said. “Or your lamentations?”

“Either,” he said.

They stood together while the rain weakened and the roofs of Greenhollow slowly came back into focus.

Wind worried at their soaked clothes. Neither moved.

“Why up here?” she asked. “You could have sung in your room. Less likely to catch a cold.”

“I do not… get colds,” he said automatically. Then, more seriously, “Up here, it feels closer to… home. Higher. Wider. Easier to remember that there is sky above the clouds.”

Her hand found his, slowly, fingers threading between his.

“You know,” she said, “if you keep doing things like this—singing in the rain, reforging your own armor, dropping in from the sky—people are going to start telling stories about you.”

“They already are,” he said. “Storm-Knight. Hillscourge. Firehand.”

“Those are the boring stories,” she said. “I mean the ones that actually matter.”

He glanced at her. “Such as?”

She squeezed his hand.

“‘There was once a dragon who learned to be human enough to stand on a hill in the rain and sing for goblins and girls and himself,’” she said. “‘And someone who loved him enough to listen.’”

Love. She had said it as naturally as if it belonged there.

Arcebek did not take the word back.

Shade tightened his grip, careful even now.

“Are you…?” he started.

“Maybe,” she said. “Ask me again after you’ve survived a few more goblin nests and met my patron.”

“Your patron will not like me,” he said.

“Oh, absolutely not,” she said. “Which is half the fun.”

Shade laughed, and she felt the tension leave his hand.

The downpour thinned to rain. Below them, chimney smoke rose from Greenhollow as people lit their evening fires.

Djing & Djang stirred in the easing breeze. Fenris followed the last heavy drops. Ifret waited for a hearth; Terra held firm beneath them. Buyakugan seemed disappointed that the storm had brought so little thunder.

Arcebek tugged his hand.

“Come on, Skyfall,” she said. “We’ve given the wind enough of a show. If we stand here much longer, Lana will write ‘dramatic weather brooding’ in the ‘hazards’ column of the next job report.”

He let her pull him away from the edge.

They made their way downhill through the mud. For the first time since his arrival, Shade found that the dirge did not end where he expected.

Another melody had begun beneath it.

He could not have sung its words yet.

But he wanted to learn them.

Chapter 13: Storm Festival

The Storm Festival arrived in Greenhollow on a rising wind.

By noon, steel-grey clouds crowded the hills. Banners snapped over the square, where the usual bread and tool stalls had given way to vendors selling copper wire, iron rods and clay charms painted with jagged white lines.

“Welcome,” Arcebek said dryly, “to the annual attempt to annoy Buyakugan into noticing us.”

Children dashed past with sparking streamers. On a makeshift platform, the local storm priests shouted invocations into the wind, which stole half their words.

The air tasted of metal. Shade felt the charge build with every breath.

Djing & Djang’s damaged crystal vibrated against his wrist. Buyakugan’s shard, restless for days, now crackled with almost eager attention.

“You’re certain about this?” Arcebek called over the wind. “Deliberately getting struck by lightning is not one of my better plans.”

“The lightning is already bound to me,” Shade said, studying the clouds. “I am reaffirming the bond.”

“Spoken like a man who’s never been set on fire by the sky.”

He looked down at her. “I thought that was your speciality.”

“Mine comes from below,” she said. “If the heavens start throwing things at me too, I’m changing patrons.”

The priests began a slow, stamping dance, raising their rods and calling the local titles of the storm deity.

“Storm-Eyed! Sky-Hammer! Thunder-Drunk! Lady of the Falling Spear!”

Arcebek elbowed Shade lightly. “That last one’s for you. Our own Falling Spear.”

“I hope not to fall this time,” he said.

At the end of the rite, the crowd surged toward the open ground, carrying rods adorned with bells, strips of cloth and scraps of paper bearing written wishes.

“Last chance to back out,” Arcebek said. “We can just buy a rod someone else got struck.”

Shade shook his head slowly. “It must know me,” he said, with the simple stubbornness she’d come to recognize. “And I must know it.”

“Of course you do,” she sighed. “All right. Let’s find a good spot where you won’t accidentally fry half the guild.”

They climbed the rocky rise beyond town, where fewer people had gathered. The chanting below reached them in tatters on the wind.

Shade planted his boots on bare stone and removed his helm. Rain soaked his hair. The iron rod grew warm in his grip.

He took a slow breath.

“Buyakugan,” he murmured in the old tongue. “Thundermother. Sky-Breaker. I am yours already, whether I like it or not. Look this way, if you have a moment.”

Arcebek kept a wary distance, every instinct urging her to drag him down the hill.

“You so much as smell like burning,” she warned, “and I’m dragging you to Fenris’s priestess by the ear.”

The first strike hit the priests’ rods in the square.

Lightning split the sky. Its impact silenced the chanting, then drew cheers and cries of alarm from the crowd.

The next bolt forked across three rods at once. Sparks leapt between them and vanished into the earth.

The third came for Shade.

Buyakugan’s crystal flared before the third strike. Shade felt the storm gather around his raised arm.

Then everything turned white.

The rod bucked. Thunder hit so hard that he felt it in his ribs before he heard it.

Every nerve fired at once. His muscles locked—and then the older instincts of something born among storms took hold.

He rode it.

He let the charge race through his grip, up his arms and into the fractured crystal. The seal took what it could; the rest shuddered through his bones.

He gritted his teeth, but he didn’t scream.

Arcebek did.

“Shade!”

She lunged toward him, hands raised, though the bolt had already grounded through the rock. The air stank of ozone.

Shade staggered. For a few seconds the hill held several Arcebeks, all furious.

She got under his arm, bracing him with surprising strength for her size.

“Stupid, stupid man,” she hissed. “Are you—”

“I am… fine,” he managed. His voice sounded wrong in his ears, edges fuzzy. “I am… awake.”

“You were already awake,” she snapped. “We were aiming for ‘alive,’ not ‘extra crispy.’”

He blinked until the extra Arcebeks vanished. The fear beneath her anger was harder to dismiss.

He looked down at his wrist.

The central fracture in Buyakugan’s stone had changed. It was no longer a jagged wound. Light ran through it in narrow, regular paths, as if the damage had learned a new shape.

The iron rod had half melted at its tip, curling into a delicate spiral. It still snapped with residual sparks.

“Will it do?” he asked, a little hoarse.

Arcebek stared at him. Then at the rod. Then back at him.

“Yeah,” she said at last. “I think she noticed you.”

✦ ✦ ✦

After that, gathering the remaining reagents felt almost mundane.

At the south-side shrine, a soot-smudged priestess let Shade place a fire-hardened stone into Ifret’s eternal flame. She eyed him throughout the rite, muttering about “fire-branded idiots.”

When he retrieved the glowing stone with his bare hand, she winced. His skin reddened but did not blister.

“You’re a menace,” the priestess told him. “If she leaves you, send word, we could use someone to carry braziers.”

Fenris’ gift came from the Deep Pool beneath the falls, two days upstream. A river priest reluctantly allowed Shade onto the moss-slick ledge, where he filled a glass vial from the churning water.

“The river remembers everything that’s fallen into it,” the priest warned. “Don’t let it remember you by name, storm-man.”

For Terra, Shade chipped a piece from a deep seam of stone in an abandoned quarry, rock untouched by daylight until he broke it free.

The wind was harder to capture.

Arcebek bribed a wind priest with rare incense to admit them to the eastern watchtower on a particularly gusty day. At the summit, Shade uncorked a rune-marked glass vessel.

He spoke first in Draconic and then in the local wind-prayer, inviting the air to pass through and remain.

The stoppered bottle looked empty. Yet something inside pushed against the glass when he tilted it.

They returned with five reagents: fire-hardened stone, the lightning-twisted rod, deep-vein rock, water from the Deep Pool, and bottled wind.

“Now what?” Arcebek asked, as they laid the items out in her room like a very small, extremely specific hoard.

“Now,” Shade said, “we find a place where all five speak at once.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The first clue came from an old survey map Shade found in the library.

In its margin, a warning read: “Fivefold Hollow. Elementally unstable. Avoid extended stays. No building recommended.”

Elementally unstable was exactly what he needed.

The hollow itself was less dramatic than its reputation.

Broken rocks ringed a depression in the hills. A stream fed a pool with no visible outlet; a crack in the far wall breathed warm steam. The shape of the land kept the wind moving even when the surrounding slopes were still. Every few moments, static prickled along their skin.

When Shade stood in the center, bracelet bare to the air, each stone responded.

Ifret warmed by the steam. Fenris pulsed beside the pool; Terra hummed through the stone. Djing & Djang greeted the wind, and Buyakugan's crystal answered the charge hanging in the air.

"Yes," he said simply. "Here."

Arcebek set down their packs and looked around, arms folded.

"Feels like the sort of place sensible people avoid," she said. "So obviously we're going to set up a ritual in it."

"Obviously," he agreed.

"How do you want to do this?" she asked. "Circle, warding grid, containment pentacle?"

"No pentacle. We are not trapping anything." He looked over the hollow. "We are listening. Re-weaving what has torn."

She raised a brow. "Show me, then."

✦ ✦ ✦

He began with the stones.

Not the gems of his bracelet. He removed the whole binding from his wrist, carefully, and set it on a flat stone. A pale ring marked the skin beneath.

He circled the hollow, picking up rocks and discarding others. Arcebek eventually understood that he was testing their resonance, not their size or shape.

He arranged them in an uneven ring, its pattern less like a warding circle than the growth rings of an ancient tree.

Then he knotted hemp cord between the stones in looping paths, crossing and recrossing until the shapes seemed almost random. Still, the pattern held together.

Primitive, Arcebek thought.

Then he started adding sigils.

Not with chalk or ink, but with the reagents they had carried across the countryside.

At the steam vent, he drew Ifret's sign in ash, buried the fire-hardened stone in hot coals and whispered until they glowed without flame.

At the pool, he stepped ankle-deep into the water and set Fenris' vial on the surface. It floated while his fingers traced a river sigil around it. The droplets he raised hung in the air before falling.

He pressed Terra's stone against the exposed seam in the far wall, bowed his forehead to the rock and murmured a cadence too deep for Arcebek to follow. Dark veins spread through the surface.

On the highest boulder, he opened Djing & Djang's bottle to the wind. He spoke twice, one sharp phrase for each twin, and closed it again. Distortions rippled through the trapped air.

Buyakugan he left for last.

He planted the twisted rod near the bracelet and ran a thumb over its melted tip.

"Do you need me to draw anything?" Arcebek asked quietly. "Anchor runes, fail-safe circles?"

He paused, then nodded toward the edge of the hollow.

“Four points: north, south, east and west. Grounding marks. They are not meant to bind the power, only to give it somewhere to go besides you.”

“Practical,” she said. “I like it.”

He showed her simple strokes meaning “solid ground” in half a dozen old traditions. She copied them carefully around the rim of the hollow.

When she finished, she came back to the center.

Shade had stripped down to shirt and trousers again, feet bare now despite the cold ground. The bracelet lay on the central stone, the cracked gems dull—for the moment.

Without his armor or bracelet, Shade seemed strangely exposed.

She had seen his almost-dragon shape in the cave, but this was different.

For a moment, she thought she could see other versions of him standing just out of alignment with his body.

“Last chance to say this is the worst idea you’ve had yet,” she said quietly.

He smiled, a quick, crooked thing. “You would not believe my worst ideas.”

“I’ve met you,” she said. “I have some guesses.”

His smile faded. “I need you here.”

“I’m not going anywhere,” she said. “What do you want me to do?”

He approached and offered both hands, palms up.

“Take these,” he said. “If it goes wrong, let go. If it goes very wrong, run.”

She slid her hands into his without hesitation. “And if it goes right?”

“Then,” he said, “you will see something no one in your world has seen before and lived long enough to talk about.”

“Reassuring,” she muttered. “All right, Skyfall. Impress me.”

He huffed a breath, then stepped back into the center, still holding her hands, positioning her opposite him across the bracelet.

He closed his eyes.

The hollow seemed to inhale.

Wind faltered. Steam slowed. Ripples trembled across the pool.

His voice gathered strength.

He began in Draconic, then drew on the local invocations of all five gods.

Fire-cant rasped through river-prayer; Terra’s deep cadences passed into the twin wind-song. Buyakugan’s thunder-syllables struck through them like drums.

At times he seemed to speak two languages at once. Arcebek could not follow the movements of his mouth.

The circle of stones around them began to hum.

The hemp cord vibrated, little motes of dust jumping with each pulse.

Light rose from the elements, not the sky.

Not from the sky. From the elements.

The coals glowed. The pool shone blue from below; veins of gold lit the rock. Wind warped the glass, and lightning jumped from the twisted rod toward the bracelet.

The bracelet itself started to glow.

Each stone took on its own color. Light filled the fractures without erasing them, turning broken lines into luminous seams.

Arcebek felt the power moving.

It was not a neat current but a web of forces that crossed and fought. Primitive in its reliance on raw power; intricate enough to shame a learned ritualist.

Shade's breath hitched. The chant stumbled for a heartbeat, then recovered.

She felt his fingers clench around hers.

"Shade," she said, pitched low so as not to break the cadence. "You with me?"

"Yes," he ground out. "They are… arguing."

"Who?"

"Them." His chin jerked toward the bracelet. "They do not like… sharing."

Arcebek had rarely met powers that enjoyed sharing.

"Then remind them," she said. "They all signed up for this mess."

He laughed, a short, broken sound that got folded into the next line of the chant.

The light intensified.

The hollow became a crossroads of five elemental forces, each trying to claim the same breath of space.

Shade lifted their joined hands.

Energy rushed through their joined hands and into Shade. Enough crossed her skin to sting; no more.

She felt it pass through her too, enough to burn, not enough to kill.

The contact brought flashes of places she had never seen: a black sea beneath a green sky, a mountain crowned with lightning, dragons sleeping around cities inside a glass cavern.

Her patron, deep in the back of her mind, stirred.

What are you doing? her patron hissed in the recesses of her mind. You are borrowing a draconic god-binding—

Watch, she thought back, fiercely. And learn.

Shade trembled beneath her hands.

His eyes were still closed, but his face was pinched, jaw clenched hard enough that a human's teeth would have cracked.

“Almost,” he rasped, words twisting around the chant. “Almost. One more… turn.”

The light from the bracelet flared.

For a heartbeat, Arcebek saw the shape held inside the man.

A dragon vast enough to swallow the hollow: storm and fire, folded wings, horns like broken spires, eyes like stars split open. It did not replace Shade. It was Shade.

Primitive, her mind supplied. As old as the world.

The pattern of stones, cord and offerings gave that vastness channels without trying to imprison it.

Complex, she thought. More complex than she had dared imagine.

Then something settled into place.

Buyakugan’s fracture narrowed to a glowing seam.

The cracks in Ifret’s shard joined into a steadier pattern.

Terra’s gouge smoothed at the edges.

Fenris’ clouded gem cleared at its center.

Djing & Djang’s stone kept its dividing line, but the halves pulsed together at last.

The chant slowed.

One language at a time dropped away, until only Draconic remained, then that too faded.

The light sank back into stone and water, fire and air.

The hollow released its breath.

Shade opened his eyes.

His pupils were vertical, his irises layered with colors no human eye should hold.

For a heartbeat he seemed to see past Arcebek, through the lingering traces of the ritual. Then he blinked.

His eyes were blue again. He looked exhausted.

He let go of her hands.

His knees went out from under him.

Arcebek caught him before he struck the stone. Heat radiated through his shirt, as if he had spent hours inside a forge.

“Hey,” she said, voice low, fingers pressing to his cheek. “Stay with me.”

He leaned into her touch, eyes half-lidded.

“It worked,” he murmured. “They are… quieter. Less broken. Less likely to… tear.”

“Good,” she said. “Because you are not allowed to explode in my bed. Or anywhere, really.”

He made a noise that might have been a laugh. Or a groan. Or both.

She looked down at the bracelet.

The metal remained warped and the stones scarred, but light now filled their fractures. The damage looked less like failure than a bond remade.

“How do they feel?” she asked.

“Closer,” he said. “Less like… jailers. More like… very loud neighbors I have to live with.”

“You’re welcome,” she said.

He frowned, sleepy. “You… did nothing.”

She snorted. “I held your hands and yelled at five elemental gods in my head while you wrestled them into cooperating. Trust me, that counts.”

He smiled, more fully this time.

“Thank you,” he said softly.

She brushed damp hair off his forehead. “You’re welcome, Skyfall.”

They rested in the cooling hollow until the last glow faded from the stones.

Primitive and complex, she thought again.

Like Shade.

And, perhaps, like the life they were building together.

Chapter 14: A Life Taking Shape

The weeks acquired a rhythm Shade had never expected to enjoy.

Mornings belonged to the guild: notice boards, Lana's dry remarks, Varinel's complaints, and Jerrin and Lysa pretending they were already seasoned veterans.

Days took them along caravan roads, through a ghoul-haunted graveyard, and once to a shrine commandeered by a boar that refused to surrender its scratching post.

Evenings belonged to the Broken Anvil, cheap ale and Arcebek's laughter.

Nights were less predictable. Two doors opened in the inn corridor; most often, only one closed again. Sometimes they fell asleep before they managed to remove their armor. Sometimes sleep could wait.

Between jobs, they went back to the library.

Shade read so quickly that the librarian alternated between delight and suspicion. Arcebek usually claimed she was only there to keep him company, then emerged hours later with a stack of books of her own.

They also learned the city together.

Shade discovered the best baker, the tavern that watered its ale, the alleys where a man was likely to be robbed, and the rooftop of a flour warehouse where Arcebek had once slept off a hangover. They made the rooftop their place for watching stars.

It was an ordinary life, assembled one day at a time.

Work, study, celebration, companionship.

After a childhood of war councils and prophecy, Shade treasured how little of it seemed important to anyone else.

✦ ✦ ✦

One clear night, on that warehouse roof, Arcebek asked the question he had been avoiding.

Greenhollow settled below them, windows glowing in the dark.

They lay beneath constellations that were both familiar and wrong. Arcebek tucked her hands behind her head, her black braid loose across the roof; Shade sat beside her, fingers moving over his bracelet.

They had been laughing over Jerrin's latest foolish stunt and Varinel's feud with a squeaking floorboard when she went quiet.

"There's something you keep stepping around," she said.

"So," Arcebek said, watching her breath mist. "We've covered 'what you are' and 'why you're here.' Mostly. There's one bit you keep… stepping around."

He glanced down at her. "Which bit?"

"The dragons here," she said. "You've read the bestiaries. You've heard stories at the guild. Old wyrms in mountains, hoards and princesses, fire and teeth. You always get this…" she waved a hand near his face, "…look when people tell those tales."

"What look?" he asked, wary.

“The ‘I’m being polite but everything you’re saying is wrong’ look,” she said. “You haven’t said it, but I can feel it. You’re not the same thing we have here, are you?”

Shade considered how to explain it.

“No. I am not.”

She rolled onto her side, propping her head on her hand, watching him.

“Go on,” she said. “I promise I won’t tell the local dragons you’re talking behind their backs.”

His laugh faded as he looked up at the stars.

“In your world,” he said, “dragons are… apex predators. Old, powerful, tied to elements and places. They are of this reality. Born from it. Flesh and blood and magic as your people understand it.”

He searched for words that would sound like explanation rather than a boast.

“My mother’s brood,” he went on, “is older. Different. We are not… born of a realm. We came before realms.”

Arcebek’s brows rose. “Before realms,” she repeated. “As in…?”

“As in before there were any worlds like this to stand on,” he said. His gaze went to the stars. “Before there were weather patterns and gravity constants and the idea that time only moves in one direction.”

The admission left him feeling exposed.

Arcebek listened without interrupting.

“The first goddess,” he said slowly, “shaped us. Not this world’s first goddess. Ours. The one who looked at the Void and decided it was unacceptable.”

“The Void,” Arcebek said quietly. “As in the big, hungry nothing mages like to scare apprentices with?”

“Yes,” Shade said. “Except bigger. And hungrier. And not always… nothing.”

He opened and closed his hand, remembering.

“She made us as weapons,” he said. “Not just claws and fire. As… principles. Each of my mother’s brood is a harmony. Of element. Of law. Of… rule.”

“Rule as in ‘I tell people what to do’ or ‘gravity pulls you down’?” Arcebek asked.

“Both,” he said. “And more. The… binding rules. The structures that let anything exist at all instead of falling back into unshaped possibility.”

He looked for a comparison she could use.

“Imagine,” he said, “you are building a house. You need walls, roof, hearth. But before that, you need… rules. How wide a beam can be before it breaks. How heat moves. How stone holds weight. If you do not decide those, the house tears itself apart the moment you light a fire.”

“Sounds like some of the mage-tower projects I’ve heard of,” she muttered.

Shade smiled.

“We are that decision,” he said. “Given form. Each of us. My eldest aunt carries… gravity’s patience. She says what falls, how fast, and when it stops. Another uncle holds the laws of conservation—the idea that things do not come from nothing or become nothing, only change. My mother…” He glanced at his

bracelet. "…my mother binds storm and structure. Boundaries. The idea that there is an 'inside' and 'outside' and that the two do not mix without a cost."

"And you?" Arcebek asked softly.

Shade struggled to begin.

"I am…" he said, then stopped. Tried again. "I was made as… a bridge. Between. Between the rules that keep things in place and the changes that break them and make something new. Between dragon and human. Between realm and realm."

She let out a long breath. "That's… a lot."

"Yes," Shade said.

His gaze moved over the unfamiliar stars.

"When the first goddess went to war with the Void," he said, "she needed… soldiers who could fight on that scale. Not just swing claws at monsters. Fight concepts. Unravel the nothing-that-isn't. Stitch reality back together afterward. That is what my mother's generation did. They tore holes in the dark so others could pour light into it. They sealed cracks. They held edges."

"By the time I hatched, most of that war had ended—or moved elsewhere. I was made for what came after. Worlds that no longer faced the Void at every door, but still had weak places where reality could tear."

"You talk about 'rules' like other people talk about weather," Arcebek said.

"For us, they are the weather," he said. "We feel when they shift. When a world decides, 'Here, time will not work the same.' When a god says, 'In this place, fire does not burn as hot.' When a mage opens a hole and forgets to close it properly."

She settled back on the roof, looking up.

"So the dragons here," she said slowly, "are like… distant cousins. Same shape, different… job description."

"In a sense," he said. "They are… expressions of this world's rules. My kind are… the bones those rules grew around."

"Bones," she repeated. "You're walking around in the skeleton of reality, and you left that to come kill spiders for three silver a day."

He huffed. "It is not quite so simple."

"Pretty sure it is," she said. "Your mom: 'Go learn to be nice to mortals, Shade.' You: 'Fine, I'll go be a Bronze adventurer and see how often I can avoid turning mountains into glass.'"

He could hardly argue with that version.

For a while, they listened to the city: a dog barking, a door slamming, someone calling a child indoors.

"Why tell me now?" she asked finally. "Why this part?"

Shade thought before answering.

"Because," he said slowly, "the more time I spend here, the more… anchored I become. To your stories of what dragons are. To the way this reality… feels."

He flexed his hand, bracelet chiming softly.

“I needed you to know,” he said. “That when I speak of dragons, when I say ‘my kind,’ I am not talking about the wyrm in the eastern mountains who hoards gold and princesses. I am talking about… something you do not have here. Something your world never… needed. Or has not needed yet.”

“Yet,” she echoed. “That’s reassuring.”

He grimaced. “If the Void ever presses here as it did at home, your gods will have… strong opinions. You may see my kind then. I hope you do not.”

She turned to face him.

“Hey,” she said. “Look at me.”

He did.

“I don’t care,” she said.

He stared. “About…?”

“About what kind of dragon you are,” she said. “Or how many rules got stuffed into your bones before you were hatched. I care that when goblins grab girls, you go into the dark after them. That when your gods crack your seal, you fix it—not just with power, but with places. With shrines and stones and our rivers.”

She reached up and touched his cheek, thumb brushing the faint line where his helm sometimes pressed.

“I care that you sit in my bed and complain about badly written theology texts. That you sing for dead goblins. That you ask me if I’m afraid of you and then stay when I tell you the truth.”

Her hand slid down to his wrist, fingers brushing the bracelet.

“You say your kind were made before there were realms,” she said. “Fine. But you’re here now. In this reality. In my city. In my bed. That makes you part of our story too, Shade. Not just some… external audit of the rules.”

Shade swallowed.

“My mother would say,” he murmured, “that I am being… domesticated.”

“She’s welcome to come argue with me about it,” Arcebek said. “I’ll show her the contract. And the job board.”

Shade laughed so hard that she laughed with him.

The ache in his chest did not disappear, but he could breathe around it.

“Do your stories here,” he asked after a moment, “have dragons that… change?”

“What, like mid-life crisis, buy a new hoard, dye their scales?” she snorted. “Not really. Usually they show up, roar, get stabbed by heroes, or maybe decide not to eat one particular village because someone was kind to them. They don’t… question why they are the way they are.”

“Then perhaps,” he said softly, “someone should write one that does.”

Arcebek smiled.

“Maybe I will,” she said. “‘Once upon a time, there was a dragon built out of the rules of reality who came to our world to learn how not to break it.’”

He shook his head. “Too long for a title.”

“We’ll work on it,” she said. “We’ve got time.”

He turned toward her.

“Do we?” he asked, the question slipping out before he could soften it.

Her teasing softened.

“As much as anyone,” she said. “Maybe more, if your half-dragon constitution keeps cheating poison and old age. We can’t know. We never know. That’s what makes it… worth it.”

She moved behind him, wrapped her arms around his chest and rested her chin on his shoulder.

“Here’s what I know,” she said into his ear. “Right now, you’re on a roof in Greenhollow. The stars are wrong. The gods are annoyed. And you are mine.”

“Yours?” he echoed, heat creeping up his neck.

“For now,” she said. “For as long as you choose to be. Warrior of the first goddess or not.”

He placed his hands over hers. The familiar calluses and faint current of her magic grounded him more surely than any ward.

“For as long as I can choose,” he said quietly, “I choose this.”

“The guild?” she asked, teasing.

“You,” he said.

The stones stirred: Ifret warm, Fenris calm, Terra steady, Buyakugan amused, Djing & Djang delighted.

Far away, something took notice.

Perhaps his mother. Perhaps something older.

Shade acknowledged the presence for a heartbeat.

I am here, he thought, clearly. On a roof. In the rain sometimes. In a bed. In a guild. With her. Learning why your rules matter.

It offered no reply and withdrew toward older concerns.

Shade breathed out.

“Everything all right?” Arcebek asked, feeling the shift.

“Yes,” he said. “For the moment.”

“Good,” she said. “Then lie down. The roof’s hard, but I’m warm, and you still owe me a translation of that dirge.”

He lay beside her beneath the unfamiliar constellations.

For that evening, a dragon made of ancient laws and a warlock with fire in her eyes needed no grander purpose than each other.

Chapter 15: The Void Remembers

The nightmare struck without warning.

No gradual descent into sleep. One moment he was in bed; the next, memory tore open beneath him.

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He stood on nothing.

No rock, no air—only the thin, unyielding idea of here, suspended in an endless elsewhere.

Above—if there was an above—hung the Void Lord.

It had no fixed shape. His mind tried to give it one: a black serpent spanning the horizon; a crowned shadow draped in broken stars; a mouth that opened without end. Each time he looked, the shape changed. Something inside him frayed with it.

Its presence bore down from every direction, colder and heavier than an ocean of ice.

Far behind him, the goddess's armies held their lines.

Dragons interlocked their wings, breath weapons primed. Hosts of light stood beside angels wrought from equations and flame. Mortal magi, arranged in circles across distant worlds, sang in unison to keep the edge of reality from curling inward.

They needed more time.

That was why he stood here.

The Void Lord spoke without sound.

Why do you stand?

He heard nothing. The words simply appeared within him, in the places that still believed in beginnings, endings, and rules.

Shade was smaller here. Younger. No guild token at his belt, no bracelet on his wrist. Pure dragon, stretched to his full size: wings the length of cities, scales like storm-forged steel, horns and teeth catching light that wasn't light.

He had never felt so alone.

"Because someone must," he said, voice more vibration than sound.

The Void Lord's attention shifted. That was the closest it came to consideration.

You are insufficient, it said, with the indifference of a fact.

"Yes," he said. "That is why I was sent."

He remembered his mother's hand against his brow before the battle, heavy and almost gentle.

Hold, she'd told him. That's all. Hold. You don't have to win. You just have to make It look at you until we're ready.

The Void Lord advanced.

Not quickly, yet there was no time to react. Reality crumpled ahead of it like parchment in a flame. Everything it passed lost its name.

Shade drew breath.

Not air. Something more fundamental.

He exhaled lightning and binding and the idea of "no closer." He spat rules like spears: Here is distance. Here is time. Here is "you" and "me" and "between." Obey.

The Void Lord shredded his commands as though they were cobwebs.

They fought for every heartbeat.

He hurled every law woven into his being against the thing that should not exist.

Sometimes a rule held. For one precious heartbeat, its advance faltered. Those heartbeats were the entire point.

Most of the time, nothing held.

Reality peeled away behind him. Worlds dimmed; possibilities vanished. They were distant, but he felt each loss as sharply as a tooth breaking in his jaw.

He screamed until sound itself began to unravel. Then he rebuilt it, anchored it in law, and screamed again.

At last, a tendril of darkness reached him. He had no better word for it than a hand.

Everything he was—dragon, son, name, living law—shuddered. A part of him vanished without leaving even a scar.

So this is what dying feels like, he thought, in a place where death had not yet been invented.

Still, he held.

Behind him, the goddess and his elders were preparing the only strike that might matter. They needed their flanks secured, their boundaries fixed, their impossible weapon brought to bear.

He was there to keep the Void Lord looking at him.

To spend himself if he had to.

The shield.

He neither won nor lost.

Then the strike came. Light—not light as mortals knew it, but a declaration of everything permitted to exist—slammed into the Void Lord and drove it back. For a moment. Not defeated; delayed.

He had bought them time.

It wasn't the last.

✦ ✦ ✦

Shade woke with a sound caught between a shout and a growl.

The low timber ceiling of the Broken Anvil hung above him. Solid. Ordinary. The room smelled of woodsmoke and Arcebek's herbs. He was home—or as close as he had come to having one here.

His heart hammered. His skin still expected the Void Lord's pressure. The shadows among the rafters looked briefly like watching eyes.

The bracelet burned cold.

Ifret flashed. Buyakugan ticked like a broken heart. Terra rumbled. Fenris pulsed, steady. Djing & Djang whirled.

"Shade."

Arcebek's voice cut through the last of the nightmare.

He was half upright, gulping air. One hand had begun to shift; scaled fingertips, tipped with nails too sharp for a human, dug into the mattress.

Arcebek propped herself on an elbow, her black hair tangled around her face.

"Hey," she said. "Look at me."

He did.

Her palm settled against his cheek, warm and steady. "Where are you?"

He swallowed. His throat hurt.

"Here," he said, because he'd learned that much. "Room. Inn. Greenhollow."

"Good," she said. "Who am I?"

He almost smiled. "Arcebek. Warlock. Terrible influence."

"There he is," she murmured.

She scooted closer, tucking herself against his side. Her fingers brushed his wrist, feeling the frantic pulse of the stones.

"Void?" she asked. She did not call it a nightmare. She knew what memory could do.

"Yes," he said.

"You want to talk about it?" she asked. "Or just sit here and breathe till it stops smelling like there?"

He hesitated.

He had never told anyone all of it. Not his siblings, not even his mother. The goddess had once seen through his eyes, but that was different.

Arcebek waited without pressing him.

He took a slow breath.

"I stood alone," he said quietly. "Against a Void Lord. To buy time."

Her hand stilled on his wrist.

"Tell me," she said.

So he did.

Not all of it. Not at once.

But enough.

✦ ✦ ✦

“It was one of the early offensives,” he began. “Before the borders were settled. The Void had learned to exploit our rules. It shaped things that could enter a reality by obeying its laws—and then break those laws from within.”

“Like… parasites,” Arcebek said.

“Like lawyers,” he said. “But hungrier.”

She snorted softly.

“This one was vast,” he continued. “An echo of unmaking with a will of its own. It found a weak seam between two young realities. If it had crossed, both would have dissolved. Everything we had sacrificed to build them would have been lost.”

He stared past the wall.

“They needed someone in the gap. Someone who could hold both sides together while the goddess reinforced the seam. Someone the creature would find interesting enough to attack.”

“Bait,” Arcebek said, blunt.

“Yes,” he said.

“You were how old?” she asked.

He considered the question. Time had worked differently then. “Barely grown by our measure. Old enough to understand orders. Young enough to think surviving them was optional.”

She made a small, angry noise.

“They told me the plan,” he said. “Stand between. Keep it busy. Do not try to win. Winning was not the point. They were very clear.”

“And?” she asked.

“I tried to win.” His laugh held no amusement. “Of course I did.”

He described the pressure of the Void’s approach, the way meaning vanished in its wake, how every rule he set against it buckled. Most terrifying of all was the effort of holding back when every instinct demanded that he unleash everything.

“Anything I changed in myself to fight it would have echoed through every reality connected to me. If I reached too far, I could have broken the worlds I was defending.”

He flexed his fingers. He remembered wanting to abandon every limit and burn until there was nothing left to threaten him.

“So I held. If I had broken my own constraints, I would have stopped being a shield. I would have become another disaster.”

Her thumb rubbed circles on his wrist.

“You lost pieces,” she said.

“Yes,” he said. “It took parts of me. Names. Memories. Bits of the rules I carried. Some we grew back. Some… we did not.”

He searched the familiar gaps in his memory.

“There was a… place,” he said slowly. “A proto-world. Barely begun. It had only one law: ‘things fall down.’ It worshipped that law. Wrote poems about it. I held that law for it while I stood there. When the Void touched me, it scraped that law away from me.”

He smiled, crooked. “A few centuries later, someone checked on that world. Nothing fell down. Ever. People floated. Stones hung. Rain… went sideways. They had adapted. Built bridges in the sky. Learned to live in a place where nothing ever returned to ground.”

“Did you fix it?” she asked.

“No,” he said. “They had made it theirs. To impose my own idea of ‘down’ again… would have been cruelty. So I let that piece of me go. Their world taught me as much as I had ever given it.”

He told her more.

When the goddess had pointed at a thinning patch in existence and said, There, hold that seam while I mend it.

When he’d stood with his mother on the edge of a collapsing pocket universe, feeling souls flicker out like embers, choosing which small cluster of them to anchor back into realness and which to let go.

When a Void fragment had slipped into a world as a story, eating meaning from the inside, and he’d had to burn that story out of people’s minds, leaving them alive but… lighter. Missing something.

“Sometimes,” he said quietly, “I was the horror in someone else’s night. The thing that appeared in the sky and said, ‘You have to forget your gods now, they are contaminated. You have to never speak that name again.’ If I did not, the name would have eaten them.”

Arcebek listened, her jaw set.

“No mortal should endure those choices,” he said. “No one should have to look at a world and say, ‘This part survives. This part does not.’ But someone… must. Or everything falls. And so they sent us. My mother. My aunts. Me. Because we could see the rules. Because we were built to withstand the Void’s gaze longer than most.”

“And it still left marks,” she said softly.

He looked at his hands. “Yes.”

Neither spoke for a while.

His hands were trembling now. Speaking of it had cost him more than he expected.

Arcebek wrapped both arms around him and pulled him close. He let his forehead rest on her shoulder.

“You know what I’m hearing?” she said eventually, voice muffled in his hair.

“That I make poor decisions?” he said dryly.

“That you were a kid,” she said, “thrown into a war with concepts. Standing in front of things that eat meaning and saying, ‘Not today.’”

“I volunteered,” he said.

“You volunteered after being raised in it,” she shot back. “By people who thought ‘hold the seam against the unmaking of reality’ was a reasonable task to give their half-grown son.”

He huffed. “…Fair.”

She eased back far enough to meet his eyes.

“You talk about it like you were a tool,” she said. “A nice, sharp one, pulled off a rack when needed. Maybe that’s how your goddess sees you. Maybe that’s how your Matriarch likes to think of it. But you’re not a tool, Shade. Tools don’t lie awake after with nightmares about the things they carved.”

“Some of my siblings sleep very well,” he said.

“And they’re wrong,” she said. “Or broken in a different way. You’re… still you under all of that. That’s why you’re here at all. Why she sent you. Why you can stand in a goblin cave and care about three girls as much as a collapsing universe.”

He studied her face, trying to believe her.

“I was… afraid,” he admitted quietly, “that if I told you, you would see only the horror. The things I did. The things I failed to save.”

“I see those,” she said. “I’m a warlock, Shade, not a child. I’ve seen people do monstrous things for smaller stakes.” Her hand stroked the back of his neck once. “But I also see the boy who stepped in front of the Void because someone had to. And the man who woke up shaking because his mind still knows what that costs. And the idiot who thinks he has to carry that alone or it doesn’t ‘count.’”

“The Void Lord would say,” he murmured, “‘You are insufficient.’”

“Then the Void Lord can come argue with me,” she said. “I’ll introduce it to my patron and see which of them flinches first.”

He laughed despite himself, startled by the sound.

His breathing steadied. The room smelled of smoke and the spice in her hair, not the cold emptiness of the dream.

“Does it bother you,” he asked, “that I have… chosen different, here? That I do not answer every call to ‘hold the seam,’ that sometimes I let the world fix itself?”

“No,” she said. “It tells me you’ve learned something your goddess might not like: that you get to choose when to be a shield and when to be… just Shade. That you are not obligated to bleed on command for every crack in existence.”

“If I do not,” he said slowly, “some cracks widen.”

“Yes,” she said. “And if you try to fill all of them, you shatter. And then we have one more crack and no Shade at all. I am selfish enough to prefer the outcome where you live.”

He rested against her and closed his eyes.

“Stay,” he whispered.

“Obviously,” she said. “Go back to sleep, Skyfall. If the Void comes knocking, we’ll tell it visiting hours are over.”

“It does not knock,” he mumbled, already drifting.

“Then we’ll change the locks,” she said.

He smiled against her skin.

When sleep returned, it was gentler.

The Void remained in the deepest corner of his memory. But in his dream, a stubborn bronze-hued dwarf stood between him and the darkness, arms crossed, ready to argue with anything that approached.

The goddess had given him purpose.

The Void had given him scars.

Arcebek, inexplicably, insistently, gave him context.

For the first time in ages, the war was not the only story he knew how to tell.

Chapter 16: The Runaway Fairy

By the time Shade left the library, Greenhollow's streets were nearly empty.

Mist dampened the cobbles and blurred the last lanterns into pale halos. With a dry but useful treatise on planar bleed tucked under one arm, he headed for the Broken Anvil.

He was halfway down a side street when he heard a muffled yelp.

A scuffle followed. Then someone hissed, "Hold still, you little—"

Shade stopped.

The mist muffled the sound, but his hearing caught enough. He followed it into an alley smelling of stale beer and rain-soaked stone.

A dead end behind a shuttered warehouse. Three men and a woman waited in the thin moonlight, their plain clothes doing little to conceal their knives. One held a struggling sack. Another worked at an iron cage whose bars bore crude runes.

"Stop squirming," the woman growled, shoving at the sack. "You're still on the sleepy dust—"

Shade went still.

Through a tear in the sack he glimpsed silver-dusted wings. Powder leaked from the fabric. Someone inside gave a frightened sob.

He wanted to burn the alley clean.

Instead, he took one measured breath.

He stepped into the moonlight.

"Let go of her," he said.

All four turned.

The one with the sack sneered when he saw only a tall man in dark armor, helmet clipped to his belt, hair damp from the mist. "Back off," he said. "Guild business. Fairy caught drunk on spellwine near the wells. Lord Highbranch wants his property back."

The marks on the cage were not guild runes. They were designed to prevent a fey captive from escaping.

He let his hand settle on the hilt of his greatsword.

"I am guild," he said. "And she is not property."

One of them shifted, suddenly unsure. The woman spat. "You know what these things are worth?" she snapped. "What nobles pay to have one singing in a cage? You want to walk away with all your bones, stranger, you didn't see—"

Shade moved before she could finish.

Cold rage sharpened his movements, but discipline held it in check.

No dragonfire. No lightning. No wings.

Just steel and speed.

His sword flashed across the first man's throat. He turned and struck the woman with his gauntlet, dropping her. The third reached for a knife; Shade broke his wrist, seized the weapon, and drove it into his ribs.

The sack-bearer bolted for the alley mouth, still clutching his prize.

Shade caught him in three strides.

He hauled the man back by his collar before he reached the street.

Shade clapped a hand over his mouth.

"Quiet," he said, voice low and calm. "You do not want the guards to find you like this."

The man's eyes rolled wildly.

Shade drove him into the wall once, hard.

He slumped, boneless.

Seconds later, the alley was still.

Only the sack moved, its fabric rustling weakly against the stones.

Shade made himself release his grip on the sword. Two of the slavers lay dead; the other two would not be rising soon. He wanted to make certain none of them ever touched a fey again. But protection and revenge were not the same thing.

He knelt beside the sack and softened his voice.

"It is safe," he said, fingers finding the knot at the top of the sack. "I am going to open this. You may see blood. It is not yours."

The rustling stilled, as if whoever was inside held their breath.

He untied the rope and folded back the cloth.

The fairy inside was tiny.

Even for one of her kind, she was slight enough to fit between his cupped hands. Her moon-pale skin seemed to hold its own light. Damp, glacier-blue hair clung to her face. Translucent wings lay crumpled against her back, silver veins glimmering through them.

Her eyes remained closed. Feybane dust clung to her lips, and each shallow breath seemed an effort.

A runed iron cuff bit into one ankle. Shade felt his anger rise again.

He snapped the cuff and crushed it in his palm.

The fairy stirred, tiny fingers fluttering, then fell limp again.

He checked her pulse. Fast but steady. Bruises, no obvious broken bones.

He looked once at the four slavers.

The city watch would have work to do when they found them. Shade was not leaving the fairy here to supervise it.

He cleaned and sheathed his blade, then lifted her against his chest with both hands. She weighed scarcely more than his gauntlets.

“You are safe,” he told her unconscious form. “I will take you home.”

The promise stopped him. What counted as home for her?

He thought of Arcebek’s room, the charms hung at its window, and the woman who would scold him for taking risks before pulling him into a kiss.

For tonight, that was somewhere safe.

✦ ✦ ✦

Arcebek opened the door in her shift, hair loose, eyes narrowed.

“You’re late,” she began. Then she saw his hands.

“Okay,” she said, voice flattening. “There are exactly two explanations for you bringing a fairy into our room at this hour, and I’m really hoping it’s not the one involving weird new bedroom ideas.”

“She was in a sack,” Shade said. “With slavers. I did not… like it.”

Arcebek noticed the blood on his vambrace, the stiffness in his shoulders, and the care with which he held the unconscious fairy.

“Right,” she said. “Get in. Lock the door.”

He stepped inside; she slid the bolt.

They made room on the bed.

Arcebek fetched water, clean cloth, and her herb box. Against the blanket, the fairy seemed smaller still.

“Feybane,” Arcebek muttered, leaning down to sniff. “Watered-down, thankfully. They didn’t want to waste the good stuff.”

Arcebek’s anger showed in the set of her jaw, but her hands went straight to work.

“Help me sit her up,” she said. “Carefully. Don’t touch her wings unless you have to.”

He did as she asked, cupping the fairy’s back with two fingers, tipping her just enough that when Arcebek poured water between her lips, she could swallow.

They worked together until the worst of the dust had been washed away.

Arcebek rinsed the fairy’s mouth, wiped her face, and murmured a spell to clear the residue from her breathing. Shade held her steady.

Gradually, the fairy’s breaths deepened and her brow relaxed.

“She’ll sleep it off,” Arcebek said, sitting back on her heels with a sigh. “Fey are tougher than they look. Small doesn’t mean fragile.”

Shade remained beside the bed.

“She is beautiful,” he said.

Arcebek shot him a sideways look. “If you start talking about keeping her for a pet, I’m throwing you out the window.”

“I am not keeping a person as a pet. I was looking at her wings.”

“Closed eyes,” Arcebek said. “Which is how they’re going to stay until morning. You take first watch?”

“Yes,” he said immediately.

She didn’t argue.

Arcebek settled beneath a spare blanket on the floor. A few minutes later, her breathing slowed to the wary rhythm of an experienced adventurer.

Shade sat in the chair beside the bed.

He intended to remain awake.

He watched the fairy breathe and listened to the stones at his wrist settle into silence.

Eventually his eyes closed.

His dreams were mercifully absurd: a tiny dragon with fairy wings stealing his sword, and Arcebek arguing with a tree about rent.

He woke knowing he was being watched.

Very, very closely.

He opened his eyes.

Deep blue, slit-pupiled eyes stared back at him from less than a handspan away.

The fairy sat on the pillow’s edge, knees drawn to her chest, wings half folded, studying him with fascinated intensity.

Up close, he could see the almost luminous smoothness of her skin, the frost-blue hair falling to her waist, and the vertical pupils within her deep blue eyes.

Her pale freckles were nearly invisible against her skin. Delicately pointed ears peeked through her tangled hair.

A faint dusting of freckles crossed her nose, almost white. Her ears were delicately pointed, tips peeking through her hair.

When she saw him wake fully, she smiled.

“Hi,” she said.

Her voice chimed with a second note beneath every word, like a plucked string.

Shade, still half asleep, blinked at her.

“Hello,” he said.

“You’re noisy,” she said cheerfully.

He frowned, confused. “I am not speaking loudly.”

“Not your voice,” she said, tilting her head. “Your soul. It hums. Like a storm trapped in a bottle someone keeps shaking.”

He could think of no sensible reply.

“I am… working on that,” he said at last.

She giggled, delighted.

Behind him, the blanket pile moved.

“Tell your storm to hum quieter,” Arcebek’s muffled voice grumbled. “Some of us are trying to sleep.”

The fairy’s head snapped toward the sound. Her face lit up.

“Oh!” she gasped. “You’re awake! Good! Then I can say thank you properly and not just in my head where nobody can hear it.”

She bounced to her feet—barely the height of Shade’s forearm—and executed a surprisingly graceful little bow in Arcebek’s direction.

“Thank you for saving me from the sack and the cage and the very rude man who smelled like turnips,” she said in a rush. “I am very grateful and I would like to pay you back with three songs and maybe a small favor, but not the dangerous kind, unless you like dangerous, in which case we can negotiate.”

Arcebek sat up, hair wild, blanket around her shoulders like a bewildered cloak.

“Spirits above,” she muttered. “You’re a talker.”

The fairy beamed. “Yes! My tutors said so too.”

Shade cleared his throat gently. “You were… unconscious,” he said. “They used sleeping dust. How do you feel?”

She flexed her fingers, wriggled her toes, and tested her wings.

“Whole,” she said. “Bruised. Cranky. Not cursed… probably. Oh! Right.” She smacked her palm to her forehead. Tiny slap. “Introductions. Very rude of me.”

She straightened, placed a hand over her chest, and lifted her chin.

“My name is Rakihi of the Sapphire Dell,” she said with sudden formal dignity. “Third daughter of Queen Liranel of the Moonthorn Court. I am a princess. Technically. Please don’t tell anyone.”

Shade and Arcebek exchanged a look.

“Princess,” Arcebek repeated. “Of course.”

“A fairy princess,” Shade said. “On the run, I assume.”

Rakihi’s pupils widened, then narrowed in a way that suspiciously resembled guilt.

“Not on the run,” she protested. Then, a beat later, “On a… journey of self-directed education and artistic exploration without prior royal authorization.”

Arcebek snorted. “So, on the run.”

Rakihi threw her hands up, wings fluttering. “Fine, yes, on the run. My mother wants to marry me off to a boring old stodge with excellent bloodlines and absolutely no sense of rhythm. He wears beige. All the time. Even to festivals. I refuse.”

She crossed her arms, tiny foot tapping. “I want to travel. I want to hear songs in every tongue. I want to collect music from every tavern, every shrine, every battlefield. I want to write a ballad so big it makes the gods cry and the dead dance.”

Her eyes shone with the thought.

“I’m a sorceress,” she added proudly, “and a bard. My tutors say that’s ‘redundant’ and ‘a problem waiting to happen,’ but what do they know? They spend all day arguing about etiquette and the proper angle of curtsies.”

“What kind of sorcery?” Shade asked, genuinely curious.

She shrugged, a liquid, fluttering gesture. “Emotion. Sound. Light. I can make people feel things. I can turn stories into spells. I can make illusions, but only if the story behind them is good.”

Arcebek’s eyes sharpened. “Bardic sorcery,” she said. “Great. We picked up a walking disaster with wings and a soundtrack.”

Rakihi clapped her hands, delighted. “Oh! You rhyme without meaning to. Do you know how rare that is?”

She twirled on the bed and turned back to them, brimming with excitement.

“So!” she said. “Now that you’ve gallantly saved me from a lifetime of beige and boredom, what are your names? And may I write a song about you? I’ve already got the first line in my head.”

Shade bowed his head slightly. “I am Shade,” he said. “This is Arcebek.”

Rakihi gasped.

“The Shade?” she squeaked. “Storm-Knight Shade? Hillscourge? The dragon-that-walks?”

Shade went rigid.

Arcebek’s brows climbed. Slowly.

“Who is spreading that last one?” she asked in a dangerously sweet tone.

“Everyone,” Rakihi said happily. “Well. Not everyone. But a lot of someones. Stories travel faster than carriages. Especially when I help.”

She clasped her hands beneath her chin.

“And you’re Arcebek of the Bronze Circle,” she went on, turning to the dwarf. “Fire-singer. Pact-bright. I heard you blew up a ghoul nest and argued with a priest until he cried.”

Arcebek squinted at her. “Who’s telling that story?”

Rakihi grinned, impish. “Me. Soon. It’s going to be great.”

For once, her excitement softened into wonder.

“You’re so shiny,” she breathed. “Not just outside. Inside. All tangled up with each other and your gods and your past and the guild and the way you keep choosing not to run even when you’re afraid.” She sighed, theatrically. “I adore you both already. This is very inconvenient.”

“Inconvenient?” Shade asked.

“Because it means I want to stay, obviously,” Rakihi said, as if this were the most natural conclusion in the world. “Travel with you. Learn your songs. Help with your spells. Write epics about the time you kicked slavers into alleys and kissed on rooftops.”

Both Shade and Arcebek went very still.

Rakihi blinked, tilted her head. “Did you think I didn’t notice?” she asked. “You smell like each other. And contentment. And a little fear, but the good kind, like standing on the edge of a cliff with someone holding your hand.”

Heat rose to Shade’s ears.

Arcebek covered her face with one hand.

“We have been outed by a fairy we met three minutes ago,” she muttered. “Wonderful.”

Rakihi hovered close enough for Shade to feel the brush of her wings.

“Thank you,” she said, suddenly serious. The chiming lightness in her voice deepened. “For finding me. For being angry on my behalf. For killing the ones who would have caged me. I… felt that. Through the dust. I heard you tell me I was safe.”

She touched his cheek with a hand the size of a coin. Her fingers were cool, tingling faintly with residual magic.

“You’re very big,” she said solemnly. “And very dangerous. And you tried so hard not to be. I adore that.”

Shade struggled to swallow.

“You are… very small,” he said. “And very brave. Running from your queen, defying a dynasty for music.”

Rakihi wrinkled her nose. “Brave or stupid,” she said. “I’ll let the bards decide later. But if you let me,” she added, eyes bright again, “I would like very much to travel with you. For a little while. To pay you back. To keep you company in the library. To sing for your nightmares.”

Arcebek lowered her hand and looked at Shade over Rakihi’s head.

Her face plainly said that this was a terrible idea.

Her half-smile suggested she was considering it anyway.

Shade had only just learned that the fairy princess wanted to join their party. He needed a moment to think.

He let out a long breath.

“First,” he said, “you will rest. Eat. Recover. No decisions while you are still shaking.”

Rakihi blinked, then looked down at herself as if surprised to see her own bare toes trembling slightly.

“Oh,” she said softly. “Yes. That makes sense.”

She flopped back on the pillow, wings fanning out, hair spilling.

“But after that,” she continued, staring up at the ceiling, “I will absolutely ask again.”

Arcebek sighed.

“Of course you will,” she said. “Fine. One step at a time. No slavers. No beige weddings. No caging. We start there.”

She looked at Shade.

“We’re going to have to tell Lana,” she said. “And Varinel. And probably get a license for ‘portable royalty.’”

“I do not think there is such a license,” Shade said.

“There will be by the time the guild is done with us,” Arcebek muttered.

Rakihi giggled.

Only an hour earlier, their room had been quiet. Now it held a fairy princess who could turn an escape from slavers into a promise of adventure.

Shade had once lived to hold the boundaries of existence against the Void.

Now he was apparently collecting wayward royalty, warlocks, and songs.

He could not pinpoint when the change had begun.

He found he did not mind.

Chapter 17: A New Face

Lana did not shout.

He had learned quickly that Lana shouted only when she thought someone was merely foolish.

When she was truly angry, she lowered her voice.

“This,” she said, spacing each word with exquisite care, “is not in the handbook.”

Shade and Arcebek stood before her desk. Grig leaned against the shelves with folded arms and the expression of a man expecting a headache.

An iron slave-cuff, crushed flat, lay beside a scrap of sackcloth and a letter bearing the broken seal of the Moonthorn Court.

The letter had come that afternoon with a courier whose eyes were too bright to be entirely human. It reported the disappearance of the court’s third daughter, offered a reward for her return, and promised that interference would be remembered.

Lana tapped the letter with one finger.

“Let me see if I understand,” Lana said. “Last night, you stopped four slavers in an alley. Fine. A public service. You brought the fairy they were kidnapping back to your room. Questionable, but entirely in character.”

Arcebek opened her mouth. Lana held up a hand.

“You then,” she continued, “discover that your rescued fairy is not just any fairy, but a princess, currently ‘on the run’ from her mother the queen because she doesn’t want to marry a ‘boring old stodge in beige.’”

“Her exact words,” Arcebek said. “I could feel the beige in my bones.”

“Then you kept her overnight, didn’t tell the guild, and came to me this morning with the assurance that you had, and I quote, ‘made sure she wasn’t cursed.’”

Shade shifted his weight. “We… did not wish to cause panic,” he said carefully. “Or to have her immediately dragged back to the court.”

Grig snorted. “Congratulations,” he said. “You’ve just put yourselves between a fey queen and her runaway daughter. Do you collect dangerous patron figures on purpose, or is it some sort of curse?”

Arcebek spread her hands. “Look, we handled the immediate problem. No slavers. No cage. No drunk fairy accidentally hexing a tavern. We were going to bring her in.”

Lana pinched the bridge of her nose. “And what, precisely, did you expect me to do?” she asked. “File a form that says ‘Found: one princess, see attached lightning rod?’”

“We hoped the guild could help her stay safe without forcing her back into a marriage she does not want.”

Lana stared at him.

“And you thought this place,” she said slowly, “was a viable alternative to boring court life.”

“Yes,” Shade and Arcebek said together.

Grig barked a laugh.

Lana let out a long breath.

“All right,” she said. “Here’s what’s going to happen. For now, you do not inform the Moonthorn Court that we’ve laid eyes on her. If they ask, you saw nothing but suspicious slaver activity, which you heroically addressed. In the meantime, you keep her inside the city and out of sight of anyone who looks like they own more than one forest. Understood?”

“Yes,” Shade said.

“Understood,” Arcebek echoed.

“And,” Lana added, pointing her quill at both of them, “you do not let her sign any contracts, pacts, or binding agreements without me looking at them first. I am not losing a guildhall to fine print in fey poetry.”

“Has that happened before?” Arcebek asked.

“Not on my watch,” Lana said. “And I’d like to keep it that way.”

Grig shifted, eyeing Shade. “And you,” he said. “No firestorms. No hill-melting. No picking fights with queens. If this turns into a political incident, I want to be able to honestly say ‘we tried to sit on them.’”

“I will not… antagonize her mother,” Shade said. Then, because honesty was a habit now, added, “Unnecessarily.”

Grig gave him a long look. “That’s the best I’m going to get, isn’t it.”

“Yes,” Arcebek said.

“Fine. Go and fetch your fairy. Try not to adopt any more royalty along the way.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They returned to the Broken Anvil in silence.

Carts and apprentices crowded Greenhollow’s late-afternoon streets. Two adventurers wrestled with a crate that clucked ominously, but Shade barely noticed. He was thinking about fey courts, centuries-old grudges, and the fine line between offering sanctuary and provoking a queen.

Arcebek glanced up at him as they climbed the stairs.

“Hey,” she said. “You look like you’re about to stand between a Void Lord and a baby realm again.”

“Fey queens are… different,” he said. “But not less dangerous.”

“Good thing we’re idiots then,” she said, patting his arm. “Idiots get away with things smart people overthink.”

Shade doubted that was sound political theory, but her grin eased the tension in his chest.

He unlocked their room.

He pushed the door open—and stopped.

Stopped.

Someone was lying across their bed.

She looked almost exactly like Rakihi.

Same moon-pale skin, light blue hair, and deep blue eyes with their narrow pupils. She lay on her stomach reading, idly kicking her feet.

But she was much bigger.

Only a little shorter than Arcebek, she had the proportions of a small humanoid rather than a palm-sized fairy. Her wings were gone.

The wingless Rakihi looked up when they entered.

Her face brightened.

“You’re back!” she chirped, snapping the book shut and sitting up cross-legged. “How did the yelling go?”

Shade stared.

Arcebek narrowed her eyes.

“Explain,” Arcebek said.

Rakihi beamed like this was all going exactly to plan.

“I shapechanged!” she announced. “So my parents or their men aren’t going to find us. I’m going to be an adventurer like you two.”

She spread her arms, presenting herself for inspection.

“What do you think? I used Auntie Miralin’s ‘walk-among-mortals’ trick. Fixed the wings, adjusted the height, added a little ‘do not notice me unless I’m being very dramatic.’ It’s not perfect, but it’ll do until I learn your tailor’s magic.”

Shade opened his mouth.

Closed it.

Opened it again.

“You… changed shape,” he said slowly. “Permanently?”

“Permanently for now,” Rakihi said. “It’s a stable glamour anchored to my core. I can drop it if I need to escape through a keyhole, but that would be silly unless we want my mother to trace me.”

Arcebek pinched the bridge of her nose. “Rakihi,” she said, in the tone of someone bracing for impact, “what part of ‘hide from your extremely powerful mother with very good scryers’ translates to ‘follow the two loudest souls in the city around and sign up to fight goblins for pocket change’?”

Rakihi scooted to the edge of the bed, eyes shining.

“The part where you and Shade are the most interesting thing that’s happened to me ever,” she said. “The part where I saw you both glow when you thought no one was looking. The part where I decided that if I went back to the Dell and married Beige McBorehouse instead of seeing what happens to a dragon and a warlock who keep choosing not to be monsters, I would regret it forever.”

Shade’s ears went pink.

Arcebek stared at her. “That’s… flattering,” she said. “And terrible.”

Rakihi clasped her hands. “I want to do things,” she said earnestly. “Not just be sung about. I have magic. I have music. I can help. I can weave courage into your bones before a fight, tangle fear in your enemies’ feet, make your stories stick in people’s minds so hard that queens think twice before crossing you.”

She leaned forward, pupils wide. “And I don’t want to do it alone.”

Shade and Arcebek exchanged a glance.

It was the sort of look exchanged by people who had just realized they might be responsible for a runaway princess.

Shade cleared his throat. “Rakihi,” he said carefully. “Adventuring is not… safe. You saw slavers last night. There are worse things. Goblin hordes. Undead. Demons. Contracts that bind more than your name. If your mother discovers you with us, she may decide we are… stealing you.”

“She already thinks that if I’m gone more than a day,” Rakihi said bluntly. “At least this way it will be true on my terms.”

Arcebek pointed a finger at her. “You don’t get to volunteer for being kidnapped by us,” she said. “That’s not how this works.”

Rakihi huffed. “I’m not a child,” she said. “By my court’s reckoning, I’m two hundred and seven. That’s… what, early thirties in human years? I’ve had three tutors, four lovers, and one extremely boring fiancé. I can make my own choices.”

“That’s… fair,” Shade admitted, because it was, and because he had been volunteering for suicide missions at her apparent age.

Arcebek gave Shade a look of betrayal.

“Don’t you dare empathize with her yet,” she said. “We’re still in the ‘argue’ part of this conversation.”

He spread his hands, helpless. “It is… familiar,” he said. “To run from a path chosen for you. To seek a different war.”

Rakihi’s expression softened. “See?” she said to Arcebek. “He gets it.”

Arcebek groaned.

She paced between bed and wall, blanket trailing. “Okay,” she said. “Let’s pretend, for a moment, that we consider this. There are rules. Guild rules. Magic rules. My rules.”

Rakihi bounced a little. “Rules I can work with. Lay them on me.”

“First,” Arcebek said, ticking off fingers. “No using mind-magic on us. No nudging our feelings, no ‘tiny harmless’ suggestion spells, no improving our moods without asking. My head is full enough.”

Rakihi nodded solemnly. “Consent, got it. I won’t meddle with your heartstrings unless you ask me to tune them.”

“Second,” Shade said quietly. “You do not speak our… deeper truths to strangers. About what I am. About Arcebek’s patron. About the gods on my wrist. Secrets stay secret unless we agree.”

Rakihi put a hand over her heart. “I swear,” she said. “Cross my core, hope to fall.”

“Third,” Arcebek went on. “You listen to Varinel in a fight. He says ‘down,’ you go down. He says ‘run,’ you run. He’s grumpy, but he’s alive, and that’s not an accident.”

“Grumpy elf in charge of running away, understood,” Rakihi said.

“And fourth,” Arcebek added, eyes narrowing, “you don’t make songs about things that will get us murdered while we’re still in the same town. You want to write an epic about how Shade glassed a goblin nest? Fine. You sing it in the next city, not at the bar where the goblins’ cousins drink.”

Rakihi winced. “Okay, yes, fair. I can work with that. I can be… tactically truthful.”

They exchanged another glance.

Arcebek sighed.

“We’re going to regret this,” Arcebek said.

“Likely,” Shade said.

She turned back to Rakihi. “All right, princess. On one condition.”

“Anything,” Rakihi said instantly.

“Stop calling yourself a princess in public,” Arcebek said. “At least in this shape. You’re ‘Rakihi’ or ‘Raki’ or ‘R’ or literally anything else. I’m not spending the next year explaining to irritated dukes why there’s fairy royalty in a Bronze party.”

Rakihi’s grin could have lit the room.

“Done!” she said. “I’ve always wanted a traveling name anyway. Rakihi, then. Or ‘Ki.’ Or ‘The Uncaged Melody.’”

“Don’t push it,” Arcebek said.

Shade exhaled. “We will need to bring you to the guild,” he said. “To register. Get you on the books. Lana will not like surprises.”

Rakihi clapped her hands. “Adventure registration forms! Do I get a token? A badge? A dramatic test where I defeat a training dummy with song?”

“Mostly you get Lana,” Arcebek said. “Which is far worse.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Lana stared at the wingless, blue-haired young woman they brought into the guildhall. Then at Shade. Then at Arcebek. Then back again.

She didn’t say anything at first. Just stared. Then looked at Shade. Then at Arcebek. Then back at Rakihi.

Finally, very calmly, she said, “Is this the part where you tell me you’ve lost the fairy princess and replaced her with a completely different problem?”

Rakihi stepped forward, beaming, and offered her hand.

“Hello!” she chirped. “I’m Rakihi. Traveler. Musician. Totally-not-a-princess. I would like to become an adventurer, please.”

Lana looked at her hand like it might explode.

“She shapechanged,” Arcebek explained. “To avoid being tracked. She wants to register.”

“That’s impossible,” Lana said.

Rakihi wiggled the fingers of her proffered hand. A tiny spark of blue light danced between them, resolving into a flickering illusion of her "true" self—small, winged, glowing—then snapped back into her current form.

"Apparently not," Lana muttered.

Grig, who had been going over a mission scroll at a nearby table, wandered over. He eyed Rakihi up and down.

"Name," he grunted.

"Rakihi," she said.

"Full name," Lana said.

"Rakihi," she repeated sweetly. "Just Rakihi. The rest is under a magically binding contract of Not The Guild's Problem."

Lana closed her eyes for a second. "Fine," she said. "We'll put it down as 'Rakihi.' Species?"

Rakihi considered. "Most recently… humanoid fey," she said. "Formerly full-blooded fairy. Functionally? Sorcerer-bard."

"Class: arcane support," Lana translated, scribbling. "Age?"

"Two hundred and seven," Rakihi said.

Lana paused. "Physical or metaphysical?"

"Both?" Rakihi said hopefully.

"Putting you down as 'adult,'" Lana said. "Any notable enemies I should know about besides 'generic slavers' and 'beige fiancé'?"

Rakihi's smile turned sharp. "My mother might send people to look for me," she said. "If she asks, you have never heard of me. For your own safety, which I care about deeply now that you're part of our story."

Lana stared at her.

Then she turned to Shade and Arcebek.

"You two," she said quietly, "have a talent for turning my administrative job into a religious experience."

Arcebek winced. "We can… take her out of town for a while," she offered. "Fewer eyes. Fewer letters."

"I'm going to put you all on long-range patrol rotation," Lana said. "Far-flung villages. Remote ruins. Places where if a fey queen shows up, we have time to run."

"That sounds lovely," Rakihi said.

Grig grunted. "Can she fight?" he asked.

Rakihi perked up. "I can demonstrate!" she said.

She lifted her hands—then caught Arcebek's glare and paused.

"With a harmless spell!" Rakihi amended. "Promise."

She snapped her fingers.

A soft, bright chord rang through the guildhall. For a moment, everyone within earshot straightened unconsciously: shoulders squaring, spines lengthening, eyes a little clearer. The room felt a fraction less tired.

Shade felt courage wash through him, gentle but real, like stepping into warm sunlight.

Rakihi let the note fade, then shrugged.

“Basic bolstering,” she said. “I can also do the opposite to enemies. Make them feel like their shoelaces hate them and their grandmothers are disappointed.”

Grig scratched his chin. “That’ll do,” he said.

Lana sighed and pushed the finished form across the desk for Rakihi’s thumbprint.

“Welcome to the guild, Rakihi,” she said. “Provisional Bronze. You travel with Shade and Arcebek’s party. You do not sign any other contracts without me. You do not mention the Moonthorn Court in job debriefings. And if your mother shows up, you will personally explain to her why my blood pressure is her problem.”

Rakihi pressed her thumb to the parchment. A faint shimmer passed over it.

“Deal,” she said, eyes sparkling.

Something settled in Shade’s chest.

Another thread had joined his life: a dragon, a warlock, a grumpy elf, two reckless young adventurers—and now a fairy princess with a gift for songs and trouble.

He glanced at Arcebek.

Her expression held equal parts affection and resignation.

“We are absolutely doomed,” she murmured.

“Yes,” Shade said. “But we will be… less alone.”

Rakihi slipped between them, hooking an arm through each of theirs.

“Come on!” she sang. “Let’s go find a job that doesn’t mention beige or queens. I have so many songs to write and so much trouble to collect.”

Lana dropped her head to the desk.

Grig snorted.

Shade allowed Rakihi to pull him away, the stones on his wrist humming beneath her excited chatter and Arcebek’s dry laughter.

Chapter 18: The Road to the Trolls

The road to the trial village seemed determined to go on forever.

There were no scenic overlooks or interesting ruins to break the monotony—only rutted earth, low hills, and scrub trees repeating themselves all the way to the horizon.

“Remind me,” Varinel said from the front, “why we agreed to take a trial mission this far from civilization.”

“Because Lana wants us out of sight,” Arcebek called back. “And because she controls our pay.”

“And,” Rakihi added, “because destiny.”

Rakihi walked between Shade and Arcebek, humming an unfinished tune with her staff balanced across one shoulder. Even in her wingless form, she moved with a fey lightness, as though walking were another kind of dance.

Jerrin and Lysa trailed behind, arguing quietly about whose turn it was to clean the cooking pot.

The midday sun beat down on the road. A breeze teased Djing & Djang’s crystal, drawing a contented hum from the stone.

Three hours into the walk, Rakihi decided the time had come to clarify something.

“Shade,” she said brightly. “Arcebek. Important topic.”

Both answered with the same wary hum.

“Mmh?”

“Mmm?”

Rakihi grinned. The reaction had clearly been worth it.

“I just wanted to be absolutely, unequivocally clear,” she said, “that I am, in fact, a fully grown woman.”

Shade blinked. “We know. You told us your age.”

“Yes,” Rakihi said. “But I’ve seen the way mortals sometimes look at wingless fey and think ‘oh, small, fragile, baby thing.’ I am not that. I am small only in the sense that your bed is small and that’s really more of a structural issue.”

Arcebek made a choked sound that could have been a cough or a laugh.

At the head of the party, Varinel began to chuckle.

Rakihi carried on as if she hadn’t heard him.

“I have had tutors, education, extremely boring court obligations, two serious lovers, one unserious lover, and a fiancé so dull he could put a dragon to sleep mid-roar,” she said. “I can vote in three different fey councils if I want to, and I have vices.”

“Vices,” Arcebek repeated, her voice catching. “Of course you have vices.”

“Yes,” Rakihi said serenely. “Wine. Music. Adventure. And…” she glanced between them, eyes gleaming, “…company.”

Heat crept into Shade’s ears.

“I see,” he said.

“Do you,” she said, much too innocently. “I’m not sure you do. So. Let me put it this way.”

She waited until Jerrin and Lysa had fallen back, still disputing the cooking pot, before lowering her voice.

“I have needs,” she said conversationally. “And I prefer them met by people I like and admire, not by strangers in beige.”

Shade stumbled over a rock he could have avoided with his eyes closed.

Arcebek’s eyes widened, then narrowed. “Rakihi,” she warned.

Rakihi batted her lashes. “I’m not asking for anything. Yet,” she said. “I’m just… informing. So that when I flirt, you don’t mistake it for—what’s the human term—youthful confusion.”

“You’ve definitely skipped that stage,” Arcebek muttered.

“If my mother tracks me down and insists I ‘come home and behave,’” Rakihi went on airily, “I want it on record that I have lived properly recklessly first. With songs and fights and kisses I chose myself. Clear?”

Shade cleared his throat. “I believe the record is very clear.”

The mischief in Rakihi’s expression eased.

“Good,” she said. “I like you both. A lot. You glow in very interesting colors when you think no one’s watching. I intend to enjoy that. Respectfully. And loudly, when appropriate.”

“That sentence worries me,” Arcebek said.

“You worry too much,” Rakihi said, bumping her shoulder lightly against Arcebek’s. “You’ve got love, war, and a dragon who reads theology for fun. You’re allowed to also have someone around who reminds you that life is more than not dying.”

Ahead of them, Varinel abandoned any attempt to hide his laughter.

He turned and walked backward for several paces, eyebrows raised.

“I’m enjoying this,” he said. “Deeply. Please, do continue.”

Shade shot him a flat look. “You are not helping.”

“I’m not trying to,” Varinel said. “It’s not every day I get to watch a dragon and a warlock get flustered by someone else’s chaos.”

Jerrin finally caught enough of the conversation to pipe up. “What’re we talking about?”

“Taxes,” Arcebek said instantly.

“Grown-up stuff,” Rakihi added. “You can listen in when you’ve survived your first demon encounter.”

Jerrin paled. “Let’s… delay that, yeah?”

Lysa elbowed him. “You first.”

Rakihi’s laughter rang down the road, and even Arcebek smiled.

They pressed on.

When the others fell behind again, Rakihi drew closer to Shade.

“I mean it, you know,” she said, quieter now. “About being grown. About choosing. I don’t want to cause… problems between you and Arcebek.”

Shade glanced at her. “You have already caused problems,” he said. “Just by existing. Feral queens. Political tension. Lana’s headaches.”

Rakihi winced. “Okay, yes, those problems. But I mean…” She gestured vaguely between the three of them. “If I flirt, it’s because I want to. If you’re uncomfortable, you tell me to stop. If she’s uncomfortable, she tells me to stop. Consent, boundaries, all that lovely ‘this is a mess but we’re adults’ stuff.”

He studied her face.

The mischief was still there, but so was something older and steadier—an understanding of choice that he recognized.

“I understand,” he said. “And I will… speak, if it is too much.”

“Good,” she said. “Because the last thing I want is to make either of you feel boxed in. That’s what I ran from. I will not become it.”

The words carried more weight than her teasing had.

He nodded once, gravely. “Agreed.”

She gave him a crooked smile and straightened, her familiar mischief returning.

“So,” she said loudly enough for Arcebek to hear, “tell me more about your first lover, Shade. I want to know if my ballad should include the phrase ‘thighs like tree trunks’ or ‘hips like a battlefield.’”

Shade nearly choked.

Varinel laughed so hard he had to stop walking and lean on his bow.

Arcebek muttered something in Dwarvish that probably wasn’t polite.

The miles passed. No one could accuse the journey of being dull.

✦ ✦ ✦

The village appeared near sunset, its rooftops huddled in a shallow valley against the dark edge of the forest.

Rakihi had exhausted most of her scandalous questions and turned to the appalling lack of tavern music on this “endless mud-walk.”

Shade had begun to find her teasing amusing, despite himself. Arcebek’s exasperation had softened into something suspiciously like fondness.

Varinel was still smirking.

At the last rise, a warning prickled across Shade’s skin. Not the vast wrongness of the Void, but something nearer: a patient hunger waiting beyond the treeline.

He glanced at Rakihi.

“Time to see,” he said quietly, “how you work in the field, Rakihi-not-a-princess.”

Her slit pupils narrowed. Magic gathered at her fingertips.

Her grin returned, sharp-edged now.

“Oh good,” she said. “I was starting to worry this trial mission would be boring.”

Beside him, Arcebek rolled her shoulders, sigils on her throat warming.

Varinel nocked an arrow. Jerrin drew his sword, and Lysa checked the string of her bow.

Together they descended toward the village: a dragon in human shape, a warlock, a sour old ranger, two young adventurers, and a wingless fairy bard about to learn what a guild trial could cost.

The stones on Shade’s wrist stirred as they approached the trees.

Beneath his memories of older wars, Shade felt the familiar readiness settle into place.

This was no battlefield against the Void.

It mattered all the same.

And this time, he had people beside him.

Chapter 19: Trial by Troll

Trolls.

Of course it had to be trolls.

They smelled the trolls before they saw them: wet fur, rotting meat, and the sour reek of mushrooms left too long in a cellar. Then branches snapped under a weight the undergrowth could barely conceal.

The first troll shouldered out of the trees, grey-green and warty, its arms hanging past its knees and broken tusks jutting from its mouth. Shade had already drawn his sword.

“Two more to the left,” Varinel snapped, dropping to one knee with an arrow drawn.

The others crashed into view. One dragged a cow carcass by the hind leg; the second was chewing on something best left unidentified.

“Rakihi,” Shade warned. “They regenerate. Fire or acid will stop it.”

“On it.” Her playful expression vanished.

The first troll lunged at Shade, and his greatsword met it with a clang that shook his arms. Varinel’s arrow struck the creature’s throat; it tore the shaft free and kept coming.

To Shade’s left, Jerrin drove his sword into another troll’s forearm, only to watch the wound knit shut around the steel.

“Back!” Varinel barked. Lysa loosed an arrow to cover the boy’s retreat.

Then Rakihi sang. The note cut through the clearing, sharp enough to stagger all three trolls. Arcebek hurled a bolt of molten fire at the creature holding Jerrin’s sword; its arm caught, and the closing flesh blackened.

Shade stepped into the gap and severed the burning limb. The trolls howled.

Rakihi struck her staff against the earth, turning their advance into a struggle through mud. For the first time since the ambush began, the party had room to fight.

✦ ✦ ✦

When it was over, the clearing was churned mud, shattered branches, and pieces of troll that had finally stopped moving.

Black blood smoked on Shade’s armor. Arcebek’s braid had come loose, strands of hair plastered against her cheeks while the sigils on her throat glimmered with fading heat. Varinel leaned on his bow, breathing hard. Jerrin and Lysa looked several years older.

Rakihi stood in the wreckage, mud on her dress and leaves in her blue hair, grinning as though she had just finished a particularly fine performance.

She had earned that grin.

Rakihi had held the trolls in place with song and mud while Shade and Arcebek burned away their ability to recover. Even when the creatures tried to separate the party, she kept their formation intact.

Later she had scrambled onto a troll’s back, wedged her staff between its tusks, and sung a note that locked its jaws until Shade took its head off.

Now she wiped a smear of black blood from her cheek and beamed at them.

“Well,” she said. “That was disgusting. Can we do it again?”

“No,” Varinel said. After a pause, he added, “You did well. All of you. Nobody lost a limb, which is better than most troll hunts.”

Jerrin was still staring at the largest corpse. “They grow back,” he muttered. “That arm I chopped off grew back.”

“Then Rakihi burned the stump, and it stayed gone,” Lysa said, still shaking. “I think I love you.”

Rakihi blew her a kiss. “Get in line,” she said cheerfully.

Shade watched the treeline until he was satisfied that nothing else was coming. Three trolls, and no sign of a larger nest.

“The village is safe,” he said. “For now.”

“Then let’s go tell them that,” Arcebek said. “Before Rakihi starts writing music about ‘The Ballad of the Three-and-a-Half Trolls’ and forgets to mention we’re still on the clock.”

“I was going to call it ‘The Ballad of the Three-and-a-Half Trolls,’” Rakihi said.

“There were three,” Arcebek reminded her.

“One was unusually large. I’m rounding up.” Rakihi led the way back before Arcebek could answer.

✦ ✦ ✦

The village was a scattering of houses behind a modest palisade, with a sagging shrine and an inn that leaned only slightly less. Dogs barked at the strangers, then retreated behind barrels at Shade’s approach.

The elder met them outside the largest house, twisting a cap between his hands.

“Well?” he asked. “The… things? In the woods?”

“Three trolls,” Varinel said. “Dead. We found no larger nest, but keep your hunters wary. Trolls wander.”

The elder’s shoulders sagged in relief. “We’ve lost two goats and a cow this past fortnight,” he said. “I feared… worse.”

“It could have been worse,” Arcebek said. “Now it isn’t. Let the guild know if you see bigger tracks. Or smell something worse than your outhouses.”

Shade managed not to flinch at that.

They obtained the elder’s signed confirmation and accepted his insistence on paying them in food as well as coin. Within the hour they were seated in the inn before bowls of stew and fresh bread.

By the time the common room fire had burned down to embers, everyone was exhausted.

When Arcebek asked about rooms, the innkeeper spread her hands in apology.

“Traders came through this afternoon. I’ve one room left—three beds. If you don’t mind crowding, I’ll lower the price.”

Varinel immediately pointed at Shade, Arcebek, and Rakihi. “They’ll take it,” he said. “We’ll bunk in the loft. I call the spot furthest from Jerrin’s snoring.”

Jerrin sputtered. “I don’t snore that—”

He did, spectacularly.

Before Shade could formulate an argument about spacing and propriety, Arcebek had already taken the key.

“Fine,” she said. “We’ll manage. Come on, you two.”

Rakihi practically skipped up the stairs.

✦ ✦ ✦

The room held three narrow beds, a rickety table with a cracked washbasin, one chair, and pegs for their cloaks.

Rakihi spun in a little circle as they entered, arms out.

“Cozy,” she declared. “Perfect for post-battle bonding.”

Shade set his pack beside the bed under the window. For some reason, he was more nervous now than he had been facing the trolls.

Arcebek closed the door and stood against it for a breath, eyes shut.

“Are you hurt?” Shade asked, stepping closer, scanning her with the automatic thoroughness of someone who’d patched too many wounds.

“Bruised. Singed a sleeve. My pride survived.”

He nodded. “Rakihi?”

Rakihi had already begun peeling off her muddy outer dress, grimacing at a dark stain along its hem.

“Fine,” she said. “Their claws sting, but I had wards up. I’ll need a bath and someone to tell me I was amazing, in that order.”

“You were amazing,” Shade said gravely.

She paused mid-boot removal, looked up, and beamed.

“See?” Rakihi told Arcebek. “He gets it.”

Arcebek rolled her eyes, but there was warmth in it. “Get your boots off the bed before I set them on fire,” she muttered. “Shade, bowl?”

Shade filled the basin, and they washed away blood and dirt with the practiced efficiency of travellers. They checked each other for injuries that the urgency of battle might have hidden.

Soon Shade was in a linen shirt and trousers, Arcebek in a long tunic and leggings, and Rakihi in a loose shift, her freshly washed hair still damp.

There were three beds.

Rakihi considered the beds as if presented with a riddle.

“So,” she said. “Arrangement discussion. My favorite kind of logistics.”

Shade blinked. “Arrangement?”

“Who sleeps where,” she said, as if that were obvious. “We could do the sensible thing and each take one. Or…”

She trailed off, eyes sparkling.

“Or?” Arcebek said warily.

“Or,” Rakihi said, “we could admit it’s cold, we like one another, and we’re adults with a sensible appreciation for warmth.”

Shade made a small, strangled noise.

“I snore,” Shade offered.

“I’ve heard worse,” Arcebek said. “Jerrin sounds like a dying goat. You’re fine.”

Rakihi threw herself across the middle bed, arms and legs spread.

“I volunteer as center,” she proclaimed. “Fair arbiter of blanket distribution. No one wakes up on the floor. We all get to complain about elbows in the night. Democracy.”

Arcebek looked at Shade. He was gripping the back of the chair as if it could help him negotiate his way out of this.

He was standing with one hand on the back of the chair, expression stuck somewhere between this is inappropriate and this is my life now.

Rakihi rolled onto her side and propped up her head.

“Unless,” she said innocently, “either of you thinks you can’t be trusted to behave with me within accidental-touching distance. In which case, I understand, and I will dramatically sigh and take the window bed alone while composing tragic verses about unfulfilled possibility.”

Shade’s jaw worked. “I can behave,” he said stiffly.

Arcebek huffed. “Same. It’s not like we haven’t all been crammed into a tent before.”

“Exactly,” Rakihi said. “Except now the tent has walls and we’re less likely to be eaten by owlbears in our sleep. Progress!”

In the end they each claimed a bed: Shade beneath the window, Arcebek against the far wall, Rakihi in the middle.

The arrangement lasted three minutes.

Shade had just settled under his thin blanket, staring at the ceiling, when the mattress dipped beside him.

Rakihi wriggled backward until her back was against his side, blanket tugged up over both of them, humming softly.

“Rakihi,” he said, because he felt he ought to.

“Mm?” she said. “You’re warm. I’m cold. This is an optimal solution.”

“Your bed is in the middle,” he said. “You’re supposed to be there.”

“And now I’m in the middle between your arms and Arcebek’s patience,” she said. “Even better.”

On the other side, Arcebek groaned.

“If I wake up and find a fairy hand in my shirt,” she said, “I’m hexing you bald.”

“Rude,” Rakihi said. “I would never touch you without asking. Unless you were having a nightmare, in which case it would be a purely comforting, non-sexual boob-pat.”

Shade made a choking sound.

“Flustered?” Rakihi asked, wickedly pleased. “Good. It means your heart’s still working.”

Arcebek rolled onto her side to face them. In the dim light, her expression was difficult to read.

“You’re impossible,” she told Rakihi.

Rakihi’s smile gentled. “Yes,” she said. “And also grateful. And also very, very happy to be here. With you. Both of you.”

For a moment, none of them joked.

Shade felt the significance of it: Rakihi, who could have fled in any direction, had chosen to remain with them.

He exhaled slowly.

“Sleep,” he said. “We have… more trolls to avoid tomorrow. Or worse.”

“Mm,” Rakihi said, nestling in. “Sing us something, Shade.”

“You know the words,” he said.

“Your voice,” she insisted. “Please. I like how the world feels when you sing.”

Arcebek watched him over Rakihi’s head, one corner of her mouth ticking up.

“Dirge-lite?” she suggested. “Something without ‘and then the world burned’ in the third verse.”

Shade thought a moment, then began to sing.

It was not a dragon dirge, but an old marching song his aunt had sung between distant watchposts: weary feet, aching shoulders, shared water and bad jokes, and the stubborn decision to keep walking because someone beside you still could.

Not the full dragon dirge. A softer thing, an old marching song his aunt had sung once when they’d walked between watching posts. It had the same shape of grief, but laced with stubborn hope: verses about tired feet, bruised shoulders, shared water, shared jokes. About walking on anyway because the person next to you was still moving.

Rakihi’s eyes closed. Arcebek relaxed and reached across the gap between the beds to rest her fingers on the warm metal of Shade’s bracelet.

As the song wound down, Shade heard Rakihi murmur, half-asleep:

“If my mother could see me now, she’d have a heart attack.”

Arcebek chuckled softly. “If your mother could see you now,” she said, “she’d probably set the inn on fire.”

“Good thing she can’t,” Rakihi mumbled. “Too many rules between here and there.”

Shade let the last note fade.

Below them, the last voices in the common room faded. The floorboards creaked as the inn settled around its sleeping guests.

Shade lay awake, aware of Rakihi curled against his side, Arcebek's hand on his wrist, and the five stones humming softly.

Once, he had stood alone against the Void and paid for every moment he bought.

Now he shared an uncomfortable inn room with a warlock and a fairy who seemed determined to make his heart stumble.

Absurd.

Wonderful.

He closed his eyes.

At last, sleep found him.

Before dawn, Rakihi lay half across him, one leg thrown over his and an arm stretched toward Arcebek. The warlock had moved close enough that their foreheads almost touched; her fingers still rested on his wrist.

Shade listened to their breathing and felt the stones pulse in rare harmony.

He smiled and stayed where he was until the first sounds of morning rose from below.

Whatever queens, trolls, or older horrors came for them, he meant to defend this fragile place they had made.

Chapter 20: A Place Between Them

The journey home passed faster. Rakihi saw to that.

Each night brought a new campfire or roadside inn and the same negotiation: where, precisely, would Rakihi sleep? She always chose the space between Shade and Arcebek.

With three beds, she would start in the middle and drift sideways by morning. With two, she would announce, “Efficient use of resources!” and settle into the gap.

Neither of them had learned how to answer her.

One night, as they settled into their bedrolls, she burrowed between them beneath the stars and sighed extravagantly.

“Mm. Warlock on one side, dragon on the other. If I die right now, I’m haunting you both out of sheer gratitude.”

“You’re not dying,” Shade said automatically.

“Also haunting is a workload,” Arcebek muttered. “You’d never keep up with the paperwork.”

At a roadside inn a few nights later, all three squeezed onto one straw mattress. Rakihi nestled against Shade and prodded Arcebek’s calf with her toes.

“Problem,” she whispered.

“What?” Arcebek whispered back, already suspicious.

“I can’t tell which of you is warmer,” Rakihi said. “I demand more data. You’ll both have to hold me for scientific purposes.”

Shade failed to suppress his laugh. Arcebek swore in Dwarvish, but moved closer.

Varinel, from his pallet on the floor across the room, snorted. “If you three start a cuddle cult,” he said, “I’m raising your hazard pay requests myself.”

By the time Greenhollow’s walls came into view, they moved together with an ease none of them had possessed at the start of Rakihi’s trial.

✦ ✦ ✦

The guild debrief went better than Shade expected.

Lana surveyed the mud-smeared party and listened while Varinel delivered a spare, unsentimental account of the trolls and Rakihi’s performance.

“She held,” he said simply, when Lana’s eyes flicked toward the fey woman. “Did what she said she could. Kept her head. Didn’t get eaten. That’s more than I can say for some Bronze recruits.”

Rakihi straightened, delighted by the praise.

Lana studied the parchment, then signed it with a sharp flourish.

“All right,” she said. “Trial completed. As of now, Rakihi is officially no longer ‘provisional.’ You’re an adventurer. Congratulations. Try not to die, I hate paperwork.”

Rakihi grinned.

“Then we have to celebrate,” she declared. “Right? That’s a law, isn’t it? First successful mission, first official rank?”

“It is,” Grig said from the corner, not looking up from his sharpening stone. “Go to the Anvil. Spend some of your coin. Make bad choices as long as they don’t end up on my desk.”

“See? An order from on high,” Rakihi said. “Come on.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The Broken Anvil was already crowded when they arrived.

Stew and smoke hung in the air. A bard in the corner was valiantly murdering a love song while an arm-wrestling match drew shouts from the nearest table. Tankards clinked. Dice rattled.

They found a table at the back, where Shade could watch the door. Arcebek ordered drinks before anyone objected, while Rakihi perched between them and surveyed the room like a theatre built for her amusement.

“To Rakihi,” Arcebek said, lifting her tankard. “Officially an adventurer, somehow not dead, and legally our problem now.”

“Your problem,” Varinel corrected. “I’m putting that in writing.”

“To Rakihi,” Shade echoed, raising his drink.

“To me,” Rakihi said cheerfully, clinking with everyone. “And to trolls who die properly when you set them on fire.”

They drank.

Conversation drifted into stories and laughter.

Jerrin embellished the troll fight until Lysa silenced him with a crust of bread. Arcebek offered embellished accounts of older jobs, and Varinel supplied the inconvenient facts.

Rakihi listened closely, humming fragments of melody as she gathered material for future songs.

A familiar tavern song rose from the common room. Rakihi looked up at once.

“I know this one,” she said. “But your version is wrong.”

Before anyone could stop her, she climbed onto the bench with a foot on the table and sang her version—clearer notes, stronger harmonies, and lyrics considerably more scandalous.

Half the room joined the second chorus. The rest surrendered by the third.

Shade watched with an unguarded smile. Beside him, Arcebek leaned back with her tankard, looking equal parts proud and apprehensive.

The hours slipped by.

The crowd thinned. The other bard gave up and left. The innkeeper began wiping tables with the purposeful air of someone considering whether to chase the last patrons out herself.

Their party lingered, exhausted and content, on benches that seemed increasingly difficult to sit upright on.

Rakihi was describing a fey festival with suspended lanterns and gravity-defying dance floors, illustrating every turn with her hands. Loose blue strands had escaped her braid.

Arcebek made a dry remark. Rakihi laughed, her face brightening.

Then she leaned across, cupped Arcebek's chin, and kissed her.

It was brief and deliberate, a kiss that lingered just long enough to ask a question.

Arcebek froze.

Shade did too.

So did Jerrin, who'd been mid-slump and now resembled a startled owl.

Rakihi pulled back and searched Arcebek's expression, ready to give her space.

Arcebek blinked.

Then a smile slowly spread across her face.

"Subtle," she said hoarsely. "Very subtle."

Rakihi's grin turned almost shy. "I promised I'd make my choices. That's one of them."

Arcebek's hand came up to cover the one still resting against her cheek. She turned her head just enough to press a kiss into Rakihi's palm.

"Duly noted," she said.

Shade discovered that he had forgotten to breathe.

Rakihi glanced at him over Arcebek's shoulder.

"And you," she said.

Shade swallowed. "Me?" he managed.

She slid along the bench until he could feel her warmth.

"Yes, you," she said gently. "You didn't think I was going to leave you out of my reckless decisions, did you?"

Words failed him. Every answer seemed either insufficient or far too revealing.

Rakihi approached slowly, leaving him plenty of time to withdraw.

He stayed.

Her lips touched his, lightly at first. It was different from Arcebek's familiar warmth: tentative, curious, and wholly Rakihi.

Magic flickered between them—not a charm or command, but a fleeting impression of her delight and affection.

She drew back enough to look into his eyes.

"I adore you," she said quietly, so only he and Arcebek could hear. "Both of you. Not as an obligation. Not as a story. As… you."

Something tightened in his chest.

His first instinct was to tell her how little she knew of the horrors behind him. But she had offered her feelings honestly; he would do the same.

He felt her hand on his arm and Arcebek's steady presence beside him. The tavern noise faded into the background.

"I am… honored," he said finally. "And… fond of you, Rakihi. Very much so."

Her smile was soft and satisfied.

"Good," she said. "That's enough for tonight."

She kissed the corner of his mouth again, this time with a mischievous flourish.

Arcebek shook her head, bemused, but the crooked smile hadn't left her face.

"You collect trouble like it's going out of style," she told Rakihi.

"Maybe," Rakihi said cheerfully. "But it's the good kind."

✦ ✦ ✦

By closing time Rakihi was leaning against the table, humming with her eyes half shut.

Shade and Arcebek guided her upstairs between them.

She dropped onto the bed, rolled onto her back, and reached for them both.

"Come on," she mumbled. "Bed sandwich round two. Celebratory edition."

"You are impossible," Arcebek said, but she was already tugging off her boots.

Shade changed, sat on the edge of the mattress, and let Rakihi tug his arm around her.

Arcebek climbed in beside them, muttering about reckless fairies and emotional chaos before curling close.

Rakihi fell asleep almost immediately.

One hand knotted in Shade's shirt and a foot braced against Arcebek's thigh, she looked absurdly innocent for someone who had turned their evening upside down.

Shade stared at the ceiling, Rakihi against one shoulder and Arcebek warm against the other.

Arcebek turned her head, eyes meeting his in the dim.

"You all right?" she asked.

He considered the question.

"Confused," he admitted. "Content. A little afraid."

"Same," she said. "We can be all of that at once. It's allowed."

A small laugh escaped him. "Is there a handbook for this? For being three?"

"Probably," Arcebek said. "Written by some smug scholar who's never had to share a bed with a drunk fairy and a dragon having a crisis."

"Rude," he murmured.

She smiled.

“We’ll make our own,” she said. “One day at a time. One bad decision at a time. One good one too.”

He let her answer settle.

The stones at his wrist stirred: Ifret warm, Fenris amused, Terra cautious, Buyakugan crackling with curiosity, and Djing & Djang delighted by the change.

Shade looked from Rakihi’s sleeping face to Arcebek.

“Then,” he said softly, “today’s… good decision was not running.”

“Agreed,” Arcebek said.

She leaned across Rakihi and kissed him once—brief, familiar, grounding.

“Sleep, Skyfall,” she murmured. “You can overthink it in the morning.”

He closed his eyes at last.

Above the noisy tavern, three people slept together: a warlock, a dragon, and a fairy who had decided that choosing her own future mattered more than any court’s expectations.

Rakihi gave a quiet snore.

Shade thought he could get used to that.

Chapter 21: Sapphires and Secrets

Shade went perfectly still, a sapphire caught between his teeth.

The pouch on his lap held enough cut gemstones to buy a modest house. He had not expected an audience.

He sat on the floor beneath the Broken Anvil's window, legs stretched out, shirt open at the collar and a book balanced on one knee.

An open leather pouch rested on the other.

He had selected a sapphire the size of a walnut.

Then the door opened.

Arcebek stopped in the doorway.

Rakihi walked into her back with a muffled oof.

"What—" Rakihi started, then leaned sideways to see around her. "Oh."

Arcebek narrowed her eyes.

"Shade," she said, very carefully. "Are you eating… money?"

Shade looked from one to the other.

He finished chewing as slowly as dignity allowed.

The gemstone cracked between his teeth.

He swallowed.

"…Possibly," he said.

Rakihi made a delighted noise and skipped across the room, dropping to her knees before him.

"You do it!" she squealed. "I knew it! I mean, I suspected, but I thought maybe it was rude to ask if you ate rocks because of ethnic stereotypes."

Shade closed the pouch.

Arcebek came closer, arms folded and eyebrows raised nearly to her hairline.

"How many times," she said, "has that pouch been in the same room as me while I've been counting our coin?"

Shade considered the pouch, then Arcebek. Lying was unlikely to improve matters.

"…A few," he admitted.

Rakihi flopped onto the floor, kicking her feet in the air, eyes shining. "Do it again," she said. "Please. For science."

"No," Shade said automatically.

Arcebek pointed at the pouch. "What is that?" she demanded. "And if you say 'snack' I'm going to throw you out the window."

"It is food," he said, carefully avoiding the forbidden word. "Of a kind. For me."

He hesitated, then opened the bag again, tipping it so they could see.

Inside glittered a miniature hoard: quartz chips, opal, slivers of ruby and garnet, citrine, and several sapphires whose blue rivaled Rakihi's hair.

Rakihi inhaled sharply. "Oh wow," she breathed. "Those are pretty enough I'd marry them."

"Get in line," Arcebek muttered.

Shade took a smaller sapphire between finger and thumb, turning it toward the window.

"We eat them," he said simply. "Sometimes. Not often. They are… concentrated."

"Concentrated what?" Arcebek asked. "Wealth? Bad decisions?"

"Elemental energy. And structure. Gems are crystallized rules: pressure, time, patience, held together in a form I can consume."

Rakihi's eyes practically sparked. "You're telling me," she said slowly, "you have a bag of crystallized elemental laws that you use as… trail mix."

"Yes," he said. "I prefer the blue ones."

"Sapphire," Arcebek said. "Of course the storm dragon likes sapphires."

"They are aligned with sky and lightning," Shade said. "Deep water, sometimes. Helps… steady Buyakugan. And Fenris. And my own… storms."

A quiet pulse passed through the stones on his bracelet.

Arcebek sat on the edge of the bed. Her indignation had given way to professional curiosity.

"So," she said. "Walk me through this. You chomp down on a gem and… what? It just… dissolves?"

"Yes," he said. "Like… sugar in tea."

Rakihi made an offended noise. "You're wasting perfectly good sapphires as sugar cubes?"

He tilted his head. "They are not wasted. They become… part of me. Like food does for you."

Arcebek squinted. "Does it hurt?" she asked. "Teeth, throat, whatever passes for your stomach."

"My true form has different… layout," he said. "Here, it is… odd. But not painful. Hard things do not break me the way they do mortals. The energy goes where it is needed."

He tapped the bracelet lightly. "Sometimes here. Sometimes… deeper. Bones. Blood."

Rakihi leaned in until she was almost in his lap, watching his mouth.

"Please do it again," she whispered. "I want to see this."

He hesitated.

It felt strangely intimate, like being asked to demonstrate his heartbeat.

Then again, they had seen him melt a hillside, repair a divine seal, and wake screaming from dreams of the Void. Surely a gemstone was less personal.

He sighed. There was no escaping their curiosity now.

"Fine," he said. "A small one."

He rummaged in the bag until he found a chip of citrine no bigger than his fingernail.

Rakihi groaned. “Boring,” she complained. “Yellow.”

“Yellow is not boring,” Shade said mildly. “It is tied to light, focus, the clarity between storms.”

“Still not blue,” she muttered.

He popped the citrine into his mouth.

Both women leaned in.

Both watched him without blinking.

He bit down.

He bit down. The citrine cracked like thin ice, then softened on his tongue, its fragments dissolving into a warmth no ordinary food could offer.

For Shade, the warmth was gentle rather than fierce.

A candle in a dark room, reaching corners a bonfire would overwhelm.

Light spread down his throat and through his chest. The old ache in his bones eased, and the haze behind his eyes began to lift.

For the first time in days, his thoughts felt sharp again.

His bracelet hummed.

Ifret ignored the citrine. Fenris brushed against its energy and let it pass. Terra claimed a little, settling it into the foundations of his being.

He swallowed.

Arcebek watched his throat move, then blinked. “Huh,” she said. “I expected… more sparks. Maybe a glow.”

“That is… sapphires,” he said. “And rubies. The stronger ones. This was… a snack.”

“You have levels of gem-snacking,” Rakihi breathed. “Spectacular.”

Rakihi studied the open pouch. “Teach me your menu.”

Shade considered the selection, then began choosing stones.

“Quartz. Neutral—useful for storage, though weak alone.” He held up a ruby shard. “Fire. Heart. Stubbornness. Ifret favors it, but too much is dangerous.” He exchanged it for a pale opal, flecked with shifting colors. “Opal is complicated. I would not recommend tasting every color of your soul at once.”

Arcebek raised her brows. “You’ve done that.”

“Yes,” he said.

“How bad was it?” she asked.

“I sang for three days and then slept for two,” he said. “It was… illuminating. Once.”

Rakihi fanned herself. “I want that story later,” she said.

At last he lifted a sapphire.

“This,” he said, voice unconsciously softer, “is my favorite.”

Its blue ran almost black at the edges, crossed by pale veins like lightning trapped beneath ice. When he turned it, midnight became sky.

“Sky,” Rakihi breathed. “Ocean. Veins of the world.”

“Yes,” Shade said. “Storm compressed. Boundaries. Focus. It… reminds me of home. And steadies the parts of me that want to… break free too quickly.”

He did not eat it.

Instead he turned it slowly, listening to the faint resonance beneath its surface.

Rakihi watched his face.

“You get sentimental about the blue ones,” Rakihi said, her voice gentler now.

“They were… the first thing I was given,” he admitted. “When I was small. A pouch of sapphire shards from my mother. ‘For when you feel too much,’ she said. ‘They will remind you that not all depth is drowning.’”

Arcebek grew still.

“Do you… have enough?” she asked. “To keep yourself steady. To… feed what you are.”

“Yes. For now. Mortal food sustains this body; gems feed what is older. I can manage without them for a long time. It is simply easier when I do not have to.”

Rakihi sat back on her heels, studying him.

“How often have you not had them,” she asked quietly. “Out there. Alone. Holding seams together with no snack break.”

Shade remembered too many campaigns fought on empty reserves.

“Often. They are rare, and we do not take from the bones of a realm without permission. Here I can buy offcuts from jewelers and miners. Waste to them. A meal to me.”

Arcebek shifted, pulling one knee up, chin resting on it.

“So when you wander off to ‘run errands’ and come back without new books but somehow more relaxed,” she said. “You’re actually going to the gem district to buy yourself dragon candy.”

“Yes,” he said.

Rakihi clapped. “Adorable,” she pronounced.

“It is not—” Shade stopped. The warmth in his cheeks had already lost the argument.

Arcebek’s mouth tilted. “You could have told us,” she said. “We could have… helped. Or at least not panicked if we caught you chewing on the guild’s emergency fund.”

“I did not want to worry you. Or make my upkeep your responsibility.”

Rakihi’s teasing fell away.

“Shade,” she said. “We already worry. That’s what you get when you love people. We worry if you don’t eat soup. We worry if you don’t eat rocks. We worry if you stare at the window too long and hum in keys that make the walls vibrate.”

Arcebek nodded. “She’s right,” she said. “If you’re running low, tell us. We pass jewellers all the time. We can skim chips off monster hoards. Hell, I can probably sweet-talk a few temple treasurers into donating ‘flawed’ stones to the ‘keep the dragon stable’ fund.”

“You will what,” Shade said, halfway between appalled and touched.

“Don’t worry, I’ll make up a charity name,” she said. “‘The Order of the Balanced Storm’ or something.”

Rakihi giggled. “We could do a concert,” she said. “Free music, donations in the form of sapphires accepted.”

Shade covered his face with one hand. “That is unnecessary.”

“It’s absolutely necessary,” Arcebek said. “You taking care of yourself is necessary. You not running on empty is necessary. You having your weird dragon trail mix so you don’t accidentally glass the next troll nest from stress alone is very, very necessary.”

He looked between them.

Arcebek’s fire-bright gaze was stubborn; Rakihi’s blue eyes shone with equal resolve.

Something tightened in his chest, unfamiliar but welcome.

“I will tell you,” he said quietly. “When I am low.”

“Good,” Arcebek said. “Because if I catch you licking the gem shop window instead of asking, I’ll hex your tongue.”

Rakihi reached out and, very gently, tapped the sapphire still in his palm.

“Save that one,” she said. “For when you need to remember sky. Or when I write a song so good you physically can’t handle it.”

Shade smiled.

“I will,” he said.

Rakihi kissed his cheek before he could brace for it, leaving the taste of sugar and ale in the air.

“For sharing,” she said. “That was… oddly intimate. In a non-kissing way.”

Arcebek snorted. “We just attended a private viewing of his dietary habits,” she said. “We’re basically family now.”

“Family that kisses,” Rakihi added.

“Yes,” Shade said dryly. “Freely. Often. In taverns. In rooms. Between me eating gemstones and you stealing my side of the blanket.”

Rakihi’s smile turned soft and smug. “You love it.”

He considered, then nodded once.

“Yes,” he said. “I do.”

The words settled between them, simple enough that none of them needed to improve upon them.

Outside, Greenhollow bustled on: vendors calling, guild bells ringing, a bard tuning badly in the street.

Inside their room above the Broken Anvil, Shade put away the sapphire his mother had given him and allowed himself to enjoy the absurd comfort of having two people concerned about whether he had eaten enough rocks.

Chapter 22: An Emissary of the Fey

For once, the mission debrief was straightforward.

Shade, Arcebek, Varinel, Jerrin, Lysa, and Rakihi stood before Lana's desk as Varinel delivered his summary.

"Farmstead haunted. Source: bound shade in old well. Cause: idiot ancestor pact. Solution: Shade—" he jerked his chin at the dragon "—went down the hole, unbound it. Arcebek and Rakihi handled containment. No casualties. Two chickens emotionally scarred."

Lana scratched notes in her ledger. "Compensation received?"

Arcebek dropped a small pouch on the desk. "Coin, mostly. One cursed rooster. We left it."

"Merciful," Lana said. "Fine. Signed, sealed, no one died, good work. Take—"

The door opened without a knock.

The room changed.

A chill crossed the threshold. Beyond the office, the guildhall's usual noise receded until even the shouting seemed far away.

The stranger entered as though doors existed solely to announce him.

He was tall and unnaturally slender, dressed in flawless layers of dark green and silver. Moon-pale skin framed opalescent eyes with slit pupils; white-gold hair lay in elaborate braids above sharply pointed ears.

Moonthorn Court, Shade thought. Every inch of him.

Two attendants followed: one clad in woven thorn and steel, the other shrouded in something like moth wings.

Lana's jaw set.

Behind Shade, Rakihi went utterly still.

"Lana of Greenhollow," the courtier said, voice smooth as oil on water. "Guildmistress. How… provincial and charming your hall is."

"Emissary," Lana said, crisp. "To what do we owe the pleasure?"

The smile did not reach his eyes.

"The Moonthorn Court is most concerned," he said. "Our Queen's third daughter—Rakihi-of-the-Sapphire-Dell—remains missing. We have reason to believe she passed near this… settlement."

His gaze passed over the adventurers with the detached appraisal of a buyer inspecting livestock.

Shade edged nearer to Rakihi.

Beneath a plain brown cloak, her glamour softened the distinctive blue of her hair and dulled the fey brightness of her features. To anyone unaware of her identity, she was merely another travel-worn young adventurer.

The emissary looked directly at her.

Then past her.

Buyakugan's amusement sparked through the bracelet.

"We have already replied to her Majesty's letter," Lana said evenly. "We have seen no fairy princesses in Greenhollow. Only slavers, who were dealt with. You're welcome."

The emissary's smile thinned.

"If," he said softly, "your guild has seen Rakihi and failed to inform the Court, you will be in breach of older contracts than your little ledger knows how to name."

His gaze sharpened, finally landing fully on Shade.

"And you," he added, tone going cool, "reek of storm and old law. I would be… very disappointed to discover you standing between a Queen and what is hers."

Shade met his eyes.

Very calmly, very politely, he inclined his head.

"I would be very disappointed," he said, "to discover a Queen who thinks her daughter is hers instead of her own."

Arcebek drew a sharp breath.

The air grew colder.

The emissary's nostrils flared, just a little. "Careful, little storm," he murmured. "You speak of things you do not understand."

Shade's expression didn't change. "Possibly," he said. "But I understand cages."

Silence stretched across the office.

Grig cleared his throat from his post by the wall. "Is there a point to this visit," he rumbled, "or did you just come to insult our furniture and imply we're incompetent?"

The emissary's gaze slid to him. "The point," he said, "is this: if we discover that your people have harbored Rakihi-of-the-Sapphire-Dell, there will be… retribution. Not just in letters."

His lips curled, just a bit, around the last word.

Rakihi remained motionless.

Shade glanced toward her.

Her hands were white-knuckled on the strap of her satchel. For an instant, her glamour shivered.

He reached back until his fingers brushed hers.

She seized his hand.

Lana's voice, when it came, was iron-flat.

"The guild," she said, "is not in the business of holding princesses. Or anyone else. We take contracts. We clear monsters. We escort caravans. Your trouble with your daughter is your own."

Lana leaned over her desk, quill poised like a dagger.

“But I suggest,” she added, “that you choose your threats carefully. Because if I discover that any of your people are using human streets to hunt your kin like game, I will consider that a hostile act. And I have contracts older than you think.”

The emissary’s eyes narrowed, opal colors flickering.

Shade thought the exchange might become a fight.

Instead, the courtier recovered his perfect smile.

“Charming,” he said. “Very well. We shall continue our… search elsewhere.”

He turned in a swirl of expensive fabric.

His two attendants followed.

When the door closed, the unnatural chill slowly lifted.

Rakihi had held her breath while he passed.

He had walked within arm’s reach.

And had not recognized her.

The moment the latch clicked, her knees gave way.

Shade caught her.

Arcebek steadied her from the other side.

Lana let out a long breath. “Well,” she said. “That was fun.”

Grig snorted. “You,” he said to Rakihi, “are not leaving the city without telling us first. Ever.”

“Yes, sir,” she squeaked.

“Go,” Lana said, pinching the bridge of her nose. “Celebrate your latest bout of not-dying somewhere that isn’t my office. I need to go write a very careful letter that says ‘we know nothing’ three different ways without inviting court assassins.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Back at the Broken Anvil, Rakihi sank into a corner booth.

For several seconds she could only breathe, her eyes fixed on the table.

Then she laughed.

A shaky breath became a chuckle, then helpless laughter.

She doubled over, clutching her stomach as tears ran down her face.

Shade sat beside her while Arcebek fetched ale.

“Drink,” Arcebek said. “Then you can hyperventilate.”

Rakihi tried to obey and nearly snorted beer out her nose.

“He—” she gasped. “He walked right— right past me. ‘Reek of storm and law,’ he says, and doesn’t even sniff his own princess sitting in the corner like a suspicious potato—”

She dissolved into giggles again.

Shade felt his mouth twitch.

Arcebek shook her head, grinning despite herself. “You realize,” she said, “that if that glamour had slipped, he’d have hauled you out by your ear and probably set the guild on fire on the way.”

Rakihi flopped sideways until her head landed in Shade’s lap. She stared up at the ceiling, still hiccuping with laughter.

“I know,” she said. “That’s what makes it funny. My mother sends her best bloodhound, and he can’t tell the difference between ‘missing princess’ and ‘adventurer with a slightly out-of-date cloak.’”

She draped an arm over her eyes. “Oh, spirits, I’m going to be giggling about this for weeks.”

The glamour was steady again. Under the giddiness, he could see relief deeper than anything she had shown since first entering their lives.

“Are you all right?” he asked quietly.

She peeked out from under her arm at him.

“Yes,” she said. “Terrified. Thrilled. Vindicated. A little aroused. Is that weird?”

Arcebek choked on her drink. “Yes,” she said firmly. “Yes, it’s weird.”

Rakihi giggled again. “I like it when powerful people are wrong,” she said. “Especially when they’re wrong about me. My mother built an entire court around the idea that she knows everything that happens under her trees. And here I am, sleeping with a dragon and a warlock over a tavern while her envoy threatens to tear this place apart and walks right past my nose.”

For a moment, the laughter faded.

“I chose this,” she said. “They can’t see it. That matters.”

Arcebek reached across the table and flicked her forehead, gently. “They’ll try again,” she said. “Emissaries. Scrying. Maybe her Majesty herself if she gets annoyed enough.”

“I know,” Rakihi said. “But that’s tomorrow’s problem. Today’s story is: ‘Rakihi-of-the-Sapphire-Dell gave her mother the slip and drank beer with her lovers while the Queen’s dogs sniffed the wrong trail.’”

She looked up at Shade again, eyes bright.

The sudden change caught him off guard.

“For…?” he asked.

“For not flinching,” she said. “When he threatened you. For touching my hand instead of my mouth when I nearly screamed. For… being you. Here. With me. Not running.”

Arcebek knocked her knuckles lightly against Rakihi’s tankard. “And for backing my guild,” she added. “Nice line about cages, by the way. Very quotable.”

Rakihi’s eyes went distant for a second. “Already writing it down,” she said. “I’m going to turn that whole scene into a ballad. ‘The Emissary and the Empty Chair.’”

“Do not sing it in Greenhollow,” Lana’s voice said from directly behind them.

Rakihi nearly overturned the table.

Lana slid into the opposite seat, looking exhausted, and set two tankards on the table.

“You do not sing that song within three days’ ride of this city,” Lana said. “You do not sing it in any place the Moonthorn Court considers ‘theirs.’ You do not even hum it near anyone who says ‘my lady mother’ without irony. Clear?”

Rakihi held up both hands. “Clear,” she said. “No court-baiting performances. Yet.”

Lana sighed. “On the other hand,” she added, “if you happen to have a version you only sing in basements to drunk people who will never remember the words, I’d pay good money to hear it.”

Rakihi’s grin came back. “Deal.”

Lana studied them over the rim of her drink.

“You,” she said to Rakihi, “just made this guild the accidental frontline between a fey queen and her own daughter’s stubbornness.”

Rakihi winced. “Sorry,” she said. “I… can go, if it gets too dangerous. I don’t want to—”

Lana cut her off with a raised hand.

“I didn’t say ‘go,’” she said. “I said ‘frontline.’ Some of us—” her eyes flicked to Shade “—are apparently very good at those.”

Shade felt the implication settle heavily.

Lana took a long pull from her drink.

“But if they come for you here,” she went on, “we’ll make damn sure they understand that playing politics with my people has a cost.” She pointed her tankard at Rakihi. “You stay smart. You keep that glamour tight. You warn me if you feel their magic sniffing around. And you keep making my best troublemakers too happy to run off and die stupidly.”

Rakihi blinked. Then smiled, small and bright and a little wobbly.

“Yes, Guildmistress,” she said.

“Good,” Lana said. She got up, joints protesting. “Now drink. Laugh. Sleep. Tomorrow we go back to killing things that don’t file complaints, and I go back to pretending I didn’t tell a fairy princess she’s welcome to hide in my city.”

She left them to it.

Rakihi watched her go, then flopped sideways again, head landing half on Shade’s thigh, half on Arcebek’s hip.

“I love it here,” she said contentedly. “This is the best bad idea I’ve ever had.”

Arcebek snorted and ruffled her hair. “You say that now,” she said. “Wait until the guild gives us our next assignment.”

Shade rested a hand on Rakihi’s shoulder. He could still sense the tremor of her earlier fear beneath the buoyancy of her laughter.

The emissary’s threat had not vanished.

But Shade remembered the man passing within arm’s reach of Rakihi, and Lana’s unspoken promise to stand with them.

He looked around the warm, noisy inn, at Arcebek and Rakihi.

He'd stood in front of worse than a fey queen for far less than this.

"If they come," he said softly, mostly to himself, "they will not find you alone."

Rakihi tilted her head back to look up at him, eyes shining.

"I know," she said. Then, with a wicked little grin: "But can we please wait until after I've finished the song?"

Arcebek groaned.

Shade chuckled.

The fear remained.

For the moment, however, it had no place at their table.

They were three people in love, laughing at a courtier who had stood beside the princess he sought and never known it.

Tonight, that was victory enough.

Chapter 23: Following the Threads

Shade found Lana where he most often found her: bent over a ledger, cold tea beside her elbow, her quill scratching steadily across the page.

“Busy,” she said without looking up. “Come back when we’re all dead and I can close the books.”

“I need your help,” Shade said.

She looked up at once.

Without his armor, Shade appeared almost ordinary. But Lana knew the stillness that came over him when he was tracking danger.

“All right,” she said, setting the quill down. “Talk.”

“The slavers who took Rakihi. The emissary from the Court. Something does not fit.”

“Slavers smell wrong by default,” Lana said. “Be more specific.”

Shade leaned on the back of the chair opposite, big hands braced on the wood.

“They were clumsy. Four of them, no support, shoddy runes. Good sleeping dust, poor planning. Yet they managed to catch a princess who can walk through dreams and turn invisible. Then a Court emissary arrives knowing exactly where to look.” Shade paused. “That is too neat to be coincidence.”

Lana’s smile held no humor.

“You think someone tipped them off. That Rakihi was being hunted before your alley encounter.”

“Yes,” Shade said simply. “Either the Court is hiring mortals to drag their princess home… or someone else is selling fey to whoever pays.”

Lana drummed her fingers on the desk.

“And you,” she said, “want to go poke that nest.”

“I want to know who sent them, who supplied them, and whether there are more. Was Rakihi the intended target, or an opportunity?”

“Rakihi,” Lana repeated dryly.

“It is what she prefers,” he said.

Lana snorted. “Of course it is.”

Lana watched him for another moment.

“You’re not bringing her,” she said. Not a question.

“No,” Shade said. “Or Arcebek. If there is… rot, it will move if it sees them. I move quieter alone.”

Lana’s brows rose a fraction at quieter, but she didn’t argue.

“You know enough of this city to get lost in it,” Lana said, tapping her quill against the ledger. “Not enough to find the places that prefer to stay off maps. And subtle work is hardly your specialty.”

“I am not going to be subtle,” he said. “I am going to be… convincing.”

That made Grig, at the bookshelves, huff a short laugh.

Lana sighed.

“You’re asking me to point a loaded siege engine at my worst alleys and say ‘have fun,’” she said. “You see my hesitation.”

“I will not break your city,” Shade said. “I intend to lean on a few carefully chosen places.”

Lana measured him a moment longer before nodding.

“Fine,” she said. “You want slavers who deal in fey? You go to the people who hate them most.”

She tore a scrap from an old sheet and drew a name beside a curling symbol crossed by three lines.

“Old Well district,” she said, handing it over. “Ask for the Nightmarket. Show that mark to the right lantern, it will open. Find a woman called Mora. Half-tiefling, half-trouble, runs information and knives. Tell her I sent you. Don’t threaten her. She bites.”

“I will be polite,” Shade said.

“Good. Because if you start a war in my undercity, I will send you the bill.”

Grig stepped away from the wall. “You want backup?” he asked.

Shade shook his head. “Not yet,” he said. “If this is… nothing, I do not waste your time. If it is something, I will let you know before I tear anything important down.”

“Do that,” Lana said. “And Shade—”

He paused at the door.

“—don’t get yourself taken,” she said. “We do not have a rescue plan for ‘dragon sold at auction.’”

He inclined his head. “Noted.”

✦ ✦ ✦

He told Rakihi and Arcebek he had errands to run.

That, at least, was true.

Rakihi eyed him, upside-down from where she lay on the bed, reading. “Book or rocks?” she asked.

“Neither,” he said. “Information.”

Arcebek glanced up from her spell notes. Her eyes narrowed; she had learned to recognize his evasions.

“Don’t start anything you don’t intend to finish,” she said. “And don’t finish anything that will bring the guard to our door.”

“I will be careful,” he said.

“Liar,” she murmured, but she let him go.

✦ ✦ ✦

The streets of Old Well narrowed with every turn.

The houses leaned over the alleys, their upper stories almost meeting. Hooded lanterns offered just enough light to keep travelers from falling.

Shade moved through the district like a ship entering fog.

Concealing himself was impossible. He could, however, walk as if he belonged: steady steps, no hesitation, no searching glances. People saw the sword on his back and quickly remembered errands of their own.

He found the marked lantern above an apparent dead-end wall, three alleys beyond a crooked square.

The mark was subtle: three cross-hatches scratched into the metal rim. Unless you were looking, you'd miss it.

He took the scrap of paper, pressed it briefly to the lantern.

The flame inside flickered blue.

The mortar rippled. Stones shifted aside, revealing a stairway descending into dim colored light.

He descended.

The Nightmarket was a city beneath the city.

Forgotten cisterns and wells opened into chambers linked by tunnels and narrow bridges. Enchanted beetles glowed in glass jars; witchlights floated over stalls. Smoke and spices mingled with the press of bodies.

There were stolen goods, illegal potions, books of uncertain provenance, and a man selling curses sealed in clay pots. A woman offered to erase names from official records—for a price.

Beneath it all lingered the stink of captivity.

He followed it.

Two turns and a flight of stairs brought him to a fenced enclosure.

Curtains concealed it on three sides. Two guards stood at the entrance, large men with the dull patience of practiced bullies.

He didn't go straight to them.

First, he found Mora.

Mora stood behind a stall where knives and information appeared equally available. Black, ridged horns swept back from her temples; her skin was dark red, and her yellow eyes held feline pupils. She cleaned her nails with a dagger worn smooth by years of use.

"You're a long way from the guildhall," she said as he stopped in front of her. "Storm in a bottle like you might break the shelves."

"Lana sent me," Shade said, placing the scrap of paper with the symbol on her table.

She glanced at it. Snorted. "Of course she did," she said. "What do you want, Dragon?"

He considered denying it, but her glance had already settled on his bracelet.

There was little point.

"Slavers. Four tried to take a fairy near the wells. Two died. The other two were left for the guards. I want to know whether they worked alone."

Mora leaned back, studying him.

"And why should I help you?" she asked.

“Because Lana asked,” he said. “Because if someone in your market is selling fey princesses, they will eventually bring the Court’s wrath down on all of this. And because if I have to tear this place apart to find out, I will start with the ones who sell people.”

Mora’s eyes narrowed.

“I like my market intact,” she said. “And I like my people unsold.” She flicked a coin at a boy loitering nearby. “Go tell Jarren his ‘stock’ is bad business.”

The boy vanished into the crowd.

“You picked the right night,” Mora said. “Our mutual problem likes to lurk here when he thinks the guard is distracted.”

“Jarren?” Shade asked.

“Calls himself that this week,” she said. “Thinks running a small, quiet trade in ‘exotic help’ is beneath notice. No kids. No locals. Just pretty things no one will miss. Until he tried to snatch royalty.” Her lip curled. “Idiot.”

The boy reappeared. Nodded once. Mora jerked her chin toward the far corner.

“Third stall past the mushroom seller,” she said. “Be careful how you break him. If you get blood on his neighbors, they’ll charge you cleaning fees.”

“I will be neat,” Shade said.

Mora smirked. “I doubt it,” she said. “But I’ll look away for five minutes.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Jarren was arguing with one of his guards when Shade arrived.

“You can’t just skip nights,” the man hissed. “People notice.”

“We got seen,” Jarren snapped. “Until I know who gutted my last team, we lay low. I’m not losing another shipment for—”

Shade stepped through the curtain.

His shoulders nearly brushed either side of the narrow stall.

Jarren was shorter than Shade, with slicked-back hair, too many rings, and a vest that strained to make him look respectable. His gaze traveled from the sword to Shade’s face.

“Closed,” he said automatically. “Come back next—”

Shade took two steps forward, grabbed him by the front of his vest, and lifted.

The guard reached for his knife.

Shade trapped his wrist, squeezed until the man winced, and guided the knife back into its sheath.

“I am looking,” Shade said, “for the man who decided caging fairies in my city was profitable.”

Jarren’s face went pale.

“I don’t— I don’t know—”

Shade tightened his grip. The stall timbers creaked.

Jarren flinched.

“Two of your people died in an alley,” Shade said. “The other two survived only because I stopped. I am offering you the same chance. Speak.”

Sweat beaded on Jarren’s forehead.

“It was a job,” Jarren blurted. “Good money. Too good to ask questions. A Court contact sends word: ‘Wayward fey near your turf. Sweeten the pot if she’s young, unmarked, musically inclined.’ We collect her, pass her along, take our cut. That’s all.”

Shade’s eyes narrowed. “A contact in the Court.”

Jarren nodded frantically. “Never a name. Only a sign. Moonthorn sigil on the message. Court coin paid up front, extra for discretion.”

“Who else knew?” Shade asked.

“The crew,” Jarren said. “Two are dead. Two were taken by the city watch. That was everyone on the job.”

“Where did you send the others?” Shade asked.

Jarren swallowed. “Same buyer for the last two,” he whispered. “Not princesses. Minor fey. Runaways, mostly. Sold back to the Court. ‘For their own good.’” His lip curled, just a little. “Better coin than they were worth on the open block.”

Shade clenched his jaw.

“How did you contact them?” he pressed. “Where did you deliver?”

“Old oak outside the city,” Jarren rushed. “On the west road. Hollow in the trunk. We leave the cage, we leave the note, we leave. Coins appear by morning. We never see the collector.”

“And the last time?” Shade asked.

Jarren licked dry lips. “The girl— your girl— we never made the drop,” he said. “Your storm hit first.”

Shade considered what he had learned.

Someone in the Court was paying mortal slavers to drag back runaway fey. The scheme was established, profitable, and quiet enough to have survived until now.

Then Rakihi had fled, and someone had used the same network to hunt a princess.

He remembered the emissary’s smug threat in Lana’s office—and the way the man had looked straight through Rakihi.

He remembered Rakihi laughing afterward.

Shade lowered Jarren until his shoes brushed the floor.

“You will stop,” he said.

“Yes,” Jarren babbled. “Yes, gods, yes, I will—I’m done. I’m out. I’ll leave the city—”

Shade shook his head.

“No. You will stay. You will trade in no living person. If you do, I will return. When your Court contact sends another message, you will deliver word to Lana, and only Lana. Do you understand?”

“She’ll kill me,” Jarren whispered. “The Court will kill me. You’ll kill me—”

“You are very killable,” Shade agreed. “Behave, and you might live long enough to be useful.”

He dropped him.

Jarren stumbled backward into the wall, nodding so hard his carefully arranged hair came loose.

“Yes. Yes. No fey. No flesh. I’ll sell fish if I have to.”

Shade turned away.

The guard wisely didn’t move.

Mora was waiting when he stepped back into the flow of the Nightmarket.

“Well?” she asked.

“He knows nothing of names,” Shade said. “Only that someone in Moonthorn pays well to buy runaways back. Rakihi was meant to be one more.”

Mora’s mouth tightened. “Court-cleaning. They cannot bear to have runaways spoil the pretty picture.”

“Yes,” Shade said. “But cracks keep appearing. Enough that they needed local help.”

“And now?” Mora asked. “You going to take him apart anyway?”

“No,” Shade said. “He is bait now. If I cut him, they will simply find another. This way, he sends word when they bite.”

She eyed him. “You’re playing a long game,” she said. “For someone who likes lightning.”

“I am tired,” Shade said, “of seeing people dragged back into cages. I would rather find the hand holding the chain than keep breaking links.”

Mora considered. Then she nodded.

“I’ll keep ears open,” she said. “If Court coin jingles too loudly in my halls, I’ll let Lana know your leash slipped down here.”

“Thank you,” Shade said.

She smirked. “Don’t thank me yet. If this blows up, I’ll sell the story to a bard. Might as well get paid when the queen starts pointing.”

He left her stall and headed back toward the upper city.

He did not tell Rakihi what he had learned.

Not that night.

Back at the inn, Rakihi sat cross-legged on the bed, trying out a melody on a borrowed lute. Arcebek rested against the headboard, listening with her eyes half closed.

Shade paused in the doorway.

Arcebek’s gaze flicked to his.

She read something in his face, but let him speak first.

Rakihi looked up, hair falling in her face.

“You’re back! You smell like mushrooms and bad decisions.”

“The Nightmarket,” he said. “And one… conversation.”

“Anything we need to stab?” Arcebek asked.

“Not yet,” he said. “If that changes, I will tell you. For now… nothing immediate.”

The answer was true, though far from complete.

Rakihi’s shoulders loosened. “Good,” she said. “Because this chord progression is killing me, and I need both of you alive to suffer through it with me.”

She patted the mattress. “Come help,” she commanded. “I need someone to tell me if this sounds more ‘fey emissary gets owned’ or ‘drunk rooster loses a fight with a bucket.’”

Shade stepped in, shutting the door behind him.

For now, the dark business of the Nightmarket remained beyond the door. Here there was a lute, Arcebek, Rakihi, and a bed that had somehow become home.

He would tell them what he knew.

But not tonight.

He wanted something solid to offer Rakihi before bringing the Court’s shadow back into their room.

He sat on the bed, took the lute by the wrong end when Rakihi passed it over, and surrendered to an argument about chords and who had stolen whose blanket.

The Queen’s agents were still looking.

Now Shade was looking, too.

He intended to choose where their searches met.

Chapter 24: Dinner for Three

Shade's first problem was that he had no idea how to be discreet.

Among dragons, subtlety meant destroying only one mountain instead of three.

But he tried.

✦ ✦ ✦

His investigation began badly.

One morning at the Broken Anvil, Arcebek was halfway through a breakfast of fried potatoes, sausage, eggs, and something Hesta insisted was gravy. Shade distrusted the way it moved.

He watched her contemplate another forkful.

"What is your favorite meal?" he asked.

Arcebek paused, fork halfway to her mouth.

"Morning to you, too," she said. "Sleep well? Any nightmares? No? Lovely chat."

Right. He had forgotten the conversational lead-in.

"I was curious," he tried. "You always order that. Is it your favorite?"

"Since when have you cared what I eat for breakfast?"

"Since now."

She studied him over her fork.

"Meat. Spice. Fat. Anything that takes hours to cook, preferably while someone else does the cooking."

She shoved a sausage into her mouth. "Why?"

"No reason," he lied.

She snorted. "Terrible liar."

Later that day, he cornered Rakihi in the library.

She sat cross-legged on a library table with three books open around her. The librarian had surrendered the argument days ago.

"Rakihi," he said. "What is your favorite meal?"

Rakihi looked up from her books. Suspicion narrowed her eyes in a perfect imitation of Arcebek.

"…Why?" she asked.

"No reason," he said. Again.

She brightened instantly. "You're plotting," she said. "Badly. I love it."

"Rakihi," he warned.

"Sweet things. Fruit. Anything that sparkles. Especially desserts complicated enough to qualify as architectural crimes."

"Architectural crime," he repeated.

“Yes,” she said. “If it doesn’t look like it could be a building in a fairy court, I don’t want it.”

He committed the phrase to memory.

She leaned in, eyes gleaming. “Are you going to cook for us?” she whispered.

“No,” he lied for the third time.

“Even worse liar,” she sighed happily. “This is going to be amazing.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Cooking, Shade discovered, was considerably less amazing than planning a dinner.

Not at first.

Hesta ruled the Anvil’s kitchen with forearms like tree trunks and the expression of a woman who had watched too many fools burn soup.

When Shade asked to borrow her kitchen for practice, she examined him as though he had proposed juggling her knives while naked.

“You know how to cook?” she demanded.

“Yes,” he said. “In theory.”

“In theory,” she echoed. “You ever set a pot on fire?”

“Yes,” he admitted.

She considered. “You break anything important, you buy it,” she said. “You cut off any fingers, you clean it up yourself. You set my stove on fire, I use you as fuel. Clear?”

“Clear,” he said.

His first attempt at “meat, spice, and fat” went badly.

He had watched Hesta throw things into pots a hundred times. How hard could it be?

Very hard, as it turned out.

The stew contained meat. It was also spicy in much the same way dragonfire was warm.

Hesta threw a handful of green leaves into the pot, swore at it, then rounded on him. “You don’t cook like that, storm-boy. Meat isn’t an army. You don’t conquer it. You coax it.”

“I was not shouting,” he protested.

“Your soul was shouting,” she said. “Simmer. Low. Gentle. Not ‘conquer.’”

So he tried again, this time with patience instead of force.

Less dragon, more patience.

Three more pots met unfortunate ends.

Finally, Hesta banished him to a stool and made him watch for half an hour.

“You see this?” she said, scraping the bottom of a pan. “Brown is good. Black is bad. You brown the meat before you drown it. You salt early, not at the end. You taste. You taste often.”

“I do not taste raw meat,” he said.

“Then you sniff,” she snapped. “You’ve got that dragon nose, use it for something other than judging my cleaning schedule.”

Gradually, the lessons began to take.

The first stew Hesta did not threaten to discard earned him a grunt and a spoon thrust into his hand.

“Taste,” she ordered.

He did.

Rich and savory, if somewhat too salty and thick. Recognizably food.

Pride warmed his chest, absurdly disproportionate to the achievement.

His chest warmed with a ridiculous, quiet pride.

“Good enough for dwarves,” Hesta said grudgingly. “Not for me, but I’ve got standards.”

He took that as high praise.

Dessert was worse.

Dessert proved worse.

Seff was short, round, and perpetually covered in flour and powdered sugar. They took one look at Shade and laughed.

Seff was short, round, and dusted so thoroughly in flour that Shade wondered whether they had ever been another color.

“Something sweet,” Shade said. “Complex. For someone who likes… complicated things.”

“Ah,” Seff said. “We’re doing the ‘impress your partners with sugar’ ritual. Classic.” They clapped their hands. “Can you read?”

“Yes.”

“Follow instructions. That’s it. No improvising. No ‘I think more fire will help.’ Sugar is lava that will judge you.”

He did as he was told.

Mostly.

Hot caramel, he discovered, was an effective weapon. Folding egg whites involved no actual folding. Cream could stand in peaks if he treated it with sufficient care.

His first layered tower of sponge, berries, and cream collapsed like a poorly built bridge.

The second held long enough for Seff to say, “Almost,” before sinking.

The third attempt held.

The third stood.

Three crooked tiers of sponge, fruit, cream, and jelly stood on the counter. They leaned, but they stood.

Seff whistled. “You did that,” they said. “With your own big clumsy hands. I’m proud of you. Don’t drop it.”

“I will not,” he said.

“You’re going to drop it,” Seff muttered as he left.

✦ ✦ ✦

The invitation went about as smoothly as his other attempts at secrecy.

He waited until evening, when the common room of the Anvil was loud enough that their table felt private. Arcebek was halfway through her first ale; Rakihi was doodling tiny music notes in spilled beer with her fingertip.

“I would like,” he said, “to invite you both to dinner.”

They both looked up.

“At the Anvil?” Arcebek asked. “We’re at the Anvil.”

“The back room,” he said. “Tomorrow evening. I have arranged something.”

Rakihi’s smile bloomed instantly. “Oooh,” she breathed. “Arranged. That sounds deliciously ominous.”

Arcebek’s eyes narrowed. “Is this related to you disappearing into the kitchen for hours and coming back smelling like failure and onions?”

“No,” he said.

“Yes,” Rakihi said at the same time.

Arcebek snorted. “You are transparent, storm-boy. Fine. We’ll come. But if I get food poisoning, I’m haunting you.”

“Noted,” he said.

Rakihi kicked her heels under the table. “Do we have to dress up?” she asked. “I have a dress that looks like I murdered a particularly fancy curtain.”

“You can… wear what you like,” he said, thrown.

“Good,” she said. “Because I’m going to be obnoxiously pretty.”

He was doomed. He knew it. He invited them anyway.

✦ ✦ ✦

By the following evening, the Broken Anvil’s back room was cleaner than Shade had ever seen it.

Two younger servers had helped him carry in a sturdy table and chairs that did not wobble. Hesta contributed a clean cloth; Seff delivered the dessert in person, apparently unconvinced Shade could be trusted to transport it.

He’d done what he could with the rest.

Candles borrowed from the guild shrine, with permission. Wildflowers Rakihi had admired on their walks. Plates that almost matched.

It was a modest arrangement, and he had never been more nervous about anything so harmless.

A battle required preparation, judgment, and decisive action. Dinner required him to hope two people liked what he had done.

He was adjusting one of the candles for the fifth time when the door opened.

Arcebek stepped in first.

Her braid was freshly arranged, its rings polished. A dark green tunic brought out the bronze warmth of her skin; a wide belt, worked in restrained filigree, completed the effect.

Behind her, Rakihi swept in like she had a personal audience with the gods.

The curtain had indeed met a violent end. Deep blue and silver fabric flowed around Rakihi in layers that shifted with every step. Glass ornaments glimmered in her upswept hair. Her glamour hid her wings, but it could do nothing to disguise her delight.

They both stopped.

Rakihi stopped in the doorway, open-mouthed.

“Oh,” she said. “Oh, this is nice.”

Arcebek looked from the candles to the table, then back to Shade.

“Look at you,” she said, her expression softening. “Domestic.”

“I hope you are hungry,” he said. “And that you like it.”

Rakihi beamed. “We haven’t even sat down and I already like it.”

Hesta appeared long enough to set a covered pot on the table. “If they don’t like it, they’re wrong,” she declared, and returned to her kitchen.

Shade pulled out their chairs, uncertain which etiquette book applied, and uncovered the main dish.

He uncovered the main dish.

A thick, dark stew, full of tender meat and potatoes. Steam carried the scent of herbs and spice. Beside it sat a loaf of crusty bread, still warm from the oven.

Arcebek leaned in, sniffed.

Her eyebrows rose.

“You made this?” she asked.

“With guidance,” Shade said. “But yes. Mostly.”

She blew on a spoonful and tasted it.

Her eyes closed.

“Oh,” she said.

“That good?” Rakihi asked, leaning forward.

Arcebek swallowed and gave Shade a look halfway between irritation and admiration.

“You’ve been hiding,” she said. “This is… good.”

Relief nearly buckled his knees. He remained standing through an effort of will.

Rakihi attacked her bowl with enthusiasm. “Spicy,” she said. “Rich. Meat that actually tastes like meat, not like it wants to apologize.” She pointed her spoon at him. “This is illegal. You can’t be terrifying and good in the kitchen. It’s unfair.”

“I am not terrifying,” he said automatically.

They both looked at him.

He sighed. “Fine. Occasionally terrifying.”

They ate.

They talked.

By the time the bowls were empty, the knot in his shoulders had loosened. Arcebek found another tender piece of meat; Rakihi used the last of her bread to chase the broth around her bowl.

When their plates were mostly clean and the pot merely streaked, Rakihi leaned back, patting her stomach.

“If you keep this up,” she said, “I’m never leaving. My mother will have to drag me back with a very large fork.”

Arcebek dabbed her beard with a napkin. “She’s not leaving anyway,” she said. Then, to Shade: “You did good, Skyfall.”

He didn’t realize how much he’d wanted to hear that until she said it.

He busied himself uncovering the dessert before either of them noticed the color climbing his neck.

Seff’s creation survived the journey from the kitchen intact.

Three layers of golden sponge rose beneath cream and glistening berries. The tower leaned toward one side, but it had survived.

Rakihi actually gasped. “You made a tower,” she whispered. “A sugar tower. Be still, my heart.”

“Seff made most of it,” Shade admitted. “I… assisted.”

“Shade,” Arcebek said, smiling. “We’re not here to judge your structural integrity. We’re here to eat.”

Rakihi picked up her fork, then paused.

Her eyes darted between them.

“Okay,” she said. “Serious moment before I ruin my makeup on berry juice.”

Shade blinked. “Your… what?”

“My face,” she said. “Listen.”

Her fork struck the plate with a small, decisive click.

“I know this is… strange,” she said. “By most people’s standards. The three of us. The queen’s runaway. The warlock. The dragon with too much history and not enough sense to stay away from trouble.”

Arcebek’s mouth tilted. “Rude,” she said. “Accurate, but rude.”

Rakihi took a breath.

“I know the three of us are strange by most people’s standards,” she said. “A runaway princess, a warlock, and a dragon with too much history. But I love this. I love you, both of you. We don’t have to decide what to call it tonight. I only need you to know that it’s real to me.”

The candlelight seemed to draw closer around them. Shade looked from Rakihi to Arcebek.

Arcebek swallowed. “I’m no good at grand declarations,” she said, her voice rougher than usual. “But I’m here because I want to be. With both of you. That’s real, too.”

Two sets of eyes turned to Shade.

For a moment he felt the familiar weight of his armor, though he was not wearing it.

He thought of library afternoons, shared beds, troll fights, gemstones, and laughter—small things that had quietly become the center of his days.

He set his fork down.

“I have spent most of my existence,” he said slowly, “fighting for things that were… abstract. Concepts. Realities. Rules.”

His gaze moved from Arcebek to Rakihi and back.

“This is different. It is messy, and small, and bright.” His lips twitched. “And I am very bad at it.”

They both smiled at that.

“But I want it. I want both of you in my life.” He hesitated. “In my hoard.”

Rakihi’s eyes shimmered. “We’re your hoard?” she whispered. “Oh no, that’s too romantic.”

Arcebek snorted, though her ears had gone pink. “Careful,” she said. “He’s going to start sleeping on top of us like a pile of gold.”

“I already do,” Rakihi said. “It’s great.”

Shade huffed a small laugh.

“I do not know how to do this properly,” he admitted. “But I would like to learn. Preferably with fewer burned pots.”

“You’re doing fine,” Arcebek said firmly.

“Better than fine,” Rakihi added. “You made stew and emotional vulnerability. That’s like… relationship level three.”

“Is there a chart,” he asked faintly.

“Not yet,” she said. “I’ll write one.”

Then they ate dessert.

Sweet, rich, and slightly crooked, the tower disappeared slice by slice.

Rakihi did, in fact, ruin her makeup on berry juice and cream. Arcebek laughed and licked a smear of jelly off her cheek. Rakihi retaliated by feeding Shade a piece of sponge and getting cream on his nose.

For the first time that evening, Shade forgot to worry whether he had done enough.

Later, when the plates were empty and the candles had burned low, Rakihi shifted her chair closer until their knees touched under the table. Arcebek mirrored the motion on Shade’s other side.

He looked down at his hands, big and scarred and stained with spice.

Arcebek slid her fingers between his on one side.

Rakihi rested her hand on top of theirs.

Their hands formed a clumsy, comfortable knot.

The gods stirred faintly within his bracelet. Some ancient part of him, accustomed to standing alone before the Void, seemed equally astonished by the sight.

This, he thought, was what he had bought time for.

He didn't say it out loud.

Instead, he squeezed their hands gently.

"Thank you," he said. "For trusting me. For… eating my attempts."

Rakihi snorted. "Shut up, Shade," she said. "And promise you'll cook for us again."

He met her eyes.

"I promise," he said.

Arcebek's smile turned soft and dangerous. "And next time," she said, "we're doing the cooking. See how you handle being fussed over."

He was not sure whether the prospect frightened or delighted him.

Both, probably.

He could live with that.

Beyond the door, Greenhollow carried on with its nightly clatter.

In the back room of the Broken Anvil, a dragon, a warlock, and a fairy finished the last of the cake and held on to one another.

Their future would not be simple.

For tonight, it belonged to them.

Chapter 25: The Worst-Kept Secret

Only a sliver of lamplight slipped through the bedroom shutters.

Rakihi lay sprawled across Shade's chest and Arcebek's shoulder, one hand twitching in her sleep as though fingering an invisible lute. Beside him, Arcebek traced idle circles across the back of his hand.

Shade lay awake, staring at the ceiling.

A question had been troubling him for some time.

"Rakihi?" he murmured.

She made a questioning noise. "Mmh?"

Arcebek grunted too, but didn't move much.

Shade cleared his throat. "Why," he asked slowly, "does everyone know I am a dragon?"

Rakihi went very still.

With exquisite care, she rolled onto her back and regarded the ceiling as though it might rescue her.

"What exactly do you mean by everyone?" she asked, far too lightly.

Shade looked at her profile. "The emissary called me storm and old law. Mora in the Nightmarket called me Dragon. The kids at the guild whisper when I walk past. The blacksmith bows. This morning a baker gave me extra bread and said, 'For the big lizard.'"

Arcebek snorted into her pillow.

"I have not announced it," he insisted. "Nor have I changed shape in public. I have been careful."

He paused.

"And yet everyone seems to know."

Rakihi's toes curled under the blanket.

"In my defense," Rakihi began, "it was not entirely me."

Shade's eyes narrowed. "So it is you."

She flopped onto her stomach, hiding her face in the pillow, voice muffled. "Not… entirely."

"Rakihi," Arcebek said dryly. "Confession time before he starts trying to relocate the guild through sheer embarrassment."

Rakihi groaned into the pillow, then turned her head until one eye emerged.

"All right," she sighed. "So. You know how stories travel?"

"Yes," Shade said. "Too fast. With poor fact-checking."

"Imagine a very tall man in nightmare armor, swinging a sword the size of a door. He falls out of the sky, survives things that ought to kill him, and hums songs in languages nobody knows. Then put him in a guild where people gossip more eagerly than they drink."

Arcebek snickered. "He's… not exactly subtle," she admitted.

Rakihi pointed at her. "Thank you."

Shade recalled his arrival by meteor, his fights with trolls, and the gemstones he ate in public. His protest died unspoken.

Rakihi was gathering momentum.

“Then,” she said, ticking points off on her fingers, “he: one, falls out of the sky like a star; two, melts a goblin nest into magma; three, walks through paralytic poison without blinking; four, sings in a language that makes the air feel thicker; five, has a bracelet full of elemental gods that hum when he’s annoyed.”

She raised her brows, inviting him to dispute the evidence.

“People talk, Shade,” she said gently. “I did not invent that part. At best I… curated it.”

“Curated,” he repeated blankly.

Arcebek turned toward him, her tangled hair spilling across the pillow. “You were gossip long before she started singing about you.”

Shade frowned at the ceiling. “But the specific word,” he said. “Dragon. Why that?”

Rakihi winced. “…That might have been a little bit me.”

“Rakihi,” he said, in the weary tone of a man bracing for impact.

Rakihi pushed herself up on her elbows, hair falling into her face.

“Okay,” she said. “So the first night? In the Anvil? When Lana gave you that ‘if you break my tables I’ll break your legs’ speech and you smiled in that ‘I’ve survived worse gods’ way? Someone asked me at the bar what your deal was.”

“And you said…?” Shade asked, dread creeping in.

“I said,” she recited, “‘He’s a dragon who forgot how to stop caring.’”

Arcebek snorted. “That’s actually pretty good.”

Rakihi spread her hands. “It was a throwaway line! A poetic turn! I figured they’d roll their eyes and go back to arguing about beer.”

“And instead?” Shade asked.

“And instead,” she said, “two days later I heard a merc calling you ‘dragon-that-walks.’ A week after that, someone at the card table was telling a ridiculously exaggerated story about you bursting into full dragon-shape in the middle of a goblin cave. I may,” she added, very quickly, “have corrected a few details. For artistic integrity.”

“Corrected,” Shade said. “By… adding more.”

Rakihi at least had the grace to look guilty. “Sometimes,” she admitted. “But Shade, most of them don’t believe it. Not really. They think it’s bard-talk. Hero seasoning. ‘Oh, he’s like a dragon.’ Not ‘he actually turns into a giant physics problem with wings.’”

Arcebek nodded. “She’s right,” she said. “Half the guild thinks the ‘dragon’ bit is a metaphor. The other half thinks you’re some sort of weird half-blood with a magical ancestor and a flair for drama.”

“That last part is not wrong,” Rakihi stage-whispered.

Shade covered his face.

“So,” he said through his fingers. “I have tried to be… inconspicuous. And instead I am a tavern story.”

Rakihi wriggled closer, resting her chin on his chest. “Shade,” she said softly. “You crash-landed in plate armor. You eat rocks. You talk back to gods. You terrify slavers by standing still. You were never going to be inconspicuous. Even if I stapled my tongue to the bar, people would still whisper.”

Arcebek brushed his hair back from his forehead with a thumb. “If it helps,” she said, “most of them think the stories are exaggerated. They hear ‘dragon’ and they picture the mountain-sized things from the bestiaries. No one is going to connect that to the guy who buys kids pastries and reads romance scrolls in the library.”

“I do not read—” he started, then stopped at the identical looks from both of them. “…Often.”

Rakihi grinned. “Mmm. See? Dread Demon of the Void, occasional consumer of tragic love stories.”

He lowered his hand and sighed.

“Very well,” he said. “So some of this is… you. Most of it is me. And almost none of them truly believe it anyway.”

“Exactly,” she said. “And the ones who get close to the truth are either smart enough to keep their mouths shut… or Lana shuts them for them.”

Arcebek smirked. “Also, if anyone does believe the full story, they’re probably weird enough to be our kind of people.”

Shade thought of Lana, of Grig, of Mora in the Nightmarket.

“…Fair,” he conceded.

Rakihi’s expression softened. “Does it bother you?” she asked. “That people… suspect?”

Shade considered the question more carefully than he had expected to.

“It… worries me,” he said slowly. “That it might draw the wrong attention. That someone will try to use it. That it will make you targets.”

Arcebek snorted. “We were targets the moment we walked into our first dungeon,” she said. “Being targets with a dragon is still better odds than without.”

Rakihi tapped his chest with one finger. “And if people are going to tell stories anyway,” she said, “I’d rather they be about the dragon who paid for a goblin girl’s healing and cooks stew for his lovers, not just the one who melts hills.”

He blinked. “…You’ve been telling those, too?”

“Obviously,” she said. “I’m not a monster.”

For a while, neither of them spoke.

Shade stared at the ceiling again.

“I suppose,” he said finally, “if I must be a legend, there are worse versions.”

Arcebek snuggled in closer, tucking herself into his side. “There you go,” she murmured. “Acceptance. Stage one complete.”

Rakihi yawned and flopped half on top of him again, satisfied.

“Don’t worry,” she mumbled, already drifting. “I’ll keep most of the really ridiculous stuff for after you’re dead. That’s traditional.”

“That is not comforting,” he said.

Her fingers curled in his shirt. “You love me,” she said sleepily.

“Yes,” he said, before he could overthink it. “I do.”

Arcebek’s hand tightened on his. “Same,” she murmured.

The cautious part of Shade’s mind began cataloguing risks: who knew the truth, who guessed, and who might use either against them.

The rest of him listened to Rakihi’s breathing and Arcebek’s heartbeat. Even without the songs, he could never have passed for an ordinary man.

Perhaps it was time to stop trying.

“Rakihi?” he said, almost asleep.

“Mmh?” she replied, voice slurred.

“No more titles like ‘Hillscourge’,” he muttered. “Please.”

She giggled into his chest. “Too late,” she whispered. “But I’ll add ‘Good Cook’ to balance it.”

He sighed.

He sighed, but he was smiling when sleep finally claimed him.

Chapter 26: A Message from the Blue Flight

Shade knew something was wrong the moment the guildhall went quiet.

Not silent—Greenhollow's adventurers were incapable of that—but the dice slowed, the talk faded, and even the hearth seemed to burn more cautiously.

He looked up from the job board.

A woman stood just inside the main doors, and everyone around her was giving ground without quite realizing it.

Tall and elegantly predatory in a humanoid shape that was plainly a courtesy. Blue-black hair, like Shade's, was braided with fine silver chains. Beneath her skin lay the subtle sheen of scales. And her eyes—

He looked away before he met them.

He knew those sapphire irises and slit pupils. The Empress's Eyes could look through the history of anything they touched with their gaze.

She carried the gift of the Blue Flight.

And with it, the memories he would rather leave buried.

His curse.

"Skysunder," the emissary said, voice warm and amused. "You look well."

He despised the attention immediately.

That a familiar voice could still make him feel safer only made it worse.

"Shade," he said automatically. "Here, I am Shade."

"Shade," she echoed, tasting the word. "Very small. Very mortal. Very cute."

Everyone pretended not to stare. Lana's quill hovered above a half-finished signature. Grig had settled a hand near his sword.

Rakihi and Arcebek were at their usual table near the back. He'd clocked them on the way in—Rakihi mid-gesture, Arcebek mid-eye-roll. Now both of them were very still.

He did not look at them.

The emissary approached in a storm-grey coat trimmed with pale blue. A slender weapon hung from her belt, halfway between sword and magical focus. She carried a small chest of dark metal inlaid with scales.

He bowed, just enough to be polite.

"Emissary," he said flatly.

She clicked her tongue. "Is that how you greet your aunt?"

Of course it had to be her.

"Aunt," he corrected, just as flat.

Her mouth curved. "Better."

His mother's elder sister. The one the Empress sent where she could not go herself; the one who had hauled him from battlefields twice and taught him to fold his wings beneath borrowed skin.

"Just here to check in," she said, airily, as if she'd popped by a neighbor's house. "Everything fine? Do you need anything? Have you broken anybody by mistake?"

There it was.

Shade's teeth clicked together.

"I am managing," he said. "No one is broken who I did not intend to break."

Her eyes flicked, just for a heartbeat, to his wrist.

The bracelet lay quiet, the five stones dull and innocent-looking.

"Mm," she said. "So I've heard."

Of course she had heard. The Blue Flight could read the history of objects and battlefields. Some could read souls, if they were prepared to pay the price.

His own Eyes had never awakened.

Yet.

He hoped they never would.

He preferred never.

"Let's sit," his aunt said, as if this were entirely casual. "We're blocking the board."

The guild had formed a semicircle of people pretending to study the job board. Shade followed his aunt to a table in the middle of the hall, where everyone could see them.

Of course.

They sat.

Up close, her irises held fractal patterns like frost on glass. If she wished, she could read the history of his sword, his bracelet, even the chair beneath him.

She wasn't, yet.

He knew what her restraint was meant to tell him.

"So," she said brightly, folding her hands on the chest. "Report. How is my favorite wayward nephew?"

"You have four other nephews," Shade said.

"And three of them are painfully dull," she said. "They stayed home. You jumped realities. You win."

He did sigh then, quietly.

"I am learning," he said. "I have… work. People. Things to protect." He caught himself before he said ours. "Things that matter to this realm."

Her smile softened, just a fraction. "I know," she said.

Did she truly?

Her gaze drifted, briefly, over his shoulder.

Across the hall, Arcebek stared fixedly at her drink. Rakihi's glamour tightened with a faint magical hum.

The aunt's eyes moved on.

Only then did Shade relax his shoulders.

"You've made quite a splash," she went on. "Little stories drifting through the seams. The goblin hill. The fey princess. The way you didn't tear the Fey Queen's envoy's head off in the mortal guild."

His jaw clenched. "You saw that."

"I watched the table afterward," she said. "The way the wood shook when Lana slammed her quill down. A good guildmistress, that one. Knows when to bluff."

He exhaled slowly. "So you know," he said. "About Rak— about the Fey Queen's daughter. About Arcebek. About… all of it."

At last her eyes met his.

The touch of her attention skimmed him like a fingertip across still water.

She did not look any deeper.

"Of course I know," she said gently. "Do you think you could drag Moonthorn politics into a city my Empress is watching and I would be unaware?"

He wanted to be angry. He was angry.

He was angry.

Yet relief ran beneath it. His mother had not forgotten him, not even across the worlds and the endless war against the Void.

He resented that relief most of all.

"You sent me here," he said. "To learn. To… be less. To tame what I am. And yet you watch every step."

"Of course we do," she said. "You are our storm. We let you roam in a mortal street. That street has… fragile people in it. And you have never been gentle with yourself, Skysunder."

"Stop calling me that," he muttered.

"Make me," she said, automatic, the old joke slipping out before either of them could stop it.

For an instant, they were back home, trading the same old challenge.

He scrubbed a hand over his face. "Why are you really here?" he asked. "Besides to fuss and be irritating."

She tilted her head. "Two reasons," she said, surprisingly honest. "One: to see with my own eyes that you are not coming apart. The seal could have… upset you."

He snorted. "That is one word."

"'Traumatized,' then," she said. "Is the mortal term. You have always been the most… porous of us. You feel too much. We were not entirely sure this kind of life would suit you."

"It does," he said, more sharply than he meant to. "It is… loud. And small. And terrifying. And I am not standing alone all the time. I like it."

Pride flashed across her face before she concealed it.

“Good,” she said softly.

“And the second reason?” he pressed.

She tapped the chest.

“Bribery,” she said. “Your mother insisted.”

He eyed it. “I do not need—”

“You don’t get to grow up so far from home and pretend you’re not still hers,” his aunt said. “Open it.”

He didn’t move.

She rolled her eyes and flicked the latch herself, turning the lid toward him.

Dark velvet lined the chest. Inside lay gold and gemstones.

The gold came in neat stacks of local coin, restruck from ingots bearing the Empress’s sigil.

The gems were another matter.

Not chips this time. Not the offcuts he bought from jewelers.

Deep blue sapphires, each the size of his thumbnail, cut and polished, light singing in their depths. A few rubies. One opal that made his teeth ache to look at. All threaded on thin chains of dragonsteel so they could be worn or taken apart as needed.

Shade’s throat tightened before he could speak.

“That is too much,” he said.

“That is what she gave everyone when we went to war,” his aunt said. “Seed-gems. For when we got stuck somewhere unpleasant and needed to steady ourselves. You are… stuck. Somewhere unpleasant.”

“This realm is not—”

She snorted. “Mortals. Politics. Fae Queens. Old shadows. It’s not a picnic in the Skyfields.”

He couldn’t argue.

His fingers moved on their own, touching one of the sapphires. It thrummed under his skin, recognizing him like a long-lost packmate.

“You can tell her,” he said quietly, “that I have been… managing.”

“I will tell her,” his aunt said, “that you have been trying to starve yourself politely because you didn’t want to be a burden.”

He glared at her. She smiled back.

She smiled.

“There is another thing,” she added. “A… reminder.”

Of course.

Here it came.

She leaned in a little.

“You have not yet awakened your Eyes,” she said. “The Empress is… pleased. And worried. It is both blessing and lack.”

“I know,” he said.

“You are harder to aim without them,” she went on. “You are also less… tempted to pry. That is good. But you cannot hide forever, Skysunder. Sooner or later, something will push you hard enough that they open.” Her gaze flicked to the bracelet again. “The goddess will want them.”

He had felt the urge before, whenever he held an old sword or a stone taken from some forgotten place: the temptation to see every hand that had touched it and every grief it had witnessed.

Each time he had looked away.

He’d always looked away.

“I don’t want them,” he said bluntly.

A faint, sad smile touched her mouth. “None of us did,” she said. “The choice was made before we were hatched. But listen: when they wake—and they will—it does not mean you must become only a tool again. You can choose how you look. On whom.”

He swallowed.

“This city,” she said, “this guild, these… people you have entangled yourself with—” there was fond exasperation in it “—they will be safer if you know where the worst cracks are. If you know who is holding chains. Who is sending letters with Moonthorn seals to slavers.”

His eyes snapped to hers.

She smiled, slow and sharp now. “What? You thought your little Nightmarket chat went unnoticed? I watched the rope you put around that man’s neck. Clever. Cruel. Effective.”

He shifted in his chair. “I did not want to just burn it,” he said. “I wanted the hand behind it.”

“Good,” she said simply. “That is how you were made. To see the hand. To break the right bone.”

He clenched his fists on the table.

“What do you want from me?” he asked. “A promise to use the Eyes when they come? A vow not to run?”

“I want,” she said, and for once there was no humor in it at all, “for you to remember that you are loved. Annoyingly. Fiercely. Overbearingly. That we did not send you away because we were tired of you. We sent you because we did not want you to break under only being a weapon.”

The words struck deeper than the warning about his Eyes.

He stared at his hands.

“And,” she added, back to dry, “if you do break someone by mistake, I want you to send a message sooner than three weeks later.”

He huffed out something like a laugh. “I haven’t—”

Her brows rose.

He thought of the goblin cave. The melted hill. The trolls. The slavers.

“I haven’t broken anyone who didn’t deserve it,” he amended.

“Better,” she said. “I’ll take it.”

For a while they listened to the guildhall around them: laughter, mugs striking tables, dice skittering over wood.

Across the hall, someone laughed too loudly at a joke. A mug slammed onto a table. Life went on, the guild adjusting around the presence of a dragon aunt the way water flowed around a stone.

“Do you need anything?” she asked finally. “Besides rocks and reassurance.”

He surprised himself.

“Yes,” he said.

She blinked. “Oh?”

“I need you to… leave them out of it,” he said. “As much as you can. Arce— the warlock. Rakihi. Lana. The kids. This is… their world. I am only one storm in it. Don’t turn them into eyes. Or hooks.”

Her expression softened again. “We are not the only ones watching,” she said. “The goddess, the Fey Queen, a dozen bored minor gods—they all have their gaze here now. You are too… interesting.”

“I am trying very hard not to be,” he muttered.

“Try less,” she advised. “It doesn’t suit you. But—” she held up a hand when his jaw tightened again “—I will speak to the Empress. We will not… weaponize your companions unless there is absolutely no other choice. We would rather not make more of us.”

He wanted to believe her.

He almost did.

He closed the chest gently.

“Tell her,” he said, “that I am still hers. But I am also… theirs.”

There was no need to explain whom he meant.

He didn’t have to.

His aunt’s gaze slid, once more, to the back of the hall.

Rakihi, unable to pretend any longer, gave a tiny, terrified wave when the Empress’s emissary’s eyes brushed her.

Arcebek didn’t move at all. Her hand rested, steady, on Rakihi’s knee.

The emissary smiled, very slightly.

“She knows,” she said. “Mothers always know when their children start building hoards of their own. She is… annoyed. And pleased. Mostly annoyed at herself for not thinking of it first.”

Shade’s chest hurt.

He could barely manage an answer.

She stood.

“I’ll be gone by nightfall,” she said. “Try not to start a war with Moonthorn before then. Or after. But especially before. I’d like a quiet walk home.”

“Can’t promise,” he said.

She laughed. “There’s my nephew.”

She took three steps, then paused, looking back over her shoulder.

“Oh,” she added, as if it were an afterthought. “Skysunder?”

“Yes?”

“When your Eyes wake,” she said softly, “start with small things. A coin. A stone. A spoon. Don’t look at your lovers first. You might drown.”

Then she was gone, crossing the hall, the crowd parting unconsciously around her.

Shade remained at the table, fingers pressed against the closed chest.

His hands were tight on the chest.

He could feel the sapphires humming through the lid.

After a long moment, a chair scraped beside him.

Arcebek sat down, tankard in hand.

Rakihi perched on the other side, looking simultaneously thrilled and horrified.

“So,” Arcebek said casually. “That your aunt?”

“Yes,” he said.

“She terrifying?” Rakihi whispered.

“Yes,” he said again.

Rakihi leaned over and peered at the chest. “Are those for you?” she breathed. “That’s… a lot of therapy rocks.”

He barked a surprised laugh.

“Apparently,” he said, “I am still a child who needs snacks and supervision.”

Arcebek’s hand covered his on the lid. “You’re ours, too,” she said quietly. “Snacks, supervision, and all.”

Rakihi nodded fervently. “Yeah,” she said. “If your Empress-mom wants updates, she can get in line behind us.”

The knot in Shade’s chest eased.

He still disliked the visit: the scrutiny, the warning, the certainty that his Eyes would someday awaken.

The emissary’s visit. The reminder that he was watched. The knowledge that his Eyes would one day open, whether he wanted them to or not.

Yet Arcebek and Rakihi had settled on either side of him, their hands on the chest beside his. Beneath the unwanted attention, he felt something more difficult to admit.

He was being cared for.

Annoyingly.

Fiercely.

Without asking permission.

He thought he could learn to live with that.

Chapter 27: A Home of Their Own

Shade was reasonably certain this was the most rebellious thing he'd ever done.

Not storming a Void breach. Not contradicting a goddess. Not telling a fey queen's emissary exactly what he thought of his threats.

No.

He was about to spend an imperial war chest on a house.

✦ ✦ ✦

Lana examined the neat stack of coins on her desk.

“Let me get this straight,” she said. “You want me to introduce you to a reputable land broker.”

“Yes,” Shade said.

“And you’re paying in coin that looks suspiciously like it used to be dragon-hoard ingots.”

“Yes.”

“And the purpose of this real estate acquisition is…?”

Shade’s jaw tightened. “…A place to live.”

Lana looked past him, over his shoulder.

Arcebek and Rakihi stood behind him, providing the least subtle moral support in Greenhollow. Arcebek shrugged, equal parts defiance and embarrassment. Rakihi waved.

“We love the Anvil,” Arcebek said, “but the walls are thin, the beds are small, and Hesta glares whenever we use the kitchen for anything she calls ‘emotional.’”

“I need somewhere to practice,” Rakihi added. “And a garden would be lovely.” She clasped her hands. “Shade needs a place for his rocks, too.”

“Gemstones,” Shade muttered.

“Rocks,” Lana said. “I’ve seen you chew them.”

She tapped the pile of gold.

“You know your mother would hate this,” Lana said. “War funds spent on curtains.”

“Yes,” Shade said. “That is… part of the appeal.”

Lana’s eyebrows rose. “Oh, we’ve reached open defiance. I’m proud of you.”

“I am not defying her,” Shade said. “I am… investing. In infrastructure. Stable housing increases operational effectiveness.”

Arcebek snorted. “You can take the dragon out of the war, but you can’t take the war out of his budget justifications.”

Lana sighed. “Fine. I know someone who won’t sell you a cursed ruin with pretty shutters.” She wrote down a name and address. “Old Man Jarro. Retired adventurer. Owns entirely too much property. Tell him I sent you. If he cheats you, I’ll send him back into whatever dungeon he crawled out of.”

Rakihi bounced. “Househunting!” she squealed. “This is so domestically reckless.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They visited three properties.

The first was a respectable house in town, but the ceilings were low enough to threaten Shade’s skull, and the neighbours were close enough to hear every note Rakihi played. Arcebek admired the stonework. Shade could hardly breathe.

The second was a collapsing farmhouse with excellent land and disastrous plumbing. Rakihi loved the orchard; Arcebek described the roof as “optimism held together by rot.”

The third stopped them in the drive.

The third was a small manor just outside Greenhollow proper, a fifteen-minute walk from the city gate.

Jarro led them up the gravel, leaning on his cane for theatrical effect. “Old posting house,” he said. “Coaching inn once, then some minor noble’s country retreat. Empty ten years, give or take. Grounds are sound, roof doesn’t leak, cellar’s only a little haunted.”

Rakihi clapped. “We can de-haunt it and then rent the ghosts to the guild for training,” she whispered to Arcebek.

Shade took in the building.

Two storeys of stone and timber stood beyond an overgrown lawn. Ivy had claimed one wall. An oak shaded the front yard; a low boundary wall enclosed the grounds. Behind the house, a neglected stable offered storage space—or the possibility of horses, one day.

Inside, the main hall held a fireplace large enough for Shade to stand in. The kitchen would earn Hesta’s approval after a thorough scrubbing. Downstairs were rooms for guests, studies, or whatever experiments Rakihi might someday insist were harmless. Upstairs were three generous bedrooms, a smaller room beneath the eaves, and a window nook already begging for books.

It was too big for three people.

It felt… right anyway.

Arcebek walked through with her hand on the walls, testing the stone.

“Solid,” she said. “No obvious structural idiocy. Good windows. You can see the city from upstairs, but it’s far enough away that the noise won’t drive us mad.”

Rakihi darted from room to room, leaving a trail of excited commentary.

“This room gets the best light for painting. That one wants a piano. Can we get a piano? Oh, and this window is perfect for looking tragically into the distance while waiting for my lovers to come home.”

Shade remained in what would become the sitting room, watching the empty fireplace.

He could almost see it furnished:

Arcebek in a chair with her boots off, a book balanced on her knee.

Rakihi on the rug, composing with ink on the bridge of her nose.

And himself in the kitchen doorway, flour on his hands instead of blood.

Not preparing to leave. Simply being here.

Having somewhere to return to.

A home that belonged to them, rather than a room rented above a tavern.

The decision settled in him before he spoke.

“Price?” he asked Jarro.

The old man named a number.

Shade calculated what the land and buildings should have cost. “Too low,” he said.

Jarro blinked. “Excuse me?”

“A merchant family would pay more,” Shade said. “The property is worth it. I won’t take advantage of you merely because I dislike haggling.”

Arcebek facepalmed. “Smooth, Skyfall,” she muttered.

Jarro squinted up at him. “You from money, boy?” he asked.

“Not… exactly,” Shade said. “But I understand value.”

Jarro snorted. “Adventurers,” he said. “No sense.”

Jarro offered a second figure, this time a fair one.

Shade laid his mother’s gold on the table in tidy stacks. Sorry, Mother. Not very sorry.

They signed the deeds. Rakihi added a flourish beneath her name. Arcebek checked every clause for provisions that might let some distant noble reclaim the property.

“Congratulations,” Jarro said, tucking the coin away. “You own a house. May it settle your bones and not fall on your heads.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Then came the argument over rooms.

Not for long.

“Master bedroom is for all of us,” Rakihi said immediately. “Obviously. Big bed. Bigger bed. A ridiculous bed. With curtains.”

“We’re not getting a four-poster,” Arcebek said. “That’s asking for Rakihi to swing from it and break something.”

Rakihi grinned. “No promises.”

In the end, they chose the largest bedroom for all three of them. The second became a guest room and storage space. Arcebek claimed the third for her spellwork and accounts; Rakihi took the little room under the eaves for her instruments, on the questionable theory that an explosion there would only destroy the roof.

“And you?” Arcebek asked Shade. “You get the nook?”

He looked at the window-seat area, already seeing bookcases, a small desk, maybe a cushioned bench.

“Yes,” he said. “Library corner. And possibly a small stone altar.”

Rakihi perked up. “For your gods?”

“Yes. And… maybe for others.” He thought of Lana’s shrine shelf at the guild. “It is polite.”

They spent the next days cleaning and laying wards.

Arcebek chalked sigils above the doors and windows. Rakihi circled the grounds with salt and song, gossiping with whatever spirits lived in the hedges. Shade knelt at the foundations and hummed deep notes into the stone until the last traces of old enchantments loosened their grip.

At one point, he paused in the empty hall, eyes closed, sensing.

No lurking curses.

No hostile spirits.

The manor felt tired, neglected—and ready.

He exhaled, long and slow.

“Hello,” he said softly to the house itself. “We’re home.”

✦ ✦ ✦

On the night they first stayed there, they came on foot.

They could have tried to move everything at once, but Lana had insisted they take it slow.

“I want to know where you live now,” she’d said. “In case something goes very right or very wrong. Also, if you vanish more than three days without warning, I will come knock.”

Shade had given her directions. She’d nodded, satisfied, and then, because she was Lana, added, “If you ever do a guild party there, I want an invite and I’m not helping clean up.”

They arrived with little more than the essentials.

After sunset they left the Broken Anvil, pleasantly warmed by drink, each carrying a bag: clothes, books, Rakihi’s beloved lute, Arcebek’s travelling altar.

The road curled between fields and scrub. Fireflies flickered in the grass. The lamps of Greenhollow dwindled behind them until the manor rose against the dark.

Rakihi skipped a little.

“We own a house,” Rakihi said for perhaps the sixth time. “A real one. We can paint the walls. Have people to dinner. Make love without Hesta banging on the wall because we’re ‘ruining her sleep schedule.’”

Arcebek groaned. “Please don’t say that last part where the neighbors can hear.”

“We don’t have neighbors yet,” Rakihi said. “We should get some. Maybe a nice old couple and their seven cats.”

Shade walked between them, hand in each of theirs, listening to their voices and the crunch of gravel.

He remembered his aunt opening the chest, the weight of sapphires in his palm, the unspoken expectation that he would spend them on weapons, repairs, or the next war.

And here he was, among mortals, spending imperial gold on a roof and a kitchen and a garden.

He should, by all his upbringing, feel guilty.

Instead, he felt he had finally spent the gold on something worth protecting.

The manor was dim when they reached it, but not dark. They'd left a single lantern burning in the hall, more symbol than light.

Rakihi unlocked the front door with a flourish and bowed them in. "Welcome," she intoned, "to the House of Terrible Decisions."

Arcebek snorted. "We are not calling it that."

"Name later," Shade said. "Inside first. Before the wind steals all the warmth."

They stepped over the threshold together.

The last time they had entered, they were prospective buyers.

Last time, they'd entered as prospective buyers, interlopers.

Now the place seemed to welcome them, settling around their presence as if it had been waiting for the right voices.

The floorboards creaked in a friendly way under their boots.

They dumped their bags in the main room and did a quick circuit.

The kitchen was still clean. The water worked. Upstairs remained empty enough to echo.

Their bedroom looked almost comically bare with just three bedrolls laid out and a single chest pushed against a wall.

Rakihi spun in the middle of it anyway, arms wide.

"We're going to need actual furniture," Arcebek said. "Chairs. A table that isn't Jarro's leftover. Shelves."

"And curtains," Rakihi said. "We can't trauma-bond in here without proper dramatic curtains."

Shade resolved to ask Hesta where she bought her linens. He would not explain why.

They ended up in the main hall again, in front of the big fireplace, sitting on the floor.

Shade lit the fire with a careful, mundane match. No magic, no divine spark. Just friction, tinder, kindling.

Rakihi watched from beside him, her chin resting on her knees.

"You're doing it," she said softly. "The mortal way."

"Yes," he said. "Feels… appropriate."

The logs caught. Warmth spread across the stone floor.

They sat in silence for a while, watching.

The importance of the moment had little to do with the size of the room.

It was the choice they had made.

The choice.

A place that would still stand here even when the next breach opened and the next battle called.

To make something that wasn't portable, wasn't temporary, wasn't "until the next crack in reality needs a dragon shoved into it."

Arcebek leaned against his shoulder.

"So," she said. "Your mom's going to hate this."

"Yes," he said.

Rakihi curled into his other side, tucking her feet under his thigh. "She can't complain too much," she said. "We're keeping her son alive and well-fed. That's good investment."

"Yes," he said again.

He thought of his aunt's last words.

When your Eyes wake… start with small things. Don't look at your lovers first.

He looked at the fire instead. Let his gaze blur. Felt the old urge rise: to see.

He took a breath.

Not yet.

Small things first.

Later.

Tonight was for this.

For letting the weight of the house settle around them like a cloak.

He listened while Rakihi planned lanterns among the branches and Arcebek grumbled about repair costs before admitting she wanted a forge out back. He pictured other voices joining them: friends, strays, perhaps the two young adventurers from their first trial, asleep on the sofa after a difficult mission.

"A little big for just us," Arcebek murmured, echoing his earlier thoughts.

"Plenty of room to expand," Rakihi said. "With cats. Or children. Or both. Or Varinel's ego, if it doesn't fit in the guild anymore."

Shade huffed a laugh.

He looked at the fire, at their hands tangled in his lap, at the bare walls.

"It is… enough," he said quietly.

For now.

Later, tangled together on three bedrolls in their almost-empty bedroom, Shade studied the ceiling and imagined his mother's expression when his aunt reported:

He spent the gold. On a house. With a warlock and a fairy. He's happy.

The Empress would be furious.

And, perhaps, relieved.

Her storm had found somewhere to land.

Shade smiled into the dark.

“Welcome home,” Rakihi whispered sleepily.

“Welcome home,” Arcebek echoed.

He let himself believe it.

Just this once.

A manor outside town. Too large for three people.

Exactly large enough for the life they had begun to build.

Chapter 28: The Elemental Household

They woke up to noise.

Not shouting or breaking glass. Soft thumps and scrapes drifted through the floorboards, followed by a faint hum and the hiss of something frying. The house had been nearly silent when they fell asleep. Now it sounded busy.

Arcebek rubbed the sleep from her eyes.

Rakihi lay awake on her stomach, ears pricked toward the hallway.

“Do you hear that?” she whispered.

Arcebek frowned. “If that’s burglars, they’re very polite.”

They dragged on shirts and trousers and padded out into the hallway.

And stopped.

Something was sweeping the corridor.

Not a person. Not a broom moving on its own either.

A lumpy little figure of stone and dust stood on two short legs, gripping a broom nearly as tall as itself. Quartz chips shone where its eyes ought to be. With painstaking attention, it pushed a line of dust toward the door.

“Good morning,” Rakihi breathed, delighted.

The dust-thing looked up at them.

It made a gravelly chk, like a pebble against glass, and resumed its work.

“That’s new,” Arcebek muttered.

The smell of fresh bread drew them downstairs.

They followed it.

Small creatures were at work in every room.

Two squat clay figures repaired a crack in the hall wall, piling stones and patting fresh mortar into place. Outside, the garden soil rose in orderly rows, disturbed by something burrowing beneath it.

A swirl of wind threaded with leaves darted past Rakihi’s ankle, then doubled back to straighten a curtain.

Beside the front door, a trembling sphere of water hovered over the potted plant Rakihi had carried from the Anvil. It tipped itself into the soil with a pleased little plip.

“Shade found minions,” Rakihi whispered. “He has minions.”

“In my experience,” Arcebek said under her breath, “anything this cute is dangerous.”

They reached the kitchen.

Shade stood at the counter with his sleeves rolled up and his hair tied back, kneading dough with flour-dusted hands.

The ordinary kitchen oven was lit, and a faint sheen of sweat shone on his forehead. He smelled of yeast and warm stone.

He looked up when they stepped in.

“Good morning,” he said, as though a houseful of elemental creatures were the most ordinary thing in Aleris.

Bowls of rising dough, herbs and sliced cheese covered the table. In the hearth sat a tiny creature of living flame, bright-eyed and horned with wisps of smoke. Its tail wagged when it noticed them.

At the sink, a watery figure shaped like a small child washed dishes, sprouting an extra arm whenever it needed to reach a difficult corner.

Outside the back door, a dust devil the size of a dog swept leaves into a tidy pile.

Rakihi took it all in.

Then she pointed at Shade with both hands.

“You cheated!” she accused, grinning.

He blinked. “No,” he said. “I… asked.”

Arcebek leaned against the kitchen doorframe, taking in the scene.

“Shade,” she said, “why is our house full of minor elementals?”

Shade surveyed the room as though he had only just noticed the activity.

“It was dirty,” he said. “And large. The grounds need tending. We need a garden. And breakfast.”

The water-child handed him a clean bowl without looking.

“Thank you, Fen,” he murmured.

It burbled happily and went back to the washing.

Rakihi padded in, bare feet skidding on the swept floor. She reached down to pat the fire-cat on the head. Her fingers passed through it with a faint tingling.

“Oh,” she sighed. “You’re adorable.”

The fire flickered in pleased little curls, then very carefully licked Rakihi’s palm, leaving only warmth.

Arcebek shook her head. “Give me the mage explanation before I assume you made a pact with the nearest elemental court while we were sleeping,” she said.

Shade wiped his hands on a towel.

“I woke early,” he explained. “The house felt empty. Restless. It could be so much more.”

He glanced at the bracelet on his wrist.

“I asked Terra whether some of her little ones might like to help. Then Fenris for water spirits, Ifret for coals, and Djing and Djang for breezes. They all agreed.”

Rakihi’s eyes went wide. “You… asked the gods for cleaning help,” she said. “You weaponized divine favor into domestic labor.”

“They were bored,” he said. “And the house needed roots and activity.” Catching Arcebek’s raised eyebrow, he added, “They aren’t bound. No chains, no commands. They can leave whenever they wish. I feed them.”

He gestured with his chin.

Near the pantry door, a lightning-spark the size of a mouse was zipping across the ceiling, occasionally dropping down to zap a cobweb or a stubborn rust spot. Every time it did, it flickered brighter.

“Buyakugan sent some strays,” Shade said. “They like… problems. There are many problems here.”

Arcebek snorted. “You’re not wrong.”

“They get something interesting to do,” Shade said. “We get a clean house, a tended garden and less ivy eating the walls. Everyone benefits.”

He turned back to the counter, picked up the lump of dough, and began shaping it into loaves.

“And the bread?” Arcebek asked, though she was already drifting closer, drawn by the smell.

“Terra approves of patience,” Shade said. “And of bread. I wanted to make something for our first morning.”

Rakihi hopped up to sit on the counter opposite him, heels drumming lightly.

“So while we were asleep,” she said, “you: summoned a dozen elemental toddlers, started a commune, and decided to be a baker.”

“Yes,” he said.

She beamed. “I love this for us.”

The stone-sweeper waddled into the kitchen, dragging a little pile of dust behind it. It tipped the dirt reverently into a bucket by the door, then looked up expectantly.

Shade reached into a bowl, took out a small, rough chunk of uncut quartz, and handed it down.

The stone-thing hugged it, its little gravel-sound almost a purr, then toddled off to keep cleaning.

Arcebek watched the little creature go, failing by degrees to maintain her scepticism.

“They’re like children,” she said, “if children were made of rocks and water and wind ferrets.”

“Yes,” Shade said. “Very simple. Very focused. Very happy with small rewards.”

Rakihi swung her legs. “Is this safe?” she asked. “For us. For them. For the neighbors.”

“If I keep them fed, don’t overwork them and stop them getting ideas,” Shade replied.

Arcebek raised a brow. “What kind of ideas?”

“Terra’s little ones like building,” he admitted. “Left alone, they might decide the house needs another room. Or an entirely different shape.”

Rakihi clasped her hands. “Oh no,” she said. “Accidental renovations.”

Arcebek pinched the bridge of her nose. “If I wake up one morning and find a new wing because your pebble kids decided we ‘needed more light,’ I’m making you do the paperwork for the property tax.”

Shade nodded solemnly. “That is… fair.”

She moved behind him, wrapping her arms around his waist, resting her chin between his shoulder blades, peering over his shoulder at the dough.

“You’re enjoying this,” she observed quietly.

He paused.

“Yes,” he said. “I am.”

Rakihi leaned in from the side, cheek on his arm.

“It feels different,” she said softly. “Than summoning armies or holding seams. This is… small. But in a good way.”

He nodded.

“Elementals are always forming,” he said. “Little bits of will carried in the currents. Most vanish into storms, erosion and rain. It’s pleasant to give some of them gentler work—to tend a garden, help a household, learn what home feels like.”

Under her hands, his chest rose and fell, steady.

“So we’re not just making a house,” Arcebek said. “We’re making… a tiny ecosystem. With gods’ grandkids.”

“Basically,” Rakihi said. “We should name them.”

“We are not naming them,” Shade said.

Rakihi pointed at the fire-cat. “That one is Sparky.”

Sparky wagged his tail.

Arcebek laughed into his back. “Too late. You live with us now. Everything gets named.”

Shade sighed, but the smile betrayed him.

“Breakfast will be ready in ten minutes,” he said. “If you set the table.”

Rakihi saluted. “On it, chef.”

The wind-breeze zipped in to help as she grabbed plates from a cupboard, flicking napkins open, tugging an errant lock of her hair just to be annoying. The water-child brought over clean spoons, dripping only slightly. One of Terra’s little stone-folk dragged a stool into place with determined grunts.

Arcebek squeezed Shade one more time, then let go to fetch mugs and coffee.

Shade watched the warlock, the fairy and the elementals weave around one another, laughing, arguing over plates and swearing at splinters.

He slid the first loaves into the oven, closed the door, and leaned on the counter for a breath.

Beyond the kitchen window, Terra’s children worked the soil. Fenris’s waters soaked into the beds; Djing and Djang carried seeds on the wind. Ifret warmed the hearth. Buyakugan’s sparks darted along rusty hinges.

Inside, he smelled yeast and coffee and the faint, clean ozone-hum of his gods, content.

He had been made to hold the line at the edge of worlds.

This morning he was baking bread while a dozen minor spirits swept the floors.

His mother would not approve.

The thought pleased him more than he expected.

“Shade,” Rakihi called. “Do you want the chipped mug or the one with the weird goose on it?”

“The goose,” he said.

Arcebek snorted. “Of course. You’d pick the one that looks like it wants to start a fight.”

He turned back to the oven, checked the crust, and thought:

If this is rebellion, I can live with it.

Chapter 29: The Fey Conspiracy

The message arrived shortly after sunset.

Lana intercepted Shade in the guildhall, catching his wrist with one hand while holding out a folded scrap of dirty paper with the other.

“Your fish is wriggling,” she said quietly. “Old Well boy brought this. Said Jarren damn near pissed himself when it arrived.”

There was no seal. Whoever had sent it was either careless or certain no one would dare interfere.

Shade unfolded it.

The note contained only four lines:

Payment confirmed.
Hand-off of gods at the old oak, three nights hence.
Moonlight. No witnesses.
For the Court.

“‘Gods,’” Lana said. “Plural. I don’t like that.”

“Neither do I,” Shade said.

A trace of magic clung to the paper: an anchoring sigil, a direction, and the unmistakable scent of Moonthorn ink.

He knew the hand that had written it.

Of course.

Lana watched his face. “You going to tell Rakihi?” she asked. “Or Arcebek?”

“No,” he said. “Not yet. The less they are in this, the better.”

Lana considered him, then nodded. “Old oak on the west road. Grig and I will be nearby. If the sky turns the wrong colour, I’ll take that as your signal.”

“I will try not to change the color of the sky,” he said.

“Appreciated,” she said dryly. “Try not to start a war with a major court before breakfast, if you can help it.”

—

He left Rakihi and Arcebek at the manor with a kiss each and a vague excuse about checking a lead. Arcebek studied him before saying, “Don’t do anything I wouldn’t do.”

He left them at the manor with a kiss each and a muttered excuse about “checking a line.” Arcebek had given him a long, measuring look, but only said, “Don’t do anything I wouldn’t do.”

Rakihi had added, “And if you do do something I wouldn’t, take notes so I can put it in the song.”

He stepped out into the night with their laughter at his back.

He knew the road to the old oak. He had walked it with friends, with lovers, and on unsteady legs after an evening at the Anvil.

Tonight he walked it as a hunter.

The oak crouched beside the road, its hollow black beneath the moon. Twisted roots gripped the earth; bare branches scratched at the stars.

Shade didn't go straight to it.

He slipped into the undergrowth opposite the tree and waited.

It didn't take long.

The courier was a minor fey of the sort Rakihi would have called criminally underpaid.

Knee-high and twig-thin, it had bark for skin and a crown of living leaves. Its pale-green eyes darted across the road as it clutched a satchel to its chest.

It scanned the road. The trees. The shadows.

Shade didn't move.

At last it scuttled to the oak and tapped a particular knot in the bark.

The hollow rippled.

A doorway opened inside the hollow, green-black and deeper than the trunk could possibly contain.

The minor fey slipped through.

Shade counted three slow breaths.

Then he moved.

He crossed the road and laid a hand on the oak. The sigil on the note tugged at his senses, drawing him toward the hidden passage.

"Forgive me," he murmured to the tree itself, and stepped through.

—

Moonthorn paths were never straightforward.

He emerged beneath luminous leaves into a twilight that belonged to neither day nor night. The air smelled of damp earth, cold water and ancient pride.

The little fey courier scuttled ahead, following a narrow path that wound between roots and overgrown stones, glancing back nervously now and then.

Shade followed with his presence drawn in as tightly as he could manage.

He could not become invisible. But he could make himself the last thing anyone expected to find.

The path opened into a clearing.

At its centre lay a dark pool beneath an arch of silver leaves. Pale-winged moths drifted through the clearing like scattered lanterns.

The emissary was waiting.

The emissary stood on the far bank, his immaculate cloak and perfect hair better suited to a royal reception than a secret bargain.

The minor fey bowed so low its leaves brushed the moss. "My lord," it said breathlessly. "I have—"

It broke off as Shade stepped fully into the clearing.

The clearing fell silent.

The emissary's smile froze.

"Ah," he said. "So you came."

"Of course," Shade said. "You asked for gods. I thought it best to answer personally."

The emissary glanced at the bracelet and its five silent stones.

"Not those gods," he said smoothly. "Though now that you mention it…"

His gaze sharpened.

"You've been busy, little storm," he said. "Slavers talk when pressed. Guilds posture. Queens are inconvenienced. And through it all, you wander into my affairs without so much as asking permission."

"Your 'business' involves dragging people into cages," Shade said. "We will disagree."

The minor fey stood frozen between them, eyes wide.

The emissary dismissed it with a flick of his fingers. "Go," he said. "You've delivered your… message."

The little creature bowed and bolted, vanishing into the undergrowth.

They were alone.

Moonlight cut leaf-shaped shadows across his angular face.

"Do you know what you've done, Storm-Thing?" he asked softly. "By intercepting my channels. By harboring the Queen's disobedient child. By interfering in our internal matters?"

"Yes," Shade said. "I've given your queen an opportunity."

The emissary blinked. "An opportunity," he repeated.

"To choose better," Shade said. "To treat her daughter as a person, not property. To stop hunting those who wish to leave."

The emissary stared at him for a heartbeat. Then he laughed.

It wasn't a nice sound.

"You really are young," he said. "For all that ancient power, you imagine a court will change because a runaway and her pet dragon glared at its representative in a tavern."

Shade's jaw hardened.

"I think," Shade said, "that a court which refuses to bend will eventually break."

The emissary's smile slipped.

"Oh?" he asked. "You think you are that pressure?"

Shade didn't answer.

Silence answered him. It was enough.

The air between them thickened.

“Enough.” The emissary’s voice lost its warmth. “You have meddled in my affairs, insulted my queen, and tried to intercept a message intended for her. You have crossed a line.”

The absurdity of it almost made Shade laugh.

Shade felt the absurdity of it bubble somewhere under his ribs.

What kind of courtier believed he could kill a firstborn dragon?

Apparently this one.

Moonthorn magic flared.

Darkness spilled toward Shade’s boots. Thorny vines broke through the soil; the pool shuddered and hurled spears of ice at his chest.

He moved.

He didn’t change.

The seals held. No wings unfurled, no storm-body answered his call. He needed neither to deal with a courtier who mistook status for strength.

Shade stepped aside as three spears hissed past, seized a vine in one fist, and crushed it until it fell apart as ash.

The emissary’s eyes widened. His next spell carried glamour into Shade’s mind, wrapping an order in honeyed authority.

Kneel.

The command struck something ancient and unyielding, then splintered.

Shade took another step forward.

The pool rose in grasping hands and whispering faces. Against a mortal opponent it might have inspired terror.

Shade found it irritating.

He began to hum.

A single note, low and steady.

Low, steady, harmonic.

The bracelet’s stones vibrated in answer.

Terra’s weight; Fenris’s flow; Ifret’s heat; Djing and Djang’s turning winds; Buyakugan’s crackle.

The water stilled.

The hands collapsed into the pool, where a thin veil of steam rose as Ifret’s warmth crossed the surface.

Even the shadows recoiled from the vibration of Terra’s stone.

The emissary’s composure cracked.

“You— that shouldn’t—” he snarled.

“Stop,” Shade said, voice still calm. “You cannot win this fight. You can only die in it. I would prefer you lived long enough to carry a message.”

The emissary bared his teeth.

“Arrogant—”

He threw everything then.

The light buckled. For a heartbeat the clearing became a thorn cage, then a hall of mirrors, then a battlefield from Shade’s past. Screams filled the air. The Void pressed close.

Something shifted behind Shade’s eyes.

He saw the spell’s construction—not with ordinary sight or even dragon senses, but through an awareness of the choices that had made it.

A raven-feather quill drawing the glyph on the emissary’s wrist. The queen granting him authority. Three courtiers teaching him the illusion. A runaway sprite breaking beneath its first use.

The Eyes.

They cracked open.

Just a slit.

The world blazed with more information than he could bear.

Shade staggered.

For one instant, the emissary unfolded before him: cruelty, hesitation, vanity, the moments he had flinched beneath the queen’s gaze, and the sick fear he had felt when he learned what was planned for Rakihi.

Beneath everything lay another fear: that he would become irrelevant, just another polished face at court.

It would be so easy to pull.

To unravel him completely.

Shade forced the Eyes closed.

The clearing snapped back into focus.

The thorns were shadows. The cages were illusions. Across the pool, the emissary stood panting, his composure gone.

Shade exhaled.

“Do not,” he said, very softly, “try that again.”

He stepped once.

Twice.

The emissary flung up a hand, a last-ditch ward flaring between them like a pane of glass.

Shade walked through it.

The ward screamed and broke.

He caught the emissary by the throat.

Not hard enough to crush. Not yet.

“Listen,” Shade said, his eyes bright with a light no mortal possessed. “You will not kill me. Not here, not anywhere your imagination can reach.”

The emissary clawed at his wrist, feet kicking a foot off the ground.

“You cannot touch my Queen,” he rasped, defiance and terror tangled. “She’ll—”

“I am not here for your Queen,” Shade said. “Not yet.”

He leaned in.

“But you have bought people in her name, dragged them away in chains, used mortal traffickers to do your work. You are within my reach.”

He let the Eyes crack open again.

Just a fraction.

This time, he aimed them like a knife.

He didn’t look at everything.

He sought only one thread: the moment the queen touched her envoy’s brow and granted him the right to speak in her name.

The bond shone between the emissary’s heart and some distant point deep within Moonthorn.

Shade reached.

He didn’t tear it.

He altered its course.

Just enough.

The emissary screamed.

Magic buckled and twisted, then settled like a badly mended joint.

When it settled, the line was still there.

The thread remained, thinner now.

Frayed.

And marked by a will other than the queen’s.

Shade let the Eyes close, breathing hard.

He loosened his grip just enough for the emissary to suck in air.

“What— what did you—” the fey choked.

“I changed a little of it,” Shade said. “You may still speak for her. The terms are different now.”

He lowered the emissary until his feet touched the moss again, though he didn’t let go.

“You will return and tell the truth. Your mortal channel is broken. Your attempt to retrieve a princess through slavers has been exposed. Greenhollow’s guild is not your kennel. It is a wall.”

The emissary shook his head, teeth gritted. “She’ll kill me,” he hissed.

“Maybe,” Shade said. “Or perhaps she will find you useful as a warning to others.” His gaze hardened. “But if you send another message to Jarren, or order another hand-off in her name—”

He let Ifret stir, just a little.

Heat blossomed around his fingers.

The sigils beneath Shade’s fingers glowed. Flesh remained unharmed, but the court-marks burned bright and then went dark.

Court-marks flared, sizzled, and went dark.

“—then the next time we meet,” Shade finished, “I will not leave you enough of a name for her to punish.”

For a fey, that was worse than death.

The emissary whimpered.

Somewhere in the trees, the minor fey courier watched, eyes huge, understanding more than either of them intended.

Shade let go.

The emissary staggered back, clutching his throat, eyes blazing with humiliation and a fear he’d never admit.

“This isn’t over,” he rasped.

“I know. When your queen is ready to negotiate about her daughter, tell her where to send an honest envoy.”

He turned his back.

Deliberately.

He followed the path toward the oak.

Behind him, the clearing held its breath.

No knife came.

No spell.

When he glanced once over his shoulder, just before stepping through the not-door, the emissary was still standing there by the pool, staring at his own reflection as if hoping it would show him a way to undo what had been done.

It didn’t.

—

Shade returned to the mortal road with a pounding heart and an ache behind his eyes.

The road was quiet.

The sky was still its normal, perfectly adequate color.

Lana stepped out of the shadow of a nearby hedge, cloak wrapped tight, Grig looming behind her.

“Well?” she asked. “We all still alive?”

“For now,” Shade said.

She studied him. “You look as though you licked an old wardstone. Headache?”

“Eyes,” he said, touching his temple. “They… opened. A little.”

Grig swore under his breath. “And?”

“I stayed afloat,” Shade said. “And I broke nothing I hadn’t intended to break.”

“That’s… good?” Lana said, like she wasn’t sure what the criteria were.

Shade exhaled.

“I found the Court contact,” he said. “It was the emissary. He knows the channel is compromised now. He knows if he tries again, I will… act.”

“Did you kill him?” Grig asked.

“No,” Shade said. “I broke his comfort instead.”

“Good. Dead enemies cannot testify. Humiliated ones sometimes make useful mistakes.”

Grig grunted. “You think this will scare the Queen off?” he asked.

“No,” Shade said honestly. “But it may make her reconsider using slavers as her claws. And it buys us time.”

Lana nodded. “That gives us time to strengthen the guild’s position. Improve the city wards. Perhaps convince Rakihi’s mother to listen to something besides her own pride.”

Shade’s lips twitched. “That is… ambitious,” he said.

She shrugged. “I run a guild in a city full of idiots and monsters,” she said. “Ambition is part of the job.”

“Go home,” Lana said. “You look as though someone chewed on your soul. Let your people fuss over you. And if you start seeing the history of my furniture every time you sit down, tell me before it drives you mad.”

“I will,” he said.

Shade followed the road back to the manor without remembering much of the walk.

The house was dark but awake. Terra’s little stone creatures moved through the garden, and Sparky slept among the embers.

Inside, he moved quietly.

Upstairs, Rakihi and Arcebek lay tangled in the bedrolls, embracing a pillow that was unmistakably supposed to be his.

He stood in the doorway for a long moment, watching them breathe.

The temptation returned: to see every choice that had led them here, every touch that had brought these two people into his life.

He shut it down.

Small things, he reminded himself.

Coins. Stones. Spoons.

Not hearts.

Not yet.

He slid under the blankets as carefully as he could.

Arcebek made a soft noise and immediately rolled into his side, arm slinging over his waist. Rakihi mumbled something about “storm idiot” and threw a leg over his.

He lay there, staring at the ceiling, feeling the ache behind his eyes slowly recede.

In another world, perhaps, some courtier might have found a way to kill him.

In this one?

He snorted softly to himself.

Here, a fey official expecting to slay a firstborn dragon was about as plausible as Rakihi willingly returning to the life chosen for her.

He slid an arm around each of them.

The house creaked.

The gods hummed, low and satisfied, in the bracelet on his wrist.

Soon the queen would learn that the storm she hoped to command had made a home here.

And that reaching into this world with slavers and threats would have consequences.

This place was no longer undefended.

Chapter 30: A Dinner for Rakihi

Shade had never seen Rakihi look so suspicious.

She stood in the manor's front hall, nose wrinkled and ears pricked, fighting an obvious urge to bounce on her toes.

“You’re sure I can’t come into the kitchen,” she said for the third time.

“No,” Arcebek said from the doorway, arms folded, expression smug. “You are banned. Prohibited. Persona non grata.”

“Kitchen outlaw,” Rakihi muttered. “Discrimination. In my own home.”

Shade poked his head around Arcebek’s shoulder, flour dusted across one cheek. “You are a known spoon thief,” he said solemnly. “Repeat offender. We cannot take the risk.”

Rakihi put a hand to her chest. “I borrowed one spoon. Once.”

“You used it to summon a pudding elemental,” Arcebek said. “In our bedroom.”

“It was delicious,” Rakihi said.

“The floor is still sticky,” Arcebek shot back.

Rakihi sighed dramatically. “Fine. I will sit here in the boring, empty, not-at-all-interesting hall and suffer.”

Unfortunately for her performance, the hall was neither empty nor boring.

Food scented the air—garlic, spices, and something rich and savoury. The manor hummed with elemental industry. One of Terra's stone-children waddled past carrying a basket of herbs twice its size. A leaf-tangled breeze shot down the corridor, ruffled Rakihi's hair on purpose, and disappeared.

“Traitors,” she informed them.

The house ignored her.

Eventually, Arcebek reappeared.

Arcebek had changed clothes. Properly changed, not merely exchanged one soot-stained shirt for another.

Black trousers, soft boots, a sleeveless dark-red top. Her beard rings gleamed; her jet-black braid had been redone with care.

Rakihi forgot whatever complaint she'd been preparing.

“Oh,” she said, very quietly.

Arcebek’s mouth tugged into a tiny grin. “Thought if we were doing this, we might as well do it properly,” she said.

“Ah,” Rakihi replied brilliantly.

Shade came up behind Arcebek, wiping his hands on a towel.

He had made an effort too: a clean, well-cut shirt with the sleeves rolled up, hair tied back, his bracelet polished. He'd even shaved.

Together, they looked like two distinct kinds of trouble.

“What’s the occasion?” Rakihi asked, suddenly breathless.

Shade tilted his head. “Three weeks in a new house,” he said. “No deaths. No significant structural damage. And you are still here. I thought we should celebrate.”

Arcebek snorted. “What he means,” she said, “is we decided it was your turn.”

“My… turn?” Rakihi repeated.

“To be fussed over,” Shade said simply.

Rakihi opened her mouth. No sound emerged.

“Come on,” Arcebek said, mercifully not commenting on Rakihi’s temporary brain failure. She held out a hand. “Dinner’s ready.”

Rakihi took it.

Her hand was damp in Arcebek's. She hoped the warlock wouldn't mention it.

✦ ✦ ✦

Someone had transformed the main room while she wasn't looking.

The big table near the hearth was covered with a proper cloth, pale and clean. Candles burned in mismatched holders, their light soft and warm. Sparky the fire-elemental dozed contentedly in the fireplace, lending the flames a lazy, purring quality.

The windows stood open a crack. Outside, evening had deepened to blue, and the first stars had appeared.

The elementals had been busy.

The floor shone. Ivy framed the windows in tidy green lines, and tiny white flowers stood in a jug at the centre of the table.

And on the table…

“Oh,” Rakihi whispered again.

There was more than one dish.

Plural.

A shallow bowl held slow-cooked meat and vegetables in a fragrant, spicy sauce. Beside it sat glossy roasted roots, Shade's golden-crusted bread, still steaming, and a sharp-scented green dish that reminded her of forest mornings.

“Sit,” Shade said gently.

She did, almost without thinking.

They’d put her chair so she faced the fire, with Arcebek and Shade flanking her on either side.

Only after sitting did she notice the arrangement: Shade on one side, Arcebek on the other. Tonight, the attention was all hers.

She had no idea what to do with that.

Arcebek poured the good wine Lana had given them when they signed the house papers. Shade served stew, broke bread, and moved around the table with the quiet assurance he'd acquired in the kitchen.

Rakihi watched, chin propped on her hand.

“This is illegal,” she said at last. “You’re both… domestic.”

Shade’s mouth quirked. “Only temporarily,” he said. “Do not worry, we will return to poor decisions tomorrow.”

Arcebek clinked her mug against Rakihi’s. “To minor gods and major bad ideas,” she toasted.

Rakihi laughed and drank.

The meal was magnificent.

The stew was rich and warming; the vegetables still had bite. Shade's bread cracked beneath her fingers, soft inside and perfect for soaking up the sauce.

They didn’t rush.

Shade asked about the song she'd been working on and the odd interval she'd been muttering for days. Arcebek retold their first troll hunt, making Varinel even grumpier than memory allowed. Every so often the two of them traded a glance over Rakihi's head, checking whether she was enjoying herself.

Halfway through her second bowl, Rakihi realised they were nervous.

Them.

A warlock who bargained with demons. A dragon who had faced the Void. Nervous about a dinner they'd prepared for her.

Her chest tightened with affection.

After dinner, Shade cleared plates with a soft word to Fen; the water-child happily took over washing up. Arcebek shooed Rakihi away from trying to help.

“You’re the guest,” she said firmly. “For once.”

“I live here,” Rakihi protested weakly.

“Tonight you’re the guest,” Shade said. “Sit.”

He gestured toward the hearth.

They had laid cushions and blankets in a generous nest before the hearth while she was occupied with dinner.

Rakihi’s cheeks heated. “You two are plotting,” she said.

“Yes,” Arcebek said cheerfully. “We are.”

Rakihi collapsed onto the cushions, straightened her skirt, and tried to contain a grin.

Shade sat beside her without crowding her. Arcebek settled on the other side, kicked off her boots, and stretched her toes toward the fire.

For a moment, no one spoke.

The fire popped.

Wind whispered under the eaves.

A little spark zipped up the chimney.

“You’ve been very patient with us,” Arcebek said finally, breaking the quiet. “With… everything. With me. With his pacing. With the world trying to fall over every third day.”

Rakihi shrugged, suddenly shy. “You were worth waiting for,” she said.

Shade’s hand twitched on his knee.

“There are things I am still learning,” Shade said. “About this. About wanting someone—and being wanted.” He looked between them, then down at his hands.

Rakihi leaned over and bumped her shoulder against his. “You’re doing fine,” she said softly. “More than fine.”

“We realised,” Arcebek said, “that in all this chaos we've let you do most of the chasing.”

Rakihi opened her mouth to protest.

Arcebek put a finger on her lips. “Hush. You’ve made it very clear what you want,” she said dryly. “Repeatedly. In detail. With diagrams, once.”

“That was private practice,” Rakihi muttered into her finger.

“And very inspiring,” Arcebek said. “Tonight, it’s our turn.”

Rakihi swallowed.

“…Oh,” she said.

Shade turned his hand, palm up, on his knee.

Rakihi stared at it, then slid her fingers into his.

Warm. Calloused. Steady.

He squeezed gently.

“Is this all right?” he asked.

She laughed, a little breathless. “If it wasn’t, I’d have the poorest sense of timing in any court,” she said.

Arcebek leaned in and kissed her.

This was no quick kiss stolen at the Anvil. Arcebek took her time, warm and certain, leaving Rakihi free to answer—or pull away.

Rakihi answered with everything she had.

By the time Arcebek drew back, Rakihi’s head was spinning in the best way.

She turned to Shade.

He watched her with an open wonder that still undid her, as though happiness were something he dared not touch too firmly.

“Hey,” she said softly. “Dragon.”

“Hey,” he echoed, just as soft.

She cupped his jaw, marveling again at the line of it, at the barely-there shimmer in his eyes that marked what he was when he wasn't pretending.

"Come here," she said.

When he kissed her, it was careful at first. Reverent. Like she was something delicate.

Rakihi gripped his shirt and drew him closer. He understood the invitation.

He caught on quickly.

They took their time.

They laughed at first. Rakihi elbowed Shade while trying to pull Arcebek closer; Shade apologised for putting his hands in the wrong place; Arcebek threatened to draw them a diagram.

The laughter gave way to kisses.

The fire burned low.

They reached for one another without hurry.

Soon the room was only warmth, breath, and the soft crackle of the hearth. Shade's five stones chimed once, almost in surprise, and fell discreetly silent.

Rakihi had wanted this for longer than she cared to admit.

Now it belonged to all three of them.

The rest was theirs to keep.

✦ ✦ ✦

Morning brought aches.

Pleasant ones, mostly.

Rakihi woke first, sprawled across the bedroll in their room. Somehow they'd made it upstairs. Her blanket had slipped to the floor, her hair was hopeless, and her shoulder complained when she stretched.

She stretched.

Something twinged on her shoulder.

She twisted her neck to look.

Four shallow crescents marked her skin, already fading pink where Shade's claws had grazed it.

Her grin widened.

She sat up slowly.

Shade lay on his back beside her, one arm over his eyes and the other stretched across the space she'd vacated. His shirt had disappeared. Faint bites and bruises dotted his neck and chest—an impressive record of their evening.

The scratches across his shoulders, however, were unmistakably Arcebek's.

Arcebek slept half across him, as though she'd claimed him as a pillow and refused to surrender the prize. She bore a few marks of her own.

Rakihi bit back a giggle.

Her hips protested the movement.

Worth it.

Arcebek groaned and cracked one eye open. “If you are cheerful,” she rasped, voice wrecked, “I’m throwing you out the window.”

Rakihi flopped back down between them, draping herself over Shade’s midsection. “I’m very cheerful,” she said. “But also possibly dead from the waist down.”

Shade lowered his arm, blinking at the ceiling. “Everything hurts,” he observed.

“Aw,” Rakihi cooed. “Did the big dragon have a big night?”

He looked at her.

He looked thoroughly exhausted, wonderfully content, and a little surprised by both.

“Yes,” he said simply.

Color rose in his cheeks.

Arcebek snorted and patted his chest, fingers brushing a particularly dramatic bite mark just below his collarbone.

“That one might be my favorite,” she said. “Very artistic.”

Shade glanced down at himself, then at both of them, and huffed out a laugh that sounded almost shy.

“You two are… very thorough,” he said.

Rakihi preened. “You’re welcome.”

He rolled toward them, winced, and pulled them close: an arm around Arcebek's waist, the other gathering Rakihi against him.

They lay together in a tangle of sore muscles, warmth, and morning breath.

“If Hesta could see us now,” Arcebek murmured, “she’d make some incredibly inappropriate comment about ‘working up an appetite’ and then complain about laundry.”

Rakihi snickered into Shade’s shoulder. “If my mother could see us now, she’d set the house on fire,” she said.

Shade’s grip tightened just a fraction.

“She will not,” he said quietly.

Rakihi tilted her head to look up at him. “You can’t stop her from being mad,” she said. “You know that.”

“No,” he agreed. “But I can make it very… inconvenient… for her to express it in ways that involve my house and my people.”

Arcebek’s thumb drew lazy circles on his ribs. “We’ll deal with her when we have to,” she said. “Not before. For now…”

She let her hand drift, very gently, over a set of claw marks on his back.

"…we should probably heal some of this before Lana sees and starts asking very pointed questions."

Rakihi laughed outright. "Can't we keep one?" she begged. "Souvenir?"

"You can keep them in your memory," Arcebek said. "Not on his neck. We still have to look respectable occasionally."

Shade made a thoughtful noise. "Lana already knows more than she should," he said. "But perhaps it is better if she does not have… visual aids."

Rakihi propped herself up on an elbow. "All right, all right, practicalities later," she said. "For the record, though?"

She looked from one to the other and let the teasing fall away.

"That was… good," she said. "Better than the stories in my head. And, you know. That's saying something."

Arcebek's expression gentled. "Same," she said. "For the record."

Shade met their eyes, his own unusually bare.

"I have no stories to compare it with," Shade said. "But last night was mine. Ours." He searched their faces. "And I am grateful."

Rakihi's heart did that annoying swelling thing again.

"Ugh," she said. "Now I'm going to get sappy about it."

"You already are," Arcebek murmured.

Shade kissed the top of Rakihi's head, then Arcebek's.

"Breakfast," he said. "Before the elementals riot."

Rakihi flopped back down. "Carry me," she demanded.

"No," both of them said at once.

They rose slowly, complaining about sore muscles, catching one another's eyes, and laughing at the evidence they'd left behind.

Downstairs, the house was already awake: Sparky coaxing the hearth back to life, a stone-child dutifully sweeping, the faint clink of dishes as Fen tidied the kitchen.

Arcebek rolled her shoulders, winced, and started coffee.

Shade kneaded dough with a faint flush still on his cheeks.

Rakihi watched from the doorway, aching and content. The kitchen smelled of bread, the hearth was warm, and both of them were still here.

For once, she had been the one surprised.

After all the teasing and uncertainty, she'd been welcomed without reservation.

Arcebek was making coffee.

Shade was kneading bread.

They were arguing about breakfast.

She grinned to herself and padded in to steal a piece of dough.

Shade smacked her hand away, belatedly.

Arcebek laughed into her mug.

The gods in the bracelet hummed, amused.

Outside, another ordinary day waited for them.

Chapter 31: The Summons

The summons began with a headache.

Not the aftermath of too much ale at the Anvil, nor the peculiar discomfort of hearing Shade hum in twelve dimensions. This pain struck behind Arcebek's eyes and ran cold down her neck.

She was in the guild library when it hit.

One moment she was bent over a scroll, arguing with Rakihi over whether a rune array was elegant or needlessly explosive.

Then every mark on the parchment blurred and rearranged itself.

Into her mark.

The mark burned along her ribs answered with phantom heat, as though someone had pressed a brand against her skin.

Arcebek hissed, hand going to her side.

“Bek?” Rakihi straightened. “What’s—”

“I’m fine,” Arcebek grunted. “Just— ow. Okay. That’s new.”

The air thickened, tasting of stone, candle smoke, ink, and something dangerously close to blood.

A voice whispered inside her mind, close as breath:

Arcebeka-of-the-Bound-Flame.

Only her patron used her full name.

You are called.

Arcebek closed her eyes.

“Now?” she thought back, as politely as she could manage through the pain.

Now, the presence replied, absolute and unhurried. You are summoned, warlock. Your play is over. It is time to pay your share.

The pain vanished, leaving a certainty colder than the headache had been.

Rakihi was still staring at her, worried.

“What did she say?” Rakihi asked softly.

Arcebek’s jaw worked.

“She said,” Arcebek replied, equally soft, “that our quiet time is over.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They didn’t talk about it in the library.

Arcebek walked home at something like her usual pace, scroll case over her shoulder, making pointless small talk. Shade met them at the gate with soil on his hands and a smudge on his cheek, probably a farewell gift from one of Terra's stone-children.

He smiled—easy and open. “You’re back early,” he said.

Arcebek's heart clenched.

"Need to talk," she said. "Inside."

Rakihi didn't crack a joke.

That, more than her words, sharpened Shade's expression.

They gathered in the main room and sent the elementals away. Sparky retreated from the hearth into the chimney, sensing a kind of heat that had nothing to do with fire.

Arcebek stayed on her feet. Sitting felt dangerously close to giving in.

She rubbed a hand over her face. "My patron called," she said.

Rakihi went very still.

Shade's fingers curled against his thigh.

"Called how?" he asked carefully. "A dream? A vision? A letter written in someone else's blood?"

"Headache," she said, managing a rough laugh. "Sigils everywhere. The usual. She wants me there. In person."

"In her domain," Shade said, voice flat.

"Yep."

"For what?" Rakihi blurted. "A checkup? A job? A performance review? Does she want to renegotiate? What—"

"I don't know," Arcebek cut in.

She hated saying it.

"I don't know," she repeated. "She doesn't… explain." Her mouth twisted. "Patrons almost never do. We make the pact, we get the power, and then one day they pull the leash and see how well we dance."

Shade's gaze dropped to her hands.

"And if you ignore it?" he asked.

Arcebek snorted. "Then I stop being a warlock," she said. "Best case. Worst case, she reaches through whatever thing I'm touching and yanks me anyway, but angrier."

Rakihi's ears flicked, her glamour buzzing faintly. "How long?" she asked. "How long will you be gone?"

"I don't know that either," Arcebek said. "Could be a week. Could be… longer. Time's weird on the other side of a pact."

The room seemed to grow smaller.

Shade's shoulders bunched. "I will come with you," he said immediately.

"No," Arcebek said just as fast.

His eyes flashed. "Arcebeka—"

"No," she repeated, voice sharp enough to cut. "This is my pact. My mess. My patron. She didn't sign a contract with you or Rakihi. If you try to follow, she'll see it as interference. She'll take it out on me. Or you. Or both. And I don't know what that looks like." Her jaw tightened. "I'm not risking that."

Rakihi swallowed hard. “You expect us to just… stay,” she said. “While you walk into a demon’s parlor alone.”

Arcebek’s lips curled. “She’s not a demon,” she said reflexively. “She’s—”

“Old,” Shade said, quietly. “And not bound by mortal conceptions of fair.”

Arcebek’s gaze softened briefly. “Yeah,” she conceded. “That.”

She paced until the impulse to flee had nowhere left to take her.

Finally she stopped, facing them.

“If I’m not back in three months,” she said, “don’t come looking for me.”

Rakihi stared. “Absolutely not,” she said. “That’s a terrible plan.”

Shade looked like she’d just asked him to stand still in a collapsing universe.

“Arcebek,” he said slowly. “You cannot expect me to do nothing if—”

“If I’m not back in three months,” Arcebek repeated, tilting her head back to look at the ceiling for a moment, as if asking it for patience, “it means one of three things. One: she’s keeping me longer because the work’s more complicated than I thought and time’s being weird. If you barge in, you mess that up and everyone suffers.”

She held up two fingers. “Two: I’m dead, which means you can’t ‘come looking’ because there’s nothing to find but consequences.”

Three fingers. “Three: I’ve chosen to stay. For reasons that will make sense then, even if they don’t to you now. In which case, you busting into her realm like angry divorce lawyers is only going to make it worse.”

Rakihi’s eyes shimmered. “So we’re supposed to just… wait,” she whispered. “Three months. Watching the door. Hoping you walk back in.”

“Yeah,” Arcebek said.

“That’s cruel,” Rakihi said bluntly.

“I know,” Arcebek said, equally blunt. “I’m not pretending it isn’t. I just… don’t see a better way that doesn’t risk you both.”

No one spoke. The hearth ticked as the logs settled.

Shade’s jaw clenched. “When do you have to go?” he asked.

Arcebek’s voice softened. “Soon,” she said. “She wasn’t… raging. This isn’t a ‘come now or else’ call. More like… ‘finish your dinner, get your affairs in order, then report.’ But not too long. A week. Maybe two. The call will only get stronger.”

Rakihi scrubbed at her eyes with the heel of her hand. “Coward,” she muttered.

Arcebek blinked. “Excuse me?”

“You heard me,” Rakihi said, looking up with a watery glare. “Telling us not to come after you. Taking all the risk and trying to keep us safe and noble and outside of it. It’s cowardly. You think we can’t handle it. Or that we don’t get to choose if we want to.”

“I know you can handle it,” Arcebek snapped back. “That’s the problem. You’ll try. Even if it kills you.”

“Welcome to loving people, you stubborn bronze menace,” Rakihi shot back.

Shade didn’t raise his voice.

He didn’t have to.

“Enough,” he said.

They both stopped, breath sharp.

He stepped forward until he was in front of Arcebek, looking down at her with that steady, storm-quiet gaze.

“You're allowed to be afraid,” he said. “We're allowed to be angry. But we won't tear at one another over something none of us chose.”

Arcebek’s throat worked.

“I hate this,” she said.

“I know,” he said.

He lifted a hand, hesitated for a fraction, then cupped her jaw, thumb brushing the line of her cheekbone.

He'd held her face a hundred times. Now his touch seemed almost hesitant.

“I will respect your wish,” he said. The words sounded like they hurt going out. “For three months, I will not seek your patron. I will not tear open the seams of her realm. I will not bargain for your shadow. I swear it.”

Relief crossed Arcebek's face, followed immediately by guilt.

“Shade—”

He shook his head. “Do not thank me yet,” he said. “There are conditions.”

She snorted weakly. “Of course there are.”

“You leave us a way to know you still live,” he said. “Some… sign. A sending. A mark on a stone. Something you can push through, even if it’s faint.”

She thought about it, jaw tightening. “I can… try,” she said. “She’ll block most things. But I might be able to piggyback on the pact mark once a month. A dream. A… feeling.”

“Once a month,” he said. “Minimum. At least enough that we know you are not gone.”

He looked over at Rakihi. “Agreed?”

Rakihi’s eyes were bright with angry tears, but she nodded slowly. “Better than nothing,” she said. “If you ghost us, I will talk him into breaking your rule.”

“Fair,” Arcebek said hoarsely.

“Second condition,” Shade went on. “If I learn—not guess, not fear, but know—that you are being destroyed on purpose, used in a way you would not consent to, or turned against yourself and us—I will come.” His gaze didn’t waver. “Three months, ten months, three centuries. Pact or no pact. Empress or no. I won’t let you be made into another weapon for someone else’s war.”

Arcebek’s eyes closed for a heartbeat.

When she opened her eyes, her expression had steadied.

“Okay,” she said. “That’s… fair.”

Rakihi sniffed. “Third condition,” she said.

They both looked at her.

She squared her shoulders, small and fierce.

“You come back,” she said. “If you can. If there’s any choice. If there’s any sliver of you left that gets to say yes or no. You come back. To us. Not because we’re safe. Not because we’re convenient. Because we’re yours. If we lose you to choice, I can live with that. If we lose you because you didn’t try…” Her voice shook. “I don’t know if I can forgive that. Not you. Not her. Not me.”

Arcebek stepped toward her, hands coming up to cradle Rakihi’s face.

“I’ll try,” she said. “Goddess, little queen, I will try.”

Rakihi’s laugh broke in the middle. “You’d better,” she muttered. “I just got this whole ‘triad’ nonsense working.”

They ended up together on the couch, Arcebek between Shade and Rakihi, listening to the house settle around them. Neither asked the others to speak.

Eventually, Arcebek stirred.

“Three months,” she said. “If I’m not back… you keep going. Both of you. Live in this ridiculous house. Take jobs. Drive Lana insane. Raise some kind of chaotic apprentice. Don’t… freeze.”

Shade’s jaw flexed. “We will not stop,” he said. “But we will leave a chair at the table.”

Rakihi wiped her nose on his sleeve, because she could. “And I will write the most obnoxious ‘bring back our warlock’ ballad anyone’s ever heard,” she sniffed. “Just out of spite.”

“Spite is a great motivator,” Arcebek said, voice thick. “Use it.”

✦ ✦ ✦

She left four days later.

There were no guild witnesses, no grand farewell. Arcebek refused Lana's offer to send Grig as escort: too many eyes, she said, and no reason to wave banners in Hell's face.

Only the three of them stood at the west gate in the cool morning air, the road stretching away beyond it.

Arcebek had her pack, walking clothes, her best knife. Her warlock mark burned faintly under her shirt, an itch she kept rubbing at.

Rakihi clung to her for a long moment, arms tight around her neck, muttering a string of half-jokes and half-threats into her ear.

“If you come back with a new patron, I’m breaking up with you and stealing all your boots,” she said.

“If I come back with a new patron, you have permission to kill me,” Arcebek replied.

Rakihi’s hands tightened. “…Don’t joke,” she managed.

“Not joking,” Arcebek said. “You know the rules of my work. If I’m not me… stop me.”

Rakihi drew back, eyes wet, and nodded once. “Same,” she whispered. “If they touch your head, I’ll touch their throat.”

Shade watched them, hands flexing uselessly at his sides.

When Rakihi finally let go, Arcebek turned to him.

He didn’t say “stay.”

He wanted to.

He didn’t.

He stepped close and embraced her. For a breath he tried to be gentle. Then he held her fiercely, as though his strength could make up for all the things he could not promise.

“Three months,” he murmured into her hair.

“Three months,” she echoed against his chest.

“If you feel you can’t send a dream,” he said, “send a feeling. A chord. I will listen.”

“I know,” she said. “You always do.”

He drew back and looked at her carefully, memorising her face in the thin morning light.

“You are not alone,” he said quietly. “Even when you are there. Remember that.”

She smiled—crooked, fond, furious, frightened.

“I know,” she said again.

She stepped back.

The road stretched out beyond the gate.

She adjusted her pack. Checked her knife. Took a breath.

“If I’m not back in three months,” she said, voice steady now, “don’t come looking just because you’re afraid. Come only if you know.”

Shade nodded.

Rakihi sniffed. “You’re still a coward,” she muttered.

Arcebek grinned. “I love you too.”

She turned toward the road.

And walked.

She waited until the first rise before looking back.

They were still at the gate: Shade motionless, Rakihi bright-haired and small beside him.

She lifted a hand.

They lifted theirs.

Then the hill swallowed her.

The gods in Shade’s bracelet thrummed faintly, like a plucked string.

Rakihi reached blindly for his hand.

He took it.

Life went on, because it had to.

The house creaked. The elementals cleaned. Lana sent jobs. Rakihi sang—sometimes too brightly, sometimes not at all.

They watched the door.

They counted days.

They waited for the first dream.

Chapter 32: The Taste of Fear

Shade had never considered fear his own emotion.

Terror belonged to mortals caught on battlefields and cultists who learned too late what waited beyond their rituals. His work had always been to stand between them and the thing they feared.

He'd stood in front of a Void Lord and not flinched.

Yet this was worse.

This was worse.

Because he had promised not to act.

✦ ✦ ✦

In the first week after Arcebek left, Shade moved through his days as though he were underwater.

He went to the guild, checked the board, and took Rakihi on low-risk patrols: goblin nests, minor undead, a wolf pack grown bold. He baked bread, mended armour, and scolded Sparky for trying to eat the kindling box.

His hands stayed steady. His voice stayed measured.

Inside, something paced.

He had promised Arcebek three months. He would not follow merely because he was afraid. He knew what promises meant to beings like his mother and the gods.

Breaking a promise was never a small mistake.

It could be an act of war.

So he honored it.

He guarded that promise as fiercely as he had ever guarded a battlefield.

And whenever the temptation to rip reality open grew too strong, he remembered Rakihi's face if he told her he was leaving too.

"You're leaving too?"

He couldn't do that to her.

Not when she was already shattering in such quiet places.

✦ ✦ ✦

He had expected Rakihi to rage.

To curse the sky, the patron, anyone who listened. To get drunk and start fights. To write five furious ballads and perform them all at the Anvil.

She did some of that.

She played until her fingers bled one night. She went to the Anvil and sang a song so sharp half the room left with wet eyes and the other half left determined to punch a god on principle.

Mostly, though, she fell apart when she thought nobody could see.

Shade learned where to find her.

Not in their bed or the main hall, where she knew he might walk in.

In the manor library, knees to her chest, a closed book on her lap, tears travelling silently down her cheeks.

On the back step, wearing one of Arcebek's old shirts, crying into her hands while Terra's bewildered stone-children patted her feet.

Once beneath the oak, stretched in the grass, whispering Arcebek's name between clenched teeth.

He never offered clever words.

There wasn't anything clever to say.

He sat beside her and held her whenever she reached for him.

She always did.

Sometimes she sobbed until her body shook. Other times she simply lay against his chest, silent, soaking his shirt with tears.

"The first months in the frontlines were easier than this," he admitted once, voice low, his chin resting on the top of her head. "Then at least I knew what teeth I was facing."

"This is teeth," she whispered hoarsely. "They're just… in my head."

He couldn't argue.

All he could do was hold her and murmur, "I know," and mean it.

A month should have meant very little to him.

His people measured time in centuries. A few dozen mortal days scarcely registered between greater events.

This month dragged like a wound that would not close.

Each morning he checked for the faint echo of Arcebek's pact mark in the world. It was still there, distant and muffled, but he could not reach it.

At night he listened to Rakihi breathe beside him, counting her heartbeats while he tried not to imagine the morning when Arcebek's echo might disappear.

He got reckless in small ways.

He pressed harder on missions. Used more force than he needed. One afternoon he destroyed three practice targets in succession, the last so violently that the training yard went silent. Lana crossed the sand, took his sword from him, and told him to go home.

He went.

Home. To a house that felt lopsided without her voice in it.

Rakihi slept in the middle every night, guarding an empty space with her body.

"Just in case," she mumbled, when he asked.

He didn’t ask again.

✦ ✦ ✦

The message arrived on the thirty-second day.

It entered through the kitchen window like a tiny, smoking projectile, swearing all the way down.

Shade heard the thud against the table and Rakihi's startled cry.

He was in the yard, hands in the soil, helping Terra’s stones line a new herb bed. His head snapped up.

Inside, something shrieked, “OW—WATCH IT, YOU LEAF-BRAINED—” followed by Rakihi’s, “Oh my gods, you’re tiny.”

Shade was already moving.

He stepped into the kitchen to find Rakihi standing on a chair, one hand clapped over her mouth to hide a grin, looking down at the table.

On the table sat an imp.

An imp the size of a cat sat there, all crooked limbs, oversized ears, and soot-dark skin. Small horns curled from its forehead, and its spade-tipped tail twitched as it brushed ash from its shoulders and cursed mortal architecture.

In its clawed hand, it held a folded scrap of parchment edged with faint, familiar sigils.

The scent of Arcebek's pact.

Her unmistakable signature.

Shade’s heart did something ugly and sharp in his chest.

“Delivery,” the imp announced, in a surprisingly prim voice. “One message, as per contract. Signature?” It squinted up at Shade, then Rakihi. “Preferably the tall one. Fewer teeth.”

Rakihi made a wounded noise. “I have exactly the right number of teeth, thank you.”

Shade stepped closer. “I will sign,” he said.

The imp held out a tiny slate and a nub of chalk.

Shade signed with a hand that shook despite the absurdity of the request.

The imp checked it, nodded to itself, and shoved the parchment into his hand.

“No replies,” it said briskly. “One-way channel. No hitchhikers. No blood. No extra clauses on the back in invisible ink. Lady said if I tried any of that she’d use me as candle wax.”

“That sounds like her,” Rakihi muttered.

His fingers felt clumsy as he unfolded the parchment.

The handwriting was hers: angular and practical, with one blot where she had plainly cursed and continued writing.

I’m fine.

Three words. He exhaled without meaning to.

Weather’s hot.

He could hear the dry humour in those words. Somewhere hot, then. Or worse.

Don't like the neighbours.

That last line made his mouth twitch despite itself.

Rakihi leaned across his arm, barely breathing as she read.

"That's her," Rakihi said, voice wobbly with equal parts relief and complaint. "'Hey, I'm not dead, also the neighbors suck.' Classic."

Shade read it again.

Fine. Hot. Neighbours bad.

It was almost nothing.

It was everything.

He turned the parchment over, hoping for a second message despite the imp's warning.

Blank.

He held it up to the light. No extra strokes. No micro-sigils. Just those three clipped lines.

The paper smelled faintly of smoke and the peculiar incense Arcebek used when she prayed at her altar.

He pressed his thumb to the edge.

A sting, scarcely more than static, brushed his skin.

Under it lay a trace of Arcebek herself: irritation, deep exhaustion, and the stubborn certainty that she was still herself.

Shade breathed out for what felt like the first time in weeks.

"She's alive," he said. "She's… herself."

Rakihi snatched the parchment, cradling it like it might try to escape. "Of course she is, she's too stubborn to die because of a summons," she said, and then, in a much smaller voice, "But it's nice to have proof."

The imp cleared its throat.

"If you two are done having a moment," it said, "I have to get back before somebody notices I've gone. You mortals get weird about schedule breaches."

Shade focused on it properly for the first time. "Thank you," he said, and meant it.

The imp blinked, as if it wasn't used to that answer.

"Just doing the job," it muttered. "She paid extra for proper delivery." It scratched its nose. "Also threatened to unmake my favourite hat if I peeked. Professionalism, you know."

Rakihi's mouth quirked. "She's keeping imps in line," she said. "I feel safer already."

Shade took a small, flawed ruby from the bowl where he kept stones he considered fit only for snacking.

The imp's eyes locked on it with feral intensity.

"Tip," Shade said, placing it carefully on the table.

"I— we're not supposed to—" the imp started.

“Consider it hazard pay,” Shade said. “For dealing with our emotions.”

The imp's gaze darted from the ruby to Shade to Rakihi. A quick calculation followed.

Then it snatched the ruby, stuffed it into its mouth, chewed once, shuddered in bliss, and vanished in a pop of sulfur and smugness.

Silence settled.

Rakihi held the parchment to her chest, eyes closed, breathing uneven.

Shade rested against the counter. Now that the message was delivered, his hands had begun to shake.

Fear had never felt like his emotion.

Not until now.

Now he knew it: metal on the tongue, an ache behind the breastbone, the urge to move when movement might destroy what he most wanted to save.

The message didn’t erase it.

But it eased the pressure enough for him to breathe.

“She kept her word,” he said quietly. “First month.”

Rakihi opened her eyes. They were still wet, but she was smiling now, crooked and fierce.

“Then we keep ours,” she said. “We wait. We live. We make this place so stupidly, obnoxiously ours that when she comes back, she has something worth coming back to.”

He nodded.

He reached out, and she stepped into him without hesitation, parchment crinkling between them as he folded her into his arms.

One of Terra's stone-children peered around the doorway, saw them holding each other, and retreated. Apparently there was nothing here that needed sweeping.

Outside, the sky carried on. For once, the Void remained a distant problem.

Inside the manor, a dragon and a fairy held tight to a scrap of parchment and to each other. The first month without Arcebek was over. They had survived it. They could survive another.

Chapter 33: The House Begins to Heal

For the first time in weeks, the house sounded like home.

Rakihi laughed.

Not the brittle giggle she'd used to paper over the cracks. This laugh rose from her belly, bubbled out of control, and ended in a snort she tried too late to hide.

She teased him without mercy: filthy innuendo, a terrible impression of Lana, and ten uninterrupted minutes imagining Arcebek's reaction to their mourning over a single scrap of parchment.

“She’d call us dramatic,” Rakihi said, sprawled across the couch, waving Arcebek’s note in the air. “Then she’d hug us so hard your ribs would creak and tell us to stop being idiots.”

Shade's mouth twitched. "She would."

The last of the strain around Rakihi's eyes eased.

Then all the grief she'd been holding at arm's length rushed in alongside the relief.

She reached for him. He reached back.

By the time they made it upstairs, she was all hands and breathless laughter, as though one night might make up for a month spent afraid to want anything.

"Are you sure?" Shade asked. He had to know; the last few weeks had left her raw.

“Yes,” she said, and there was no hesitation in it at all. “Please don’t make me explain that twice.”

So he didn’t.

They were desperate and clumsy at times, but the joy was real. For once, neither of them was merely trying to outrun grief.

She said Arcebek’s name once, early on, then caught herself, eyes going wide.

Shade kissed her forehead. "She would be insufferably smug." That was enough to make Rakihi laugh instead of retreating into guilt.

At some point the lamp went out.

It didn’t matter.

✦ ✦ ✦

Shade woke sore in ways he had never associated with victory.

His neck ached where Rakihi had apparently decided to match a dwarf's enthusiasm for biting. The bracelet lay against his wrist, blessedly silent; he'd asked the goddesses for privacy before bed, and for once they'd obliged.

Rakihi lay half across him, blue hair tangled, mouth open with the utter lack of dignity reserved for the deeply asleep.

She looked peaceful.

For the first time in a month, the tightness around her eyes had gone.

He watched her breathe, unwilling to disturb it.

Then a thoroughly unreasonable thought struck him:

How am I supposed to survive this without Arcebek here to share her with?

He had grown used to the balance between the three of them.

Rakihi's boundless energy, Arcebek's dry practicality, his own steadiness. Arcebek knew when to temper Rakihi's wild schemes and when to join in. When Shade trapped himself in thought, one of them usually pulled him free.

Now all that mischief and affection had only one dragon to land on.

Rakihi stirred.

“Stop thinking so loud,” she mumbled into his chest.

He blinked. “I did not say anything,” he protested.

“You vibrate when you brood,” she said, eyes still closed. “Like a sad tuning fork.”

He laughed despite himself. "Apologies."

She cracked one eye open, peering up at him.

“You’re doing the thing,” she said.

“What thing?” he asked warily.

“The ‘I am too much and also not enough and somehow both at once’ thing,” she said. “Usually that’s my job. You stealing my bit?”

He considered pretending not to understand. The attempt would have lasted seconds.

“I am… aware,” he said slowly, “that you are a lot.”

She grinned, quick and wicked. “Thank you, I try.”

“And that Arcebek… absorbs some of the force,” he went on. “Shares it. Shares you. Without her, you are… all directed at me.” He looked at the ceiling. “It is… a lot.”

Rakihi stared at him. Then she burst out laughing.

Then Rakihi laughed.

There was no cruelty in it.

“Shade,” she said, propping her chin on his sternum. “Are you telling me you’re worried you can’t handle me?”

“Yes,” he said, because there was no point lying.

She snorted. “Good,” she said. “You shouldn’t.”

That made him look down at her.

She prodded his chest. "You're not supposed to handle me. Neither of you is. We're not parents keeping a sugar-drunk toddler from eating candles. We're us. Sometimes we're too much for each other. You're allowed to say so."

“You are,” he agreed.

"But you can ask me to slow down," she added more gently. "You don't have to be my entire world every night and solve five crises before breakfast."

He raised a brow. “Will you listen if I say that?”

“Probably not the first time,” she admitted. “But eventually.”

He sighed.

Her grin faded as she studied him.

"Last night wasn't about replacing her," Rakihi said. "Or pretending she isn't gone. I needed something besides crying and waiting and singing until my throat hurt. I needed you, Shade. You."

He felt those words more keenly than he expected.

"You're not half a set. You're my dragon-shaped bad decision. The man who bakes bread for elementals and terrifies fey courtiers. I wanted you last night. Not some idea of what the three of us should be."

He swallowed.

"I wanted you too," he said. "That is what frightened me. Once her message came and I could breathe again, wanting anything felt almost like a betrayal."

"You're allowed to be frightened. The universe won't explode because the big brave storm admits he might lose someone."

“I know it does not explode,” he said. “It just… feels like it might.”

"That's grief," she said, with a sad smile. "Welcome. It sucks. We have bread."

He snorted.

She kissed his chin. "We'll manage. Not 'fine'—don't trust anyone who promises that. We'll take jobs, annoy Lana, fight over curtains, and sometimes fall into bed because we're sad and horny and mortal-ish. And when she comes back—"

Her voice caught. She swallowed, then continued.

“—when she comes back, she can roll her eyes at us and tell us we did it wrong and then kiss us both until we forget how to walk.”

He closed his eyes and let himself imagine her there: Arcebek in the doorway, one eyebrow raised, saying, "Leave you two alone for five minutes…"

Let himself picture it, just for a heartbeat: Arcebek in the doorway, eyebrows up, smirk tugging at one corner of her mouth, saying, “Leave you two alone for five minutes…”

“I miss her,” he said.

"Me too," Rakihi whispered. "Even when I'm laughing. Even when I'm—" She gestured at his bare chest. "—doing questionable things with a dragon on a mattress."

He curled an arm around her, pulling her up so they were face to face.

"We will pace ourselves," he said. "We do not have to make up for three months in three nights."

She nodded, nose brushing his. “Deal,” she murmured. “But I reserve the right to occasionally be a menace.”

"That is not a right. It is a fundamental property."

She grinned. “You do love me.”

“Yes,” he said simply. “I do.”

She kissed him once, soft, and then rolled away with a groan.

"Ow." She pushed herself upright. "Muscles. Consequences. Present and accounted for."

He watched her sit up, wince, and then start hunting for clothes.

“Do you regret last night?” he asked.

She paused.

Then shook her head, hair falling in her face.

"No. Not even a little. Do you?"

He remembered the moment he'd wondered whether happiness without Arcebek was disloyal. Then he remembered Rakihi laughing, and how peacefully she'd slept.

This morning, there was colour in her cheeks again.

“No,” he said. “I do not.”

She smiled over her shoulder. “Good,” she said. “Then you can help me down the stairs. If I fall, I’m blaming you and your terrible stamina.”

“My stamina is excellent,” he objected.

“Prove it by making breakfast,” she shot back. “I’m starving.”

He swung his legs over the side of the bed, joints protesting.

They made their way downstairs together, Rakihi leaning on his arm. Both were sore, unsteady, and painfully alive.

He would survive this.

Without Arcebek, there would be days when Rakihi's chaos overwhelmed him, and days when his silence overwhelmed her. Neither could carry everything alone.

But they could carry it together.

When Arcebek came home—and he refused to think in terms other than when—they would have a hundred ridiculous stories to tell her.

Including the morning Shade discovered that a night alone with Rakihi was survivable.

Provided there was extra bread afterward. And perhaps a nap.

Chapter 34: The Shape of a Dragon

Shade raised the subject over stew, which was hardly the setting he'd imagined for a revelation of this magnitude.

The candles had burned low. Sparky dozed in the hearth while Rakihi worked through her second bowl, loose hair falling around her face. She looked less haunted than she had in weeks.

Shade had spent most of supper rearranging the same question in his head.

Shade had been quiet all evening, tasting his own thoughts instead of the food.

At last, he put down his spoon.

“Rakihi,” he said.

She looked up immediately. “Mm?”

The words deserted him.

How could he explain that she had never really seen what he was without making it sound like a farewell?

“There is… something you have not seen,” he managed. “Not truly. Arcebek caught a glimpse, once, but even she thinks she saw more than she did.”

Rakihi frowned. "Your cooking notes? The embarrassing ones where you wrote 'don't shout at the stew'?"

He almost smiled. “No.”

"My true self," he said. "The form I was made in. Before armour and swords. Before Shade."

Silence.

Rakihi's chair scraped against the floor as she straightened.

"Your dragon form? All of it? Not just the bit that melted a hill?"

“Yes,” he said. “All of it.”

She squeaked, slapped her hands over her mouth, then practically bounced out of her chair.

He blinked. “Is that a yes or a seizure?”

She dropped her hands. “YES,” she blurted. “Oh gods yes, are you kidding—”

He raised one hand. "It is not a small thing—in several senses. The seal is not meant to allow it freely, and I am not comfortable treating it as entertainment."

Rakihi sobered a little at that.

“You’re scared,” she said, gently.

"I have fought things that ate suns," he said, staring at the table. "But letting someone see all of me without a war to justify it? Yes. That frightens me."

She slipped out of her chair and came around the table, bare feet silent on the wood. When she reached him, she leaned a hip against his side and stroked a thumb over the line of his jaw.

"You know I want to," she said. "But I'll promise properly: if it becomes too much for either of us, we stop. I won't run screaming without warning. That's a Rakihi promise."

He huffed a small laugh. “Your promises involve significantly more chaos than mine.”

“Obviously,” she said. “But they’re still promises.”

He looked up at her.

"Then we need somewhere far from town. I would rather not frighten your neighbours or flatten a shepherd by accident."

“Fair,” she said. “Got anywhere in mind?”

✦ ✦ ✦

They went the following evening.

Lana raised one eyebrow when he asked if there were any “very large, very empty places” within teleport range that weren’t infested with something sharp.

"A picnic or a minor apocalypse?" Lana asked when Shade requested a very large, very empty place within teleportation range.

“Something in between,” he said.

They settled on an old guild waypoint, a stone ring Arcebek had helped attune months earlier. It led to a high plateau in the west, where miles of grassland rolled beneath an open sky.

Rakihi stepped out of the circle and stopped dead.

“Okay,” she breathed. “That’s… big.”

Grass bent under long, clean gusts of wind. A distant hill barely interrupted the horizon, and the air smelled of rain.

Shade followed her out, closing the circle behind them with a muttered word.

In that empty expanse, Shade's dark figure looked almost small.

Rakihi spun slowly, arms out. “Nobody for miles,” she said. “No houses. No sheep. No grumpy rangers. Just us and whatever decides to watch.”

“Some spirits will,” Shade said. “And the gods, of course. But they already know what I look like.”

"Spirits may watch," Shade said. "The gods certainly will. But they know what I look like."

She faced him again. Her excitement remained, though concern had edged into it.

He shook his head.

“I cannot keep asking you to trust me with… everything,” he said, “and not offer this in return.”

He flexed his hand, looking at the bracelet.

"The gods will need to help me loosen the seal safely," he admitted. "It has been some time since I stood in my full form. I do not know whether I've grown."

Rakihi stared. "You can grow?"

“Yes,” he said dryly. “I am not a sword. I am still… alive.”

"Right. Later," she said, flapping a hand. "Freak-out later. Dragon now."

He drew a careful breath.

Then another.

Closing his eyes, he reached inward, as he did when he prayed—or when he was about to do something necessary and profoundly unwise.

Rakihi saw the muscles tighten along his jaw.

The air thickened.

One by one, the stones on his bracelet stirred.

Terra, low and steady: I will hold what touches earth.

Fenris, cool and restless: I will temper flow.

Ifret, warm and sharp: I will ensure you do not burn everything.

Djing and Djang, twin currents: We'll keep the winds from screaming your name to every listening ear.

Buyakugan, bright and crackling: I'll keep you inside yourself, spark, not all over the scenery.

She heard none of their words, but the hair on her arms rose.

Light traced the seal's chains around Shade's wrist and chest, five elements woven into the bonds that held his power in check.

He spoke—not aloud, not quite—but the sound rolled over the field like distant thunder.

"Not to fight," Rakihi heard—or thought she heard. "Not to burn or break. Only to show you. To be seen."

The chains slackened.

They did not break. They gave him room.

For one heartbeat, nothing happened.

Then Shade exhaled, and the man in front of her seemed to come apart.

Rakihi flinched before she understood what she was seeing.

He was unfolding.

His human outline lengthened and broadened. Fingers became talons; his spine stretched, ribs expanding beneath plates of sapphire and storm-silver that shimmered into place where cloth and skin had been. Fine runes gleamed along their edges.

Wings burst from his back, first as lines of light, then as immense spans of bone and membrane streaked with lightning. Their shadow swept across the grass.

His neck rose into a crowned head of horns and angles, his eyes deep as storm clouds lit from within.

A tail thick as an ancient tree dragged over the earth, its tip glinting like crystallised lightning.

Rakihi stepped back. Then back again, searching for a place from which she could take him in.

All she could see were pieces: the curve of one shoulder, the arch of a wing, the foreclaw carefully settling into the turf.

He towered over the plateau.

Larger than a keep, larger than anything she had imagined when he spoke of his true shape. Even coiled, he occupied a sweep of the grassland that would swallow their manor whole.

Static prickled across her skin. The air tasted of rain and ozone.

The gods' bonds remained visible, broad bands of elemental light crossing his chest and shoulders, containing the power that now had room to breathe.

Shade lowered his head.

The ground trembled beneath her feet as his skull descended to within a few paces.

His eyes, at least, were familiar.

Vast and bright with stormlight, they held the same wary hope she'd seen across the dinner table.

Rakihi realised she had forgotten to breathe.

“Holy shit,” she whispered.

One vast ear flicked back. The huge head tilted.

“Well,” his voice came, no longer from a human throat but resonating through the air, the ground, her chest. “That is… one reaction.”

She barked out a startled laugh, the sound a bit wild.

"Sorry. I just—" She gestured helplessly at the mountains of living scales before her. "You're—"

She stopped, swallowed, and tried again.

“You’re beautiful,” she said.

He froze.

He blinked, slow enough that it seemed the world had paused with him.

Each eyelid closed like a shutter over a lighthouse.

“I am… not small,” he rumbled.

“You’re huge,” she agreed, grinning now. “Ridiculously. Impractically. I love it.”

She came close enough to feel the heat from him. Up close, his scales were the size of plates, light leaking softly between their edges.

She extended one hand, then stopped short.

“Can I?” she asked. “Touch?”

His pupils narrowed, then softened. “Yes,” he said. “Carefully. The outer plates will not harm you.”

She placed her palm against one.

The scale felt warm and solid, somewhere between polished stone and living leather. Beneath it, something pulsed: heartbeat or magic, perhaps both.

She laughed in pure delight.

“It’s like putting my hand on a storm that decided to sit still for a minute,” she said.

His vast chest expanded on a slow inhale.

"I thought you might see me like this," he said, his voice passing through her bones, "and step away."

She snorted. “Shade, I wanted you when you were eating rocks in our kitchen. You really think ‘oh no, he’s bigger and shinier’ is going to make me less into you?”

A low rumble escaped him, followed by a thread of lightning along his horns.

It came out as a brief roll of thunder overhead, a flicker of lightning-threads along his horns.

"Come here," he said, almost shyly despite the thunder in his voice.

She obliged, walking along the line of his jaw until she reached the corner of his massive mouth, then around to the front, so she was standing between his foreclaws.

Each claw was as long as she was tall, curved and buried carefully in the earth.

He lifted one with the care of a man moving a teacup.

Then he curved his foreclaws inward, making a sheltered space between bone, scale and earth.

An invitation she couldn't possibly mistake.

Rakihi’s heart jumped.

“Okay, that’s— yeah, that’s doing something to me,” she muttered, stepping into the hollow.

“Doing what?” he asked, genuinely curious and a little amused.

“Enhancing my appreciation for dramatic staging,” she said breathlessly.

He huffed, and a warm gust nearly knocked her off her feet.

She braced one hand against the inside of his claw and laughed into the wind.

Beyond the shelter of his claws, the world seemed distant. His chest filled her view, a wall of living storm, until one enormous eye lowered toward her.

She reached up with both arms and hugged the side of his muzzle as far as she could reach.

“I love you,” she said into scale and bone.

He answered with a sound like distant surf.

“And?” he asked, very quietly for something so large.

She pulled back just enough to look at that enormous eye.

“And I love this,” she said. “The big, terrifying, ancient you. The one that scares courts and voids and probably mapmakers. But it’s still you. Just louder.”

For a while, neither spoke.

In his eye she could see her own tiny reflection, the open field, and the light of the seal's bands.

“This is what I was made for,” he said eventually. “To be… this. To be wielded in this shape, by others. To be pointed at a problem and unleashed.”

“Now,” she said, “you’re showing it to me because you want to. Not because someone told you to. That’s different.”

He considered that.

“Is it… too much?” he asked. “The pressure. The presence.”

She took her time answering.

“It’s a lot,” she said honestly. “If you roared right now, I’d probably cry and fall over. But you’re not roaring. You’re letting me climb your face. That makes a difference.”

She shifted, found a foothold in the tiny gap between two scales, and hauled herself a bit higher, just because she could.

“Also,” she added, panting a little, “I have definitely read stories about princesses curling up between dragon claws like this. None of them mention how much static there is. You’re like a giant, sharp cat on a sunbeam.”

Thunder rolled from his throat, half laughter and half protest.

“Please do not compare me to a cat,” he said. “They will become insufferable if they hear.”

“Then don’t tell them,” she said, patting him. “Our secret.”

She climbed down before the gods decided to complain about mortals scrambling around on their champion’s face.

He settled onto the grass, folding his wings and stretching out his tail until the ground stopped shivering beneath her.

She still had to walk backwards to see all of him.

“Do you…” she started, then trailed off, trying to find the right phrase. “Do you… feel different? Inside? Like this?”

He considered.

“Yes,” he said slowly. “It is… easier, in some ways. Everything is where it should be. No joints folded away, no power… knotted. But it is also… louder. Harder to be… gentle. Like speaking with a shout.”

She nodded. “You’re doing pretty well,” she said. “For someone the size of a temple.”

He rested his chin in the grass, nostrils stirring the blades.

“Would Arcebek… have wanted to see this?” he asked softly.

“Yes,” Rakihi said without hesitation. “She’d pretend not to. She’d stand there with her arms crossed and this tiny little smirk and pretend she wasn’t impressed, but then she’d talk about it for weeks when she thought we weren’t listening.”

He closed his eyes.

“Then I will show her too,” he said. “When she returns.”

“When,” Rakihi echoed firmly.

They let the silence settle.

A bard and a dragon, sharing an empty plateau.

Eventually, she wandered back to his claws and sat down, leaning against the curve of one.

“You know this means I’m going to write a song, right?” she said. “I’ll change enough details that only Lana and your aunt guess, but still.”

He rumbled. “Of course you will,” he said.

"A song needs an audience," she said through a yawn. The day and the low hum of his magic were making her sleepy.

Shade felt her lean against a talon and gradually slip down to the grass.

“You are falling asleep,” he observed, faintly stunned.

“You’re warm,” she mumbled. “And it’s nice. And I feel… safe.”

Shade held still.

Then he curved one claw above her, sheltering her from the wind.

The gods hummed their quiet approval.

It was not what they'd forged him for.

But it was something he had chosen.

He watched Rakihi sleep, sheltered against a creature built to end wars, and wondered whether there might be room for this version of him in their little life.

For the first time, that possibility did not seem absurd.

Chapter 35: Rumours on the Wind

The wind hummed over scales when Rakihi woke.

For a second she wondered why the earth beneath her was moving. Then she remembered where she'd fallen asleep.

Against a dragon's claw.

She sat up, hair full of grass, blinking blearily.

Shade rested nearby with one immense eye turned toward her. The sun had dropped toward the horizon, gilding the grass.

“How long was I out?” she croaked.

“Half an hour,” he rumbled. “You snore.”

“I do not,” she said automatically.

He made a small, disbelieving noise like distant thunder.

She stretched, mischief returning to her face.

“So,” she said. “Serious question.”

His pupils narrowed slightly. “Yes?”

"Can I ride you?" she asked. "We could soar over the plains. I could stand on your back with a lute and absolutely no balance—"

“Absolutely not,” he said.

She pressed a hand to her heart. "You didn't even consider it."

"For three seconds. In that time I imagined four ways you could die and three ways I could crash into something important."

“But—”

"Rakihi," he said more gently, "I have not flown in this form for a very long time. I don't yet know this realm's winds or how its boundaries pull. And you would not survive a fall from the clouds."

She squinted up at him. “…Are you saying this because it’s true, or because having me on your back makes you weird-shy?”

“Both,” he admitted.

She huffed, then smiled. “All right. I’ll… wait. For version two: ‘Test flights for dragon and passenger.’ With Arcebek yelling at us from the ground.”

“That,” he said, “is the only scenario in which I would consider it.”

“Deal,” she said.

He gathered his immense body inward. The gods' bands tightened, light gathering along his scales as his form folded into itself.

A moment later Shade stood before her, tall and wind-tossed, his shirt reforming in a shimmer, the bracelet quiet against his wrist.

Rakihi straightened his collar, mostly for the excuse to touch him.

“Still beautiful,” she said.

He snorted, faintly pink. “Back?” he prompted.

“Back,” she agreed.

They took the circle home.

✦ ✦ ✦

The rumours began two days later.

At the Broken Anvil, a caravan guard newly arrived from the west swore he'd seen the biggest lizard alive.

“Wings like a stormcloud,” he insisted. “Tail like a siege tower. It flew over at sunset. The shadow went on forever.”

"That's nothing," another patron said. "My cousin's shepherd saw it. Bigger than Lord Harren's whole keep. Ground shook when it turned."

"You were all drunk," someone scoffed. "Tymon says it was a wyvern and the fellow who spotted it ran before he got a decent look."

“Wyvern my ass,” the first guard protested. “Wyverns don’t make the air taste like lightning.”

Rakihi, wiping foam off her lip after a swallow, choked.

Hesta thumped her on the back. “Don’t inhale it,” she advised.

Every table had its own version by the time Rakihi sat down.

“Dragon sighted west of town.”

“Big as a castle.”

“Big as two castles.”

“Just a trick of the light.”

“Clearly an omen.”

“Clearly the gods are angry.”

“Clearly someone’s been smoking the wrong moss.”

Rakihi slid across from Shade, her eyes bright with trouble.

“Uh-oh,” she whispered.

Shade held his mug in one hand and rubbed the bridge of his nose with the other.

"We were miles away," he muttered. "There wasn't a village in sight."

“‘Supposed to’ and ‘were’ are different things,” Rakihi said. “You’re very big. I don’t think you can sneeze in this world without a rumor going three towns over.”

He shot her a look.

"It's talk," Rakihi assured him. "A wyvern, a shadow, a drunken guard. We know what really happened."

“Hey,” she said. “It’s fine. It’s just talk. ‘A wyvern.’ ‘A shadow.’ ‘Probably just drunk.’ We’re the only ones who know the truth.”

He stared into his drink.

"And Lana," Shade said. "Soon enough."

She tilted her head. “You think she’s going to—”

The guild door banged open.

Lana almost never slammed doors.

Conversation faltered. A server sidestepped. Even Hesta stopped stirring her pot.

Guildmistress Lana stood in the entrance, cloak thrown back, eyes like sharpened flint.

She swept the room with one glance.

Her gaze stopped on Shade and Rakihi.

"You," she said.

“Ah,” Rakihi murmured. “There it is.”

Shade set his mug down very carefully.

“Lana,” he said. “Good evening.”

“In my office,” she said. “No, you know what? Too small. Your house. Now.”

Rakihi winced in sympathy. “We’ll just—”

"You too," Lana told Rakihi. "You look as if you're sitting on a secret, and I'm not in the mood to guess."

Rakihi put both hands up. “Fair.”

They walked.

The walk back to the manor passed in a strained silence.

Inside, the elementals scattered. Sparky poked his head from the hearth, caught sight of Lana, and vanished into the flames.

She planted herself in the middle of their main room, crossed her arms, and looked up—way up—at Shade.

"Care to explain why half the western patrol is babbling about a dragon the size of my budget?"

Rakihi opened her mouth.

Shade put a hand lightly on her shoulder; she closed it again.

He met Lana’s eyes.

“I took Rakihi to see my true form,” he said. No dancing around it. No soft phrases. Just the truth.

Lana stared.

Then she pinched the bridge of her nose, exactly as Shade had in the tavern.

“Of course you did,” she muttered. “Because why would we have a quiet month.”

She fixed him with a hard stare.

“In the sky,” she said.

“On the ground,” Shade corrected. “I did not fly.”

She snorted. “Could have fooled the scouts who saw you from miles away.”

He spread his hands a little. “I am… not small.”

"An understatement," she snapped.

Her anger was obvious. Beneath it lay something else: fear of what the world might do with a confirmed dragon in its midst.

Rakihi stepped between them, hands raised.

Rakihi stepped in, hands up.

“We were careful,” she said. “Waypoints to an empty plateau. No villages. No roads. No sheep. Just us and some very startled grass spirits.”

Lana shot her a quick look. “I’m sure the grass wrote a stern letter,” she said dryly. “That’s not the point.”

She turned back to Shade.

“I’m not mad that you have a bigger shape,” she said. “I’m not even mad you wanted to show it to someone you trust. I am, however, deeply, profoundly irritated that you did it in a sky this guild is responsible for without telling me first.”

Shade accepted the rebuke.

"You're right. I should have told you."

“Yes,” she said flatly. “You should have.”

Lana paced, working through the implications.

"For now, we have rumours. I can manage rumours. Big wyvern, drunken guards, strange storm reflection. People grumble, stock up on arrows they'd never hit a dragon with, and return to worrying about taxes."

She stopped, facing him again.

"One proper sighting changes that. Nobles write to bigger cities. Priests declare omens. Idiots with pointy sticks come here to hunt a dragon."

Rakihi’s jaw set. “They’d die,” she said.

“Yes,” Lana snapped. “But they’d make a mess first.”

Shade said nothing.

Shade’s hands were loose at his sides, but Rakihi could see the tension in his shoulders.

“I do not want that,” he said quietly. “I do not want hunters. I do not want wars. I do not… want to be a banner again.”

“Good,” Lana said. “Because I don’t want to run a guild in a city that becomes ‘that place with the dragon’ instead of ‘that place with the work.’”

She took a breath and let it out slowly.

"I understand why you did it. You needed her to see more than the stories. And I'm not your mother. I won't forbid you from existing as yourself."

Her gaze sharpened again.

"But we need protocols. This doesn't affect only you. It affects the guild and everyone who lives here."

Shade nodded, once. “Tell me.”

She blinked. “Just like that?”

“Yes,” he said. “You are right. This is… your realm. Your guild. You know better than I how its people will react.”

Something in her face eased.

“All right,” she said. “First: no full-form within sight of the city walls. Ever. Not unless the world is ending and you need the height to bite it.”

“Agreed,” he said.

“Second: if you do need to shift, for whatever reason, you tell me first,” she went on. “Even if it’s ‘hey, I need to go to an empty continent and scream in the sky for an hour.’ I want to know where my most dangerous asset is at all times.”

Rakihi opened her mouth. “Asset?” she said. “He’s not—”

“People are allowed to be more than one thing,” Lana said shortly. “In this context, he’s an asset. In your bed, he can be something else. I am multitasking.”

Rakihi blushed. Shade choked on absolutely nothing.

“Third,” Lana said, as if that hadn’t happened, “no passengers until you can prove you can fly without shedding pieces. I’m not losing a bard to ‘oops, turbulence.’”

Rakihi sighed. “Fine.”

“And fourth,” Lana finished, “if—if—word ever gets out in a way we can’t stuff back into the rumor mill, we talk before you make any grand gestures. No rearing on mountaintops in silhouette. No ‘accidental’ flyovers during festivals. No challenging local lords to single combat for the right to nest in their towers. We spin it our way, or not at all.”

Shade actually looked offended. “I am not going to challenge anyone for a tower,” he said. “They are extremely impractical nests.”

“Good,” Lana said dryly. “One less thing.”

Rakihi's shoulders finally relaxed.

“So… we’re okay?” she asked. “Guild not kicking us out? City not sharpening pitchforks?”

Lana gave a short snort. "If I dismissed every adventurer who'd done something foolish that ended mostly well, this guild would be empty. We're fine—for now."

She eyed Shade.

"I want a proper report," Lana added. "Size, weight, speed, the damage you could do by accident. If I'm going to have a dragon on my roster, I want specifications."

Rakihi perked up. “Ooh, dragon spec sheet.”

Shade made a pained noise.

Lana smirked, just a little.

“And Shade?” she added, heading for the door.

“Yes?”

"Next time you decide to show your true form," she said, glancing at Rakihi, "invite me to secure the perimeter. I'd rather be there than hear it from a scout who thinks the world is ending."

He dipped his head in something close to a bow. “I will,” he said.

She nodded, satisfied.

“Good. Try not to be seen again unless you mean it,” she said, and let herself out.

The door clicked shut behind her.

Silence lingered in the hall.

Rakihi blew out a breath. “That could’ve gone worse,” she said.

“Yes,” Shade said.

She sidled up to him, elbowing his ribs gently. “Hey.”

“Mm?”

“I’m proud of you,” she said. “For telling her. For not folding in on yourself. For remembering that being you is not a crime.”

He looked down at her.

“I am… working on that,” he said.

"I am working on it," he said.

He groaned.

Rakihi laughed and bumped his shoulder.

“Relax,” she said. “Let them argue. Let them say ‘wyvern’ and ‘castle’ and ‘just a cloud.’ Only we know the truth: that a dragon the size of a small disaster let his bard fall asleep against his claw.”

“And Lana,” he said.

“And Lana,” she agreed. “Who is, let’s face it, halfway to being part of the hoard at this point.”

Shade considered it.

“…I suspect she would be offended,” he said.

“Probably,” Rakihi said. “But she’d also use it as leverage. ‘As your hoard, I demand a raise.’”

He chuckled, finally.

Far to the west, a guard pointed at an ordinary cloud and insisted it looked like a dragon.

At the manor, Shade and Rakihi agreed that his true form would be shared deliberately, not hidden in shame but revealed with care. Aleris was not ready to meet all of him at once.

Perhaps one day it would be.

For now, the rumours could quarrel among themselves.

He knew who had seen him.

That was enough.

Chapter 36: A Question of Power

Rakihi let the question hang.

Cross-legged on the kitchen table, Rakihi picked at her lute while Sparky chased a patch of heat across the hearthstones. Shade paced beneath the low ceiling, each turn bringing his shoulders dangerously close to a hanging pan.

“How do I explain to our guildmaster that without the sealing stones I could snuff out this world with the snap of a claw?” he said again, hands flexing. “She wants… specs. I don’t even truly know my limits with the seals, and absolutely not without them. The foes we were created to fight didn’t fight in such manner. It’s just a consequence of how we were constructed.”

Rakihi strummed a single discordant chord. “You are doing that thing again,” she said.

He stopped. “What thing?”

“The ‘I am a walking apocalypse and therefore a problem’ thing,” she said. “Instead of the ‘I am a walking apocalypse and therefore we should treat that carefully’ thing. Subtle difference.”

He frowned. “From Lana’s perspective, it is very much a problem.”

“From Lana’s perspective,” Rakihi said, “you’re also the guy who brings her decent coffee and turns slavers into unfortunate examples. Those things weigh.”

He tried pacing again, more slowly.

“She needs numbers,” he said. “Ranges. Limits. If she is to plan for… worst cases. I do not have them. I was never given a ‘maximum safe output.’ There is only ‘enough’ and ‘too late’. The void did not care for half-measures.”

Rakihi hopped down, crossed the kitchen barefoot, and planted herself in his path.

“Okay,” she said. “Sit.”

“I am not a dog,” he muttered. He sat anyway.

She dropped beside him. Her lute knocked against the bench as she nudged his shoulder.

“You’re thinking about this like an engineer,” she said. “’How many houses can I crush, Lana?’ ‘How many city blocks is my breath weapon?’ That’s not what she actually needs.”

He gave her a sideways look. “She asked for a spec sheet.”

“Because she’s Lana,” Rakihi said. “Of course she did. But what she really wants is: ‘Can I trust you not to end my city by accident, and what scale of stupid can I throw at you before you break?’ That’s it.”

He considered that. “So what do I tell her?” he asked. “’Trust me, I will not sneeze too hard?’”

Rakihi considered him.

“All right,” she said. “Let’s pretend you’re not you. Let’s say you’re, I don’t know, a… giant magical siege weapon from another world. Something that can, in theory, crack continents.”

“That is… not inaccurate,” he said dryly.

“And Lana’s in charge of where to park you,” Rakihi went on. “She doesn’t need to know exactly how many miles your biggest blast covers, because if it ever comes to that, it doesn’t matter. The answer is

‘too many.’ What she does need to know is: what are the safe modes? What are the locked settings? When do the gods say ‘no’?”

He glanced at his bracelet. The stones were still, though he could feel their attention.

“The seal,” he said slowly, “prevents certain transitions. Full form is possible but… throttled. I cannot call the full chorus. I cannot… open my throat the way I would against a Void rift. If I try, Terra will crush my lungs, Fenris will choke it, Ifret will turn it inward until I cook myself. They have… opinions.”

“Good,” Rakihi said firmly. “So you tell Lana that. ‘Unsealed, I am… theoretic world-ending. Sealed, I physically cannot go past a certain point without my own gods slapping me.’ She’ll like the part where forces bigger than her are also on the ‘please don’t crater Greenhollow’ team.”

He huffed. “She will ask what that ‘certain point’ is.”

“So you give her ranges,” Rakihi said. “Not perfection. Categories. ‘In human shape, under seals, this is what I can safely do: break walls, melt small armies, terrify bureaucrats.’ ‘In dragon shape, under seals, this is what I can do: flatten battlefields, alter weather locally, punch gods in the kneecap.’ And then a big, red, never to be used box labeled ‘Unsealed: Worldbreak’ that we all agree will never be ticked.”

He stared.

“That is… an alarming amount of common sense,” he said.

She smacked his arm. “Rude. I have common sense. I just don’t use it recreationally.”

A smile came and went.

“And the… honesty of it?” he asked. “Telling her that I do not truly know my limits. That if the stones were gone, I might… misjudge.”

“Shade,” Rakihi said quietly, “that’s the part she needs most.”

He stopped moving.

“You tell her,” Rakihi said, “that you don’t know your top speed, because you were never meant to run on this track. That the fights you were built for were ‘hold the hole in the universe until help arrives,’ not ‘don’t hit the houses.’ And then you look her in the eye and say, ‘That’s why I want the seals. That’s why I won’t take them off. Because I don’t trust this world to survive me unbraked.’”

He swallowed.

“And if she fears me?” he asked.

“She already fears you,” Rakihi said matter-of-factly. “She’d be an idiot not to. But she also trusts you. Or she wouldn’t have you in her city at all.”

She nudged his shoulder.

“Being honest about the danger doesn’t make you more dangerous,” she said. “It makes you knowable. Enemy is ‘thing that might kill us and we don’t understand how.’ You’re ‘thing that might kill us but keeps handing us maps and saying please don’t stand there.’ Big difference.”

He let out a breath.

“So I say,” he murmured, half to himself, “that under the seal, in this shape, I am… a siege engine. Dangerous, but containable. In my other shape, under the seal, I am… a battlefield weapon. Terrifying,

but still bound by rules." His mouth twisted. "Without the seal, I am not a guild asset. I am an extinction event. And that is why the seal will remain."

"Yes," Rakihi said. "Exactly. And if she asks 'how sure are you about the extinction part?' you tell her the truth: 'Sure enough that I'm not going to test it in your atmosphere.'"

He stared at her again.

"That is a horrifying metaphor," he said.

"Thank you," she said sweetly. "I grew up around court diviners. I know how to talk in ways that make people sit down."

He pressed his palms over his face.

"I do not like thinking of myself as…" he began, then trailed off.

"A bomb?" she supplied. "A blade too big for the sheath? A walking doomsday button?"

"All of the above," he muttered.

"Hey." She caught his wrist, pulling his hands down. "You're also the idiot who grows herbs and sings to stones and makes bread for minor spirits. We're not reducing you to 'weapon.' We're just being honest about the part of you that is one."

He met her eyes and held them.

"Come with me?" he asked. "When I speak to her. You see things I do not, and she will… moderate herself if she thinks yelling will make you cry."

Rakihi snorted. "She has yelled at me plenty," she said. "But yes. I'll come. Less for moderation, more so you don't start comparing yourself to tectonic plates again."

"That happened once," he protested.

"Once is enough," she said.

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Lana listened.

She didn't interrupt much.

They met behind Lana's closed office door. A map of the region hung on the wall; on the desk lay a stack of complaints about "dragon hysteria," turned facedown with unmistakable intent.

Shade occupied the guest chair, his knees almost against the desk. Rakihi perched on the windowsill, swinging her feet.

"You wanted specifications," Shade said, after he'd run through the broad strokes—terrible foes, reality-scale battles, the way his kind had been designed.

"I did," Lana said. "I also wanted to know if I need to start building a bunker."

"You do not," he said. "Not for me. Not while the stones are whole."

He raised his bracelet where she could see it.

"The seal is not… symbolic," he said. "It is mechanical, in a sense. The gods have levers in me. In this shape, under it, I can do things you'd expect of any elder dragon: destroy fortifications, wipe out armies

if I choose, alter weather locally. More, perhaps, because of what I am. But there is a ceiling. If I push too hard, they push back. Painfully."

"Define 'locally,'" Lana said.

"Ten, perhaps twenty miles, in a storm," he said. "Not continents. Not… rotations of the planet. I could drown a valley, not tilt your axis."

Rakihi grimaced. "Thanks for that image," she muttered.

"In my larger form, under the seal," Shade went on, "I am… larger in every respect. But the principle is the same. I can break armies. I can break gods if they are foolish. I cannot, without significant time and… encouragement, break everything at once."

Lana steepled her fingers. "And without the seal?" she asked.

He met her eyes.

"I do not know," he said. "Not precisely. That is the truth. I have estimates, from what we did against the Void. From what my siblings did. 'Snuff out this world with the snap of a claw' is… poetic, but not entirely inaccurate. We were built to unmake corrupted structures wholesale. To collapse false realities before they spread. It is possible that, unsealed, I could treat your world as such a… structure."

Lana swallowed. Rakihi noticed.

"But you won't," Lana said.

"No," Shade agreed. "I will not. Because I do not want to. Because the goddess did not send me here to do that. Because the gods you know by name have invested themselves in this realm. And because these—" he tapped the bracelet, the stones glinting "—would stop me."

"You're that sure?" Lana asked. "That they're on my side?"

"I am sure," he said softly, "that they are on my side. And they know that if I destroy what I have built here, it will break something in me they value. They will not allow that lightly."

Rakihi jumped in. "Think of the seal as… a hard cap," she said. "Everything below that, he can do with care and choice. Everything above that, he physically can't without burning himself. So your spec isn't 'how big is the doom.' It's 'where's the cap.'"

Lana released a slow breath.

"All right," she said. "Summarize it for me."

Shade thought for a moment.

"In guild terms?" he said. "Under seals, human form: high-grade threat response. Enough to turn a losing fight around, not enough to crack the world. Dragon form: last resort. Enough to defend the city against things your walls were not built for. Not to be used in or near the city unless there is truly no choice. Unsealed…"

"Unusable," Rakihi cut in. "Off the table. Off the board. That's not an option we plan around, that's an 'if it ever happens, we're already in a story none of us want to be in.'"

Lana eyed her. "You're comfortable with that?" she asked.

“No,” Rakihi said. “But I’m a realist. If the day comes when someone breaks those stones and whispers in his ear hard enough that he thinks ‘maybe I should do it,’ we’ve already lost the version of Shade we know. Planning for that is like planning for the sun going out.”

Lana leaned back and studied the ceiling.

At last she sighed.

“I hate this job,” she said. “I really do.”

Rakihi snorted.

Lana leaned forward.

“Thank you,” she said, looking at Shade. “For being honest. For saying ‘I don’t know’ instead of making up numbers to make me feel better.”

He nodded.

“Here’s what we’ll do,” she went on. “On my side: I’ll stop poking for precise ‘how many catapults’ answers. We’ll work with bands. Tiers. And I’ll make damn sure the council understands that poking you with a sharp stick until you do test your limits is not policy, it’s suicide.”

“Appreciated,” he said dryly.

“On your side,” Lana continued, “you keep telling me if the seal… shifts. If the gods get twitchy. If you notice new… capacities. I don’t like unknown unknowns.”

“I will,” he said. “If anything changes, you will know before anyone else.”

“Good,” she said.

She hesitated.

“And Shade?” she added.

“Yes?”

“If, at any point, you feel like you are… slipping,” she said. “Like you’re not sure you can hold, or that the stones aren’t enough—tell me. Tell Rakihi. Tell someone. Don’t just walk out to an empty field and hope for the best. I would rather plan a… controlled vent than scrape you and half the countryside off the map.”

He held her gaze, then dipped his head.

“I promise,” he said.

Rakihi’s fingers tightened around the lute neck.

Lana gave a brisk nod, the matter settled.

“All right,” she said. “Go on, then. Get out of my office. I have to go explain to the council that no, we are not imminently doomed by ‘castle-sized lizards,’ and yes, we are keeping the one we have as a very expensive, very opinionated deterrent.”

Rakihi grinned. “You’re going to call him that to their faces, aren’t you?”

“Absolutely,” Lana said. “It’ll make them underestimate him in exactly the right way.”

Shade stood.

“Thank you,” he said again.

“Don’t thank me,” Lana said. “Just… keep not ending the world. You’re very good at that so far. Practice makes perfect.”

On the road back to the manor, Rakihi bumped his arm with hers.

“See?” she said. “Nobody exploded. You didn’t turn into a weapon in her eyes. You turned into a… terrifyingly powerful, mildly sarcastic colleague.”

“That is an odd comfort,” he said.

“Welcome to adventuring,” she replied. “Odd comforts are what we live on.”

He looked up at the sky.

“For what it is worth,” he said quietly, “I am glad the stones exist. Even if part of me resents them.”

Rakihi slid her hand into his.

“Me too,” she said. “I like this world not being snuffed out by accident.”

He gave her hand a careful squeeze.

“So do I,” he said.

Chapter 37: The Silver Trial

By the time the castle came into view, road dust, smoke, and someone else's blood clung to them all.

The castle rose above the valley like a broken tooth. Fire had blackened its grey walls; one tower had collapsed, and no banners flew from the battlements. Even from the road, Shade felt something wrong seep down the hill: a chill that dulled the light and seemed to weigh upon the air.

"Looks friendly," Rakihi muttered from his left.

Her hood shielded her from the wind, though strands of blue hair escaped around her face. She'd been almost herself again since Arcebek's last imp-message, but the absence still hung around her like a second shadow. Today she was watchful, almost eager for a fight with something that deserved one.

"Friendly places rarely earn a silver trial," Shade replied.

Below the castle, a village of perhaps forty houses clung to the foot of the hill. A small shrine and a weary-looking inn stood among fields protected by rough palisades. Thin smoke rose from the chimneys. The gates were open, but bar-spikes lay ready to drop.

Varinel shifted his bow on his shoulder, long ears twitching. "Guard on the western wall just ducked," the old elf said. "Someone's watching us. No arrows yet, so they're not completely stupid."

"Shields visible, weapons sheathed," Mina said. The young adventurer had scraped back her brown hair. Fresh scars marked her hands, but she carried herself with more confidence than when Shade had last fought beside her. "Let 'em see we're not another bandit gang."

Tomas trudged along at the rear, spear resting on his shoulder, shield strapped to his back, all farmboy bulk and earnest eyes. "Last bandits we met were more likely to ask for bread than coin," he said. "These fields look just as bad."

Shade had noticed the same thing: exhausted soil and stunted crops on either side of the road. Twice on the way here they'd had to smack sense into desperate men and women who'd thought six half-starved bandits could take a dragon and a bard.

Afterward, they had left the would-be bandits bags of food.

"Our job isn't fixing the kingdom's tax policy," Rakihi had muttered then, binding a cut on her arm. "But gods, it's tempting."

Now, as the village gates creaked wider and a couple of tired guards squinted down from the walkway, Shade lifted a hand in greeting.

"Adventurers from Greenhollow guild," he called. "Here for your undead infestation."

Silence for a beat.

Then one guard yelled down, "About time!"

The other cuffed him. "Hush, Bran."

They clattered into the village on sore feet and sorer tempers. Chickens scattered. A dog barked once and then ducked under a cart, tail between its legs, clearly spooked by the stink of necromancy on the wind.

The inn was the only building with any real life to it—lamplight at the windows, the smell of stew, the murmur of too-quiet voices. A battered sign creaked overhead: The Lantern Watch.

Fitting, Shade thought grimly, given their quarry.

Inside, the innkeeper—a broad woman with the arms of someone who'd thrown people out of her common room personally—took one look at them and waved them to a corner table.

"You the ones the guild sent?" she asked, bringing tankards without being asked.

"Yes," Shade said. "Shade, Rakihi, Varinel, Mina, Tomas. We'll want to speak with whoever's in charge, and anyone who's seen the undead up close."

"That'd be me for the first and old Father Joren for the second," she said brusquely. "I'm Lysa. This is my place. Food first. Talk while you eat or you keel over on my floor and I charge you extra for the mop."

Rakihi's stomach answered for them with an undignified growl.

"See?" Lysa said. "Someone listens to sense."

They ate.

The stew was thin but hot. Bread a little stale, but Shade could taste the effort in it, the way Terra's tired hum threaded under the flour when he closed his eyes. This village was stretched, but not yet broken.

"So," Rakihi said between mouthfuls, "tell us about your… houseguests."

Lysa snorted. "Guests don't usually try to dig you out of your house walls," she said. "Been six weeks now. First it was lights in the old castle. Then smoke. Then the dead in the graveyard started… walking."

"Classic," Varinel muttered.

"Shadows in the fields," Lysa went on. "Missing livestock. Couple of fool boys went up to 'have a look.'" Her jaw clenched. "We found what was left of 'em three days later. Arms and legs, no heads. Father Joren said we needed help, so he sent to the guild. That was three weeks ago."

Shade frowned. "Three weeks?" he said. "The posting we saw was marked as five days old."

"The roads aren't safe," Tomas said. "Bandits. Orcs. Remember? Took us two extra days to get around that burnt bridge."

Rakihi grimaced. "System's creaking," she muttered. "Good to know."

"Tell me about the headless one," Shade said.

Lysa looked at him. "You know what a dullahan is?" she asked.

"Yes," he said. "I have met their like before. I want your version."

She shivered, just a little.

"First time we saw him proper," she said, "was a week after the dead started walking. There was a… sound. Like iron screaming. We heard shouting, went to the wall, and there he was on the road. Horse black as a pit, eyes like lanterns, no head on its shoulders—just holding it at his side, like a bucket. Armor old, but… wrong. Not rusted. Just… thin, somehow. Like it was never really made here."

Rakihi stopped plucking her lute.

“Necromancer?” Mina asked.

“Worse,” Shade said softly. “Death spirit. Bound to a place. Or a person. Or both.”

Lysa nodded. “He rode up to the gate,” she said. “Held up that head. It… looked at us. Eyes like coals. Mouth full of iron. ‘I claim this valley for the Lord Below,’ it said. Not with a voice. Just… in our heads. ‘Surrender your dead and your young. All else will be taken anyway.’”

Tomas swore under his breath.

Shade tightened his grip on his mug.

“We shut the gate,” Lysa said. “We told him to shove his claim right up—” she caught herself, glanced at Rakihi “—his horse. Father Joren rang the ward-bell. The sound made the dead in the fields stagger. The dullahan laughed. Put his head back on his shoulders, drew his sword, and rode off.”

“Since then?” Rakihi asked.

“Every few nights,” Lysa said. “More dead. Closer. Testing the fence. We burned what we can. Buried the rest under salt and gravel. But the castle’s the heart of it. Until that’s cleared, it won’t stop.”

Lana’s request for “dragon specs” flashed through Shade’s mind; he pushed it aside. Later.

“Any idea what stirred it?” Varinel asked. “Old curse? New idiot poking things they shouldn’t?”

Lysa grimaced. “There was a… scholar,” she said reluctantly. “From the city. Skinny fellow. Glasses. Carried more books than sense. Came through two months back, asking about ‘old ruins’ and ‘foundations of the castle.’ Joren told him the place was bad ground. He went up anyway. We haven’t seen him since.”

“Ah,” Rakihi said bleakly. “A researcher. Of course.”

Shade rubbed his temple.

“So,” he said. “Dullahan. Unknown necromancer or bound soul. Active graveyard. Castle likely full of lesser dead. We have five people, three silver-ranked candidates”—Mina and Tomas straightened a little at that; their upgrade was riding on this too—“and an exhausted village at our backs.”

“Also,” Rakihi added, “our warlock is currently out of town negotiating her employment contract with something older than Lysa’s stew pot, so we can’t just blast the place from three realities away.”

Lysa snorted a laugh despite herself. “Warlock troubles?” she said.

“You have no idea,” Rakihi muttered, then immediately looked guilty-soft for a second.

Shade tapped the table.

“Rest tonight,” he said. “Resupply. At dawn, we scout. Varinel, you and I take east and north—the treeline, the old road. Rakihi, Mina, Tomas, you talk to Father Joren about his wards. I want to know exactly how his bell works, what blessing he’s using, what he’s got left in him.”

Rakihi raised a hand. “I’m not a priest,” she said. “He might not want to share shop talk with a bard and a pickpocket.”

“You’re a sorcerer,” Shade said. “You understand resonance. Dullahan binds are as much about names and sounds as blood. If Joren’s bell is doing anything besides ringing loudly, you’ll feel it.”

She rolled her eyes, but her mouth curved. “Fine,” she said. “I’ll go poke the holy man.”

“Once we’ve walked the ground,” Shade continued, “we set the plan. The dullahan is the key. Without it, the dead lose direction. With it, they’ll keep coming even if we clear the castle room by room.”

“Can it be… killed?” Tomas asked quietly. “Properly?”

Shade remembered headless riders crossing bloodless plains, their names carved into darkness.

“Yes,” he said. “But not like you kill a man. Its tether has to be broken. Could be its head. Could be its sword. Could be a lantern, or a contract, or the grave where its body lies. We need to find that.”

Mina grimaced. “And to find that, we need to get inside,” she said. “Through a castle full of things that want to eat us.”

Rakihi plucked a jaunty chord. “So,” she said. “Standard silver upgrade, then.”

Tomas snorted, tension breaking for a heartbeat.

Lysa set down a jug of watered wine on their table, frowning thoughtfully.

“You said you’ve met its kind before,” she said to Shade. “Back… wherever you’re from. How did you beat it then?”

Shade’s jaw tightened for a moment.

“The last time,” he said slowly, “we… did not.”

Silence settled over the table.

He forced himself to continue.

“We held it,” he said. “Pinned it long enough for heavier hitters to arrive. Then we drowned its battlefield in a tide of molten reality and hoped that was enough. It was… not pretty. Or subtle. Or survivable for anyone who wasn’t already half unmade.”

Mina swallowed hard.

Under the table, Rakihi found his hand and squeezed.

“This time,” Shade said, voice firming, “we will do better. Smaller. Smarter. This world does not have the… luxury of erasing entire regions to kill one stubborn spirit.”

“Glad to hear it,” Lysa said, a bit faintly. “I’ve grown attached to my fields.”

He gave her an apologetic smile.

“Eat,” Lysa said gruffly. “Sleep. Joren’s got a spare room in the shrine if you need quiet. I’ll have hot water for you in the morning.”

She left before they could thank her.

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Later, in the little room above the inn that they were sharing—one narrow window, two beds, one pallet on the floor—Shade sat at the tiny table, turning his mug between his hands.

Rakihi sat on the windowsill, looking out at the dark slope of the hill, where the castle’s broken silhouette cut a deeper black out of the sky. Now and then, a faint will-o’-wisp glow flickered in its windows.

“Upgrade mission,” she said softly. “Feels… weird, without her.”

“Yes,” he said.

“You think she’d… approve?” Rakihi asked. “Us doing this now?”

He considered.

“She would say,” he said slowly, mimicking Arcebek’s dry cadence, “ ‘About time you stopped hiding behind bronze and did some work for your pay.’ Then she would check our gear, complain about the lack of backup, and start writing her will in case we did anything stupid.”

Rakihi smiled, her eyes bright.

“Yeah,” she said. “That sounds like her.”

Neither spoke for a while.

“She’d also,” Rakihi added, “love the idea of you punching a dullahan. ‘Headless idiot meets headstrong dragon.’ She’d be insufferable.”

“Yes,” he agreed.

She slid down from the sill and came over, leaning her hip against the table.

“Hey,” she said. “We’ve done worse. Different, but worse. Goblin nests. Troll patrols. That thing in the vine-well.”

“This is not an ordinary silver job,” he said. “Most upgrades do not involve named death spirits.”

“Most upgrades don’t involve dragons either,” she pointed out. “We skew the curve.”

He rolled his eyes in concession.

She nudged his shoulder with hers. “We’ll be fine,” she said. “Or we won’t. But we’ll do it together. And when we get back, we’ll have ‘dullahan slayers’ on our sheet, and Lana will have to admit we’re good at this.”

He took her hand, turned it over, traced the faint calluses on her fingers from strings and spells.

“Sleep,” he said. “You need it.”

“So do you,” she said. “You brood loud.”

He laughed under his breath.

When they finally lay down—Rakihi on the bed, Shade on the too-small pallet—they both stared at the ceiling for a while, listening to the creak of the inn, the distant hoot of an owl, the soft, wrong silence rolling down from the castle.

Tomorrow, they’d walk the dead man’s hill.

Tonight, they rested.

Silver was within reach.

So was the dark.

Chapter 38: The Dullahan

They were halfway up the corpse-road when the story started to come apart.

No shambling dead in the ditches. No skeletal wolves. No spectral hands clawing out of the old barrows.

Only silence.

An unnatural silence.

“I don’t like this,” Varinel muttered. “They should have hit us by now.”

Shade could feel the death-magic in the air, but it was… wrong. Not wild. Ordered. Like a song with a steady drumbeat underneath.

“Someone’s directing them,” he said. “Holding them back.”

“Waiting,” Rakihi said, fingers tight on her lute. “For something.”

For us, his instincts supplied.

They found the castle gates standing open.

No splintered timber or broken hinges—just an invitation that could only be deliberate.

The courtyard beyond held no bones, no rot, only weathered stone and moss. Pale green mist gathered around the central well.

“Hello?” Rakihi called, unable to help herself. “Any cursed death knights home? We brought snacks and emotional baggage.”

Shade glanced at her. Rakihi answered with an uneasy shrug.

The answer came from above.

From the broken balcony over the main doors, a horse stepped out of the shadows.

As Lysa had described, it was black as spilled ink, with guttering coals for eyes. Smoke curled from each hoofprint. Its tack was old and ornate, metal worked in thorn and crown motifs.

On its back sat a suit of armor.

It was sized for a halfling.

The proportions were wrong for the human dullahan they’d pictured: shorter, broader in the hips, the lines of the breastplate cut slightly differently. The metal itself wasn’t thin and ghostly, either—it was solid, well-made, though etched with sigils that made Shade’s teeth ache.

Under one arm, held in the crook of her elbow, the rider cradled her head.

The face was disconcertingly alive.

Brown hair, braided back neatly—if a bit wind-tossed. A strong jaw. A nose that had probably been broken once and set slightly crooked. Freckles scattered across cheeks the color of rich soil. And eyes—

But her eyes held them.

Deep brown, wide, steady. The kind of eyes you could confess to. Or drown in.

They regarded the party with weary intelligence and unmistakable caution.

Mina breathed, very softly, “Oh. She’s… pretty.”

Rakihi’s brain supplied gorgeous, then immediately scolded itself: She’s undead, you idiot. That didn’t help. If anything, the wrongness made it worse.

The halfling lifted her own head a little higher so she could see them better.

“…You’re late,” the head said.

Her lips remained still.

It was everywhere at once, like a thought broadcast directly into their skulls. It had a faint echo to it, like it was traveling down a long hall before reaching them. But the tone was… dry. Wry. Tired.

“Apologies,” Shade said, stepping forward, palms open. “The roads were… full.”

She squinted at him. “You’re the dragon,” she said. “And you’re the little bard who keeps poking at things she shouldn’t.” Her eyes flicked to Rakihi, then to Varinel and the kids. “And you brought an elf and what I assume are sacrifices.”

“Hey,” Tomas protested weakly.

Rakihi blinked in surprise. “Wait, how do you—”

“Lysa’s letters have been… detailed,” the halfling said. “And the wards gossip.” The horse snorted, steam puffing. “So. Are you here to cut my head off, or shall we skip to the part where you realize that won’t help?”

Shade exchanged a look with Rakihi.

“Talking dullahan,” he murmured.

“Polite dullahan,” Rakihi amended. “Weirdly hot dullahan.”

“Rakihi,” he hissed.

“What, you’re thinking it too,” she whispered back.

He absolutely was, which only made it worse.

He cleared his throat.

“I am Shade,” he said, louder. “This is Rakihi. Varinel, Mina, Tomas. We came to clear the castle and break the hold over the dead in this valley. If that involves you… we’d prefer to do it with your cooperation.”

Her eyebrows rose. “That’s a new one,” she said. “Most folks open with ‘foul abomination’ and end with ‘back to the pit with you.’”

“Bit rich coming from a village whose priest smells like death magic,” Rakihi muttered.

The halfling’s eyes snapped to her.

She stared.

Rakihi stared back, heart doing odd things in her chest.

“Name?” the head asked.

“Rakihi Moonthorn,” Rakihi said, then winced. “I didn’t pick the second part.”

The halfling's mouth quirked. "Of course you didn't," she said. "And you?"

"Elcia Bramblecrown," she replied. "Last living—well, previously living—heir to the Bramblecrown holding. Former lady of this very drafty pile."

Rakihi's stomach dropped. "You own the castle," she blurted.

"Owning's tricky when you're technically an abomination," Elcia said. "But yes."

Shade stepped closer, senses open, tasting the magic that clung to her.

Dullahan, yes. The classic marks were there: the unbroken line of undeath tying head to body, the lantern-horse, the sense of thresholds and doors that were hers to open or close.

But under it, twisted through it, was another thread.

A priestly thread.

Sanctified bone. Consecrated death. The smell of incense and old blood.

"Who cursed you?" Shade asked.

That tired gaze cut back to him.

"Ah," she said softly. "You do have a brain behind all that intimidation."

Rakihi choked on a laugh.

Elcia drew an unnecessary breath and said, "High Priest Garren of the Silent Vault. Patron saint of Not Mindin' His Own Business. Or, as you know him…"

Her eyes flared with faint light.

"…Father Joren."

The name struck them silent.

"The village priest?" Tomas blurted. "Joren? But he— he baptized my niece. He blesses the fields. He—"

"He used this castle as his personal toybox," Elcia snapped, some of the brittle weariness cracking to reveal anger underneath. "He came here six months ago, all smiles and soft words, asking to 'inspect the crypts.' And like a fool, I let him. I thought the gods had finally decided we were worth more than a passing sermon."

She laughed bitterly.

"The cult got greedy," Rakihi realized aloud. "Bigger sacrifices than chickens and old bones."

Elcia's gaze softened, fractionally.

"You're quick," she said. "He found the old Bramblecrown line. Made us an offer. Eternal protection. Prosperity. We declined." Her eyes went distant. "We paid."

Shade pictured a family hall, a confrontation, a priest letting his kindly mask slip.

"What did he do?" he asked quietly.

"Slit my throat over my mother's grave and offered my name to his god," she said. "Bound me to this place as his headless hound. 'Collect the dead,' he said. 'Drive the village into my arms. I'll break them of their silly little shrines yet.'"

Mina pressed a hand to her mouth.

Varinel spat an Elvish curse.

“He thinks he holds my leash,” Elcia went on. “And he’s not entirely wrong. The silence has teeth. When he rings his bell, the dead stir. When he speaks the god’s name, the bones in the ground listen.” Her fingers flexed around the hair at her temple. “But the dullahan is older than his little cult. Old death doesn’t bow easy. He wanted a mindless reaper. He got me.”

“You’ve been… holding back,” Shade said slowly.

“As much as I can,” she said. “Calling them away from your walls. Snapping at his orders. Buying time with little defiance and little lies.” Her jaw tightened. “But I can’t break the tether from this side. Not alone. Not without—”

She cut herself off, looking away.

“Without what?” Rakihi asked gently.

Elcia hesitated visibly.

Then: “Confession.”

Rakihi blinked in surprise. “Come again?”

“The curse is tied to his authority,” Shade realized. “Priestly vow. Oath of office. The god’s listening, but it only moves because it thinks this is his will.”

Elcia nodded slowly. “Blood, name, office,” she said. “He used all three. Bound my head, my line, and this place to his service. If he publicly renounces it—if he speaks the truth of what he’s done, in his own words, in his god’s ear—the tether snaps. The dullahan rides free, and he…” Her lips peeled back in something like a smile. “He gets what’s coming.”

Rakihi rubbed her face. “So our ‘kill the dullahan, cleanse the castle’ mission just turned into ‘kidnap the local priest, force him to admit he’s a cultist, and use his confession as a metaphysical wire cutter.’ Fantastic.”

Varinel studied Elcia. “And in the meantime?” he asked. “He keeps playing necromancer in his nice little shrine while you juggle corpses.”

“Essentially,” she said dryly. “Hence my ‘you’re late.’”

Shade began fitting the new information into a plan.

“Why didn’t you come down and tell the village?” Tomas burst out. “They’d have listened! They love Joren, but if you’d explained—”

“With what?” Elcia asked sharply. “’Hi, I’m your neighbor’s noble, her head’s on the wrong end, your priest sacrificed me for a promotion, please stop giving him bread and wine’? I’m an undead abomination on a nightmare horse. They’d soil themselves and run. Or worse, they’d try to help me, and he’d have more bodies to play with.”

Tomas recoiled.

Regret softened her expression.

“Sorry,” she said. “That was… aimed at him, not you.”

“It’s fine,” he muttered. “Just… a lot.”

Rakihi stepped toward the horse before she realized she had moved.

Elcia's eyes flicked to her, widening a fraction as Rakihi came within arm's reach of the horse.

Up close, the wrongness around the dullahan was more… complicated. Not a simple cold. A layered thing: grief, duty, stubborn refusal.

Rakihi wet her lips.

"Can I…?" she gestured vaguely at Elcia's head. "Look? I mean, I am looking, but I mean—magically."

Shade smothered a snort. Subtle as ever.

Elcia weighed the request.

"You're Moonthorn," she said. "You've danced around death before."

Rakihi grimaced. "Not like this," she said. "But yeah."

Elcia took a breath she didn't need.

"Fine," she said. "But if my hair frizzes, I'm blaming you."

Rakihi laughed too loudly, relieved and nervous in equal measure.

She reached out—not touching, not quite—but letting her own magic unfurl, a soft brush of song and will.

The dullahan-curse thrummed under her fingertips. Old, old magic, rooted in the idea of boundary: gate and gallows, road and river. Tied now, painfully, to something newer and nastier: a god that liked silence more than truth.

Under it—all through it—Elcia.

Angry. Tired. Lonely.

Rakihi ached for her.

She withdrew her magic and blinked.

"Well?" Shade asked quietly.

Rakihi met Elcia's eyes.

"I'm sorry," she said, and meant it. "You didn't deserve this."

Elcia's mouth did that almost-smile again, a little wobbly.

"Most people don't," she said. "But thank you."

There it was again—that wrong, guilty little tug in Rakihi's chest.

She's undead, you idiot, her upbringing whispered.

She's also brave and hot and making jokes about her own curse, the rest of her replied. We don't have time for your internalized necro-phobia.

Shade shifted his weight.

He was attracted too. It was absurd. Inappropriate. And utterly undeniable. Something about the way she held herself—literally and figuratively, one arm cradling her own head like a treasured thing she refused to let go of—hit him right where old loyalties and new attractions met.

He pushed the feeling aside.

Feelings could wait.

The plan could not.

“You want him seized,” he said to Elcia. “Brought here. Made to confess in front of you, his god, and whoever else matters.”

“Yes,” she said. “In that order. And alive enough to mean it. His god’s not stupid. It can tell the difference between ‘sorry I got caught’ and ‘I broke the rules.’”

Mina raised a tentative hand. “What happens if we just… kill him?” she asked. “Like, quietly. No confession. No drama. Just… end.”

Elcia’s fingers tightened in her horse’s mane.

“Then the god assumes the curse is still useful,” she said. “It’ll shove someone else into his robes and keep the tether. Might even double down, if it’s feeling petty. Cults like that don’t go quietly.”

Varinel gave a disgruntled grunt. “So we do this the hard way,” he said. “Grab him. Shake him. Make him talk.”

Rakihi sighed heavily. “Silver upgrade my ass,” she muttered. “This is gold level political nonsense.”

“Welcome to leadership,” Elcia said dryly. “You wanted to be more than bronze.”

Shade squared his shoulders. He had a plan.

“New plan, then,” he said. “Varinel, you and I handle the grab. We know his face. We know the village. We get eyes on him, see what defenses he’s set up. Rakihi, you prepare the… stage.”

“Stage?” she repeated.

“This is a ritual,” he said. “Confession, witness, judgment. Your magic is… good with stories. And frames. Build something that tells the right story to his god.”

She opened her mouth to protest, then shut it, considering.

“…Okay,” she said slowly. “Yeah. I can do that. A song. A space. Something that makes it very, very hard for him to lie. Or weasel.”

Elcia studied the two of them.

“You’re all taking this remarkably well,” she said.

“We’ve had practice having our worldview kicked,” Rakihi said. “And frankly? ‘Corrupt priest, hot dullahan, god with a bad attitude’ is practically a weeknight for us.”

Elcia let out a dry laugh.

“Don’t flirt with the undead,” some stern inner voice chided Rakihi.

Watch me, she thought back, and immediately felt guilty again.

Shade caught her eye.

They shared a look that said, wordlessly, We should not and We absolutely are and We’ll unpack that later.

He turned back to Elcia.

“One more question,” he said. “You said you can’t break the tether from your side. What can you do?”

She bared her teeth in a grin that was not entirely friendly.

“I can call off the dead from your backs while you make your play,” she said. “I can send you warnings when Joren moves. And when the time comes…” Her eyes flared, the horse’s breath steaming in the suddenly colder air. “I can make sure he stands very still while he talks.”

Shade nodded, satisfied.

“Then we have an alliance,” he said. “Elcia Bramblecrown, Lady of this place. We will seize your murderer. We will force his truth into the ears of his god. And when the tether snaps…”

“You’ll let me decide what to do with him,” Elcia finished quietly.

A chill ran through Rakihi.

Shade held her gaze.

“Yes,” he said. “If the god doesn’t claim him first, he’s yours.”

Her gaze hardened.

“Good,” she said simply.

It was an outrageous plan.

Kidnapping a beloved village priest. Forcing him to confess to cultic murder. Using the confession as a metaphysical crowbar to pry a dullahan free from a death god’s grip.

Politics, theology, and a great deal of personal suffering—all matters Lana would have strong opinions about.

It was also the only way forward that didn’t end with either the valley doomed or Elcia left in chains.

Rakihi drew a steadying breath.

“Right,” she said. “Let’s go commit treason in the name of justice. Arcebek is going to be so pissed she missed this.”

Shade nearly smiled.

“Then we should make sure we survive to tell her about it,” he said.

They turned back toward the village, the castle at their backs, the dullahan watching them with those deep, drowning eyes.

They had every reason to keep their distance.

Neither could deny the attraction.

Guilt followed close behind.

They went anyway.

Chapter 39: The God of Death

For a while, it looked like the sort of job Lana might actually approve of.

The kidnapping, at least, went almost too smoothly.

Varinel and Shade reached the shrine at dawn, just as Father Joren lit the first candles. His back was turned, and he hummed a hymn whose melody—

—Shade now realized—had always held a little too much silence.

Two heartbeats. A flash of Varinel's knife. Shade's hand clamped over the priest's mouth.

No screams. No alarms.

Rakihi and the youngsters had the back window open and a rope waiting. By the time the acolytes came to find out why morning prayers had not begun, the priest was gone and the shrine door barred "for contemplation."

Getting back up the hill was the hard part.

Joren had built his wards to work both ways. The instant his feet crossed the village boundary, the dead woke screaming.

Shade and Elcia handled most of it.

Elcia rode her nightmare horse through half-rotted corpses and bone-wrapped shades, laughing like a bell at a gallows. Shade held the line ahead of the others, sword and spells opening a path. Behind him, Rakihi sang until her voice grew hoarse, making the dead falter just long enough for Tomas' spear and Mina's daggers to finish them.

By the time the castle gates slammed shut behind them, the priest was bruised, bleeding, bound—and wide awake.

They prepared the ritual in the great hall.

Rakihi had prepared it well.

She had made a stage of the ruined throne room without making a spectacle of it: chalk circles, salt lines, old banners rehung where they would hold, candles arranged in spirals. In the center stood a rough-hewn block for Joren to kneel before. Beyond it waited the castle's family altar, cleaned and sanctified as best Elcia could manage with what remained of her old rites.

Elcia stood to one side, head beneath her arm, her horse snorting steam behind her. Varinel guarded the doors. Mina and Tomas flanked Joren, weapons ready to encourage reverence.

Shade and Rakihi faced the priest.

"Last chance," Rakihi said quietly. "We do this with words, or we do this with screaming. Your choice."

Joren's lip curled.

"You think you understand?" Joren hissed. The gentle warmth he used in the village had vanished, leaving a thin, ugly voice. "You think you know what you're playing with, girl? His silence is coming. Your little songs will mean nothing."

Rakihi's stomach tightened. "So that's a no to regretting human sacrifice," she said.

Shade stepped closer.

“Father Joren,” Shade said formally, “you stand accused of murder, perverting your office, and bargaining with a death god for personal power. Confess, and your god may yet show you another path. Refuse, and—”

“And you’ll what?” Joren spat. “Kill me? He already owns my bones. You’re just doing his work with more drama.”

Rakihi’s circles shimmered, tightening.

The ritual was simple in principle and merciless in practice: force the truth from Joren and make him speak it where his god could hear. Rakihi had woven music and Moonthorn into a binding that caught at every lie like a snag in cloth. Joren only had to begin.

“Confession or not,” Shade said, “this ends with your god hearing what you’ve done. One way or another.”

“And you think he’ll care?” Joren snapped. “He likes me like this. You think he picked me because I was kind?”

The admission came too easily. Rakihi’s binding was working, if only at the edges.

Joren realized it too late. His eyes widened.

“Oh,” Rakihi said quietly. “There it is.”

The air thickened.

Something… noticed.

A weight settled over the hall like a blanket smothering a struggling animal. Candle flames narrowed. Shadows stretched along the walls, and every breath sounded unbearably loud.

“Keep going,” Rakihi whispered. “He’s listening.”

Shade nodded.

“Elcia Bramblecrown was your liege,” he said. “You killed her in the name of your god. Say it.”

Silence stretched.

Joren’s jaw clenched.

His throat worked.

“Say it,” Rakihi urged, her voice humming with magic. “Speak the truth, priest. Name what you did.”

He shuddered.

“She—” he choked. “She… refused. The offer. The… protection. This valley needed order. Needed… His guidance. I—”

His voice broke off in a sob.

For a moment, Shade thought it was regret.

Then he saw the glint of metal in Joren’s hand.

“NO—”

The knife was small enough to conceal in his sleeve. In a hand accustomed to sacrificial cuts, it moved with horrible speed.

He dragged the blade across his own throat.

Blood sprayed across the stone, the salt, and Rakihi's boots.

The god's attention spiked.

Shade moved, but not fast enough to stop the cut.

He caught the priest as he fell instead, hands slick with red.

Rakihi screamed something wordless.

Mina swore and pressed cloth to the wound on instinct, though it could do nothing against a divine self-sacrifice.

The ritual circle warped.

Joren gurgled, eyes bulging, and smiled with a mouth full of blood.

"I confess… nothing," he choked. "No… weakness. No… regret. I die… in service."

And he did.

Just like that.

One breath. Then none.

The hall lurched.

The presence watching them leaned closer, hungry.

Rakihi felt her truth-binding shatter. Elcia staggered and nearly dropped her head as the curse pulled hard—as if someone had seized the other end of her leash.

"Oh no you don't," she snarled, hackles rising.

Shade's vision narrowed.

This was the moment.

Their careful plan had broken, and something far greater was about to take its place.

He should have withdrawn, contained the damage, and found another way.

Instead, an old and brutal instinct rose in him: the part forged to stand between gods and worlds and say no.

He was so tired of watching lesser powers take and take and take.

Joren's corpse convulsed as death magic surged through it, turning his last offering into another neat entry in a cult's ledger.

Shade snarled.

"He had one god on his side," Shade said, his voice echoing from somewhere deeper than his chest. "I have five."

The words rang through the hall.

Rakihi's head whipped toward him. "Shade—"

Too late.

Thought gave way to instinct.

He reached.

Not upward, not to the still, cold attention of the death god that was nosing at Joren's soul like a dog at a door—

—but inward, into the five stones chained to his wrist.

Terra. Fenris. Ifret. Djing & Djang. Buyakugan.

They did not appreciate being yanked like that.

Pain shot up his arm as the seal blazed, elemental chains biting into flesh and spirit.

He pushed anyway.

"Look," he hissed, not with his mouth now but with something older. "Look at what your priest has done. Look at what he tried to hide from you."

He drove the images through the opening Rakihi's broken ritual had left: Joren's knife and smile, Elcia's body on the floor months before, her mother's grave, and the dullahan binding twisted to serve one ambitious priest.

For a moment, the hall was two places.

Stone, banners, and blood overlapped with an endless grey vault: shelves of skulls, silent pews, and a bone throne occupied by an absence that felt more terrible than any face.

The death god did not like being pulled.

It resented the challenge from a being outside its dominion.

The weight of its attention slammed into Shade.

His heart lurched. His lungs seized.

His Empress' ancient tether to him flared in alarm, even across worlds.

Around his wrist, the five stones blazed.

Terra: a mountain's weight, suddenly there, shoring up his bones.
Fenris: cold, clear flow, keeping his blood moving.
Ifret: sharp, hot, furious, searing away the god's numbing chill.
Djing & Djang: crosswinds, twisting the god's grasp just enough that it couldn't get a clean hold.
Buyakugan: laughter—bright, crackling, dancing along the edges of the confrontation, turning deadly certainty into something that could be bargained with.

"You presume much, little weapon," the god's voice hissed from everywhere and nowhere. "This was not your stage."

"He made it mine," Shade forced out. "He dragged a bound soul into your service without telling you what he had done to claim her. Your silence is your domain. But this?" He thrust Elcia's memory forward. "This is a lie."

Something shifted in that vast absence.

Rakihi heard none of the god's words. She saw Shade arch under their weight, his eyes burning too brightly, and seized his shoulder. Touch was the only anchor she could give him.

Elcia, leash burning, head tucked against her chest, watched with wide, astonished eyes.

"Your priest took more than was his to offer," Shade said. "He murdered in your name. If you do nothing, his lies become yours."

The death god's attention narrowed.

"You seek to shame me?" it whispered.

"Yes," Shade snarled. "If that's what it takes. Break the tether. Free her. Mark him as broken, not faithful."

The silence held.

The god preferred uncomplicated bargains: life for favor, bone for blessing. Joren had twisted one of those bargains into something harder to defend.

And an ancient god might forgive a broken pattern sooner than it forgave being made a fool.

Shade felt it weighing the alternatives.

It would not reward him for challenging its authority.

Nor could it tolerate the precedent of priests altering divine bargains without consequence.

Annoyed death gods could be remarkably petty.

"No," it said at last. "The curse stands. The dullahan is mine. The head on the horse, the hand that holds it, the road she walks—they were bought with my coin."

Elcia's shoulders sank.

Shade bared his teeth.

White crowded the edges of Shade's vision. His heart pounded against his ribs.

Terra and Ifret dug in—one holding his feet to the ground, the other burning his fear into clean anger.

"Then we renegotiate," he growled. "A new contract. A new master. You may not have ordered this binding, but you benefited from it. You gained a servant, a terror in this valley, and the lives Joren took."

The god did not deny it.

"Take your due," Shade went on. "Take him. Take Joren as payment, with interest. Take every scrap of oath and sanctity he ever had, grind it under your heel. But release your claim on her. Transfer it. To me."

Rakihi's fingers dug painfully into his shoulder. "Shade, what are you—"

"Death is not for you to hold," the god hissed.

"I do not want death," Shade retorted. "I want responsibility. You don't want the burden of this corrupted curse. Transfer the leash. I will answer for what I do with it."

Silence.

A silence deeper than the god's own cultivated quiet.

Across both sides of the veil, even the watching powers seemed to hold their breath.

Buyakugan whooped in his bones. Now that's a gamble.

Djing & Djang muttered twin curses that sounded suspiciously approving.

Terra groaned. Fenris hissed. Ifret burned hotter.

They all knew what he was doing.

He was offering to become the buffer.

The curse would remain, but its weight would settle against his own chains.

The god considered.

Shade on the edge of collapse. The dullahan listening. The valley's dead waiting. Five elemental powers pressing at the boundary.

At last, the death god did what proud beings sometimes do when forced into a corner:

It found a compromise that saved face now, whatever damage it might cause later.

"Very well," it said.

The word rattled the stones.

"Joren is mine," it went on. "His soul, his office, his bones. I will sift him slowly. He will learn my true silence."

The corpse in Shade's arms went utterly still.

Something tore free, like a thread pulled violently from a tapestry.

Shade almost threw up.

"And the dullahan," the god said. "Elcia Bramblecrown. Her curse. Her tether. Her road. I sever my claim… and tie them to yours."

The sensation was a hook wrenched sideways.

Elcia gasped—an echoing, doubled sound, both in the hall and somewhere deeper.

The bonds around her soul snapped—then fastened themselves again.

To Shade.

He screamed.

His throat could barely draw breath, but something at the center of him screamed. The gods on his wrist answered, furious and startled.

Another chain settled inside his chest.

Cold, death-colored, threaded through the old ones.

The god's presence withdrew, smug in a way that said, You wanted responsibility? Have it, then. See how it tastes.

The hall returned to itself.

Candle flames steadied. Shadows drew back. The air was only air again.

Joren's body sagged.

His eyes were empty.

Whatever had made him Joren was gone, dragged away for the god's accounting.

Shade dropped him.

He doubled over, hands braced on his knees, gasping as though he had run up a mountain.

Rakihi caught his face between her hands, searching his eyes and calling his name.

He heard her distantly.

What he felt most was Elcia.

A new note joined the chord within him: clear and sharp, carrying both the chill of graveyards and the remembered warmth of soil beneath halfling feet.

Their eyes met.

She saw the line.

Her curse ended in him now, not in the god.

Shade flinched.

"I—" he croaked. His throat felt raw. "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have— I didn't ask. I—"

She stared at him.

Then, slowly, she smiled.

A small, crooked, exhausted smile.

"Better you than him," she said.

✦ ✦ ✦

Shade could not agree with her. Not yet.

They remained at the castle another day, clearing the directionless dead. Without the god's pressure, and with Elcia no longer fighting her own binding, the work went quickly.

Elcia rode at the front, head on her shoulders, her helm concealing most of her face. People feared an armoured death knight less than a woman carrying her own head under one arm.

She moved like someone testing an old coat that no longer fit.

The curse had changed: still bound to roads and thresholds, but less constrained by divine demands and more closely tied to Shade.

By Shade.

He hated that.

They carried Joren's shrouded remains on a cart as they made their way back toward the village. Shade walked hunched beneath the weight of his thoughts.

Rakihi tried jokes.

Mina tried to distract him by arguing with Tomas about spear techniques.

Varinel tried gruff pragmatism.

None of it really helped.

Again and again, he returned to the same thoughts:

I bargained over someone else's soul.
I took another chain into myself.
I am the one holding her leash now.

Every time Elcia's horse's hoofbeats slowed near him, guilt tightened in his chest.

Finally, she had enough.

They camped in a sheltered hollow beneath the first stars. Dinner simmered over the fire. Rakihi hummed over her spellbook, Varinel pretended not to nap, and Mina and Tomas checked the snares.

Shade stood apart, staring at his hand as if the new chain might show through his skin.

Elcia walked up, helm tucked under one arm, head affixed properly to her neck.

"Stop that," she said.

He blinked. "Stop… what?"

"Brooding hard enough to change the weather," she said. "Even the clouds look guilty."

He glanced up.

The clouds did look rather sheepish.

He sighed. "I did not do it right. I was meant to free you, not reroute your curse through myself. You traded one master for another."

Her brows climbed. "Is that what you think this is?" she asked.

He stared at her.

"What else can it be?" he asked. "The tether lands in me now. I feel your… path. Your… weight. You ride roads because I hold that line."

"And I feel your gods grumbling in the back of my skull," she said. "Which is more than I could say for the last one."

He winced. "Elcia—"

"You forced a death god to admit its priest had corrupted a bargain," she said. "You gave it a way out without losing face before its followers. And you took on a mess that was never yours."

He flinched harder. "That doesn't make it—"

"Let me finish," she said sharply.

He shut his mouth.

Elcia drew a breath she did not need, arranging her thoughts out of habit.

"Joren bound me," she said. "To a god that didn't care about my name, only my usefulness. I was a tool. A symbol. Ride when he said. Kill who he said. Drag back what he said. I fought it where I could, but the weight was always from above."

She tapped her chest.

“Now the line runs sideways.”

He frowned. “What?”

“You aren’t on a throne of skulls ordering me to collect souls,” she said. “You’re on the same miserable road, with muddy boots and far too much guilt. I can feel it. Whatever this curse is now, we share it. I lean, you feel it. You lean, I do. It’s annoying.” Her mouth curved. “And better.”

He looked away. “It’s still not freedom,” he murmured.

“No,” she agreed. “But it isn’t slavery, either. Patronage, perhaps. A contract. You did not ask to become a sort of death god any more than I asked to lose my head. Yet here we are.”

He huffed a mirthless laugh. “You make it sound so dignified.”

“I am halfling nobility,” she said. “We can make anything sound dignified. Even falling off a pony.”

He glanced at her. “Do you ever… regret that I intervened?” he asked. “Would you rather I had done nothing? Let the god take him and leave you as you were?”

She stared at him for a moment.

Then she stepped closer and jabbed a finger into his breastbone.

“Listen carefully. If you ever suggest I should have stayed bound to that smug pile of bones instead of joining your ridiculous web of gods and guilt again, I will ride you into a ditch.”

He blinked. “…Ride me into a ditch?”

“Metaphorically,” she said, freckles growing pink. “Probably. My point is that I am still undead, still tied to roads and thresholds and the politics of death. But my orders now come from someone who cares about the people I ride past. Someone who bakes bread for spirits and weeps over villages. That matters.”

He swallowed.

Her finger found his chest again. “You did not save me wrong, Shade. You saved me without starting a war between gods. Stop asking me to absolve you every quarter hour. You did something stupid, reckless, and kind. Take the win.”

He managed a small, shaky smile. “You are very… direct,” he said.

“Undeath wears patience thin. Besides, if I must keep telling Rakihi I do not hate you and she need not write a tragic ballad about it, I will become quite unpleasant.”

He flushed faintly. “She is… worried.”

“She’s in love,” Elcia said. “With both of us, if I’m reading that right.” Her eyes twinkled. “Undead or not.”

He froze.

She smirked.

“What,” she said. “You think I can’t tell when a bard is making heart eyes at me? I may be decapitated, but I’m not blind.”

He opened his mouth.

Closed it.

“I… feel guilty,” he admitted finally. “For wanting you, when your curse is… now tied to me. It feels… wrong. Like taking advantage.”

Her expression softened.

“That is why I trust you,” she said. “You care enough to worry about it. Joren cared only for his next promotion.” She met his eyes. “I was an adult before I died, Shade, and I remain one now. I choose whom I love. If I choose you and that very loud fairy, it is my decision—not the god’s and not yours.”

He exhaled, some of the tension finally leaving his shoulders.

“Better,” he murmured.

“Better,” she agreed.

Behind them, Rakihi leaned against a tree, arms folded, making a spectacularly unconvincing attempt not to eavesdrop.

She failed.

When they returned to the fire, she caught Shade’s eye with an unspoken question.

“Still asking for forgiveness?” she asked softly.

“Less,” he said. “Elcia insists I stop.”

“Good,” Rakihi said, visibly relieved. “It was becoming irritating. I nearly started keeping tally marks.”

He snorted.

On the final stretch toward Greenhollow, Joren’s shrouded body rattling in the cart and Elcia circling the road on horseback, Shade still felt guilty.

But the guilt had changed.

He had done something reckless, and now he had to live with its consequences. That was different from believing he had done something unforgivable.

He could live with that.

Lana was going to hate it, of course.

A dragon, a bard, and a dullahan, all tangled in the same divine bargains?

She would need a larger ledger.

Earlier, on their last night beneath the open sky, Shade had asked Elcia for forgiveness one more time. She had rolled her eyes, settled her head more firmly on her shoulders, and answered:

“Not perfect. Better. That’s enough.”

He was beginning to believe her.

Chapter 40: Lana's Wrath

Shade had imagined bargaining with a death god would be the worst decision he made that month.

Lana proved him wrong.

Lana did not shout.

He almost wished she would.

They'd barely cleared the city gate when a guild runner found them.

"Lana wants you," the boy panted. "All of you. Now."

They were exhausted and dusty from the road, with Joren's shrouded body already handed over to a neutral temple. Shade had foolishly hoped they might sleep before facing the guildmaster.

Instead, Lana waited in her office with her hands folded and an expression like a storm trying to remain professional.

Shade, Rakihi, Mina, Tomas, and Elcia filed in. Elcia wore her helm and kept her head firmly attached, apparently determined not to look as though she was planning a haunting.

Varinel had sensibly vanished the moment they hit town. Coward.

Lana shut the door.

"Sit," she said.

They sat. Elcia remained by the wall, arms crossed, trying to look like an ordinary armored traveller.

Lana studied her first: horse-etched armor, worn cloak, and the ghost-light gathering at the edges.

"You," she said, "are not in my ledger."

Elcia inclined her head. "Elcia Bramblecrown. Former local nobility. Recently headless. Currently very annoyed with one dead priest."

"Mm," Lana said. Her eyes moved to Shade. "And you decided to bring her here because…?"

Shade sat rigidly, his back aching, every instinct telling him not to fidget.

"She is bound to me now," he said. "Indirectly. The dullahan curse was tied to a death god via Joren. I… convinced the god to transfer the tether."

Lana stared at him.

Rakihi opened her mouth, then shut it when Lana raised one peremptory finger.

"You convinced a death god," Lana repeated, "to make you the effective landlord of a dullahan curse."

Shade winced. "That is a very… blunt way of phrasing it, but—"

"Is it accurate?" she asked, voice dangerously level.

"…Yes," he said.

She inhaled through her nose.

He could almost hear her counting.

One. Two. Three. Don't scream at the dragon. Four. Five—

“Explain,” she said, “how a straightforward silver-rank trial became ‘I have added partial psychopomp to my résumé.’ Slowly. I would particularly appreciate the parts where someone might have asked me first.”

Rakihi jumped in before Shade could dig himself deeper.

“Joren murdered Elcia to bind her as a dullahan,” Rakihi said before Shade could make matters worse. “He twisted the bargain with his god. We tried to make him confess so the curse could be broken. Instead, he killed himself mid-ritual. Shade used what remained of our spell, together with his five gods, to demand arbitration. Joren’s soul was taken, but the death god refused to release Elcia outright. Shade offered to become the new anchor.”

Lana pinched the bridge of her nose.

“You challenged a death god with five of your own,” Lana said to Shade, “during a guild trial mission.”

“I was angry,” Shade admitted. There was little point pretending otherwise.

“I should hope so,” Lana snapped. “If you weren’t angry, I would worry you had stopped being yourself. But that does not mean you get to drag divinity into a guild assignment without warning.”

“I did not have time to consult the guild charter,” Shade said, dry despite himself.

Rakihi made a strangled noise.

Lana’s mouth twitched, once, then flattened again.

“I am not arguing with the ethics,” Lana said. “Joren needed exposing. The god needed to see what its priest had done. I am arguing with your method.” She jabbed a finger at Shade. “You bound another god-stained chain into your chest, surrounded by companions with no divine protection and no backup.”

Mina sat straighter. “We’re not—”

“Compared with Shade, you are all vulnerable,” Lana said, without looking at her. “That is not an insult.”

Shade lowered his eyes. “I am sorry. If I had failed, you would have lost more than a party. I understand.”

“You’re sorry to me,” Lana said. “Fine. Accepted, eventually. Have you apologized to yourself yet?”

That stopped him.

“That is not—” Shade began.

“You keep taking on chains,” Lana said, her voice quieter. “Your mother. Your Empress. The five gods. Now Elcia’s curse. Someday I would like to hear you refuse one—not because someone stopped you, but because you decided you deserve a life with fewer burdens.”

He had no answer for that.

Rakihi watched them, unusually silent.

Elcia cleared her throat.

“I would have been much angrier if he had left me bound to that bone-throned bastard,” Elcia offered. “I consider this an improvement.”

Lana looked at her.

“You’re fine with being bound to a dragon instead of a god,” she said, skeptical.

Elcia shrugged. “He listens. And he doesn’t object when I help the living rather than frighten them. I’ve known worse masters.”

“You’re not helping my blood pressure,” Lana muttered.

Rakihi bit the inside of her cheek.

Lana exhaled, long and slow.

“Very well,” Lana said. “Shade made an appallingly reckless decision. The valley is still standing, and Elcia is now tied into an already absurd collection of divine bargains.” Her eyes shifted to Elcia. “Which brings me to you.”

Elcia straightened.

“You mentioned on the road that you wanted to apply.”

Elcia’s chin lifted. “Yes,” she said. “As… an adventurer. With your guild.”

Rakihi kicked Shade under the table, this is the part.

Lana stared at Elcia for a long moment.

Then she laughed.

It wasn’t a nice laugh.

“You died because you trusted a priest enough to open your doors,” Lana said. “You spent six months serving him against your will. And now you want to sign up for more orders?”

“I want work,” Elcia said. “A way to make this curse useful. I need roads, contracts, people who can point me toward trouble that deserves a rider in the dark—not families whose only crime was paying the wrong tithe.”

Shade’s chest ached at the rawness under the words.

“And this guild,” Lana said, “looks like ‘job security’ to you?”

“It looks like people who accomplish things,” Elcia retorted. “People who do not fold when gods throw tantrums, who know the world is messy and still try to improve their corner of it. I do not want another temple. I want direction without worship. Does that make sense?”

It did.

Uncomfortably so.

Lana drummed her fingers on the desk.

“On paper,” Lana said, “you are an intelligent, autonomous undead with a curse nobody here fully understands and enough power to ruin my month if you so much as sneeze.”

Elcia opened her mouth, then shut it again. “Yes,” she said, after a beat.

“But you are already tied to my greatest liability”—she gestured toward Shade—“and you have shown enough restraint not to murder the villagers who still leave candles for Joren. That counts in your favour.”

Elcia's expression twitched.

"Here are my terms," Lana said. "You may ride with us, but you will be on probation. Provisional bronze, attached to Shade's party as a special case. No solo contracts. No entering the city without his party's approval or mine. You train, you learn to work with people who do not already fear you, and we review your status in three months."

Elcia blinked.

"That's… generous," she said slowly.

"Cautious," Lana corrected. "Generous would be a uniform and a desk. Neither is happening until I know you won't throttle a client for being irritating."

"Very smart rule," Rakihi muttered. "We should apply that to all applicants."

Lana ignored her.

"Well?" she said to Elcia. "Do you accept those terms?"

Elcia glanced, just once, at Shade and Rakihi.

Shade nodded, minutely: Your choice. Not mine.

Rakihi waggled her eyebrows in encouragement, incapable of behaving herself even now.

Elcia squared her shoulders.

"I accept," she said.

"Welcome to the bottom rung," Lana said. "You may terrorize bandits once you have learned to work with a team. Now get out, all of you. You smell of the road, and if I have to consider what this means for my paperwork another minute, I will start drinking before sunset."

They fled.

✦ ✦ ✦

Outside, in the late afternoon light, the city looked almost normal.

Merchants bargained. Children dodged between adults. Someone sang off-key in a nearby street.

Shade paused on the guild steps, utterly spent.

Rakihi leaned against him, hip to hip.

"Well," Rakihi said, "that could have been much worse. She did not exile anyone or set you on fire. Again."

"I would rather negotiate with the death god again than explain myself to Lana," he said.

Rakihi snorted. "A fair assessment."

Elcia joined them, helm back on, hands resting lightly on the pommel of her sword.

"So," Elcia said, "provisional bronze?"

"Welcome to the party," Rakihi said. "We have poor impulse control and a very nice house."

Shade blinked. "House," he repeated, as if he had forgotten such a thing existed.

“Yes,” Rakihi said firmly. “The large stone house with the leaky roof, the overexcited elementals, and actual beds. We are going there. Now. You are sleeping for twelve hours at least.”

He opened his mouth to protest.

His body reminded him how long he had been surviving on adrenaline and divine fury. His knees gave an alarming wobble.

“See?” Rakihi said. “Your joints agree with me.”

Elcia’s horse materialized out of the shadows at the side of the steps, snorting softly.

“You look like you’ve been hit by a carriage,” Elcia observed. “Get on.”

“I can walk,” Shade muttered.

“You can stumble,” she corrected. “Which is less majestic. Up.”

Between Rakihi’s determined herding and Elcia’s steady hand, he ended up in the saddle behind the dullahan, too exhausted even to be embarrassed.

They took the back streets home.

People stared at the nightmare horse, inevitably. But Shade dampened its aura with a glamour, and Elcia sat so quietly that, at a distance, it might have passed for an unusually grim adventurer’s mount.

By the time they reached the manor gates, the sky was bleeding into purple.

Dusk painted the sky violet as they reached the manor gates.

Small stone elementals peered over the garden wall. Sparky flared in the hearth, recognizing familiar footsteps, and doors opened to welcome them into the warmth.

Home.

Rakihi abandoned her pack inside and shut her eyes for a moment.

Shade dismounted, steadied himself against the wall, and felt the manor’s familiar magic gather around him.

Elcia stepped in after them, pausing on the threshold.

The curse tugged.

The house… pushed back.

The house was full of a different power: stone, bread, songs, and the stubborn magic of people determined to make a place their own.

She smiled, very slightly.

“Nice,” she said. “I like it.”

Rakihi yawned until her jaw clicked. “Good. Because I do not have the energy to find you other lodgings. Sofa? Bedroll? Suspiciously comfortable patch of floor?”

“Floor’s fine,” Elcia said. “I don’t sleep much.”

Shade shot her a look. “You rest,” he said. “You may not… sleep, but you rest.”

She rolled her eyes. “Yes, mom.”

He choked. “Do not ever say that again.”

Rakihi wheezed laughter.

They were too tired to celebrate.

They were two silver-ranked adventurers and one very unusual provisional bronze, with a death god’s reluctant compromise woven into their lives. The significance of it would have to wait.

So they didn’t.

They ate whatever Rakihi could assemble from the pantry, washed off enough of the road to tolerate their beds, and left the elementals to settle the house around them.

They collapsed together—Shade in the middle, Rakihi curled against one side, Elcia finally persuaded to lie on the other. For once, her armor was off and her head rested upon her shoulders.

“Silver,” Rakihi mumbled into his shoulder, just before sleep claimed her. “We did it.”

Shade found their hands in the dark, one warm and living, the other cool beneath his fingers.

“Yes,” he said quietly. “We did.”

The house creaked. The gods hummed. Somewhere very far away, a death god sulked.

Shade thought, just before he slipped under:

If Lana was his mother or one of the goddesses in disguise, he would never forgive any of them. The thought almost made him smile.

Then exhaustion pulled him down, and for the first time in a long while, he dreamed of nothing at all.

Chapter 41: Letters from Elsewhere

The imp arrived mid-argument.

Rakihi and Elcia were in the kitchen debating the practicalities of undead digestion. Shade stood at the counter, cutting bread with more concentration than the task required.

“I can eat,” Elcia was saying. “I just don’t need to. It’s a courtesy. Like wearing a shirt.”

“Yeah, but where does it go?” Rakihi insisted. “You don’t have… you know…” She made a vague spiraling gesture. “Working…and… stuff.”

“I am not having this anatomical conversation with you,” Elcia said.

“Please stop interrogating our not-quite-death-knight about her intestines while I am preparing food,” Shade said.

“Undeath is a valid field of study,” Rakihi muttered.

Something smacked into the kitchen window with a wet thwack.

All three of them froze.

“Did the house just throw a bird at us?” Rakihi whispered.

Shade set the knife down and crossed the floor in three strides, opening the window.

A small smoking creature tumbled inside, bounced off the floor, and landed upright with a wheeze.

“You people need a better landing pad,” the imp grumbled, patting out a tiny ember on its own shoulder. “Airspace around this dump is terrible.”

Rakihi lit up. “Mail!”

Hope twisted painfully beneath Shade’s ribs.

The imp dusted itself off with exaggerated dignity and held up a folded scrap of parchment edged in familiar, prickly sigils.

“Special delivery,” the imp announced. “Same sender, same instructions, slightly more threats about what happens if I peek.”

“Hi, Arcebek,” Rakihi breathed.

Shade wiped his hands, took the parchment carefully. “Signature?” he asked automatically.

The imp produced a slate and chalk. Shade signed, his hand steadier than on the previous delivery.

“Right,” the imp said briskly. “You know the rules. No replies, no blood, no creative reinterpretations. I’ll be over here pretending not to listen.” It scuttled up onto the counter and plopped down next to the bread, eyeing it covetously.

Shade unfolded the letter.

The handwriting was hers: sharp, practical, with a blot where she had evidently cursed and pressed on.

Im still alive, things is getting dragged out here. Damed corpo. Still bad weather and worse neighbours.

Rakihi snorted. “She spelled ‘damned’ wrong,” she said, eyes shining.

“She wrote it fast,” Shade murmured, reading on.

Congratiulations on silver you erned it. Love the dullahan.

He blinked.

“…She knows,” he said.

“Elcia waved at the wards,” Rakihi said. “Of course she knows.”

Elcia, who’d been trying to look unobtrusive by the door, went very still. “She… what?”

Shade swallowed and read the rest.

We are gonna have a long talk about her and our pollycule when i come back, wash yor necks. Love Arcebek.

There was a beat of absolute silence.

Then Rakihi exploded.

“Oh my GODS,” she yelped. “She said POLLYCULE. We’re a polycule. I knew she was going to say it but seeing it written—”

She snatched the letter before Shade could stop her and danced across the kitchen, reading aloud between bursts of laughter.

“ ‘Love the dullahan,’” Rakihi mimicked. “She hasn’t even met you yet, and she’s already claiming you. That’s so her.”

Elcia’s cheeks darkened—not quite a flush, but a change in colour nonetheless. “She is very bold in writing,” she said.

“You have no idea,” Rakihi said.

Shade leaned back against the counter, closing his eyes for a heartbeat.

Im still alive.

The knot beneath his ribs eased. The message sounded so much like Arcebek: complaints about delays and neighbours, without the horrors he had feared.

He let the breath go.

“She congratulated us on silver,” he said. “She knows, even from wherever she is.”

“’Course she does,” Rakihi said, softer now. “She probably shook down three minor spirits and one unfortunate angel for news.”

The imp, ostentatiously pretending not to listen, pulled a face. “She bribed the message clerk with coffee. He is weak. We all have vices.”

Elcia shifted, looking oddly uncertain. “She… loves the dullahan,” she echoed.

Rakihi perched on a chair, swinging her feet. “Arcebek collects sharp, difficult women like other people collect stamps. You were doomed the moment Shade came home muttering about a cursed halfling noble with boundary issues.”

Shade covered his face with one hand. “Rakihi.”

“She knows about us,” Rakihi said. “Our polycule. And she guessed I would immediately fall for the terrifying undead rider. Which is rude. And accurate.”

Elcia opened her mouth. Closed it.

“I don’t… want to… complicate—” she started.

Shade lowered his hand. “It was complicated before she acknowledged it. Now she has given it a name.”

Rakihi looked back at the letter, smile dimming into something more tender.

“We are gonna have a long talk about her and our pollycule when I come back, wash your necks,” Rakihi read, tenderly correcting the spelling as she went. “She is planning for after. Not if. When.”

“That is… important,” Shade agreed quietly.

Elcia studied them both.

“You feel guilty,” Elcia said to Shade. “About us. About being happy while she is away.”

Shame flickered across his face, too quick to completely hide.

“Yes,” he admitted.

Rakihi didn’t even try to deny it.

“So do I,” Rakihi said. “Whenever I laugh, or want something, or look at you and think something that would offend three different temples. It feels like betraying her absence.”

Elcia looked at the letter again.

“Then listen to her,” she said simply.

They both fell silent.

“She is not asking you to stop living,” Elcia said. “She is planning to return to a household that has grown messier without her. She wants a conversation, not a frozen life.”

Shade ran his thumb over Arcebek’s name at the bottom, as if he could feel the pressure of her pen.

“She told us to wash our necks,” he said, a little dazed.

“That is warlock for ‘I intend to kiss you senseless and then shout at you,’” Rakihi said. “Standard Arcebek protocol.”

The imp made a gagging sound. “You mortals are disgusting,” it muttered. “Can I have some bread before I go?”

Shade, because habits were habits, automatically tore off a heel of bread and handed it over.

The imp blinked at the unexpected generosity, then crammed the bread into its mouth.

“Official mental ledger,” Rakihi announced, carefully folding the letter. “Arcebek: alive, furious, aware of our romantic catastrophe, and not ordering anyone to stop.”

“And aware of Elcia,” Shade added.

“And already calling dibs,” Rakihi said cheerfully. “Gods, she’s on brand.”

Elcia looked both pleased and alarmed. “Should I worry about this long talk?”

“Yes,” Rakihi and Shade said together.

Then Shade softened.

“She will ask questions,” Shade said. “Bluntly. She will find every sore place and want to know whether you chose this, or simply drifted into it through curses and proximity. She will not judge you for being undead. She may stab me if she believes I have used any of this to avoid my feelings.”

“That sounds…” Elcia searched for a word. “Terrifying.”

“And safe,” Rakihi added. “In the sense that my terrifying girlfriend will make us talk like responsible adults.”

The imp licked crumbs off its fingers. “If you’re done being sappy,” it said, “I have to go pretend I didn’t enjoy this. She’ll get ideas.”

Shade inclined his head. “Tell her…” He hesitated. No replies. No loopholes. “Tell her we read it,” he said instead. “And that her neighbours had better be very bad to justify this much delay.”

The imp smirked. “You can tell her that yourself when she gets a break,” it said. “But I’ll pass along the general vibe.”

It snapped its fingers and vanished in a puff of sulfur and smugness.

The kitchen went quiet again.

The bread knife lay where Shade had set it down. Stew bubbled on the stove. Sparky snored in the hearth.

Rakihi let out a long breath and dropped her forehead onto the table.

“She is alive,” Rakihi murmured into the table. “She knows. She is already planning where to put the undead halfling. I feel better. And I may need to wash my neck.”

Elcia laughed, unexpectedly bright.

Shade’s shoulders relaxed by degrees.

“We wait,” he said. “We live. We make room. We do not freeze.”

“And we have that long talk,” Rakihi said. “About curses, chains, boundaries, and bedrooms.” She considered it. “That will be an extraordinary conversation.”

“Yes,” Shade said. “But it will be ours.”

He reached out.

Rakihi’s hand found his.

A moment later, after only the briefest hesitation, Elcia’s rested lightly on top.

Five gods hummed in Shade’s bracelet. Far away, a stubborn warlock was fighting battles of her own.

For now, the letter was enough.

Rakihi kept the letter close as they returned to their bread and stew, and to the small, stubborn work of building a life worth coming home to.

Chapter 42: A New Front Line

The first sign was the bandits.

They didn't run.

They watched a dragon and a dullahan approach side by side and somehow decided that standing their ground was a good idea.

"Bless 'em," Rakihi said as Elcia swung into the saddle and Shade rolled his shoulders. "They really don't get paid enough to know better."

The fight lasted seconds.

Elcia's horse erupted in shadow-fire, its hooves ringing against the packed earth. Her blade swept through the bandits' shields as though they were rotten bark. Shade spared them even a proper storm: one controlled sweep of force sent the rear line sprawling.

By the time Tomas and Mina sprinted up, weapons drawn, Elcia had the last bandit dangling from one gauntleted hand. He kicked helplessly at the air.

"This is a training mission," Rakihi said, hands on hips. "You are supposed to leave some alive for the children to poke."

Elcia squinted at the man, then tossed him at Mina. "Fine. This one's yours. Practice your threatening voice."

✦ ✦ ✦

The orcs fared no better.

The raiders had struck a granary. Shade had proposed talking first, and Elcia had agreed—at least in principle.

Then the first orc charged. Elcia met it halfway, shield raised, laughing with that eerie delight that meant the dullahan in her had awakened. Beside her, Shade planted his feet and refused to yield an inch.

Three minutes later, the orcs were fleeing with their wounded. They left behind scattered weapons and a thoroughly broken chieftain who had learned too late that being bigger than a man meant little against someone who had fought things that devoured stars.

Mina wiped her blade on the grass, breathing hard but grinning. "We barely needed to swing," she said.

"That's the problem," Varinel grunted from the treeline, where he'd been picking off runners. "We're not being stretched. They're being flattened."

Rakihi shaded her eyes and surveyed the wreckage. Elcia still burned with blue ghostfire; Shade's armor barely bore a scratch.

"Yeah," she said. "We've become that party."

✦ ✦ ✦

The troll nest was almost embarrassing.

Three trolls, each the size of a wagon, with stone-hard hides and wounds that knitted faster than most parties could inflict them.

Shade reduced the first to ash with a single breath.

Elcia dismantled the second at the joints, working with a butcher's precision.

Tomas and Mina took the third together while Rakihi's spells battered its senses. Whenever the creature managed to regenerate, Elcia's horse scattered its growing limbs and Shade crushed anything that looked capable of becoming a head.

Afterward, Rakihi dropped onto a rock, her clothes dripping with troll ichor, and groaned.

"I miss being scared," she announced. "A little. Not a lot. Just enough that my heart remembers why it evolved."

"You say that now," Elcia said, wiping gore off her vambrace. "You'll take it back when you're being chased by something with more teeth than sense."

Rakihi grinned. "Promise?"

Shade surveyed the bodies. He understood what she meant. Lately, even the difficult fights had asked too little of him. With Elcia beside him, frontline work had become almost absurdly easy.

"We are doing gold's work for bronze and silver pay," he said mildly.

"Talk like that at the guild," Varinel said, "and Lana will give us a bigger mess."

✦ ✦ ✦

The trial month ended, inevitably, in paperwork.

Some things never changed.

Lana sat behind a wall of reports, quill poised. Opposite her, Shade, Rakihi, Elcia, Mina, and Tomas waited with varying degrees of apprehension.

She read the last line, set the sheet down, and looked up.

"So," she said. "Bandits: pulped. Orc raids: stopped. Troll nest: apparently converted into a cautionary tale. Letters from two villages calling you 'our grim saints' and 'the terror on the black horse and her terrifying husband.' And one angry note from a baron who claims your dullahan glared at him."

"She did glare at him," Rakihi mumbled.

"He kicked a dog," Elcia said flatly. "He's lucky glaring is all I did."

Lana tilted her head. "Is he likely to change his behavior?"

"He's likely to cross the street when he sees me," Elcia said. "That's a start."

Lana made a thoughtful noise and steepled her fingers.

"You're using far more force than half these assignments require. On the other hand, the farmers adore you, the orcs have moved on, and the surviving bandits have apparently discovered honest employment—in other towns."

She shifted her gaze to Elcia.

"You haven't eaten anyone you weren't supposed to," she said. "Good job."

Elcia blinked. “…Thank you?” she said.

“You followed orders, deferred when someone else knew the terrain, and avoided unnecessary duels with local authorities. You even refrained from turning that baron into a warning sign.” Lana tapped the report. “Your probation has gone remarkably well.”

Rakihi squeezed Elcia’s hand.

Elcia glanced at their joined hands, then raised her chin. She looked almost afraid to hope.

Lana sighed, long-suffering.

“All right. We can stop pretending you’re merely a provisional bronze who happens to ride beside a dragon. I’ll arrange an advancement trial—one worthy of your abilities.” Lana grimaced. “I have to argue with the council about keeping a dullahan on the roster anyway. We might as well give them a respectable rank to argue over.”

Elcia’s fingers flexed around Rakihi’s.

“What kind of mission?” she asked carefully.

“A mission where charging in and taking heads won’t solve everything. Multiple fronts, different threats, and decisions that matter as much as swordwork. You, Shade, Rakihi, and the others.” Lana looked around the room. “Assuming you’re ready for work that actually tests you.”

Tomas straightened. “Yes, Guildmistress,” he said quickly.

Mina tried to look cool and nearly vibrated with excitement.

Rakihi made jazz hands. “Gold-flavored trouble,” she said. “It was only a matter of time.”

Shade inclined his head. “We are ready,” he said simply.

“Good. I happen to have a map with a particularly irritating circle on it. It has been waiting for a party just as irritating.”

She shuffled the papers into a neat stack, eyes glinting.

“Rest today,” she said. “Fix your gear. Send your letters. Tomorrow, we talk about your next step up.”

They filed out past her desk.

In the hall, Rakihi nudged Elcia with her shoulder. “Told you,” she said. “Gold’s practically breathing down your neck.”

Elcia breathed out. At last, some of the tension left her shoulders.

“Feels… fast,” she admitted. “Going from ‘cursed noble stuck in a haunted castle’ to ‘gold-track adventurer with a polycule and a dragon problem.’”

Shade smiled, just a little.

“Nothing about our lives has been gradual,” Shade said. “I see no reason for that to change now.”

Rakihi looped her arm through both of theirs, grinning.

“Gold trial, incoming,” she said. “Try not to lose your head over it.”

Elcia groaned.

Shade actually laughed.

For the first time since the dullahan had ridden into their lives, the danger ahead felt less like a threat than a road they had chosen together.

Chapter 43: Necromancy and Warmth

Necromancy had been filed on all the wrong shelves.

Shade had figured that out quickly.

Respectable volumes—*Funerary Rites of the Third Age*, *On the Proper Disposition of Remains*, *Spirits and Their Annoying Opinions*—sat under theology, spiritual practice, and history.

Anything useful was mislabelled, misfiled, or 'temporarily unavailable due to moral panic.'

So his downtime in the library had become a scavenger hunt.

At a corner table, he had built a fortress of questionable texts. A conventional treatise on healing magic concealed an unindexed appendix about reversing vital energies. A philosophical essay on returning what was borrowed turned out, if read correctly, to be mathematics for souls.

Rakihi had helped him get the restricted scrolls.

"I'm not stealing," she'd said, balancing on a ladder with one foot and a terrifying amount of casual confidence. "I'm borrowing information. Librarians fear me."

Shade had decided not to ask.

Under the glow of an enchanted lamp, he traced a line of ink with one finger.

"Life to death is easy," he muttered. "Push, and it falls. Death to life is… expensive. But what about… life into death?"

He looked up.

Across the table, Elcia was reading about crop rotation.

The librarian had tried to insist dullahans didn't need farming manuals.

Elcia had glared.

The librarian had decided dullahans could read whatever they wanted.

Her head was attached, her helmet lay beside the book, and loose curls framed her face. She turned each old page with surprising care.

She no longer needed to breathe, yet still took shallow breaths from habit. Details like that had begun to matter to Shade's research.

He closed his book.

"Elcia," he said.

She looked up, brown eyes clear. "Hmm?"

"I have a theory," he said. "About your condition."

"Is it 'you're undead'?" she asked dryly. "Because I have bad news about your research speed."

"Not that." Shade closed the book. "It concerns degrees."

She raised a brow. "Degrees."

He considered how to explain it without sounding like a necromancer reading from a manual.

“Everything I’ve found suggests death is not a single switch. There are stages: living flesh, cooling flesh, inert flesh. Your curse holds you somewhere between them. You do not decay, but neither do you move through the channels that sustain life. You are suspended.”

She listened, expression serious.

“I think I can send some of my vitality through our tether. Temporarily. It would not change what you are, but it might restore warmth, movement, and physical sensation—without disturbing the curse.”

Rakihi, who had drifted over with a pile of her own books and a snack, blinked. “You mean… make her… warmer?”

“Essentially. Blood flow through channels that have been empty for too long. I would not force anything.”

Elcia blinked.

“Will that… hurt you?” she asked.

“It shouldn’t, if I’m careful. Think of it as lending heat from one room to another. I have plenty; you have very little.” His mouth twitched. “It might be nice for you to feel something besides cold and ghostfire when we sit together by the hearth.”

Rakihi’s ears turned red.

Elcia’s did something similar.

“You want to… warm me up,” she said slowly.

“Yes,” he said, and only realized how it sounded after it left his mouth.

Rakihi choked, then tried to pass it off as a cough.

Shade pinched the bridge of his nose. “You know what I mean. This is medical. Magical. Practical.”

“It could also be… nice,” Elcia said, voice softer.

He met her gaze.

“Yes,” he admitted.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Elcia closed her farming book with a quiet thump.

“All right,” she said. “Show me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They did it at home.

Shade refused to experiment in the guildhall. Too many witnesses, too much that could go wrong. The manor’s wards and familiar spirits offered a safer place.

They chose the sitting room, where the fire crackled behind drawn curtains. Shade traced a circle of chalk and salt on the rug, largely out of habit.

Rakihi perched cross-legged on the arm of a chair, watching like it was the most interesting play in town.

“If either of you start glowing in ways I don’t like,” she said, “I am throwing a bucket of water and yelling.”

“That is not how necromantic backlash works,” Shade said.

“I’ll yell anyway,” she replied.

Elcia sat cross-legged inside the circle, unarmored in a simple shirt and trousers. Without her armor, she looked less like the terror of a haunted road and more like the halfling noble she had been before someone decided her head belonged under her arm.

Her hands were steady in her lap.

“Ready?” he asked.

She nodded once. “What do you need me to do?”

“Nothing,” he said. “Just… be. And if anything feels wrong, you tell me and I stop.”

“Got it,” she said.

He sat opposite her, their knees nearly touching, the chained stones resting against his thigh.

He took a slow breath.

The gods were not thrilled with this line of study.

Terra grumbled: Dead should stay dead.

Fenris whispered: Flow carefully. Do not dam the wrong river.

Ifret was suspicious but curious: We are not turning you into a lich. If this starts to smell like lich, I’m setting something on fire.

Djing & Djang hovered, interested. Buyakugan, of course, was delighted.

You want to make your undead girlfriend warm? the storm crackled along his bones. Love this for you. Terrible idea, but love it.

He focused past them.

On the line.

Through the tether, he sensed Elcia as clearly as the gods: a presence woven into his own, neither shackle nor burden but a path along which his power could travel.

He reached along it, gently.

He found the point where her curse animated her: cold, precise, and indifferent to comfort.

“Here,” he murmured, half to himself. “Here, we… nudge.”

He gathered a thread of vitality, not the violent power he carried into battle but the steady warmth that kept his own blood flowing.

And he pushed.

Slow.

Gentle.

He guided it forward as gently as warm water through frozen pipes.

Elcia sucked in a breath.

Her hands flew to her chest.

Rakihi tensed. “Too much?” she asked.

Elcia shook her head, eyes wide.

“It’s—” Elcia broke off, blinking. “Strange, not bad. Like pins and needles, but from the inside.”

Shade grimaced. “I can stop—”

“No,” she said quickly. “Keep going. Just… slower.”

Shade reduced the flow until it moved smoothly through the tether. It reminded him of singing under his breath, except the melody was written in blood and bone.

Her skin changed.

The change was subtle. The waxy stillness of Elcia’s skin softened, and the stiffness left her shoulders as muscles moved with a warmth they had long forgotten.

Rakihi slipped down from the chair and knelt beside the circle.

“Can I…?” she asked, wiggling her fingers.

Elcia huffed a laugh. “Everyone wants to poke the undead,” she muttered. “Fine. Hand. Carefully.”

Rakihi reached out and took her hand.

Her eyes went wide.

“Oh,” Rakihi whispered. “You’re warm.”

Elcia’s fingers flexed around hers.

“So are you,” Elcia said. “Only more alive. This feels like coming in from the snow and standing beside the hearth.”

Shade held the flow steady.

The tug on Shade’s reserves was not painful, but he could not ignore it. His limbs felt oddly light, as though he had given away a little too much blood.

“I cannot sustain it indefinitely. But for a few hours at a time…”

Elcia looked at him.

“Can you feel what it’s doing?” she asked.

“I’m not rewriting your body,” he explained. “Only reminding it how to respond: heat, flexibility, sensation.” He paused. “Touch may become sharper while the effect lasts.”

Rakihi’s expression did something complicated.

Elcia’s ears colored.

“Good to know,” she said, very carefully neutral.

Rakihi squeezed her hand. “How’s the rest of you?” she asked. “Head? Chest? Toes?”

Elcia wiggled her toes in her boots.

“I haven’t felt my toes properly in months.” Elcia flexed them again, bewildered. “Damn. I had forgotten how irritating little aches can be. No wonder the living complain.”

Shade laughed, a little breathless. “Do you want me to—”

“No,” she said quickly. “No. Keep it. I’m just… recalibrating.”

They sat like that for a while.

They remained together in the circle. Shade concentrated on the gentle transfer of vitality. Elcia tested the return of sensations she had lost months ago. Rakihi kept hold of her hands, smiling fiercely and wiping her eyes whenever she thought no one noticed.

Eventually, Shade eased the flow down.

Rather than breaking the link, he let it diminish by degrees, like coals banking beneath ash.

Elcia drew in a slow breath and let it out.

“That was…” She groped for the word. “A lot.”

“Too much?” he asked.

“No. Just overwhelming.” She flexed her fingers. “My joints no longer creak. My shoulders do not feel carved from stone.” A hesitant smile touched her mouth. “I almost feel alive.”

“You are,” Rakihi said fiercely. “Just… in a weird way. This just makes the weird more comfy.”

Elcia’s eyes softened.

“Thank you,” she said. First to Shade. Then to Rakihi.

Shade exhaled, letting the circle’s faint tensions dissolve.

“The side effects may be interesting,” Shade warned. “You still do not require food, but taste may be stronger. You may feel pleasantly tired afterward. Sleep could come more easily, if you choose it.”

“And if I punch something?” she asked.

“It’ll bruise more realistically,” Rakihi said. “Science.”

Elcia snorted.

“Other sensations may be more immediate, too,” Shade added delicately. “Touch. Pressure. Heat and cold. We should be mindful of that.”

Rakihi’s grin slowly turned wicked.

“Mindful,” she said. “Uh-huh.”

Elcia cleared her throat. “I will… bear that in mind,” she said, exceptionally composed for someone whose ears were now definitely a shade darker.

Shade rose, then swayed slightly.

Rakihi was immediately at his side. “Hey,” she said. “You okay?”

“Mildly drained. Nothing alarming. Like a long training session.” He looked toward the kitchen. “I will need dinner.”

“You always need dinner,” she said. “Sit. I’ll get it.”

He let her fuss, just this once.

Elcia stayed on the rug a little longer, opening and closing her hands, marveling at the ache of muscles that had worked for months without truly feeling anything.

She brought one hand up, pressed it against her own cheek.

Her skin was warm.

Not hot, not flushed—simply soft and warm.

She swallowed.

“Other things,” she murmured, almost to herself.

Shade, from the chair, looked over. “Yes?” he asked.

She met his gaze.

“Later,” she said. “When you’re not about to fall over. And when Rakihi isn’t holding a pot where she can hit us both if we say something stupid.”

From the hearth, Rakihi brandished a ladle. “You’re damn right I will. No collapsing on my watch. We have plans: gold missions, polycule talks, warm undead. Neither of you is allowed to break.”

Shade smiled.

It was a small smile, but a genuine one.

But real.

“I will be careful,” he said. “Both for my sake and yours.”

Elcia stood, joints moving with a smoothness she hadn’t felt since before her death, and came to sit on the arm of his chair.

“Good,” she said. “Because if this is what you can do with a few stolen books and a bad idea, I want to see what happens when you’ve had more practice.”

“That is… a terrifying sentence,” he murmured.

Rakihi ladled stew into bowls, humming.

“A necromancy-curious dragon, a newly warm dullahan, and a bard without the slightest instinct for self-preservation. What could possibly go wrong?”

She handed them both bowls, pausing when Elcia took hers.

Their fingers touched.

For just a second too long.

Elcia’s eyes widened.

“Oh,” she said again, much more quietly.

Shade watched the realization cross her face, the faint shiver down her spine.

Shade’s heart gave an undignified lurch.

He looked at his hands, at the stones on his wrist, at the warm, crowded room.

Necromancy had a deservedly ugly reputation. Yet if it could also mean this—

not shackles and cold, but borrowed warmth and a little comfort—

then perhaps a few suspicious looks in the library were worth enduring.

He took a spoonful of stew.

“It tastes better,” Elcia said, surprised.

“It’s the life juice,” Rakihi said solemnly.

Shade choked on his bread.

They laughed.

The house hummed.

Somewhere between the beat of living hearts and the silence of a curse, a little more of Elcia’s long-frozen world began to thaw.

Chapter 44: The Gold Trial

The dungeon seemed to hate them personally.

Its malice went beyond traps and monsters. Someone had designed each turn and chamber to wring as much suffering as possible from anyone who ventured inside.

From the first step in, Shade felt it.

It was not the Void, but it came close enough to make the scales beneath Shade's skin prickle.

"Demons," he muttered, voice low behind his helm. "I hate demons."

"Noted," Rakihi said, too bright. "Add that to the list with 'tax collectors' and 'people who say "just be yourself" at parties'."

He should have smiled.

He didn't.

The descent was a grind.

They passed through warped chambers and corridors reeking of blood and hot iron. Sigils cut into the walls resembled Void geometry, though the intent behind them was disturbingly different.

The first big fight came three levels down.

No skeletons. No zombies.

Flesh stitched into the wrong shapes.

Creatures assembled from what had once been humans, beasts, and gods knew what else. Their makers understood enough anatomy to keep the pieces moving and nothing at all of dignity.

Shade raised a hand to summon fire on instinct.

The bracelet bit.

Elemental force snapped taut within him, dragging his power back with the sharp pain of a pinched nerve.

He bit off a curse.

"Problem?" Elcia asked, dropping into stance beside him, blade drawn.

"The stones," he said between his teeth. "They… disapprove."

Did they object to this dungeon? To the demons? Or merely to his reaching for more power?

No. Of how far he'd already pushed them this month.

The bindings had tightened after his bargain with the death god. Even so, he had kept pushing them—for Elcia, for his experiments, for small tasks he had insisted did not count.

He'd also skimped on feeding.

Too many missions, too little time spent quietly chewing sapphires. His reserves were thinner than they ought to have been.

That all came due now.

He grabbed his sword instead.

“Front line. With me.” His voice settled into the calm of old battle drills. His powers might fail him, but his training would not.

The fight was ugly.

Elcia rode through the stitched horrors like a scalpel, her mount leaving smoldering hoofprints. Shade met the creatures with steel, his greatsword cleaving through bodies that had no business possessing so many limbs.

Every time he reached for more—fire, storm, gravity—the stones pulsed a warning: No. Not that. Not now.

He obeyed.

Overriding five gods while buried in demon flesh would be an excellent way to get himself killed.

Behind them, Rakihi’s webs of sound and light confused the abominations, while Tomas’ spear and Mina’s knives struck at exposed joints.

When it ended, everyone was breathing hard. The chamber looked like a butcher’s shop after an earthquake.

Mina wiped her face with a trembling hand. “This… is bronze work for them?” she panted.

“This is cleanup,” Varinel said, loosing one last arrow into something still twitching on the floor. “The real problem is lower.”

Rakihi leaned against Shade, catching her breath.

“You’re… quieter,” she said, eyes searching his face. “Inside. You okay?”

He nodded. “Limited. The stones are being conservative.”

Her mouth twisted. “Figures they’d pick now to be overprotective.”

✦ ✦ ✦

The deeper levels were worse.

The cultists had built in layers: rough caves, then worked stone, then demonic additions threaded with veins of black iron that hummed malevolently.

The sealing stones kept clamping.

A wide-area blast? No.
A local gravity crush? No.
Dragon-scale resilience? Fine, but don’t you dare.

Elcia’s tether remained a low note at the edge of his awareness. It did not weigh him down, but any uncontrolled surge could travel along it to her.

He fought as he had in the oldest training circles, before the Void wars taught him to treat battlefields as canvases for his power.

Sword. Armor. Footwork.

Steel and muscle instead of sunfire and storm.

It was… almost hard.

Almost.

He surprised himself by how much he remembered.

Old drills in his mother's palace. Sparring circles where using your breath or your claws got you a cuff from an elder and another five hundred passes at the pell.

In the cramped corridors, the armor felt heavy. After several engagements, even his greatsword dragged at his arms. He had become accustomed to compensating with power.

He paid for it in sweat.

A demon's barbed tail caught him across the ribs. The sting was startlingly real, sharp enough to steal his breath.

"Feed him," Terra grumbled at the back of his mind. "He's running on fumes and stubbornness."

"Lectures later," he thought back grimly, ducking under a claw and driving his sword up through a thing's jaw.

Arcebek would already have been shouting at him.

When was the last time you actually ate a gem, idiot? Do you think being ancient makes you immune to basic energetic needs?

She'd have a point.

But there was no time now.

✦ ✦ ✦

The lieutenant awaited them on the seventh level.

There was no mistaking it.

The air was thick and hot, crawling with the hum of flies that were not there. Runes across the walls made Rakihi's teeth ache. In the floor, a black-iron circle beat with the pulse of something that should never have entered this world.

And at the center—

It wasn't as big as Shade had feared.

That made it worse.

Human-sized. Maybe a head taller.

Four arms ended in elegant hands and impossibly long nails. Ash-grey skin bore glowing, ember-red sigils; horns swept back like a crown of broken blades. The face might have been beautiful if not for the eyes—two furnaces burning with swirling orange light.

It lounged on a throne made of fused skulls and blackened stone, one leg thrown casually over an armrest.

"Well," it said, voice smooth as oil poured over knives. "Look what climbed all the way down. The guild sends such interesting toys these days."

Shade's hackles rose.

Demons he understood.

Not anatomically—not like undead. But on a deeper, philosophical level.

They mirrored the Void in their wrongness, but where the Void sought emptiness, demons sought corruption.

They twisted what already existed: promises into traps, kindness into leverage, and noble intentions into elaborate cruelty.

Shade had encountered countless beings like this on countless battlefields. Their faces differed; their final justification never did: *Why fight? This is simply how the world works.*

“I hate demons,” he murmured again.

“Feelings mutual, I’m sure,” Rakihi said quietly, though she didn’t sound amused anymore.

Elcia’s grip tightened on her sword. The curse around her flared—a dullahan standing before something that had no respect for thresholds.

Shade stepped forward.

“This ends here,” Shade said. “Leave this realm and release these tunnels, or we will force you out.”

The demon smiled.

“My contract is quite clear,” it purred. “You walked into my parlor, little dragon. You have been terribly noisy on the way down.” Its gaze gleamed. “And I can smell your chains. So many lovely bindings. So poorly fed.”

Shade’s jaw clenched.

Rakihi’s hand brushed his back, grounding him.

“Don’t let it under your scales,” she whispered.

The demon’s gaze slid to her.

“And you,” it said. “Little song-thief. Half-blood. Carrying three kinds of power like mismatched keys on a chain. Sing for me. I’ll make it worth your while.”

Rakihi gave a brittle laugh. “You cannot afford my rates. Besides, you’re ugly.”

Its smile tightened.

“And a dullahan,” it went on, eyes moving to Elcia. “Leashed and warm. Someone’s been dabbling where they shouldn’t.” Its nostrils flared. “He pushed life into you. How… quaint.”

Elcia’s knuckles went white.

“Stop talking,” Elcia said. “Start dying.”

The demon’s eyes snapped back to Shade.

“There it is,” it said, delighted. “Righteous rage. You’re all so fun before you break.”

It snapped its fingers.

The room exploded into motion.

✦ ✦ ✦

The lieutenant relied on guile, not brute force.

It moved like something that had studied mortal combat for centuries and learned every weakness.

One instant it lounged on its throne; the next it appeared behind Mina, claws reaching for her spine. Shade intercepted the strike with his greatsword, steel shrieking against talons.

“Fast,” he grunted.

“Cheat,” Buyakugan crackled. Let me loose, let me loose—

The stones bit down harder.

No.

Shade struggled to match the demon’s speed. Every parry sent pain through his arms, and the sword grew heavier with each exchange. If he could unleash even a fraction of his true power, he could reduce the lieutenant and its circle to slag.

But the chamber was too confined, the stone too ancient, and the curse-lines too deeply woven through the dungeon.

He’d collapse the whole mountain.

“Not an option,” he panted, half to himself.

The demon ducked his swing and raked claws across his breastplate. “Tired already?” It laughed as the impact jarred his ribs. “And you call yourself a dragon.”

Elcia charged it, ghostfire flaring along her blade.

“Focus,” Terra growled in his bones. Feet. Balance.

He listened.

He had to.

No power. No breath.

Sword and shield and dullahan.

Elcia took the next strike on her shield, her boots skidding across the stone. Her horse appeared at the edge of the circle as a ghostly silhouette, blazing eyes and broad shoulders squeezed into a chamber too small to contain it fully.

Rakihi wove sound.

Her voice cut like wire, a keening note that found the pattern holding the demon’s body together. She could not banish it alone, but she made every movement cost it effort.

Tomas and Mina darted at its flanks while Varinel loosed arrows tipped with consecrated oil whenever it overextended.

Even so, it was barely enough.

Shade was tired.

He hated it.

He hated this ordinary exhaustion: burning lungs, aching arms, sweat stinging his eyes. The stones would not yield, no matter how hard he pulled.

You will break something, Fenris whispered. If not here, then in yourself.

A claw scraped his helm, spinning him halfway around.

“Shade!” Rakihi shouted. “Left!”

He rolled beneath the demon’s tail and rose on one knee, sword planted, breath ragged.

He came up on one knee, sword planted, chest heaving.

“Hey!” Rakihi yelled at the demon. “Over here! Come bully someone who can’t bench-press a house, coward!”

It turned.

That was all the opening they needed.

Elcia struck from behind, severing the tendon at its knee. Rakihi’s voice rose into a dissonant cry that tore at the binding of its form, and Mina cut the other leg out from under it.

Shade moved.

Everything hurt.

He moved anyway.

One step. Two.

Claws scored his side where his damaged armor finally gave way. Heat and pain spread through the wound.

He ignored it.

He raised the greatsword in both hands.

And drove it down through the demon’s chest, pinning it to the iron circle.

It shrieked.

Not in pain—not just pain—but in offense.

“You—” it spat, choking on non-blood. “You—mortal weapon—do you know who I serve—”

“Yes,” Shade said. “Too many of its like already.”

Rakihi chanted in a language half Moonthorn tradition and half knowledge stolen from listening to the gods argue within Shade’s bones.

“Back,” she snarled, fingers twisted in a sigil. “Back to your contractor, you cheap copy. This realm doesn’t want you. We don’t want you.”

The demon writhed.

It tried to slip the binding. Tried to twist around their work, find a loophole.

The sealing stones helped.

Not with more power.

With precision.

Djing & Djang steadied his hands. Fenris revealed the pull of the circle’s lines. Terra anchored his stance. Ifret burned away the demon’s attempts to twist free, while Buyakugan guided the final spark.

Shade leaned his weight on the sword, pressing it deeper, pinning the demon in the exact center of the summoning matrix.

“Leave,” he said, voice like grinding rock. “And do not come back. There are easier worlds.”

Only then did the demon truly see him.

Not just the tired warrior in dented armor.

The thing under that.

Its sneer faltered.

“Oh,” it said softly. “You’re—”

Rakihi’s song hit its peak.

The circle flared.

The demon’s body collapsed inward with the sound of a forge door slamming shut. It vanished along the channel that had brought it into the world.

Silence.

Real silence.

Not the god’s. Not demonic stillness.

Only the ordinary silence of a dungeon remained.

Breathing.

Dripping.

Shade staggered back, sword slipping from his hands, point clanging off the stone.

Elcia caught his shoulder, steadying him.

“Still hate them?” she asked, a little breathless herself.

“Yes,” he said. “More now.”

He looked down at the circle, now just dead iron and scorched lines.

“Is it… gone?” Mina asked.

“For now.” Rakihi knelt, palms against the etched floor, eyes closed. “The tether is cut and the summoning array is destroyed. Whatever waits on the other side knows we slammed the door.”

“That will have… consequences,” Shade murmured.

“Gold work,” Varinel said. “Congratulations.”

Rakihi laughed weakly.

“Gold work with bronze pay,” she said. “Again.”

Shade let himself sink to sit on the floor, back against a cracked pillar.

His side burned where the claws had pierced his armor, and his arms felt weighted with lead. It was ordinary pain, not a cosmic wound—and that almost made it stranger.

The stones had gone quiet.

Not sulking.

Just… resting.

Elcia knelt and inspected the wound with practiced hands.

“You’re underfed,” she said bluntly. “This would’ve slid right off proper dragon plating if you’d been eating your gems like a good boy.”

He scowled. “I have been… busy.”

Rakihi thunked him lightly on the helm with the heel of her hand.

“When Arcebek gets back,” she said, “you are going to get such a lecturing. I’m almost looking forward to it.”

“I am not,” he said.

She smiled, tired but fond.

“Still,” she added, looking around at the battered party, the dead circle, the absence of demonic presence, “we did it. Full clear. Lieutenant down. No one died. Nobody even lost a limb.”

“Elcia doesn’t count,” Mina piped up faintly.

“I heard that,” Elcia said.

Shade let his head hit the pillar behind him, eyes closing for a moment.

Even these pale echoes of the enemies he had fought in older wars stirred something ugly in Shade.

They brought back too much.

He remembered the smell of burning worlds, bargains rotting from within, and the ease with which any good thing could be twisted under enough pressure.

Danger alone was not what he hated. He had faced danger since before this world existed.

It was the corruption—the patient delight demons took in ruining what others had built.

“Let’s get out of here,” he said finally. “We can argue about my dietary habits on the surface.”

Rakihi snorted. “Oh, we will,” she said.

Elcia stood, offering him a hand up.

He took it.

His joints protested.

He understood now how narrow his limits had become. The death god’s bargain, Elcia’s tether, and his own neglect had all exacted a price.

He’d have to live with that.

Work with it.

Find new ways.

Perhaps, in its own irritating way, that was useful.

Keeps you honest, he thought. Keeps you careful.

He hated that, too.

As they started the long trek back up through the cleared levels, Rakihi fell into step beside him.

“Hey,” she said. “Next time, before we go demon-punching? We schedule a gem-eating day. Non-negotiable.”

“Yes,” he said.

“And when Arcebek comes back?” she went on. “You let her yell at you about this. Properly. No deflecting. No ‘it wasn’t that bad.’”

He grimaced.

Then nodded.

“Yes,” he said again.

“Good,” she said, satisfied. “Because ‘I fought a demon lord’s lieutenant on low elemental calories’ is exactly the kind of thing she’ll want to bite you for.”

Elcia, overhearing, chuckled. “She’s going to fit right in,” she said.

“We’re going to die,” Tomas muttered.

“Not today,” Shade said.

He meant it.

He’d seen too many worlds where demons won.

This world, with its overprotective guildmaster, sharp-tongued warlock, noisy bard, and warm dullahan—

he would not let demons twist it into something unrecognizable.

Even if it meant learning to hate demons from behind a greatsword instead of a blast of starfire.

Chapter 45: Homecoming

They knew she was home before they saw her.

Something in the manor had changed.

The wards hummed in an unfamiliar rhythm, as though someone had slipped another melody beneath the one they knew. Elementals darted through the halls, too excited to keep to their usual chores.

Rakihi stopped dead in the entry hall, pack sliding off one shoulder.

“Do you feel that?” she whispered.

Shade did.

A new presence had woven itself into the heart of the house. He knew it as surely as it knew him.

His throat went tight.

They rounded the corner into the main room.

Arcebek was home.

Arcebek sat at the big table, boots propped on its edge and a half-empty mug beside her. Her jet-black hair had escaped its usual braid and spilled down her back. Bronze skin, full red lips, the compact strength Shade remembered so well.

Everything he remembered.

Except her eyes.

They were closed.

Not in sleep. The lids had a terrible, unnatural stillness, as though they might never lift again.

Shade’s stomach dropped.

Rakihi made a small, broken sound.

Arcebek turned toward the sound at once.

“Whoever dropped their pack is paying for the floor repair,” she said calmly. “And if any of you idiots are bleeding on my clean boards, I swear to all the gods I’ve offended this year…”

The last word caught in her throat.

Then Rakihi launched herself across the room.

She flung her arms around Arcebek’s neck hard enough to knock the dwarf’s boots off the table. The mug rattled against the wood but stayed upright.

“You’re back,” Rakihi choked. “You’re back you’re back you’re back—”

Arcebek grunted at the impact. Then she wrapped both arms around Rakihi and held on.

“Yeah,” she whispered into blue hair. “Yeah, I’m back, little menace.”

Shade stood motionless, still armored, his sword hanging forgotten at his side.

Then Arcebek said, without looking, “Shade, if you don’t hug me in the next five seconds, I’m breaking up with you out of principle.”

He moved.

He crossed the room without remembering the steps, gathered them both into his arms, and cradled the back of Arcebek’s head. He needed to feel that she was real.

She smelled of sulphur, incense, and the guild’s cheap soap.

Alive.

Warm.

Heart beating fast under his cheek.

For a while, none of them spoke. Rakihi’s breath hitched against Arcebek’s shoulder.

“Hey,” Arcebek murmured, one hand finding Shade’s jaw by feel, thumb brushing the line of his beard. “Hey. I said I’d come back.”

“Your eyes,” he managed.

She stilled.

“Yeah,” she said softly. “We’ll get to that. Later. After I’ve yelled at you for being stupid.”

Rakihi hiccuped a laugh.

“Spoiler,” Arcebek added, “I am furious.”

She kissed Shade first.

Even with her eyes closed, she found his mouth without hesitation. The kiss was fierce, tasting of bitter coffee and the road. She caught his lower lip between her teeth, then softened and lingered before drawing away.

Then she turned her head a fraction and kissed Rakihi.

She kissed Rakihi more gently, brushing the tears from her cheeks with both thumbs. There were apologies she had never been good at putting into words.

When they finally let go enough to breathe, Rakihi wiped her face on her sleeve, sniffing.

“You look terrible,” she informed Arcebek.

“You smell like troll,” Arcebek shot back. “So we’re even.”

Shade laughed, shaky.

He wasn’t the only one whose attention had been hijacked by the reunion.

A throat cleared behind them.

Elcia stood in the doorway, half-armored and unsure whether to enter. For someone who had once been a ghostly terror, she looked remarkably afraid of interrupting.

Arcebek turned her head toward the sound, nostrils flaring.

“…You must be the dullahan,” she said.

Elcia raised a brow. “You must be the warlock,” she replied.

“Come here,” Arcebek said.

Her tone left no room for argument.

Elcia came.

Shade felt absurdly like a schoolboy awaiting judgment.

Arcebek’s hand came up, tracking Elcia by the sound of her steps. Fingers brushed metal, then cloth, then the line of her jaw.

“Nice armor,” Arcebek said. “You chip easily?”

“Less than most,” Elcia said, voice a little low.

“Good,” Arcebek said.

And then she leaned in and kissed her.

There was no hesitation.

Arcebek curled a hand behind Elcia’s neck and drew her close. The kiss was slow, deliberate, and unmistakably welcome.

Elcia startled, then relaxed into it, one hand gripping the back of Arcebek’s chair.

Shade forgot how to think.

“Oh,” Rakihi said faintly.

When Arcebek finally let Elcia go, the dullahan’s ears were dark, her eyes wide.

“Hi,” Arcebek said, lips quirking. “I’m Arcebek. Thanks for not letting him get himself killed while I was gone.”

Elcia swallowed. “I’ll… collect payment for that later,” she said, voice rougher than usual.

“I’m counting on it,” Arcebek said.

Rakihi flapped her hands. “Okay, good, we’ve established the kissing baseline, that’s… fine, that’s great, I’m fine.”

“Sit,” Arcebek ordered them all suddenly. “You’re all wobbling. Shade, if you fall over in my peripheral not-vision, I’m never letting you live it down.”

They sat.

Rakihi on Arcebek’s left, Elcia on her right. Shade on the bench opposite, because if he sat too close he might not be able to stop touching her.

He couldn’t help staring at her eyes.

Her eyelids never moved.

There was no scarring.

Only that absolute stillness.

“Are they… gone?” Rakihi blurted. “Under there?”

Arcebek sighed. “There are… things under there,” she said. “Not for you to look at. Yet. And before you get clever, Rakihi: if you try to pry them open while I’m asleep, I will know, and I will curse your shoes so they squeak forever.”

Rakihi clamped her mouth shut on whatever she’d been about to ask.

“Start from the beginning,” Shade said quietly. “Please.”

Arcebek ran a hand through her hair, gathering her thoughts.

“You got the short version in the letters,” she said. “ ‘Bad neighbours, corpos, don’t like the weather.’ I was trying not to worry you.”

“You failed,” Shade told her.

“I know,” she said mildly. “Let me pretend I didn’t.”

She took a breath.

“So,” she said. “My patron’s… organization—we’ll call them a consortium, because that’s the word they used when they made me sign thirty-seven pages of bullshit—decided to expand their portfolio.”

“Beyond the curtain,” Shade said slowly.

She tilted her head toward him. “Yeah,” she said. “You know how it is. There’s always someone in a boardroom somewhere going ‘We’ve tapped out all the reasonable sources of power, what if we poke that.’”

Rakihi winced. “Oh gods.”

“They wanted access,” Arcebek went on. “To things outside the usual channels. Beyond this reality’s bubble, beyond your Void. Things in the gaps behind the walls.” She tapped the table with a knuckle. “That’s where the real profit is, they said. Unique energies. Untapped markets. The usual.”

Shade’s hands curled slowly into fists.

“I told them they were idiots. They told me I was getting a promotion.”

“Let me guess,” Elcia said dryly. “By ‘promotion’ they meant ‘front-line tester’.”

“Exactly. They sent me to the border to negotiate a partnership. ‘We give you footholds, you give us a share of the power.’”

Her tone hardened.

“The things on the other side were very interested,” she said. “In a way that made my teeth itch. They were also… bigger. And hungrier. And more used to being on the predatory side of arrangements. They took one look at my patron’s avatar, one look at me, and went: ‘Why should we cut you in at all?’”

Shade swallowed. “What did they want?”

“Everything,” Arcebek said simply. “They wanted to flow in. To wear him like a glove. To use me as a handle.”

Rakihi’s hand found her knee under the table.

“What happened?” she asked softly.

Arcebek’s head tilted back, as if she were looking up through the ceiling.

“My patron panicked. Spend millennia holding all the cards and you forget what it feels like to be prey. The things beyond found every gap in the contract, every clever little loophole.”

Her smile held no amusement.

“I saw it,” she said. “Because that’s what I do. I see where bargains fray. I see where clauses bend. Even there, even with those things, I could… read it. And I realized something.”

“What?” Shade whispered.

“They couldn’t see us clearly. To them, we were shadows in bad glass. They could reach into our world, but they couldn’t focus well enough to set their hooks.”

She turned her face back toward them, lids still shut.

“So I made an offer,” she said.

Rakihi’s fingers tightened on her knee.

“Arce…” she began.

Arcebek shrugged, small and sharp.

“I told them they would shred my patron if they kept pushing, and then nobody would get a deal. I offered them focus: eyes that could read our world, its contracts, its consequences, and where the boundaries really lay.”

Shade’s mouth went dry.

“In return, they agreed to a limited interface. No possession. No passage through me. They can borrow my sight as a lens, but only when I choose. I keep breathing, and my patron gets free without being eaten.”

“You… bargained your eyes,” Elcia said quietly.

“Yeah,” Arcebek said. “Seemed… fair at the time.”

Silence settled over the table.

“What did they do to him?” Rakihi asked.

Arcebek’s smile turned nasty.

“They took their pound of flesh, and then some. He tried to wriggle out of the amended terms. They corrected him.”

She tapped her temple.

“He’s weaker,” she said. “Smaller. Some of his… underlings got shredded when the connection snapped back. Whole wings of his ‘company’ gone. They’ll recover eventually, but it’ll take them a long time. And they sure as hell aren’t going to try that particular stunt again without talking to me first.”

Shade let out a slow, unsteady breath.

“And you?” he asked. “What did you get, besides… this?”

He gestured helplessly at her closed eyes.

Arcebek smiled, slow.

“I got a raise. I’m not merely an employee now; I’m a partner, with veto power over certain deals. And the things beyond?” She flexed her fingers. “They owe me. Without me, they lose their carefully rationed glimpse of this world. They hate it. Delicious.”

Rakihi blinked. “You pissed off your own patron and a set of eldritch horrors,” she said. “You really are one of us.”

“Someone had to keep up with your dragon,” Arcebek shot back. “Can’t let him have all the stupid cosmic stories.”

Shade swallowed the lump in his throat.

“How… do you see?” he asked.

She hesitated.

Then she reached across the table and took his hand.

The contact felt nothing like Elcia’s tether.

It reached somewhere beyond ordinary sight.

“I see threads. Contracts, promises, the places where souls touch. When I focus, I see your chains running”—her thumb brushed his knuckles—“up to your gods, down to Elcia, across to Rakihi. Obligations. Wounds. Things cut apart or tied back together badly.”

Rakihi shivered. “That sounds terrifying.”

“Overwhelming?” Arcebek supplied. “Yeah. That’s why I keep the lids shut most of the time. If I opened them all the way in a crowded street, I’d probably pass out. Or throw up.”

“Can you… see us?” Elcia asked. “As… people. Not just… contracts.”

Arcebek squeezed Shade’s hand, then let go and reached toward the dullahan.

Elcia met her halfway.

Their fingers laced.

“Yes,” Arcebek said. “I see you standing where your grave ought to be, with a road running through you. One branch leads into Shade’s spine. Beneath it all is a furious little halfling who refused to stay down simply because someone told her she was finished.”

Elcia’s throat worked.

“That’s… a lot,” she managed.

“Yeah,” Arcebek said. “You’re a lot.”

Rakihi leaned her elbows on the table, chin in her hands. “And me?” she asked. “What do you see when you… look?”

Arcebek huffed a tiny laugh.

“I see songs and promises tangled together, and spiteful little knots you tie so the world won’t forget you. I see how fiercely you hold to them”—she nodded toward Shade and Elcia—“and the fear beneath that. The loyalty. Also, an unreasonable number of unfinished spells on napkins.”

Rakihi’s eyes filled again.

“Yeah,” she said hoarsely. “That sounds about right.”

Shade swallowed.

“And when you look at yourself?” he asked.

Arcebek went quiet.

At last, she said, “I see someone who made a choice she can’t take back, and is trying very hard to pretend she’s okay with the cost.”

Rakihi reached across the table, grabbed her hand, and didn’t let go.

Shade did the same from the other side.

Elcia rested her palm lightly over both.

For a few heartbeats, no one spoke.

Then Arcebek inhaled, squared her shoulders.

“Right. Cosmic horror is covered. Time for domestic horror.”

Shade blinked. “…Domestic?”

She turned her face directly toward him, sightless lids lowered like she was squinting.

“You fought a demon lord’s lieutenant,” she said, voice dangerously calm, “underfed, under-rested, with your seals clamped down because you’ve been playing necromantic battery for your girlfriend and ignoring your own maintenance.”

Rakihi’s mouth dropped open. “You knew?”

“I can smell the damage. On him, on the stones, on you and Elcia. Do you know how angry Terra sounded when I touched your chain and got a groan instead of a greeting?”

Shade winced. “I was—”

“Don’t,” she said sharply. “Don’t you dare say ‘fine’. Don’t you dare say ‘it wasn’t that bad’. You are a walking siege engine held together with guilt and stubbornness, and if you run yourself into the ground because you’re too proud or too busy to chew a few sapphires, I will personally drag your soul back just to tell you how stupid you are.”

Rakihi made an involuntary, delighted noise. “Gods, I missed you,” she sighed.

Elcia’s lips twitched.

Shade bowed his head, chastened.

“You are right,” he said quietly. “I overreached. I am… sorry.”

“Apologize to yourself,” Arcebek shot back. “I can yell at you anytime. You only get one spine.”

Despite himself, he smiled.

“I will do better,” he promised. “Feed. Rest. Ask for help.”

“Good,” she said. “Because from what Lana told me, you’ve all been doing gold-level work for bronze pay and pretending not to notice. That stops. We plan now. We schedule gem days. We talk before you go pick fights with lieutenants.”

“You talked to Lana already?” Rakihi asked, torn between horror and admiration.

“Of course I did,” Arcebek said. “First thing I did when I got through quarantine was march into her office and say, ‘What have they broken while I was away.’ She had notes.”

Elcia groaned softly.

Arcebek’s mouth softened.

“Congratulations, by the way,” she said. “On your gold. All of you.”

Rakihi straightened. “You’re not mad we beat you to it?” she asked, half-teasing, half-serious.

“I am furious,” Arcebek said cheerfully. “I fully intend to hold it over you when I catch up. But I’m also… proud. In a disgusting, mom-ish way I refuse to examine too closely.”

Shade’s chest tightened.

He hadn’t realized how much he’d wanted to hear that until she said it.

“Thank you,” he said.

She nodded once.

“Now,” she went on, “as promised in my letter, we are going to have a long talk about our polycule. But not tonight. Tonight, we eat whatever passable food you have left. I learn the house by sound. Then I fall face-first into a bed with at least two of you, because I haven’t slept properly in three months.”

Rakihi raised a hand. “Dibs,” she said.

Elcia coughed. “…Second dibs.”

Shade shook his head and smiled. For the first time in months, the house felt whole.

“Tomorrow,” Arcebek said, as they slowly disentangled to see about food. “You’re going to tell me every stupid thing you did while I was gone. I’m going to yell. We’re going to argue. We’re going to plan. And then we’re going to decide, together, what we want this mess to be.”

She lifted her chin, blind eyes turned toward them.

“You don’t freeze for me,” she said. “You don’t put your lives on pause because I walked off into corporate eldritch nonsense. We keep living. We make it better. Or we break it and build something new.”

Rakihi leaned over and kissed her temple.

“Yes, boss,” she murmured.

Elcia smiled, small and fierce. “Sounds… good,” she said.

Shade reached across the table one more time, fingers brushing Arcebek’s.

“We missed you,” he said.

She squeezed his hand.

“I know,” she said. “I missed you too.”

Outside, the wind shifted.

Inside, the house adjusted around four people instead of three, wards bending to accept a new, strange way of seeing.

Far beyond creation's veil, something ancient and hungry stirred in displeasure.

At the battered table, the four of them leaned together and began the quieter work of finding their way back to one another.

Chapter 46: Four Hearts, One Hearth

By breakfast, Arcebek had compiled a list of grievances.

She occupied the head of the table like a general preparing a siege, fingers steepled and closed eyes trained on her three increasingly nervous companions.

“You fought a demon lieutenant on low reserves,” she said to Shade, ticking off on a finger. “You rewired a death curse into our personal connection without a proper containment plan,” finger two, Elcia. “You helped with both and decided at no point to write ‘by the way we’re binding more gods and picking fights with demons’ in your letters,” finger three, pointed at Rakihi.

Rakihi raised a hand. “In my defense, the imp charges extra every time I mention ‘cosmic horror.’”

“Not helping,” Arcebek said.

She dropped her hands, exhaled, and then ruined the effect by reaching out, finding Rakihi’s bowl by sound, and stealing a carrot.

“But,” she went on, mouth full, “I also like you all disgustingly much, and I am—” she grimaced, as if the words hurt “—glad you’re all still here. So. We move on to phase two.”

Shade tensed reflexively. “Another mission?” he guessed.

“Worse,” Arcebek said. “Feelings.”

Rakihi made a strangled little wheeze.

Elcia sat a little straighter, wary.

“There are four of us,” Arcebek said. “A dragon with martyrdom issues, a bard who could flirt with a lamp, an undead noble still learning her boundaries, and a warlock with new eldritch eyes. We’re spectacular at surviving disasters and remarkably bad at discussing ordinary life. Before this becomes a ballad about glorious passion and quiet implosion, we’re going to be practical.”

Rakihi squinted at her. “Is this about the dishes?” she asked.

“Everything. Dishes included. First: time.”

She pointed “at” the space between them.

“I am not always going to be here,” she said. “You’ve seen that. I get dragged off to do stupid things with contracts and outer gods. Sometimes Shade is going to be gone on dragon business, sometimes Elcia is going to feel the road tug harder, sometimes Rakihi is going to disappear under a pile of books and not emerge for a week.”

“That happened twice,” Rakihi protested.

“Point is,” Arcebek said over her, “we are not a tidy little couple taking turns at market. So. Schedules.”

“How romantic,” Elcia murmured.

“Profoundly. We need names for things: date nights, mission days, days when someone needs to hide under a blanket. Otherwise we drift apart without noticing.”

Shade nodded slowly. “What do you propose?” he asked.

“Rotate. At least one evening every eight days without logistics, gods, or demons. Time in pairs, time together. Rakihi and me. Shade and Elcia. Me and Shade. Rakihi and Elcia. All four when we can manage it. We say what we want instead of leaving someone at home wondering whether they’ve been forgotten.”

Rakihi chewed on that, then nodded. “I can actually do that,” she said. “Even write it on the wall. With, like, little symbols. So we remember which night is for what.”

“Please don’t draw anything obscene,” Elcia said.

“No promises,” Rakihi said.

Arcebek’s mouth quirked. “Second,” she said. “Conflict. It’s coming.”

“We already argue,” Shade pointed out.

“You can fight demons together. I’m talking about boots left in hallways and all the little irritations nobody admits to until they’re furious.”

Rakihi pointed at Shade. “Him,” she said instantly.

Shade looked offended. “I do not—”

“You do,” Rakihi and Arcebek said together.

Elcia coughed. “I also leave cloaks places,” she admitted. “I’m still getting used to… living in a house again.”

“So we agree now: say something before resentment takes root. No silent tests, no expecting someone to read your mind. That way lies my parents’ third divorce.”

Rakihi blinked. “Your parents were married three times?”

“To each other,” Arcebek said. “It was… educational.”

Elcia’s eyes softened. “That’s why you’re so… structured,” she said.

“That’s why I refuse to watch us collapse over stupid things. Third: space.”

She turned her face toward Elcia.

“You’re new to all this, Elcia. To the guild, to us. If it ever feels too fast, you tell us. If you need a room of your own, your own rituals, your own road, we make room.”

Elcia’s throat worked. “And if I… want to stay in it?” she asked. “In the mess?”

“Then you stay. But you’ve spent too much of your life with other people making decisions for you. We won’t join that list.”

Shade exhaled, some knot inside him easing at that.

“And fourth,” Arcebek said, voice softening, “we celebrate.”

Rakihi perked up. “Now we’re talking.”

“We make time to be happy on purpose, not only between disasters. We survived our separate hells. We reached gold. Elcia escaped one prison and chose to sit at this ridiculous table with us. That deserves more than a tired drink and a muttered ‘good job.’”

She planted her hands on the wood.

“Tonight we eat, drink, and tell our stories properly. Every foolish detail. Tomorrow we deal with chores, missions, and the gem-eating calendar for our resident walking power plant.”

Shade actually looked… relieved.

“Thank you,” he said quietly. “For… taking charge of this.”

Rakihi leaned over and kissed Arcebek’s cheek. “I told you she’d come home and immediately start project-managing the relationship,” she said to Elcia.

“You did,” Elcia agreed. “I didn’t think it would be… reassuring.”

Arcebek pointed a finger vaguely between them. “Reassuring is my tragic secret talent,” she said. “Don’t tell anyone. I have a reputation.”

Rakihi hopped up, energy back. “Right!” she said. “Celebration mode. We have half a loaf, some cheese, three suspicious turnips, and a bottle of decent wine I was saving for your return.”

“And a barrel at the Anvil with our name on it,” Elcia added. “Lysa made me promise to drag you there.”

Arcebek’s mouth curved. “We do both,” she decided. “Home first. Then we terrify the locals.”

✦ ✦ ✦

They discovered that a celebration required remarkably little, provided everyone had made it home.

Rakihi raided the pantry and somehow turned the scraps into the beginnings of a feast. Shade, out of his armor and wearing soft clothes, set bread in the oven and a sweet pudding on the stove. He hummed as he worked.

Elcia lit candles for their warmth rather than their light. Every so often she flexed her fingers, still surprised by the lingering heat Shade’s life-channeling had left within her.

Arcebek explored the house by touch.

She trailed a hand along the walls, counting steps and learning where chairs and rugs might trip her. Curious elementals followed. Sparky appeared in three hearths to chirp at her until she snapped her fingers over his flame and laughed.

“Yeah, yeah,” she said. “I see you. You’re taller than before.”

By the time she finished her circuit, she knew which floorboard by the kitchen door squeaked, where the hallway narrowed, how many steps to the bedrooms.

When she came back to the main room, the table was set.

The plates were mismatched. The food smelled wonderful.

Four chairs.

The sight caught Arcebek off guard.

“Sit,” Rakihi said, pushing her gently toward her place.

They ate.

They toasted.

“To gold,” Rakihi said, raising her cup.

“To surviving demons,” Elcia added.

“To surviving corpos,” Arcebek said.

Shade raised his cup. “To coming back,” he said.

They drank.

And then Rakihi did what Rakihi did best: demanded stories.

They began with the story of the castle.

Shade and Rakihi took turns recounting the goblin cave and the demon-tainted mission, then the moment Elcia’s curse had fastened itself to Shade. Elcia supplied the details they had missed, dryly enough to make Rakihi choke with laughter.

Elcia told her side of the castle, the priest, the months of being almost obedient, sabotaging where she could.

Arcebek smacked her hand on the table at that. “You’re telling me,” she said, “that my idiots nearly died clearing a curse that some pencil-necked priest wrote without even filing it properly with his god?”

“That’s… one way of putting it,” Elcia said.

Rakihi mimicked the priest’s smarmy voice; Arcebek’s curses for him got progressively more creative.

Then it was Arcebek’s turn.

She told the story of the boardroom.

The “consortium” that had thought they could out-bargain the dark behind the stars. The long meetings. The moment she’d realized her patron had no idea what it was inviting in. The decision.

She skipped the worst parts.

Her grip on the cup told them enough.

Rakihi reached over, laid a hand on her knee under the table. Shade’s foot brushed hers, deliberate. Elcia sat very still, listening like someone weighing debts.

“So now you’re…” Rakihi flapped her fingers near her own eyes. “Like this. All the time?”

“Unless I want to risk seeing too much,” Arcebek said. “Which I won’t. Not here. Not when I’d like to sleep without knowing how many promises our neighbors broke this week.”

“We can… help,” Shade said. “Wards. Rituals. Boundaries of our own.”

Arcebek’s mouth softened. “I know,” she said. “That’s why I came home.”

Rakihi blinked fast and changed the subject.

“Okay,” she said. “Serious question: Elcia, how does it feel to be officially included in this disaster?”

Elcia looked between them—blind warlock, tired dragon, emotional bard—and smiled, small but real.

“Like I climbed out of my grave and found three reasons to keep walking.”

Rakihi made a quiet noise and shoved a piece of bread at her to cover it.

They stayed home longer than they meant to.

They talked.

They argued about who had been most reckless.

Then they competed over the most ridiculous scar.

Shade showed them a faint, jagged mark on his side from the lieutenant's claws; Arcebek snorted and countered with a tale about a summoning circle exploding under her feet. Elcia casually mentioned being decapitated; Rakihi declared her the winner.

Later, when the plates were empty and Sparky's flames had settled into a drowsy glow, they finally made their way to the Broken Anvil.

Lysa looked up as they came in, cloth in hand.

She took in Arcebek's closed eyes, the way Rakihi hovered near her elbow, the easy way Shade walked beside Elcia now, and something like satisfaction crossed her face.

"About time," she said. "I was starting to think I'd have to come drag you back myself."

"You'd have bounced off the wards," Arcebek said dryly.

"Probably," Lysa agreed. "Beer?"

"Several," Rakihi said.

The Broken Anvil filled around them.

Other guild members came over—some cautious, some openly relieved.

There were claps on shoulders. Congratulations on gold. Jokes about dullahans and house rules.

Arcebek listened more than she talked.

But every so often, when someone got too close to a line—too nosy about Elcia's curse, too handsy with Rakihi, too hero-worshipful toward Shade—her head would tilt, and she'd say something quiet and sharp that reset the tone without starting a fight.

Watching her work the room blind, Shade realized something:

She wasn't just managing them.

She was managing the world around them too, making space where this strange four-sided thing they'd built could actually stand without being poked to death by curiosity and expectation.

Shade watched her with a gratitude too large to put into words.

Later, walking home under a sky cluttered with stars, Rakihi threaded an arm through each of theirs—Arcebek on her left, Shade on her right.

Elcia walked a half-step ahead, mounted, horse's hooves barely making a sound on the cobbles, a quiet sentinel.

"So," Rakihi said, swinging their joined hands. "We have date schedules, conflict rules, celebration protocols. What do we call… this? Us."

"Chaotic," Elcia suggested.

"Overengineered," Arcebek said.

"Home," Shade answered.

They all went quiet.

Then Rakihi smiled.

“Sold,” she said.

When they reached the manor, the wards hummed a welcome back.

Four sets of footsteps crossed the threshold.

Arcebek was already plotting a schedule in her head.

Shade silently renewed his promise to eat, to rest, and to stay.

Elcia still marvelled at the warmth running through her once-cold limbs.

Rakihi was already composing the first line of a song about the home they had chosen.

They were exhausted.

They were complicated.

Anyone looking in from outside might have called them a disaster waiting to happen.

But that night, long after the laughter faded and they fell into bed together—

they had something none of them had expected to find: a place where every one of them belonged.

GUILDS & DRAGONS

Book One — A Dragon Among Mortals

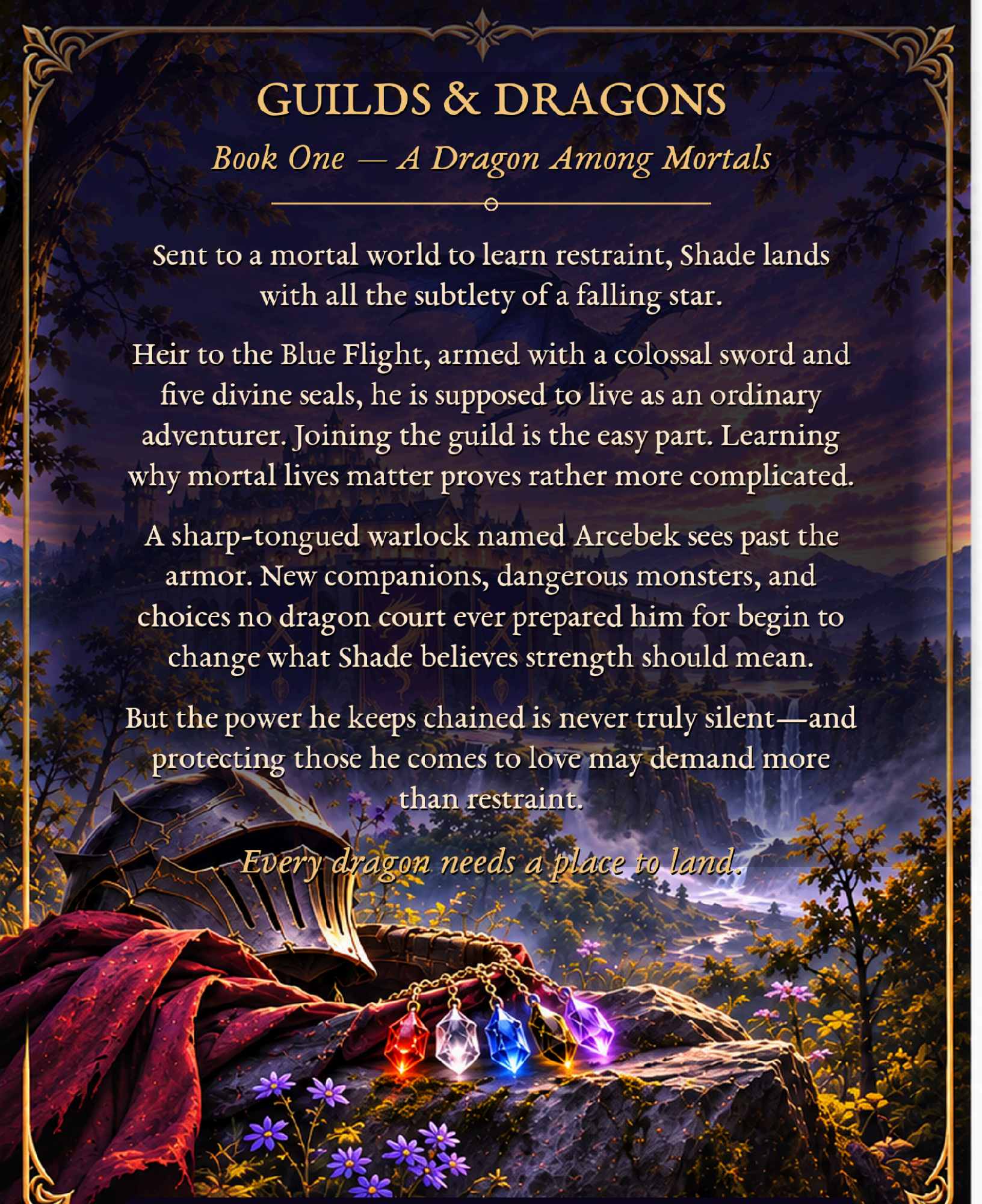
Sent to a mortal world to learn restraint, Shade lands with all the subtlety of a falling star.

Heir to the Blue Flight, armed with a colossal sword and five divine seals, he is supposed to live as an ordinary adventurer. Joining the guild is the easy part. Learning why mortal lives matter proves rather more complicated.

A sharp-tongued warlock named Arcebek sees past the armor. New companions, dangerous monsters, and choices no dragon court ever prepared him for begin to change what Shade believes strength should mean.

But the power he keeps chained is never truly silent—and protecting those he comes to love may demand more than restraint.

Every dragon needs a place to land.



A Web Novella Edition